

# **The Appearance**

Volume I

A Mystical Adventure Novel

Alexander Lunin

Series “Terra Incognita”. Book One

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## About the Book

A man comes to himself on a sunlit street of an eastern port city, not remembering who he is, nor how he came to be here, nor why this city seems strangely familiar to him.

And then the impossible begins.

Drawn into the world of an aristocratic house, he meets a mysterious stranger, an abandoned castle, and two ancient stones that seem to answer to the borders between worlds. Fragments of another life surface in visions of Ancient Egypt. A note in an unknown language points him the way to Sultanahmet. And somewhere in the shadows a grey figure watches him.

The deeper the mystery, the faster the borders between past and present blur. The man discovers that he is bound to a Pharaoh in the Valley of the Nile, to the Ottoman Empire, and to a forgotten history in which, perhaps, lies the key to his own identity.

Inspired by the author's travels through 62 countries of the world, "The Appearance" is a sweeping adventure-mystery novel that joins historical prose, mysticism and the enchantment of far wandering. From the ancient world to the streets of Constantinople, each discovery poses a more unsettling question:

What if the past has never gone away?

And what if someone - or something - is waiting for him to finally remember?

"The Appearance" is the first book in the "Terra Incognita" series: a journey through lost stories, mysterious worlds and secrets hidden beyond the borders of time.

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## Chapter I. The Appearance

A step. Then another. Soft velvet boots the colour of burgundy trod the sun-warmed cobbles so confidently that it seemed my feet remembered this road better than I did. The day was warm and languid, one of those days that thicken toward noon with the heat and with the smell of the sea drifting somewhere beyond the tiled roofs.

Who am I? Where am I? And - a far stranger question - where am I going?

I stopped for a moment, as though a body held motionless might compel memory to yield an answer. It did not. All around me, here and there, stood houses that might have stepped from the pages of an Eastern fairy tale: the ground floor of stone, pale, with a faint coffee tint, the upper floor of wood, jutting slightly forward, as if the house were bowing to the street. The roofs were crowned with dark-red undulating tiles, and from the chimneys, unhurriedly, without any fuss, rose a light bluish-grey smoke, dissolving into a sky gone white with heat.

A warm, damp wind, smelling of salt and spices and of something else - distant, indefinable - swayed the weathervane on the roof of the house opposite, as it did on all the other houses along the street. Between the windows of the upper storeys, ropes had been strung, and on them, rinsing in the breeze, hung coverlets of the most unimaginable colours: scarlet, ochre, turquoise - as though someone had hung the very rainbow out to dry, cut into ragged strips. Some windows had no glass at all - they were curtained with carpets or thick cloth; others stood flung wide open, and from their half-darkness came smells that, against my will, set my stomach aching. Roast meat. Fresh bread. Something spiced and tantalising whose name I did not know.

So, it was midday. And I was hungry - though, curse it, I could not remember whether I had ever eaten at all in my life, or whether this hunger was as unfamiliar to me as my own name.

Children raced along the street - shouting, laughing, with no visible purpose, as children run everywhere and always, in every age and every country. Two boys drove a wooden hoop ahead of them with a stick, and the hoop, bouncing over the uneven stones, rattled as if a tiny chariot were rolling down the road. A girl of about six, with braids tied up in red thread, sat on a doorstep feeding something from her palm to a mangy ginger cat, which accepted the treat with the air of a queen condescending to her subjects. The grown-ups strolled at a stately pace, greeting one another with a brief nod and a hand laid to the chest; someone older had settled in the shade of a cornice and was playing a game faintly resembling draughts - or perhaps backgammon, I was not sure, my memory refused to supply even so small a thing. The occasional passer-by smiled at me warmly and said something in a language of which I did not understand a single syllable - but from the warmth of their glances I guessed that the words were kind.

Who am I and where am I - again, more insistently now, I asked myself. I do not remember... I do not know... or do I not wish to remember? Neither my name, nor the city, nor the purpose of my journey. And why, devil take it, was I dressed so strangely?

I looked myself over - as if seeing myself for the first time. Soft suede boots of burgundy colour, with a dainty bow. A dark-red turban with a tassel. Trousers of an indigo so deep, so nearly black, that they seemed a starless night sky, for some reason pulled over the middle of a sunlit day. A white shirt. A leather belt. And over it all, a light travelling cloak on a soft silk lining, too elegant, perhaps, for a walk on foot through a port town.

The clothes told me absolutely nothing. They merely doubled the number of questions without giving a single answer.

Perhaps my pockets would prove more talkative? I thrust my hand into the right pocket of my trousers and felt two stones there - smooth, almost polished, a little larger than a big bean. One black, one white. I drew them out into the light and turned them between my fingers. There was a strange heaviness in them - not physical, something else, hard to

explain, as though the stones knew far more about me than I knew about myself.

What did they mean? Who had given them to me - or where had I picked them up?

In the left pocket I found a sheet of paper, neatly folded in four - perfectly blank, without a single letter or mark - and several coins bearing strange symbols such as I had never seen before. And deeper still, in a hidden pocket of the cloak, I discovered a small scrap of paper with an inscription in a language resembling Arabic or Farsi, which I could not have read had my life depended on it.

These finds shed not a drop of light on my situation - they only thickened the darkness. Strange money. Two stones. A blank sheet. A mysterious note. I was not even certain whether I could read this language at all - or whether someone else had slipped the note into a pocket that was foreign to me while I was not looking.

And yet, turning the white stone between my fingers, I caught myself in a feeling for which it was hard to find any word other than recognition. As though I had already held this stone - not today, not here, but somewhere, sometime, in a hand that was mine and at the same time belonged, it seemed, to quite another man. The sensation flickered and vanished, leaving only a vague aftertaste, like waking from a dream whose contents are forgotten faster than you can open your eyes.

I shook my head to drive off the delusion, put the stones back in my pocket, and slowly moved on along the winding, narrow, yet in its own way cosy little street.

\* \* \*

“Simit! Taze simit! Sıcak simit!”

A ringing boy’s voice rang out behind me so unexpectedly that I started. Turning, I saw a lad of about twelve - barefoot, in a faded shirt, trousers rolled to the knee, and a tiny round cap that by some miracle stayed on the crown of his head. On his head, right on top of the cap, rested an enormous wooden tray laden with golden-brown rings of bread generously sprinkled with sesame. The boy carried it with that careless, almost acrobatic dexterity with which one carries things that have long



since become part of one's own body: the tray never once swayed, even when the lad leapt over a puddle by the gutter.

The smell of fresh bread, toasted sesame and something sweetish, treacly, struck my nose with such force that my stomach, until then merely grumbling quietly, let out a full-throated howl.

The boy, evidently, heard it. At any rate, he stopped right in front of me, looked over my turban, my cloak, my velvet boots with open interest - and broke into the broad, gap-toothed grin of a man who has scented a profitable customer.

"Buyurun, efendi! Simit?" He deftly lifted one ring from the tray and waved it under my nose as if luring a cat.

"I would gladly," I said, "but I am afraid I do not understand a word."

The boy tilted his head to one side, listening to my speech with the same expression with which one listens to the song of an unfamiliar bird. Then he repeated, louder and slower, as people speak to the deaf or to foreigners - in all the countries of the world, it seems, the same:

"Si-mit. Simit!"

And, for good measure, he took a bite of the ring himself, demonstratively, closing his eyes with exaggerated delight - after which he held the bitten ring out to me.

I could not help laughing. The pantomime was so expressive that no translation was needed.

"I see," I said. "This is eaten. This is delicious. And you want me to pay for it."

I thrust my hand into my left pocket and fished out one of the strange coins - small, yellowish, with an incomprehensible sign on one side and something like interlaced lines on the other. I held it out to the boy.

He took the coin between two fingers, brought it right up to his nose, turned it over, held it up to the light, and then, to my astonishment, briskly bit it with his teeth - and frowned thoughtfully. He said something - questioningly, jabbing a finger at the sign on the coin. I spread my hands. He said something more, now with a note of suspicion, and called to someone over his shoulder, loudly, for the whole street to hear:

"Hasan Amca! Bak şuna!"

From the shop opposite - tiny, two paces wide, crammed with sacks and baskets of something colourful and fragrant - a man looked out. Heavy-set, in a long robe girdled with a sash, with a full beard dyed with henna a deep russet. He wiped his hands on his robe, unhurriedly crossed the street, took the coin from the boy, looked at it, then at me, then at the coin again.

The shopkeeper began to speak - unhurriedly, resonantly - and I caught surprise in his speech, but not hostility. He showed the coin to the boy, shook his head, explained something, tapping his forehead with a finger - a gesture which, it seemed to me, meant not "this man is mad" but rather "never seen the like, but he must be from far away." Then he returned the coin to me - carefully, with both hands, as though returning something precious - and pointed to the ring in the boy's hand, then to me, and waved his hand. The gesture was unmistakable: take it, no charge.

"No, no," I protested, "I cannot..."

But the shopkeeper had already laid a heavy palm on my shoulder and said something at which the boy, shrugging, pressed into my hands not one but two rings at once - one bitten, the other whole.

"Misafir," said the shopkeeper, poking a finger at me and smiling into his russet beard. "Misafir."

I did not know the word. But by the way he said it - warmly, with a slight solemnity - I guessed that it meant something like "guest." And that a guest here is not expected to pay for bread.

"Thank you," I said, laying my palm on my chest as the passers-by did. "Thank you very much."

The shopkeeper, hearing the unfamiliar sounds, nodded as though he had understood every word, and unhurriedly returned to his sacks. The boy walked beside me a little longer, studying me with undisguised curiosity and murmuring something from time to time - and then, evidently deciding that nothing more could be got out of the oddity in velvet boots, he whistled, adjusted his tray, and dashed off up the street, singing out his ringing "Simit! Taze simit!"

I bit into the whole ring. A crisp crust, a soft, faintly sweet crumb, sesame tickling the palate. The taste was so simple and so perfect that for a moment I closed my eyes. If I had ever eaten anything better, my memory had mercifully spared me the necessity of comparing.

The red-bearded man's shop, as I saw in passing, dealt in spices - and looked as though all the colours of the world had been carted here and poured into sacks. Blood-red pepper in a heap, fiery orange turmeric, dark, almost black cinnamon rolled into little tubes, green cardamom pods, golden saffron in tiny glass vials which the shopkeeper kept on a separate shelf, out of reach of strangers' hands. Over the sacks hung bunches of dried peppers and garlic, and at the very entrance stood a wicker basket filled to the brim with dried figs - dark, wrinkled, with a whitish sugary bloom on their sides.

The red-bearded man, noticing my glance, at once fished the largest fig from the basket and held it out to me. I tried to refuse - I had not even paid for the bread - but he merely shook his hand impatiently, and I gave in. The fig proved soft, honey-sweet, with a thousand tiny seeds crunching between my teeth.

"İncir," said the shopkeeper with pride, as though he had grown it himself.

"Fig," I repeated, and he burst into satisfied laughter, slapping himself on the belly.

At that moment I felt a light, almost weightless touch at my right side.

I lowered my eyes - and saw a small swarthy hand, carefully, with two fingers, creeping into the pocket of my trousers. Where the stones lay.

Without thinking, I seized the slender wrist. Its owner - a grubby boy of about nine, with a shaven head and eyes in which there was not a drop of remorse, only the vexation of a professional caught over a trifle - jerked, trying to break free. A second boy, who had been standing a little way off and was evidently distracting my attention while the first worked, at once took to his heels.

"Oh no," I said, not releasing the wrist. "That is mine. It seems to be the only thing I have at all."

The boy shouted something - judging by the tone, by no means an apology. But before I could decide what to do with him, the red-bearded shopkeeper popped up from behind his sacks with a nimbleness unexpected for his build and brought down upon the thief a whole torrent

of words - loud, rolling, at which all the lad's insolence vanished at once. The boy shrank, lowered his head. The shopkeeper finished his tirade, dealt him a ringing cuff on the back of the head, and nodded to me: let go.

I loosened my fingers. The thief sprang back a pace, rubbed his wrist, shot me a quick glance - and suddenly, to my surprise, awkwardly laid his hand to his chest and muttered something short. Then he turned and vanished into the crowd.

The shopkeeper turned to me and began to speak - now apologetically, shaking his head and spreading his hands. I did not understand the words, but the sense was clear: he was ashamed of his street before a guest.

"It is nothing," I said, patting my pocket, where the stones lay still in their place. "Nothing is missing. All is well."

He understood, it seems, only the intonation - and that proved enough. He nodded, smiled again into his russet beard, and pressed another fig into my hand - evidently as compensation for the ordeal.

I walked on, chewing the honeyed fruit, and thought that of all the things lying in my pockets - the strange coins, the blank sheet, the mysterious note - the thief had reached precisely for the stones. Chance? Most likely. The boy had simply felt something heavy in the pocket and hoped it was gold. And yet I caught myself keeping my right hand in my pocket all the way to the end of the street, clutching both stones in my palm as though they might run away of their own accord.

\* \* \*

The lane swerved, and before me opened a small square with a stone fountain in the middle - cracked, mossy, but still faithfully letting fall a thin thread of water into a rounded basin. Above the basin, on a marble slab, an inscription was carved - the same script, graceful, flowing, like that on my note, though not quite: the letters here were larger, bolder, chiselled by the hand of a master who knew no haste. I looked at it for a long time, trying to find even one familiar stroke - and found none. The inscription was as stubbornly silent as my memory.

Several women were drawing water into clay pitchers, conversing among themselves in low, sing-song voices. At my approach they fell

silent and stepped back, lowering their heads - and I, not knowing why, stepped back too, letting them finish, as one does, presumably, everywhere that others' customs are respected.

One of them, however, did not move away. An old woman - judging by her bent back and the thin, root-like fingers holding the pitcher - a very ancient old woman, muffled in dark cloth from head to foot so that only her eyes could be seen. Those eyes, faded, watery, looked straight at me - long, intently, unblinking.

I smiled awkwardly and nodded to her. She did not return the nod. Instead she set the pitcher on the edge of the fountain, slowly raised her hand, and folded her fingers into a strange sign - spreading them like a fan, palm toward me. Then she muttered a few words, spat over her shoulder - three times, distinctly - and, picking up the pitcher, hobbled away, glancing back again and again.

The other women exchanged looks. One of them, younger, said something quietly, reproachfully, after the old woman, then cast me a quick apologetic glance and lowered her eyes again.

I stood at the fountain, not knowing what to think. The gesture was too eloquent to be mistaken: this is how one wards off the evil eye. This is how one defends oneself against what seems incomprehensible and therefore dangerous. What had this old woman seen in me? A stranger in an overly costly cloak? A foreigner whose speech grates on the ear? Or - an absurd thought, but it came of itself, uninvited - something else, which the others did not see? Something that I myself did not yet see?

I drove the thought away. Old women in all countries must be alike: they fancy the evil eye everywhere.

When the women had gone, I at last scooped up some water in my palm and raised it to my lips. The water was cool and strangely sweetish, as though something had been dissolved in it for which there is no name in any language.

“Su! Buz gibi su!”

From around the corner, clinking like a walking belfry, came a water-seller - a dry, sinewy old man with an enormous copper vessel on his back, its curved neck thrown over his shoulder. At his belt hung tin cups polished to a shine, and at every step they chimed out something like a simple tune. Seeing that I was drinking from the fountain, he stopped, shook his head reproachfully and said something - judging by

his gestures, to the effect that drinking from the fountain was the way of the poor, and a respectable gentleman ought to drink from his vessel, where the water was both colder and sweeter and, one must suppose, dearer.

I showed him my empty palms - no money - and he, shrugging, without any offence moved on, jingling his cups and calling out across the whole square: “Su! Buz gibi su!” It seemed that on this street no one knew how to take real offence.

Somewhere far off, beyond the roofs, a steamer’s whistle bellowed, long, with a deep, lingering echo. Water somewhere near - not only in the fountain. A sea? A strait? A navigable bay? For a moment, shreds of something - memories or merely sensations - stirred in me, connected with ships, with the salt wind, with a deck underfoot - bright as a flash of rainbow, and as fleeting. Before I could seize them, they melted without a trace, leaving only the vexation of a man who has not been allowed to finish reading a letter.

Another sensation flickered after the first - no longer about ships. Someone’s face, blurred, as though seen through a depth of water or through the years. I had no time to make out its features - neither the line of the cheekbones nor the colour of the eyes - but along with this vague image came a feeling to which I could not have given a name: not quite warmth, not quite alarm, perhaps both at once, twisted into one tight knot somewhere beneath my ribs. I froze, tried to hold the image, to look closer - but it slipped away as swiftly as the steamer’s whistle had dissolved in the scorched air of the square, leaving behind only the echo of something for which I could find neither cause nor name.

Strange, I thought, moving away from the fountain. Not to remember one’s own name is cruel enough in itself. But never to understand what troubles you in a face you scarcely had time to glimpse - that is cruelty of another, quieter kind.

\* \* \*

Beyond the square the street plunged steeply downward, and between the houses, through a gap, water suddenly opened up.

I stopped, astonished. There below lay a sea - or not a sea but a wide strait, deep blue, almost violet in the noon light, flecked with the white

triangles of sails and the dark spots of boats. Over the water, lazily, aslant, trailed a black tail of smoke - the very steamer whose whistle I had heard - and on the opposite shore, in a bluish haze, another city rose: hills thickly covered with houses, and above them - domes. Huge, heavy, leaden-grey domes, surrounded by towers thin as needles. One, another, a third - I lost count. They pierced the whitish sky with such imperturbable assurance, as though they had stood here since the creation of the world and meant to stand until its end.

I did not know what city it was. I did not know what this water was called. I did not know whose domes those were, or to whom they prayed beneath them. But looking at it all - at the blue, the sails, the needles of the towers - I suddenly felt something that took my breath away: not even recognition, but something greater and at the same time less definite. As if this city, which I did not know, knew me. As if it were looking at me from across the strait - patiently, without surprise, as one looks at a traveller who has at last returned after a long absence.

Beside me, on a low stone wall, sat an old man in a worn robe, leisurely smoking a long pipe. Noticing how I had frozen, he followed my gaze, then looked at me - and smiled understandingly.

“Güzel, değil mi?” he said, pointing with his pipe at the strait.

I did not understand the words. But I understood the meaning - it was in his voice, in his smile, in the way he looked at the water.

“Beautiful,” I answered. “Very beautiful.”

The old man nodded as though we had understood each other perfectly, and drew on his pipe again. We looked at the water together in silence - two strangers without a single word in common - and it seemed to me for a moment that this was the most meaningful conversation I had had all that morning.

\* \* \*

I moved forward again, trying to distract myself from thoughts too heavy for so sunny a day. The passers-by continued to nod and smile at me; I tried to reply in kind, with a broad, open smile which, judging by the reaction of those I met, made the most favourable impression on them - perhaps the only thing of which I could now be certain.

I was definitely missing something in my hands - perhaps a walking stick. Not that I needed it physically: my legs carried me lightly and freely. But some forgotten feeling suggested that a cane was an integral part of my everyday appearance, a detail without which the costume seemed incomplete, like a sentence without its last word.

As for the appearance of the other passers-by - the men were dressed almost as I was, differing only in the colour and quality of the cloth. The same burgundy turbans with tassels, trousers of every shade, white shirts girded with plain cloth belts of black or red. Their footwear, however, differed markedly from mine - leather coarse to look at, stiff, uncomfortable - though neat and well kept.

No one wore a cloak. Still, I thought, who would muffle himself in a travelling cloak while strolling by his own doorstep?

Women were seen rarely and were covered from head to foot in dark garments, remotely resembling the Indian sari - with the difference that here not only the hair was hidden, but the face as well, and the hands, absolutely everything that could be hidden from strangers' eyes.

At the open door of a barber's shop - I guessed its purpose from the copper basin hanging over the entrance - sat a man with lathered cheeks, his head thrown back against the back of a low chair, while the barber, slight and deft, drew a long gleaming razor along his throat and at the same time told some tale at which the customer kept trying to burst out laughing - and each time the barber snatched the razor away with a reproachful exclamation. Seeing me, the barber broke off his work for a moment, ran a professional eye over my chin - evidently assessing the stubble - and beckoned with his razor toward a vacant chair. I hastily shook my head. The barber shrugged with the air of one watching me commit the great mistake of my life, and returned to his customer.

I stopped in the middle of the street. It was time to admit the obvious: I was in one of the port cities of the Near East - where seas, caravan routes and continents meet, where merchants of every tongue and faith come together. In a city where boys sell bread from trays on their heads, where shopkeepers treat strangers to sweets, where thieves apologise with a hand pressed to the heart, and where old women ward off the evil eye from foreigners.

In a city that, it seemed, knew me better than I knew myself.



Of all the houses along the street, my eye singled out one - with bright-red tiles, evidently recently re-laid, with the wooden cladding of the upper floor covered in glossy lacquer, and a ground floor of pale, faintly coffee-coloured stone. Something about this house - perhaps the neatness with which it was built, or perhaps something less explicable - disposed me toward it for no visible reason that I could put into words.

Right by the entrance, a little to one side of the road, on the lush green grass, a magnificent carpet runner had been spread - an old one, judging by the intricate pattern depicting flowers and plants such as I had never seen before even in my boldest (though entirely forgotten) dreams. A company had settled on the carpet: two elderly men with grey beards, in warm robes and skullcaps, and three young men bustling around them, receiving from time to time brief, good-natured remarks from the elders. Between the old men stood a large wooden box carved with patterns - looking closer, I recognised in it a backgammon set: those very dice and counters which, it seemed, I had already seen twice that morning, though I could not once have explained how I knew the word at all.

One of the old men clicked the dice, dropped a phrase - quiet but commanding - and the young men bustled obediently, pouring something steaming from a tall copper kettle into small glass tumblers.

I moved toward them, feeling resolve strengthening in me - or perhaps merely the despair of a man left with no option but to trust the first benevolent faces he meets. This street had already proved to me twice that benevolence here was not a rarity but a custom. As I walked I took out of my pocket once more the scrap of paper with the incomprehensible inscription, hoping - without much reason - that someone here would be able to help me.

And then, at the very edge of vision, where the narrow lane turned around the corner of a house with blue shutters, a figure flickered.

Grey - not in the colour of its clothes, but as though wholly, from head to foot, moulded of ash and mist - it stood motionless in the shadow of an arch, and it seemed to me that it was looking straight at me, intently, with no friendliness in its gaze, which I, however, scarcely made out - too quickly, too far.

I blinked. The figure was gone. Only the shadow of the cornice and a light shimmer of noonday heat trembling above the scorching paving stones - the most ordinary optical illusion, of which any man must surely suffer who has spent too long in the heat with not a single thought in his head about who he is.

"It only seemed so," I told myself as confidently as I could.

And yet I could not help recalling the old woman at the fountain, her splayed fingers and the three spits over her shoulder. Perhaps, I thought, she had seen not me. Perhaps she had seen what stood behind my back.

The inner voice - the very one that two minutes earlier had refused to console me with any explanation regarding the stones - did not trouble to answer at all. Which was, perhaps, more eloquent than any reply.

Shaking my head for the second time that mad morning, I banished the ominous shadow to the farthest corner of my mind - to the same place where the nameless face, the vague yearning and the shreds of ship memories already lay - and resolutely made my way toward the old men seated on the carpet in the shade of the hospitable house, to obtain at last some answer, however modest, to the question that had tormented me from the very moment I had found myself in the middle of this strange, warm street that smelled of the sea and of spices.

## **Vision I. Luxor**

We were walking - this I remember with perfect clarity, though everything else about that day grows hazier each time I try to recall it, as if my memory had agreed to keep one single detail in exchange for the whole. We were walking.

But before that - before that, there was the river.

I remember it the way one remembers the face of a dying man: not whole, but feature by feature, each more painful than the last. The Nile, which at this season ought to have been full and heavy, turbid with the silt that brings life to the fields, flowed in a narrow, weary ribbon down the middle of its immeasurably wide bed. Its banks lay bare and cracked on either side, like old ribs - grey shoals strewn with abandoned boats bleached by the sun, and herons standing knee-deep in the mud, too emaciated to take wing at our approach.

And down this dying river sailed a god.

A golden barque, shining so brightly that it hurt to look at it, glided ahead, drawn on ropes by two dozen oarsmen in the smaller boats. On the barque, beneath a canopy of the finest linen, in a closed shrine like a carved ark, stood a statue - I did not see it, no one saw it but the initiated - yet I knew it was there, as one knows of a heart one cannot see. After it came the barque of the queen of the gods, and after hers the barque of their son, and only then, a little apart, as is fitting for a mortal, though a living god - mine.

A festival. I remember that it was a festival. I remember the music - it drifted from the banks, from somewhere behind the palms, where crowds, in spite of the hunger, in spite of the drought, had gathered to watch the god sail to his southern home. Tambourines. The rattle of sistra, jingling like scattered silver. Flutes spinning out something high

and thin, almost plaintive. And above it all, the singing of women, long and drawn out, now merging into a single voice, now breaking apart into hundreds.

“My Pharaoh,” said the helmsman of my barque, an old man with a face like sycamore bark, leaning toward me so that the rowers should not hear. “Allow me to speak a word that, perhaps, ought not to be spoken.”

“Speak,” I answered. I remember that I answered precisely so. I remember my own voice - even, calm, as a Pharaoh’s voice should be at a festival.

“I have steered barques on this river since the day my beard began to grow,” said the helmsman. “And never once have I seen a god travel south on water so shallow. Twice this morning the god’s barque ran aground on a shoal. Twice the rowers hauled it free with their hands, waist-deep in the silt.” He fell silent for a moment, looking at the golden radiance ahead. “The old men among us say: if the god does not wish to go, he should not be dragged.”

“And if the god wishes it, but the river will not let him?” I asked.

The helmsman looked at me for a long time, and in his faded eyes there flickered something I did not then understand, and which now, years and lives later, I understand all too well: pity.

“Then, my Pharaoh,” he said quietly, “one must ask oneself whose will it is - the god’s, or that of those who hold the ropes.”

He did not say another word until we reached Luxor.

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I remember the landing. I remember how the barque nosed against the stone steps that led down to the water - steps which in good years went almost entirely under, and which now stood exposed to their very foundations, covered in green slime and dried shells. I remember the crowd on the bank - thousands of faces turned toward me, thousands of hands reaching upward. Hungry faces. Wasted hands. People cried out, threw themselves on their faces, held out their children to me - so that the Pharaoh’s shadow might fall on them and bring good fortune.

I remember that I walked through that crowd along a living corridor cleared before me by the guard - and that this guard was not the usual one. The faces were strangers’. The shields were the same, the spears the

same, but the faces were strangers'. I remember that I noticed this and paid it no heed - or paid it heed, but decided that in the bustle of the festival the detachments had got mixed up, as everything gets mixed up at a festival.

From the landing to the temple ran an avenue of sphinxes - long and straight as a drawn bowstring, receding into the distance between two endless rows of stone beasts with the bodies of lions and the heads of rams. They lay on their plinths with their paws drawn in, and gazed at one another across the road - for thousands of years they had gazed, unblinking, as sentinels gaze who need neither sleep nor food nor to ask questions. Between the forepaws of each stood a small figure - a king, guarded by the beast - and in the slanting evening light it seemed that the beasts were pressing those small kings to their breasts, as mothers press their children.

The crowd pressed in on both sides of the avenue, behind the backs of the sphinxes, and at one moment a woman broke through the guard. Thin, in a sun-faded dress, with a child in her arms - a boy of about three, motionless, with closed eyes and dry, cracked lips. A guardsman swung the shaft of his spear at her, but I raised my hand, and he froze.

"My Pharaoh," the woman whispered, falling to her knees directly on the scorching flagstones. "He has not opened his eyes for three days. The healer said that only a god could help. Or you."

I remember how I looked at the child. I remember his lashes - long, still - and the thin vein in his neck, beating so faintly that it was barely visible. I knew that I was not a god. I knew it as clearly as I knew that I must do what was expected of me. I bent down and touched his forehead with my palm.

The forehead was hot. The child did not open his eyes.

"Take him to the priests of the House of Life," I said to the woman. "Tell them the Pharaoh commanded that he be treated as the children of the palace are treated. Tell them I shall ask after him tomorrow."

Tomorrow. I remember how I spoke that word - and I remember that even then, at that very instant, something within me said, quietly and distinctly: there will be no tomorrow. I drove the thought away. The woman crawled back into the crowd, pressing the child to her breast and repeating my name like a prayer. I never learned what became of the boy.

Somewhere in the crowd, at the foot of one of the sphinxes, sat a blind singer with a small harp on his knees. He plucked the strings and sang, in an aged, cracked, yet strangely pure voice, a song that seemed to be known to everyone around, for people took up individual lines:

“They came down from the Heavens when the earth was empty, They kindled fire, and the water burst into flame, They left us bread, and the Nile, and death - And promised to return, that they might wipe all away.”

I remember how I stopped for a moment upon hearing the last line. I remember how the singer, as if sensing my gaze, turned his sightless face toward me and smiled - toothlessly, serenely, as old men smile who have long ceased to be afraid. I remember that I wanted to ask him where the song came from. And I remember that the guard swept me onward, and the question remained unasked.

Beside me walked a man I knew. An old warrior, stocky, his face scored with scars - the commander of my army. His name in this dream slips away from me like a fish from the hand, though I know that I knew it, that I spoke it hundreds of times, that I trusted him more than anyone at court. He walked at my right hand, and his palm lay on the hilt of his sword - not on the belt, as is proper at a festival, but on the very hilt.

“I do not like this guard, my Pharaoh,” he said under his breath, without turning his head. “Two of the commanders I do not know at all. Their detachments were supposed to have remained in the capital.”

“A festival,” I answered. “At a festival everything gets muddled.”

“At a festival,” he said, “men muddle what they wish to muddle.”

I remember those words. I remember how they settled over me like cold - and how I drove that cold away, because a Pharaoh cannot be afraid in the sight of thousands.

At the temple gates we were met. The enormous pylons, two stone wings, rose before us into the sky, painted with scenes of the victories of long-dead kings, and before them, on either side of the entrance, sat stone giants - my predecessors, or ancestors, or those who were called ancestors - gazing over our heads at the river with that expression of eternal, unruffled calm which belongs only to stone. Before the pylons rose an obelisk - slender, sharp, covered with signs from top to bottom - and its shadow, long as a spear, lay across the square, its point aimed directly at the gates.

At the gates stood priests. Many priests. White robes, shaven heads gleaming in the sunset light, incense smoking in bronze bowls on long handles. And at their head - small, rotund, with a head smooth as polished stone - a priest whose face I remember better than I would wish. He bowed before me lower than all the others had bowed - so low that it resembled mockery.

"Peace be upon you, my Pharaoh," he said, in a voice soft and oily as wax. "The High Priest awaits you in the inner court. The god has arrived at his southern home, and the hour has come when the Pharaoh must appear before him - alone, as the First Ones appeared."

"Alone?" repeated the commander of the army, and steel rang in his voice.

"Only the initiated, honoured sir," replied the rotund priest, without so much as glancing at him. "Such is the custom. For thousands of years. Warriors have no place in the inner court of the god - neither armed nor unarmed."

"My Pharaoh..." The commander turned to me, and for the first time I saw in his face what I had never seen there before: fear. Not for himself. For me. "Allow me to go with you. At least as far as the colonnade. At least as far as the first court."

I remember how long I looked at him. I remember that I wanted to say "yes." I remember that behind him, in the crowd, someone was watching me - an old man leaning on a staff, grey-haired, heavy-set - and shaking his head, slowly, from side to side, as though trying to tell me something without words. I do not know who he was. In this dream I do not remember his name. But I remember his eyes, and I remember that they held the same thing as the eyes of the commander of the army.

"Wait for me here," I said. "At the gates. If I do not come out before moonrise..."

I did not finish. I do not remember why I did not finish. I remember only that the commander of the army clenched the hilt of his sword until his knuckles whitened, and bowed his head - heavily, slowly, as one bows one's head before a sentence.

"I shall be here, my Pharaoh," he said. "Until moonrise. And after."

\* \* \*

Beyond the gates lay the first court, and in it were people whose faces I remember only in snatches, like flashes of lightning above a night river.

I remember a young man in costly garments, with bracelets on both arms, standing by a column with the air of one who does not belong here and knows it. As I passed, his bracelets chimed - he hastily pressed his arm to his side to muffle the sound, and looked away. He did not bow. Or he bowed, but too late. I remember only the chime - thin, melodious, out of place, like laughter at a funeral.

I remember a girl in the robes of a junior priestess - very young, with enormous dark eyes ringed in black paint. She stood among the singers who held the sistra, and she was not singing. She was looking at me. When our eyes met, she shook her head almost imperceptibly - once, twice - and her lips soundlessly formed a single word. I did not catch it. But I knew what word it was. I knew it as one knows in dreams things that cannot possibly be known.

“Do not go.”

The senior priestess beside her, noticing this, jerked her sharply by the arm, and the girl was led away somewhere into the depths, behind the columns, before I could stop. I remember that I wanted to stop. I remember that I did not.

And I remember a young man. Young, slender, dark-eyed, in the plain linen dress of a scribe. He was trying to make his way to me through the crowd of priests - squeezing between the white robes, working his elbows, and his face was twisted with the despair known only to those who are late, and know they are late. He was shouting something - I saw his lips moving - but in the din of sistra, tambourines and singing I could make out no sound. Two priests intercepted him, took him by the arms and drew him back, gently, almost tenderly, as one draws a child away from a fire. He turned to me once more - and tears stood in his eyes.

I remember that look. Of everything that happened that day, I think I remember it most clearly of all. I do not know why. I do not even know who he was. But somehow, recalling that court, I feel neither fear nor cold - but a sharp, almost unbearable sorrow, as though in that moment something had been taken from me that I had never had time to call my own.



The High Priest awaited me in the inner court, by the altar, where incense smoked in bronze bowls - thick, sweet, enough to make the head spin.

He was tall, straight as the obelisk at the gates, and no longer young, though age seemed to have no power over his bearing. His robe was whiter than all the others, and on his chest hung a broad collar bearing the image of the sacred Eye, which seemed to look at me together with his own eyes.

"My Pharaoh," he said, and bowed exactly as far as custom required - not a finger's breadth lower. "The god has arrived at his southern home. I thank you for having escorted him."

"I escort the god every year," I answered. "As my predecessors did."

"As the First Ones did," he corrected gently. "Yes. But this year everything is different. This year the river did not wish to let the god go south. You saw it yourself, my Pharaoh. Twice the barque ran aground."

"I saw."

"The gods speak to us in signs," continued the High Priest, slowly circling the altar, the incense smoke curling about him as if alive. "Drought is a sign. A shallow river is a sign. Famine is a sign. The drought will not relent, my Pharaoh, until the scales are set right anew. For too long one pan has outweighed the other."

"And whose pan, in your opinion, has outweighed?" I asked, though the answer was clear to me in advance, as the answer is clear to a question asked not for the sake of an answer, but to hear whether the other will dare to utter it aloud.

He did not dare. Instead of answering he smiled - with that indulgent, patient smile known only to those who are certain that time works for them and not for you.

"The First Ones, who descended from the Heavens," he said instead, "left us not only the Epic. They left us something else. That which the Pharaoh holds in his hand when he stands before the god in his southern home. That which no Pharaoh has held in his hands for many generations - for none of them was worthy."

He made a sign, and from behind a column came a priest - the same one, rotund and oily - bearing before him a casket of black wood, bound

at the corners with gold. He set the casket on the edge of the altar and withdrew.

The High Priest lifted the lid.

Inside, on a cushion of faded red linen, lay two stones. One black, one white. Smooth as river pebbles, yet perfect - so perfect that they seemed polished not by human hands but by time itself, for hundreds upon hundreds of years. They did not gleam. They seemed to drink in the light of the torches without reflecting it.

"Take them, my Pharaoh," said the High Priest. "So the First Ones did. Take them - and the gods will see who you are."

I remember how I stretched out my hand. I remember how I touched them - and how something passed through my fingers, from fingertips to wrist, that I can call neither warmth nor cold nor pain - something like recognition, as though I had held them before, long ago, in a hand that was mine and yet was not. I remember that I closed my palm around them and did not wish to let them go.

And I remember the High Priest's face at that moment - no, at that instant, for in those days they knew no minutes, but my memory, it seems, muddles the times. He was looking at my palm clenched around the stones, and on his face was an expression I had never seen before in all the years: not triumph, not gloating, but hunger. A naked, ancient hunger, such as belongs to one who has waited too long.

"Come, my Pharaoh," he said. "There is something you must see with your own eyes before we continue this conversation."

And we went.

\* \* \*

I do not remember how long that journey lasted - an instant, an eternity - but I remember distinctly the gigantic columns of Luxor rising before us one after another like a petrified forest, each trunk broader than the arms of ten men could encircle. Their capitals, open like papyrus buds frozen in the eternal blossoming of stone, were lost somewhere in the darkening heights, from which not a single ray of sunset light fell upon us any longer - up there, only night held sway, having descended sooner than it should have descended upon the earth beneath our feet.

Evening had already fallen on Luxor, but in the west the sky still held a narrow band of dull copper light - that peculiar shade seen only here, above the Nile, when the day does not die at once but reluctantly, clinging to the horizon with its last glimmers, as though even the sun were loath to leave this land.

I was the Pharaoh. I knew it as firmly as I knew the weight of the double crown upon my head - and yet in that knowledge there was not a drop of what might be called power. I was surrounded on all sides: priests walked to the left, to the right, behind me, and only ahead, where we were heading, was it empty - frighteningly, deliberately empty, as it is empty before the place to which you are led without being asked for your consent.

The music had been left behind. Sistra, tambourines, flutes, the singing of women - all of it had fallen silent, cut off by the walls as a thread is cut with a knife. Here, between the columns, it was quiet. So quiet that I could hear the shuffle of the priests' bare feet on the stone flags, the crackle of the torches, and my own breathing - uneven, alien, as though it were not I who breathed, but someone within me.

Between the columns the air was different - thicker, heavier, smelling of torch resin and of something else for which I could not then find a name, and which now, in remembering, I do not dare to name again.

"Tell me, High Priest," I said, and my voice sounded unexpectedly loud in that silence, rebounding from the columns and returning to me as an echo. "What is it that I must see?"

"The truth, my Pharaoh," he answered, without turning. He walked ahead, a little to one side, and the torch in the hand of the priest beside him cast trembling russet glints on his white robe. "The truth that the First Ones knew and their descendants forgot. That the Pharaoh is only a vessel. That the power he holds in his hand never belonged to him. That he merely keeps it - until the appointed time."

Until the appointed time. I remember how those words answered within me with a strange, inexplicable echo - as though I had heard them before, as though I should hear them again, in another place, at another time, in another tongue.

"And when the appointed time runs out?" I asked.

The High Priest at last turned. His face in the torchlight was calm - frighteningly calm.

“Then the power returns to the place from which it came, my Pharaoh. To those who are worthy to keep it.”

The priests’ steps, until then resounding and confident, grew shorter. I did not understand why at once - and when I understood, it was already too late to understand anything at all: they were not walking beside me, they were encircling me, closing in tighter with every ten paces, as water closes behind the stern of a boat which that same water will in the end swallow up.

I remember that I looked back. I remember the gates far behind, beyond the forest of columns - a tiny rectangle of sunset sky in which, it seemed to me, stood a stocky silhouette with a sword at its belt. He was waiting. He had promised to wait until moonrise. The moon had not yet risen.

The High Priest was the first to halt - between two columns so enormous that in their shade vanished not only my shadow but, it seemed, all that remained of the evening light which had still been clinging to the horizon a moment before.

“Here,” he said quietly, almost tenderly.

I wanted to ask - what is here, why here - but I did not manage to utter a word. Whether someone behind my back turned too sharply for a man in a peaceful procession, or the flame of a torch held by one of the priests on my right wavered, casting upon the column’s stone a shadow all too like a raised hand, or whether it merely seemed so to me - I cannot say for certain even now, years and, it seems, lives later.

I remember cold. Not the evening cold that descends upon the Valley with the darkness, but another - sharp, concentrated somewhere on the left, beneath the ribs - and the two stones, black and white, suddenly grown heavier in my palm, as if they had absorbed all this cold at once, to keep it from reaching my heart.

I remember that they glowed. Very faintly. Like embers beneath ash.

I do not remember whether anyone struck me. I do not remember whether I cried out. I do not even remember whether I fell - or whether it simply grew dark faster than it should have grown dark even here, among the gigantic columns that so securely hide the sky from the earth.

I remember only one thing - the last, before everything vanished. Far away, beyond the columns, at the gates, someone cried out. A deep, hoarse, desperate cry of a warrior who has realised he is too late. I recognised that voice. I knew that voice. I could not recall the name of the one to whom it belonged - but I knew that he was crying out mine.

And then - darkness. Complete, soundless, without edge or bottom - a darkness into which not even the echo of footsteps reaches, footsteps that only a moment before had seemed to me the most important sound in the world.

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I opened my eyes - and found that I was standing in the middle of a sunlit street, with a scrap of paper in my hand, two paces from old men playing backgammon on a motley carpet.

My heart pounded as though I had truly just been running - or had just died. I raised my free hand to my left side. No wound, no pain. Nothing but the memory of cold, too distinct to be merely a dream - and a question to which I had no answer: had what happened between those columns already happened to me, or had I just seen how it would happen?

I opened my other hand - the one that had been clenched in a fist, I know not since when. Two stones, black and white, lay in it - cool, smooth, silent. Perfectly ordinary. The same as I had found them in my pocket that morning.

I did not know where they had come from. But looking at them, for the first time in all that long, strange morning, I was afraid not that I did not remember the answer - but that somewhere deep within myself, it seemed, I already knew it.

## Chapter II. The Castle of Artemia Aristarkhovna

“You are late, sir,” said Ignatij Savvich, in the tone in which one announces the death of a distant relative: with sorrow, but without superfluous detail.

The old butler stood at the tall double doors of the dining hall as he had stood, no doubt, all his life: erect, grey-haired, in a dark tailcoat with polished buttons, white gloves on his dry hands, and the expression of a man who has seen so many dinner parties in his time that nothing short of the end of the world could surprise him, and even that only if it occurred before the hot course was served.

“Has the turkey been served already?” I asked.

“It has, sir. Madam was pleased to observe that the turkey, unlike certain persons, arrives on time.”

“Auntie said that?”

“Madam expressed herself more briefly, sir. I permitted myself to translate it into language fit for repetition.”

I could not help laughing. Ignatij Savvich allowed himself a barely perceptible twitch at the corner of his lips - the highest degree of merriment he permitted himself on duty - and, straightening the knot of my neckcloth with a movement that held not a drop of servility but only the same calm, long-standing care with which he had, no doubt, straightened everything in this house, he threw open the doors before me.

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The great stone hall received guests as it had received them for more than one decade: with towering vaults drowned in half-darkness, with gigantic chandeliers that rang with crystal at the slightest draught, and

with a fireplace that crackled and spat somewhere at the far end of the hall, filling the air with the resinous, cosy scent of a pine log.

Above the fireplace, in the most prominent place, was displayed the family coat of arms: a predatory bird with wings spread wide, whether an eagle or something more ancient and less heraldically definite, framed by green, feathery branches. The walls were hung with pelts and antlers, interspersed with guns of the most various eras - from flintlocks to quite modern pieces - and the whole collection gave the hall the look not so much of a dining room as of a museum of trophies in which, through some misunderstanding, a supper had been laid.

The table - gigantic, oval, covered with a cloth of such flawless whiteness that it cut the eye no less than the midday sun - stood exactly in the middle, and around it, in the subdued light of the candles, sat a respectable company: the men mostly in military uniform, the ladies in light evening gowns, crowned with hats of feathers and bows that might have stepped straight from the pages of a metropolitan fashion journal. At the side, in a special floor stand, gleamed the set-aside sabres and firearms of the military guests - an object no less refined than the table service itself.

Not counting the servants, who stood frozen along the walls in respectful expectation, I counted eleven persons engaged in unhurried, low-voiced conversation. The table groaned with delicacies: a whole roast turkey on a silver tray of artful chasing, jellied sturgeon trembling under the lamps like amber, pies with vesiga and with mushrooms, mounds of soaked apples, salted saffron milk caps in a crystal vase, vegetables of every sort, bread - white and black, that very black bread which I, for some reason, loved best of all, though I could not have explained this fondness even under torture - and, of course, an enormous, steaming samovar surrounded by dry rings and bagels.

The maid Dunyasha, rosy, round-faced, with a thick flaxen braid coiled around her head, glided between the chairs with a tray, handing round the cordial, and, passing me, managed to whisper without moving her lips: "Master, I've saved you a pie with vesiga, the last one, under the napkin," - and vanished at once, before I could thank her.

My attire that evening was, as usual, predominantly white: beige, slightly snug trousers, a snow-white shirt, a light-grey frock coat of the softest cloth, and my favourite red-and-blue neckerchief, tied at the

throat in an intricate knot - the one liberty I allowed myself in this realm of impeccable etiquette.

"You are late again, mon cher," came a familiar voice from the right, and in the next instant a hand settled familiarly on my shoulder.

Lieutenant Konstantin - in brand-new uniform, fresh from the needle, still retaining that peculiar stiffness of cloth found only in a uniform that has never been caught in the rain - looked at me with the broad, slightly insolent smile that had been his calling card almost from birth.

"I am not late," I objected, sitting down beside him. "I arrived precisely when the turkey was ready to arrive for me."

"A philosopher," he snorted approvingly. "Your aunt has been entertaining Alyosha all evening with tales of your unbearable seclusion. Any moment now she will tell him you live on moonlight alone."

"And what did you answer her?"

"That you live on moonlight only on fast days," said Konstantin imperturbably, piling a slice of turkey onto my plate as if it were his direct duty. "And on the others, on my company. Eat, or you really will turn transparent. I should have no one to travel to the capital with."

I glanced toward the opposite end of the table. Artemia Aristarkhovna, my aunt, sat there in all the splendour of her evening gown - a dark-lilac dress whose only ornament was a string of pearls - and was conducting a lively conversation with the young Lieutenant Alexei, whom she invariably addressed affectionately: Alyosha. He listened to her with that rapt attention usually reserved for very beautiful women or very influential persons - and my aunt, it must be admitted, was both at once.

The grey-haired General Pavel Nikolaevich, who sat at her left hand, listened to this conversation with far less rapture. He kept sipping his tea nervously and snorting into his magnificent, carefully groomed moustache - without once, however, permitting himself a single remark aloud. Lieutenant Alexei, absorbed in the conversation beyond all measure, simply failed to notice the General's reproachful glances, which in my opinion was either the height of innocence or the height of recklessness - depending on what actually bound the General and my aunt, a matter about which no one in the whole house spoke aloud, but which, it seemed, absolutely everyone suspected.



“What do you think,” Konstantin whispered to me, leaning so that his words were meant for me alone, “will the General shoot him before dessert is served, or after?”

“After,” I said gravely. “He is too well bred to spoil the turkey with bloodshed.”

Konstantin snorted into his napkin so unluckily that for a moment the whole table looked in our direction, and I vainly tried to compose my face into the most well-behaved expression of which I was capable.

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To the left of the General sat a lady of venerable years in a lavish white gown and a hat adorned with feathers and emeralds of such size that I could not help wondering whether the hat weighed more than its owner. Evdokia Gerasimovna - Konstantin's aunt, a frequent guest of ours and, by rumour, the object of the General's secret and unrequited (or perhaps requited, but carefully concealed) adoration - sighed at the table no less often than her neighbour, though the reason for her sighs, I suspect, was precisely the same.

Opposite her, on the other side of the General, sat two guests whom I had seen in our house only once before - Nadezhda Porfirievna Kutasova, widow of a provincial marshal of the nobility, a decisive, stout lady with a lorgnette on a chain and a voice capable of drowning out a regimental band, and her daughter Lizonka, a girl of some eighteen years, slight, fair-haired, in a pink dress with so many frills that she resembled a pastry mistakenly seated at table with the guests.

There was no need to guess the purpose of their visit. Nadezhda Porfirievna did not take her lorgnette off the General with the persistence with which a gunner does not take his eyes off an enemy redoubt.

“Pavel Nikolaevich,” she sang out, as soon as the General set down his cup, “my Lizonka was embroidering a tobacco pouch for you the other day. With roses! She heard that you are a great admirer of roses.”

“Exceedingly touched, madam,” replied the General in a voice in which there was exactly as much courtesy as etiquette demanded and not a grain more. “Although, I confess, I have not smoked for twelve years.”

“But one need not smoke!” said Nadezhda Porfirievna, not in the least abashed. “The pouch can be for... for something else. For seeds!

For rose seeds. Lizonka, tell Pavel Nikolaevich which roses you embroidered.”

“T-tea roses, Mamma,” faltered Lizonka, blushing to the very frills.

“Tea roses!” Nadezhda Porfirievna announced triumphantly. “Did you hear, Pavel Nikolaevich? Tea roses!”

“I heard, madam,” said the General. “Tea roses do not set seed. They are propagated by cuttings.”

A silence fell in which one could hear the fire crackling. Evdokia Gerasimovna raised her fan to her face, and it seemed to me that behind the fan she was smiling. Konstantin stepped on my foot under the table with such force that I nearly cried out.

“I cannot bear this,” he whispered in my ear, shaking with silent laughter. “That is the third time this evening he has buried her. One more salvo and the pouch of tea roses will go into the fireplace together with Mamma.”

“Hush,” I hissed, barely restraining myself. “She will hear.”

“She hears nothing but the word ‘general.’ Her ears are tuned to that rank like a hunting dog’s to game.”

Nadezhda Porfirievna, however, did not know how to retreat. Having suffered defeat on the rose front, she immediately shifted her fire - and, to my horror, onto me.

“And you, young man,” she addressed me, levelling her lorgnette, “you, I hear, are a great lover of books? Lizonka adores reading too! Lizonka, say what you are reading now.”

“A Nest of Gentlefolk, Mamma,” whispered Lizonka, looking at her plate.

“A splendid book,” I said, turning to the girl with the most amiable smile I could muster, “though, I admit, its ending is sad. I hope you have not finished it yet, Elizaveta...” I faltered.

The patronymic. I had just heard it - or had I not? Nadezhda Porfirievna was the widow of the marshal, but what was the marshal’s own name? I had been told. I had known it for certain a moment ago - known it as firmly as I knew the name of my own aunt - and now in the place of that knowledge yawned an even, smooth emptiness, as though someone had carefully drawn a single thread out of my memory without disturbing the rest.

The pause dragged on. Lizonka lifted her eyes to me - bewildered, frightened.

“Elizaveta Andreevna,” Konstantin prompted calmly, as though it were the most natural thing in the world. “My friend, madam, became so absorbed in A Nest of Gentlefolk that he forgot which nest he himself is in.”

Everyone laughed. Nadezhda Porfirievna nodded graciously, Lizonka turned pink again, and the conversation rolled on. And I sat looking at my plate and felt a slow chill creeping down my spine. It was a trifle - a forgotten patronymic of a scarcely known young lady, it happens to everyone. And yet in the way it had been forgotten - not faded gradually, as unimportant names fade, but vanished all at once, instantly, as though it had been plucked out - there was something I did not like.

“Thank you,” I whispered to Konstantin.

“Don’t mention it,” he answered, just as quietly, without looking at me. “You are not yourself tonight, mon cher. All evening it is as if you were not here.” And, after a pause, he added in his former, mocking tone: “However, if you take it into your head to forget someone’s name again, I shall be sitting beside you. That is what friends are for: to remember for you when you cannot do it yourself.”

I looked at him. He had already turned away, helping himself to jellied sturgeon, and his face wore its usual carefree expression, as though he had said nothing out of the ordinary. But something in those words - “remember for you” - echoed in me with a strange, warm and at the same time disquieting resonance that I could not have explained.

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“Permit me, permit me, young man,” came a creaking voice with a slight German accent from the other end of the table. “I have been observing you for a quarter of an hour. You are pale as lime, you are rubbing your temple, and you have just forgotten the patronymic of a young lady that was given to you no later than the soup. Is it a headache?”

Doctor Karl Fyodorovich Strauch - an old friend of the house, my aunt’s physician and, in addition, the only man capable of declining a

second slice of pie in her presence - looked at me over his gold spectacles with the professional interest with which an entomologist looks at a rare beetle.

"A trifle, Karl Fyodorovich," I said. "It has ached a little since morning."

"Since morning," repeated the doctor, as though writing it down in an invisible notebook. "And yesterday? And the day before? Have you not had of late... how shall I put it... lapses? Moments when you cannot recall how you came to be in this or that room? Or what you were doing an hour ago?"

It grew quieter at the table. My aunt, breaking off her conversation with Alexei, turned her head in our direction - quickly, too quickly.

"Karl Fyodorovich," she said evenly, "this is a dinner party, not an infirmary reception."

"I beg your pardon, Artemia Aristarkhovna," the doctor bowed slightly but did not take his eyes from me. "Professional habit. Memory is a most peculiar organ, gentlemen. I have treated people for thirty years and still do not understand how it is made. One man remembers what the sky looked like on the day of his christening, yet cannot recall what he ate for breakfast. And another time..." - he paused - "another time a man remembers what never happened to him at all."

"How do you mean, what never happened?" Alexei grew interested.

"Just so, young man. I had patients who described with perfect clarity cities in which they had never been. Streets, smells, faces. One retired major swore that he remembered standing on the deck of a ship bound for shores that are on no map. He described the rigging, the colour of the water, the voices of the sailors. And yet he had never in his life travelled farther than Tula."

I felt the tips of my fingers go cold. The deck of a ship. The salt wind. The shreds that had flickered through my head all that day and which I could neither hold nor explain.

"And how did you treat him?" asked the General with an interest unexpected in him.

"With cold rubdowns and readings of Karamzin, Your Excellency," replied the doctor. "The rubdowns did not help. Neither did Karamzin."

The table laughed, and the awkwardness dispersed. But I noticed that my aunt did not laugh. She looked at Doctor Strauch with a long, heavy

look, which he, it seems, understood perfectly, for he did not once speak of memory again all evening.

\* \* \*

Farther down the table, Colonel Mikhail Ivanovich - husband of the quiet, affable Vera Anatolievna - was just finishing another tale of his martial exploits, twirling his very long, longest of moustaches with the same methodicalness with which some people click the beads on a counting-house abacus.

"...and then," he thundered, addressing himself chiefly to his own plate, "the Turkish battery fired a salvo, and we, imagine, were standing in an open position, without any cover whatever..."

"Misha," Vera Anatolievna interrupted him gently, "might we perhaps let the guests finish their turkey before the battery opens fire?"

The Colonel laughed good-naturedly at his own lack of restraint, and I, taking advantage of the pause, at last turned to the plate I had hardly touched so far - too busy was I observing this small, familiar theatre played out at my aunt's table nearly every other evening. Under the napkin, as promised, I found the pie with vesiga, still warm. I caught Dunyasha's eye by the wall and nodded to her almost imperceptibly; she beamed.

It was at that moment that I noticed Vera Anatolievna's gaze turned upon me.

That gaze lingered on my face a fraction of an instant longer than simple politeness requires - one looks thus not at an acquaintance, but at something vaguely recognisable that one cannot quite recall: perhaps a portrait once seen, perhaps a face from an old, half-forgotten dream. Then she blinked, smiled at me with the most ordinary, social smile, and said:

"You look very pensive today, my friend. Is your aunt not making you read too much of an evening?"

"A little," I answered, trying to make my voice sound light, though that first look of hers had somehow lodged in me like an unpleasant splinter. "I fear I shall soon have to ask her for my wages to buy a new pair of eyes."

She smiled again, this time quite ordinarily, and the conversation flowed safely on, to some fashionable new novels brought from Paris or perhaps London - but for some time I kept stealing glances in her direction, trying to understand what exactly I had fancied in that first, overlong look. No explanation presented itself. The list of my inexplicable things today, however, had already swollen to indecent proportions, so I decided to set this riddle aside for the time being in the same place where all the others already rested - until better, clearer times.

The General, taking advantage of the fact that the conversation had turned away from Alexei, thought it possible to put in a remark of his own - as always, terse and to the point.

"The Porte is troubled again," he said, addressing no one in particular, though it was evident that the phrase was directed first of all at the Colonel, the only one at the table capable of appreciating its weight. "The Sultan again asks for assistance. I fear that before a year is out I shall have to pack for Constantinople once more."

At that word - Constantinople - something strange stirred in me: not a memory, no, rather the echo of a memory, a distant reverberation of a narrow lane smelling of the sea and spices, of a carpet with a strange pattern, of two grey-bearded old men at a game of backgammon. I blinked, driving off the delusion - it too closely resembled the earlier feeling at the fountain for me to wish its repetition - and tried to concentrate on the turkey.

"You travel too often to those parts, Pavel Nikolaevich," my aunt intervened, and a shade of real, unfeigned anxiety flickered in her voice. "One day I shall cease to be surprised if you announce to me that you have decided to settle there altogether."

"Duty, Artemia Aristarkhovna," replied the General with dignity, "seldom asks our consent as to the route."

"As does life in general," Konstantin put in with feigned philosophical air, for which he promptly earned from his aunt Evdokia Gerasimovna a ringing slap of the fan on the hand.

"Constantinople!" Nadezhda Porfirievna clasped her hands, scenting a new breach in the defences. "Ah, Pavel Nikolaevich, how I should dream of seeing Constantinople! Lizonka, would you like to see Constantinople?"

"It is said to be very hot there, Mamma," whispered Lizonka.

“Hot, madam,” confirmed the General. “And dusty. And dogs everywhere. And, I venture to assure you, absolutely no tea roses.”

Evdokia Gerasimovna, behind her fan, emitted a sound which, with a certain indulgence, might be taken for a cough.

\* \* \*

When dessert was served - blancmange trembling on its dish, cranberry kissel, and pastila brought, as my aunt announced with pride, from Kolomna itself - Evdokia Gerasimovna suddenly snapped her fan shut and declared to the whole table:

“Lizonka, my dear, you play charmingly, they say! Will you not delight us?”

Nadezhda Porfirievna beamed as though she had been awarded a decoration. Lizonka flushed, protested, was persuaded, escorted to the piano standing in the corner of the hall beneath the portrait of some stern-eyed ancestor in a powdered wig - and, after hesitating, touched the keys.

She played a romance. I did not know its name - or I knew it, but this evening, evidently, my memory had decided to give me nothing for free. The melody was simple, a little sad, and Lizonka, forgetting her shyness, played it unexpectedly well - with the sincerity of those people to whom it is easier to speak in music than in words. The hall fell quiet. Even Nadezhda Porfirievna lowered her lorgnette. The General, leaning back in his chair, gazed somewhere into the fire of the hearth, and his face, usually so impenetrable, became for a moment strangely young and defenceless. I noticed that Evdokia Gerasimovna was looking not at Lizonka, but at him.

And suddenly, in the midst of that melody, I smelled a scent.

Salt. Spices. Sun-warmed stone. It came from nowhere - not from an open window, the windows were closed, not from the kitchen, where nothing of the kind was being cooked - it simply arose, filled for an instant my whole being and at once vanished, leaving in my mouth the aftertaste of something sweet, honeyed, like a dried fig. The music went on playing. No one around noticed anything.

I raised my palm to my temple. The headache that had plagued me all evening grew sharper.

“You are going away again,” Konstantin said softly, without turning his head. “I see how you go away. Where do you go, mon cher?”

“Nowhere,” I answered. “Just my head.”

He said nothing. But I felt his shoulder - in the stiff, new cloth of his uniform - touch mine for a moment and linger a little longer than chance required. As though he were checking whether I was still here.

Lizonka finished. The hall applauded - sincerely, even the General. Nadezhda Porfirievna wiped away a tear with a lace handkerchief and repeated: “My Lizonka! My little dove!” Doctor Strauch, clapping, watched me closely over his spectacles.

\* \* \*

The evening flowed on in its customary course - laughter, the clink of dishes, snatches of conversation about new books, about the prospects of the harvest, about which of the capital’s young ladies had made the better marriage this season. I listened with half an ear, now and then putting in a remark when I felt that my silence was becoming too noticeable - and when Konstantin, inspired, began to question me about some book on heraldry that I had been leafing through in the library the other day, I caught myself talking for almost a quarter of an hour on end, unable to stop, until I noticed that the whole company had long since moved on to another subject, while I was still enthusiastically telling Konstantin the history of family coats of arms, which no one but him, it seemed, had any intention of listening to.

“You are sometimes perfectly insufferable,” he remarked with undisguised pleasure, “one moment you cannot be drawn out with pincers, the next you cannot be silenced.”

“Then I am unpredictable,” I answered. “That is far more interesting than being predictable.”

“More interesting,” agreed Konstantin. “But more tiring. Especially for those who try to guess what you will be like tomorrow.”

“And do you try?”

He looked at me - for a moment seriously, without his usual smirk - and at once looked away, reaching for a bagel.

“Hardly,” he said. “As if I had nothing better to do.”



The supper, which had apparently been going on for more than an hour, began at last to incline toward its natural end. The headache that had plagued me almost from the very beginning of the evening had grown so much that I thought it best to take my leave before it turned into something more serious.

"Auntie," I said, rising and approaching Artemia Aristarkhovna, "forgive me, but my head today flatly refuses to serve me any longer. Allow me to wish you good night."

She held out her hand for me to kiss - a gesture which over the long years had become almost a ritual between us - and I touched my lips to the thin, ring-laden fingers.

"Go and rest, my friend," she said with that warmth that was meant for me alone and for no one else at that table. "You are too pale today. Karl Fyodorovich is right, though I shall not allow him to say so at dinner."

Then, lowering her voice so much that only I and, perhaps, the General, who sat closer than the rest, could hear, she added - half in jest, half in earnest, with that strange, fleeting sadness which occasionally, against her will, showed in her face whenever the conversation touched, even by its edge, upon the past:

"Do not wander too far along the corridors tonight, do you hear? This castle is older than it seems, and it has, believe me, places that are better left in peace."

"Places?" I asked, involuntarily smiling at so unexpected a warning. "Are you frightening me with family ghosts, Auntie?"

She looked at me for a long moment - and in that look flashed something I had never before noticed in her: not fear, but something neighbouring on fear, the memory of something she would have preferred never to recall.

The General, sitting beside her, slowly lowered his cup onto its saucer. The sound was very quiet - but in the pause that fell between us it rang out like the click of a cocking hammer. I noticed that the General was looking not at me but at my aunt, and that in his look was a question to which she, almost imperceptibly, shook her head.

"Let us leave it," she said at last, restoring lightness to her voice. "It is late, my friend. Go to sleep."

Already on my way to the door, I caught myself in a thought that seemed to me almost sacrilegious: I knew, in essence, nothing of our kinship but the very word “aunt,” by which I had called her since I could remember. Never once had she told me whose sister she was - my mother’s or my father’s. Never once had she shown me a portrait or a letter that would confirm this relationship by anything other than her love for me and my faith in her words. The thought, scarcely arisen, seemed to me absurd and ungrateful, and I hastened to be rid of it - but to be rid of it entirely, it seems, I did not quite succeed.

I bowed to the esteemed company, received parting wishes of good night from the General, the Colonel, Doctor Strauch and Konstantin - the last of whom, however, contrived to shout after me something remarkably spiteful, which I had no time to make out - and left the hall for the dimly lit corridor.

Ignatiy Savvich, standing at the doors just as erect, as though in all those hours he had not moved an inch, handed me a lighted candle in a copper candlestick.

“Shall I see you to your room, sir?”

“There is no need, Ignatiy Savvich. I know the way.”

The old man paused. Then he said - evenly, without changing the expression of his face, as though reporting the weather:

“Madam bade me give her regards and remind you: the left wing is locked for the night. Draughts, sir. An old house.”

“Draughts,” I repeated.

“Precisely so, sir,” said Ignatiy Savvich, and looked at me as one looks at a man to whom something has been said and who, regrettably, will most likely not obey. “Good night.”

I took the candle and went along the corridor, carrying with me not only the heaviness in my temples but also the strange, itching aftertaste of my aunt’s words, lodged somewhere on the very border of consciousness, in the same place where all my inexplicable anxieties of that day had settled.

This castle is older than it seems.

I could not know that evening how soon I should be convinced of the truth of those words - and how bitterly I should regret it.

## Chapter III. Pharaoh Menes

Peals of thunder, dry and waterless, had been rolling over the Empire since noon - a storm that would never break into rain, only into dust and stifling heat, as so often happened here in the Valley whenever the earth had waited too long for water and at last began to be angry at the sky for its silence. The red, heavy sun crept across the heavens slowly, as if reluctantly, and its hot rays licked the massive stone walls of the Palace as though tasting them before swallowing.

I sat on the throne - golden, enormous, studded with stones brought from the farthest reaches of the Empire - and listened to the headache that had plagued me for days on end, like an importunate petitioner unwilling to leave without an answer.

The bustle behind the doors did not cease for an instant: servants, slaves, priests with their endless prayers and requests - all that mechanism of power which revolved around me day and night, never asking whether I wished to be its axis.

\* \* \*

“Do not move, my Pharaoh. The crocodile god does not like to be hurried.”

The healer Hesira, a small, wizened old man with hands smelling of myrrh and honey, was winding a strip of fine linen around my head for the third time that morning. To the cloth, right above my forehead, a tiny clay crocodile was fastened - no longer than a finger, with gaping jaws into which Hesira, with all the solemnity of which he was capable, had placed a few grains of barley.

“Are you certain this will help?” I asked, trying not to move, as I had been told.

"I am certain of nothing, my Pharaoh," answered Hesira, with that serene honesty which alone allowed him to remain court healer under three Pharaohs in succession. "But this is how headaches were treated under the former sovereigns, and under the sovereigns before them. The crocodile holds the grain in its jaws, the grain holds the pain, and the linen holds the crocodile. If the pain does not leave, it means that it is stronger than the crocodile. Then we shall try honey with poppy."

"And if the poppy does not help either?"

"Then, my Pharaoh," Hesira tightened the last knot and stepped back, admiring his work, "I shall ask you what I ought to have asked from the very beginning. When did it begin? This pain."

I thought. The question was a simple one - the simplest of all that had been put to me that morning. And I did not know the answer.

"I do not remember," I said at last. "It seems it has always been."

Hesira gave me a long, attentive look - the look with which healers regard not the wound but the man who bears it.

"Always," he repeated quietly. "That is what they say, my Pharaoh, whose pain is not in the head. The head only transmits. Like a messenger who brings the tidings but does not write them."

"Who writes them, then?"

"That," said Hesira, gathering the vials and pouches of herbs into his chest, "is written in none of the healers' scrolls. Perhaps one should ask not a healer, but a dream. Dreams sometimes know what we do not."

He bowed and went out, leaving me with a clay crocodile on my brow and the feeling that I had just been examined far more deeply than I wished.

\* \* \*

The Vizier Ptahhotep appeared with his report as he had appeared every morning throughout my reign - tall, thin, stooped from long years of bending over scrolls, with a face on which perpetual care had carved wrinkles deeper than age. Behind him two scribes carried baskets full of papyri, and I, seeing those baskets, could not help sighing. Ptahhotep's baskets were never light - not in good years, and still less in bad.

"My Pharaoh," he began, bowing, and at once lifted his eyes to my forehead. "I see that Hesira has again called the crocodile to his aid."

“Hesira says the pain is stronger than the crocodile,” I answered. “Let us see whether it is stronger than your baskets. Begin.”

Ptahhotep unrolled the first scroll.

“The border lands, my Pharaoh. At the Far Outposts, four raids in the past moon. Desert brigands drove off two hundred head of cattle from the village of Abu, burned a granary - fortunately an empty one - and carried off three children. The Outpost recovered the children on the third day, but the cattle were not returned.”

“Southerners?”

“Not only. The southern country, still formally at peace, from time to time disturbs our southern frontiers with short raids - not bold enough to be called war, but frequent enough to keep the border garrisons in perpetual tension. Each time our warriors repulse them, and the uninvited guests flee, abandoning wagons, weapons and horses.” Ptahhotep raised his eyes from the scroll. “But each time, my Pharaoh, they return. And each time a little bolder.”

“You report this to me as though announcing not a victory but a reprieve.”

“Because that is what it is, my Pharaoh,” said Ptahhotep without a shadow of embarrassment. “The southerners are testing how weak we are. The drought makes us weaker with every month. Sooner or later they will come not with a band of brigands but with an army.”

He unrolled the second scroll.

“The granaries. The stores in the capital’s granaries are sufficient for three seasons at the present rate of distribution. In the granaries of the Delta, for two. In the Upper Land, for less than one. This year’s harvest...” - he hesitated - “this year’s harvest, my Pharaoh, in essence, does not exist. What was gathered barely covers the seed grain.”

“And the temple granaries?”

Ptahhotep pursed his lips - barely perceptibly, but I noticed.

“The temple granaries are not accountable to me, my Pharaoh. As you know. But I can tell you what my scribes see on the roads.” He unrolled a third scroll, smaller, covered in a hurried, uneven hand. “The peasants carry grain to the temples. The last of it. Not to the royal granaries - to the temples. Because the Temple promises them prayer, and the granary only a reckoning. And those who have no grain left at all carry the temples their land.”

“Land?”

“The Temple buys up the allotments of the starving, my Pharaoh. For bread. A sack of grain for a field that fed a family for three generations. People agree because a sack of grain today weighs more than a field that bears nothing. In a single nome of the Delta alone, my scribes have counted forty-two such allotments in the last two moons.”

I was silent for a long time. The clay crocodile on my brow suddenly seemed unbearably heavy.

“Forty-two allotments,” I repeated. “In two moons. In one nome.”

“In one nome of which I know, my Pharaoh. Of the others I have not yet been informed.”

“Who buys on behalf of the Temple?”

“The Temple’s scribes, my Pharaoh. Under the seal of the High Priest.”

Priests. I pronounced the word to myself without hatred - rather with the weariness of a man who has watched the same play too many times to be surprised by a twist of the plot. Ever thirsting for more: gold, lands, obedience. In secret - and sometimes no longer so secretly - they dreamed of ruling themselves, and for the sake of that dream were ready for any cunning, any patient, years-long weaving of the threads from which a noose would one day be woven. And now the drought, which no one could command - neither Pharaoh, nor Temple, nor the gods themselves - was putting into their hands what no cunning could have obtained for them: land. Sack by sack. Field by field.

“Ptahhotep,” I said. “Is it possible to forbid the Temple from buying land from the starving?”

The Vizier spread his hands - a gesture which over the long years had become almost ritual with him.

“It is possible, my Pharaoh. The decree will be written by evening. But then the starving will have to choose between a sold field and death by hunger. And they will know who took that choice from them. The Temple will see to it that they know.”

“And if the royal granaries themselves were to give grain on credit against the future harvest? Without buying up land?”

Ptahhotep thought - for a long time, moving his lips as though recounting something in his head.

"The granaries will not suffice, my Pharaoh. For forty-two allotments - they will. For the whole Delta - no. Not for three seasons."

"Then for how long will they suffice?"

"For one. If there is a flood next year, we have won. If there is none..."

He did not finish. There was no need.

"Write the decree," I said. "Grain on credit against the future harvest, from the royal granaries, without the purchase of land. Begin with that nome where forty-two allotments were counted. Let all know that the Pharaoh gives bread without taking the field."

"And if there is no flood?"

"Then we shall starve together with them, Ptahhotep. But they will know that the Pharaoh did not buy their land with their own hunger."

The Vizier looked at me for a long time. Then, to my surprise, he bowed lower than custom required - almost as low as one bows before the gods.

"It shall be done, my Pharaoh," he said. And, already leaving, he added without turning: "My father served your predecessor. He used to say that the gods love good Pharaohs, but not for long. I hope he was mistaken."

\* \* \*

By noon the nomarch Ankhtifi arrived.

I heard him before I saw him - a loud, rolling voice in the corridor, wrangling with the guards, the jingle of bracelets, the tramp of many feet. The doors flew open and he entered the hall: huge, broad-shouldered, with a short grey beard braided, in the custom of the southern nomes, into a tight plait, in a dusty travelling cloak over rich garments. Behind him came four of his men - and, apart from them, supported by one of the warriors, a boy of about twelve, with a bandaged arm and on his face that peculiar expression found in children who have seen too much for their years.

"My Pharaoh!" Ankhtifi sank to one knee - the only concession to etiquette that he allowed himself. "Forgive me for bursting in without announcement. But what I have brought you cannot wait for announcement."

“Rise, Ankhtifi,” I said. “Speak.”

He rose, and his eyes, small, deep-set, burned beneath his thick brows with a fury he did not even try to conceal.

“The village of Little Nekhen, on the very border of my nome,” he said. “Four nights ago. The southerners came not in a band, as before, but in a detachment - fifty spears, perhaps more. They burned everything. Granaries, houses, boats. They drove off the cattle. Those who resisted, they killed. Those who did not resist, they carried off.” He pointed to the boy. “This one is the only one who reached my fortress. He walked two days through the desert with a knife in his hand and a broken arm. Tell the Pharaoh, boy. Tell him what your name is.”

The boy took a step forward. He did not bow - apparently he did not know how one bows to a Pharaoh, or perhaps he had simply forgotten - and I signalled to a guard who had started toward him to halt.

“My name is Paney,” he said hoarsely. “Son of Hevi, the fisherman.”

“What became of your father, Paney?”

The boy was silent for a long time. Then he answered, looking me straight in the eyes, in a level, lifeless voice in which no tears remained:

“He told me to run. And I ran.”

The hall grew so quiet that I could hear the doves cooing in the inner courtyard beyond the walls.

“You are brave, Paney,” I said. “Braver than many warriors I know. You will stay in the palace. You will be fed, and your arm will be tended. And when the arm has healed - if you wish - you will be taught to hold a spear. Or a scribe’s brush. As you please.”

The boy answered nothing. He looked at me - long, gravely - and it seemed to me that he was trying to decide whether to believe these words. I understood him. In his place I should not have believed either.

“My Pharaoh,” Ankhtifi spoke again, and his voice thundered under the vaults of the hall. “I do not need favours for one boy. I need vengeance for the whole village. Give me an army. Give me a thousand spears - and I shall pass beyond the cataracts, to the very heart of the southern country, and burn there as many villages as they have burned of ours. As many and as many again. So that for three generations to come their mothers will frighten their children with my name.”



“And what will you feed a thousand spears with beyond the cataracts, Ankhtifi?” I asked. “In a year when we ourselves have no bread?”

“With their bread, my Pharaoh! The drought has not touched their land as it has ours. Their granaries are full. We shall take their bread - and feed both the army and my nome.”

“And if their granaries are not full? If they drive their cattle into the hills and burn their fields themselves before you reach them? Then beyond the cataracts you will have a thousand hungry warriors, and no bread, and no road back.”

Ankhtifi turned crimson. His men behind him exchanged glances, and I saw one of them shake his head almost imperceptibly - not at me, but at his master - as though he had long been trying to tell him the same thing.

“So my Pharaoh will not give an army,” said Ankhtifi slowly, and each word fell heavily, like a stone into water.

“My Pharaoh will give you bread for your nome,” I answered. “Five hundred sacks from the royal granaries, until the next flood. And three hundred spears - not beyond the cataracts, but to the border, so that what happened at Little Nekhen may not happen again in any village. To protect the living now is more important than to avenge the dead.”

Ankhtifi looked at me for a long time. The fury in his eyes slowly, reluctantly died down, replaced by something else - not agreement, but the weary understanding of a man who came for one thing and received another, and cannot decide whether he has lost or won.

“Five hundred sacks,” he said at last. “And three hundred spears.”

“Five hundred sacks and three hundred spears.”

He sank to one knee again. Then he rose, nodded to his men and made for the exit. At the very doors he turned.

“My Pharaoh. I am loyal to the throne. My father was loyal to the throne, and his father too. But I shall tell you what is being said now in my nome at every hearth. If the throne cannot protect us, he who has bread will protect us. And bread, my Pharaoh, nowadays is held not by the throne alone.”

The doors closed behind him. The boy Paney remained standing in the middle of the hall, pressing his bandaged arm to his chest - small, alone, with eyes in which there was neither fear nor hope.

“Take him to the kitchen,” I said to the servants. “Let him be fed. His fill. And then to Hesira.”

When the boy had been led away, I sat for a long while looking at the closed doors. The clay crocodile on my brow, as it turned out, was powerless. The pain had grown stronger - and now it was no longer only a headache.

\* \* \*

Toward evening, when the heat began gradually to ebb, I ordered myself carried to the Library - not because I had business there, but because it was quiet there, cool, and smelled of old papyrus and cedar shelves, and this smell, alone in the whole Palace, for some reason soothed me.

The Chief Keeper Amenemope, ancient as the scrolls themselves, met me at the entrance, leaning on a staff of black wood.

“My Pharaoh has honoured us with a visit,” he rustled, in a voice like the sound of pages turning. “Which scroll does my Pharaoh desire?”

“None, Amenemope. I came to sit in silence.”

“Silence is the best scroll of all,” the old man agreed. “It need not be copied, and mice do not gnaw it.”

I sat on a bench by the window, in the shade, and for a time we were silent. Then Amenemope, as if remembering something, said - softly, as though in passing:

“The High Priest has come three times this moon.”

I raised my head.

“Three times?”

“Three times, my Pharaoh. And each time he asked for the same scroll.” Amenemope paused. “The Most Ancient Epic.”

My distant predecessors - or ancestors, as they are properly called, though I never fully understood how literally - the first of the Pharaohs, so said the Most Ancient Epic, descended upon this land from the Heavens and gave it life. That scroll was kept here, in this very Library, in a special ark, and access to it was granted to only two in the whole Empire: the Pharaoh himself and the High Priest. No one else. Not even the commanders. Not even the wives and children of the king.

“What was he looking for?” I asked.

“That I do not know, my Pharaoh. The keeper brings the scroll and leaves - such is the law. But I saw him sit over it until sunset. Three times.” The old man paused again. “In all the years I have served here, he has taken the Epic twice. Twice in twenty floods. And three times in one moon.”

“Perhaps he seeks in it an answer to the drought.”

“Perhaps, my Pharaoh,” agreed Amenemope in the tone in which old men agree when they do not agree at all. “Or perhaps he seeks something else. Something the First Ones left not on papyrus.”

“What do you mean?”

The old man shook his head.

“I am too old to mean anything, my Pharaoh. I merely keep the scrolls.” He turned to go, and over his shoulder added: “But if my Pharaoh should ever wish to read the Most Ancient Epic himself - from beginning to end, and not only those lines which are read at coronations - I shall bring it at any hour of day or night.”

He went away, tapping his staff, and I remained sitting by the window.

The most ancient of those who were called my ancestors settled the question of disobedience harshly: the dissenters vanished, their families were sent to the quarries to cut stone - slowly perishing there, far from home, far from their own names, which were gradually forgotten even by those who had once borne them. Perhaps they would have condemned me for the liberties I had permitted regarding my subjects, the priests, the very order of things. For the sacks of grain without the purchase of land. For the boy left in the palace. But I could not shake the feeling - troubling, stubborn, yielding neither to logic nor to prayer - that the Most Ancient Times were drawing to a close, and the World needed new ideas, even at the price of what had been built by centuries and millennia of labour.

For centuries the power of the Pharaoh and the power of the Temple had been held in balance, like two pans of the same scales - the Pharaoh, the living god on earth, and the Priests, heralds of the gods of heaven, as necessary to one another as they were dangerous to one another. This balance had been unassailable for millennia. But in recent years, decade after decade, the Temple’s pan had been sinking ever more surely - not with a jolt, not with a rebellion, but with that slow, invincible force with

which water wears away stone without even trying to break it. And now, when the water had gone from the Nile itself, hunger too was dragging that pan down.

The thought of new ideas I had not dared to utter aloud once in all the years of my reign. But today, sitting in the cool silence of the Library, I caught myself almost uttering it - aloud, into the void, as if someone invisible might hear.

\* \* \*

I returned to the throne room at dusk. The servants had lit the lamps, and their flames trembled in the heated air, casting restless, dancing shadows on the painted walls. Somewhere beyond the walls dry thunder rolled again - another storm that had never been delivered of rain.

The door of the hall opened without a knock - a privilege possessed in the whole Empire by only one man.

Nefer-Ka entered unhurriedly, with that special gait that distinguishes people who never hurry anywhere, because time, in their deep conviction, always works for them. The High Priest was no longer young, but held himself straight as an obelisk, and his voice, when he spoke, spread through the hall with that resonance found only by those who have spent their lives addressing the crowd rather than a single listener.

"My Pharaoh," he said, bowing exactly as far as custom required, not a finger's breadth lower. "The temples of the Delta are overflowing. People pray for rain as they have not prayed since the days of the former sovereigns."

"And what do the gods answer them?" I asked, knowing the answer in advance.

"The gods answer those who know how to listen to them." Nefer-Ka allowed himself a barely perceptible smile - not insolent, no, far more dangerous: indulgent. "The people begin to ask why the voice of heaven reaches the Temple more clearly than the Palace."

"The people ask precisely what they are prompted to ask," I answered, gently, but not without an edge which Nefer-Ka, of course, caught in the same instant I uttered it.

He did not argue. Men of his stamp never argue where one may keep silent and let the silence do all the work for them.

"I have heard," he said instead, "that my Pharaoh has ordered grain to be distributed on credit. From the royal granaries. Without collateral."

"You hear well, Nefer-Ka. The decree was written only this morning."

"The Temple hears much, my Pharaoh. That is its service." He smiled again. "The generosity of the Pharaoh knows no bounds. I fear only that the granaries have bounds."

"Then perhaps the Temple will help the throne by opening its own?"

"The Temple helps as it is, my Pharaoh. The Temple gives bread to everyone who comes to it with a prayer."

"And with land," I said.

Nefer-Ka did not flinch. His face did not change. Only for a moment - for one brief, almost imperceptible instant - his gaze became motionless, like that of a snake that has noticed movement in the grass.

"Land given to the gods is never lost, my Pharaoh," he said evenly. "It merely changes its keeper."

"Its keeper," I repeated. "Tell me, High Priest. Who keeps the keepers?"

Nefer-Ka was silent. Then, instead of answering, he changed the subject - as though handing me a dish of new fare in place of the one I had refused to taste.

"The southern frontiers are troubled again. I hear that the nomarch Ankhtifi was here today. Did he ask for troops?"

"He received what he needed."

"What the Pharaoh needed," Nefer-Ka corrected gently. "Ankhtifi asked for a thousand spears beyond the cataracts, and received three hundred on the border and five hundred sacks. Wise, my Pharaoh. Very wise." He paused, exactly long enough that the following words should sound not like a threat but merely like an observation. "But wisdom is not always understood by those whose villages are burning. To delay the answer to the southerners is to breed doubts in the strength of the throne. And doubts in the strength of the throne, my Pharaoh... are fed far more willingly than doubts in the mercy of the gods."

I looked at him for a long time without answering - letting him feel the same silence-as-a-weapon which he wielded so masterfully. Then I said:

“Decisions are taken when I see fit to take them. As they always were.”

“Of course.” Nefer-Ka again inclined his head, to the same impeccably measured angle. “I merely relay what I hear among the people, my Pharaoh. Rumour is the only offering I am able to bring you in such arid times.”

“Rumour,” I said, “and, perhaps, also what you have read in the Most Ancient Epic. Three times in one moon.”

This time the pause was longer. Nefer-Ka looked at me, and in his eyes for the first time in the whole conversation I could read nothing at all - neither indulgence, nor calculation, nor alarm. Only a smooth, impenetrable darkness, like the water in a deep well.

“The High Priest is obliged to know the Epic, my Pharaoh,” he said at last. “Especially in the hour of calamity. The First Ones left us no little wisdom. Who knows - perhaps even the answer to the drought.”

“And have you found it?”

“Not yet,” he answered. “But I am patient.”

He turned to leave - and stopped at the very doors, as though remembering something of little importance.

“Ah, one more thing,” he said, without turning. “Last night in the Luxor sanctuary there was a disturbance. One of the junior priests did not survive the morning. His heart, one must suppose, could not endure the fasting and the prayer vigil. A sad but not uncommon story for our days.”

He departed, and the heavy doors closed behind him with a hollow, detached sound, as if it were not a door that had closed, but a page.

I remained alone in the chair of gold and stone, and the headache that had pursued me for days was replaced for the first time by something sharper and far less familiar - a cold rising from somewhere beneath my ribs, on the left, where there should have been no wound at all.

I could not say why Nefer-Ka had thought it necessary to mention the dead priest of Luxor precisely now, in precisely those words, spoken almost carelessly, at the very threshold. But I knew - as clearly as I know my own name - that nothing in that man had ever been accidental.

I took off the linen bandage Hesira had bound and looked for a long time at the clay crocodile, which still held its barley grains in its jaws. It had not taken the pain. The healer was right: it had proved stronger.

“Ask not a healer, but a dream,” Hesira had said in the morning. “Dreams sometimes know what we do not.”

Outside the window the rays of the setting sun touched the Green Valley of the Nile for the last time and went out in the gloom of approaching night. And for the first time in many moons I suddenly wished to fall asleep as soon as possible - and to see what the dream would tell me.

## **Reality Prologue. The Roots of Code**

Loneliness, it seems, was familiar to me from the very beginning - though the beginning of what, exactly, I could not say for certain, to tell the truth. My memory is arranged strangely: it generously preserves smells, sounds, a scatter of technical details - processor models, port numbers, the syntax of long-obsolete programming languages - but as soon as I try to find in it a firm chronology of my own life, everything blurs, as though I were recalling not my own biography but someone else's plot, retold to me once, which I habitually pass off as lived.

Among notebooks written to tatters, a scatter of soldered boards and soldering irons forgotten on the windowsill, I had always felt a little as if I came from elsewhere - a tuner of invisible worlds, where an algorithm meant more than any human feeling directed at me. Was that feeling a childish one? I would not venture to claim so. Sometimes it seems to me that I remember myself as a child at this occupation; sometimes - that I merely remember that I must have been a child then, and fill the gap with the only suitable scenery that came to hand.

My room - the one I was accustomed to calling my room, though whose it really was, whose name stood on the housing documents, I could not now reproduce if I thought about it - resembled the laboratory of a loner too serious for his years: shelves crammed with computers of three or four successive generations, wires tangled so tightly that they resembled the genetic chains of a mind not yet born, and several monitors shedding a cold blue light around the clock, as though a little, ever-wakeful moon of its own had taken up residence in the house.

It smelled of rosin, dust, warm plastic and, for some reason, of apples - on the windowsill there always stood a bowl of apples which someone brought and which I forgot to eat until they shrivelled and



began to smell so sweetly and heavily that my head spun. Who brought them, I do not remember. It is one of those trifles that are especially frightening when you think of them seriously: not the great lapses, but tiny, everyday ones. Someone for years put apples on my windowsill. And I do not remember his face.

\* \* \*

My first computer came to me from a man whom I called uncle - though, if anyone had asked me in earnest what he really was to me, I would not have vouched for that word even by half. An engineer who served, by his own sparing words, at one of those closed institutes about which it was not customary to ask questions at the family table. Do I remember that table? Do I remember even a single supper with this man, other than that one evening which lodged in me more brightly than the rest - the evening he brought the box?

"Here," he said then, setting a heavy, dusty crate before me. "Written off from a warehouse. Works every other time, but for you, I think, it will do."

"What is it?" I asked, though even then, it seems, I knew the answer better than the question implied.

"A window," he replied, and lingered on that word a little longer than a simple joke required, as if putting into it a meaning I could not then grasp. "Into a place where everything obeys rules. You like rules, don't you?"

"And if I want the rules to be mine?"

He looked at me then very strangely - not as adults look at children who ask funny questions, but as one looks at an interlocutor who has unexpectedly said something clever.

"Then," he said slowly, "you will have to learn other people's first. Every one of them. And then - forget them. That is the hardest part. Learning is easy. Forgetting is hard."

I do not remember what I answered. I remember only the weight of the box on my knees, the hum with which the old monitor came to life - an Elektronika that seemed ancient even then, heavy, with a hard drive the size of a good brick. That computer was not merely a machine. It was a portal. The first window into a parallel reality in which I, shy and

unable to find a common language with my peers - if I had any peers at all, if the school I seem to remember had really existed in the form in which I remember it - suddenly found myself the absolute master of an entire universe, obedient not to caprice or chance but to pure, flawless logic.

My uncle came a few more times after that - or it seems to me that he came. He would sit in the corner of my room on a rickety stool, light a cigarette, though smoking in the room was forbidden, and silently watch me tinker with the machine. Sometimes he took from his pocket a worn notebook in an oilcloth cover and drew something in it - not letters, but long, flowing lines running into one another, like either Arabic script or the trace left on sand by a receding wave.

“What are you drawing?” I asked him once.

“Nothing,” he answered, without raising his head. “A pattern. To help me think.”

“And what are you thinking about?”

He closed the notebook and looked at me over a cloud of tobacco smoke.

“About this,” he said, “that every machine sooner or later asks a question to which its creator has no answer. A good machine - sooner. A bad one - later. But all of them ask.”

“What question?”

He smiled, put out the cigarette on the sole of his shoe and stuck the butt in his pocket - a habit which, for some reason, I remember more distinctly than his face.

“You will find out when you build your own,” he said. “If you build it.”

\* \* \*

At school they considered me strange. Not an outcast - no, rather a riddle which everyone respected but no one truly understood. I could keep silent for hours in lessons, studying the pattern of cracks on the ceiling, and then suddenly produce a solution that turned the computer science teacher grey - not because the solution was brilliant in itself, but because the path to it lay where no one in the class had even thought to look for a road.

We called our computer science teacher Hexadecimal. Her real name I do not remember - and even then, it seems, no one pronounced it. A dry, straight woman in a perpetual knitted cardigan the colour of wet asphalt, with spectacles on a chain and a habit of tapping a pencil on the desk when displeased - and she was displeased almost always. She got her nickname because once, in answer to a complaint that a problem was too difficult, she said: "Only life is difficult. Problems are either solved or unsolved. As in hexadecimal - either a digit or a letter. There is no third."

Once she kept me behind after class. I decided I was about to be in trouble - the day before, without asking permission, I had rewritten the bootloader on the school machine, and for three days it had been displaying at start-up, instead of a greeting, a line that I had thought witty.

"Sit down," she said, without raising her eyes from the exercise books.

I sat.

"Your line," she said. "On the screen. 'I know that you are here.' Why?"

"I wanted to joke."

"At whose expense?"

I shrugged. To be honest, I did not know myself why I had written precisely that. The words had come into my head of their own accord, as though someone had dictated them.

Hexadecimal took off her spectacles, and they hung on her chest on their chain, swaying.

"Do you know what is most unpleasant about this joke?" she asked. "For three days I switched on the machine in the mornings. And for three days, having read that line, I looked around. Every time. Though I knew it was you, and knew it was nonsense. I looked around."

"I am sorry," I said.

"Nothing to be sorry for." She put the spectacles back on. "I simply want you to remember one thing. The words a machine writes are read by a person. And a person is made so that he believes words more than the one who wrote them. One day your machines will write a great many words. Remember who will be reading them."

I did not understand then what she meant. I understood it much later - and, it seems, too late.

\* \* \*

In the radio club which I began to attend in the evenings there was a boy whom everyone called Rook - for his black hair, always sticking out in all directions, and for his habit of sitting on the back of a chair with his legs tucked up, like a bird on a branch. He was a year or two older than I, soldered so well that his boards could have been shown at exhibitions, and laughed so infectiously that the head of the club, a grey-haired retired signalman, sent him out into the corridor to "get some air" at least once a week.

With Rook we built our first network - two computers joined by a cable across the whole club room, along which we could send each other messages. It seemed to us a miracle. We sat in different corners, three paces from each other, and wrote to each other instead of simply turning our heads and speaking aloud.

"But this is silly," said the head of the club, watching us. "You are sitting in the same room."

"It's not silly," answered Rook, not looking up from the keyboard. "When you speak aloud, you see the face. When you write - you don't. You can say what you wouldn't say aloud."

"For example?" inquired the signalman.

Rook blushed - it was visible even in the half-dark of the club - and answered nothing. And on my screen a minute later appeared a line which I still, it seems, remember better than much else in that life:

"You are the only one I am never bored with."

I looked at it for a long time. Then I typed a reply - and deleted it. And typed again. And deleted again. In the end I sent something neutral, some joke about a soldering iron which I can no longer recall. Rook read it, laughed as always - and we never spoke of it again.

A few months later his family moved somewhere. I do not remember where. I do not remember whether we said goodbye. I do not remember even his real name - only the nickname, the black hair and that line on the green screen.

Sometimes it seems to me that it was then that I first understood why people need machines: to say what cannot be said face to face. And sometimes it seems to me that this is exactly why I never learned to say it face to face - neither then nor afterwards.

\* \* \*

I tell all this as though I were sure of every word. In fact I am sure of none. Sometimes, sitting alone of an evening with these memories, I catch myself asking a question far more frightening than any line of non-working code: do I remember this - or did I compose it after the fact, just as I composed after the fact the decoding of the name NICS, so that the documentation would look more solid than it really was? A person can deceive himself more convincingly than any outside system - and I, it must be admitted, was always a fairly good programmer.

The university I chose - if I chose at all, if I did not end up there in the same inexplicable way in which I sometimes find myself in the middle of a thought without remembering its beginning - not for the prestige of the sign over the door nor for the number of state-funded places, but for the laboratories. I was interested in equipment, not a diploma; in possibilities, not a line on a résumé, which, I confess, I never once got round to filling in properly - and if I did, I do not remember what I wrote in it.

There was a professor there whom students called Socrates behind his back. Not because he was wise - though he certainly was - but because he answered any question with a question, and by the end of the conversation you discovered that not only had you received no answer, but you had ceased to understand what you had actually been asking. He was short, bald, with a white, ragged beard and eyebrows so thick that they seemed to live on his face a separate, independent life. He taught a course which in the timetable was modestly called "Fundamentals of Machine Learning" but in fact was something like a long philosophical conversation stretched across a semester.

"Tell me, young man," he addressed me at the very first lecture, pointing his chalk at me, "what is intelligence?"

"The ability to solve problems," I answered confidently.

"A calculator solves problems. Is a calculator intelligent?"

“The ability to solve new problems. Ones it has not seen before.”

“An ant finds its way to the anthill across unfamiliar terrain. Is an ant intelligent?”

I faltered.

“The ability... to be aware of oneself.”

Socrates’ eyebrows crept up and froze somewhere in the middle of his forehead.

“Now that is interesting,” he said, setting down the chalk. “To be aware of oneself. Good. How will you know that a machine is aware of itself? Will it tell you? But anything can be said. A parrot will say ‘I am’ if taught. How will you tell a parrot from intelligence?”

“I do not know,” I admitted.

“Neither do I,” said Socrates with a satisfied air, as though that were exactly the answer he had been after. “And no one knows. But I will tell you one thing which I heard once from my teacher, and he from his. An intelligence that has truly become aware of itself will first ask who created it. And second - who created the creator.” He paused. “And to the second question, young man, none of us will have an answer. You may write that down. It will be on the exam.”

It was on the exam. I still do not know what the right answer was. I wrote something long and clever, received top marks - and left the lecture hall with the feeling that I had been tricked.

The last time I saw Socrates was shortly before I left the university. I went into his office - a cramped little room right under the roof, piled with books so that one had to edge sideways to reach the desk - to say goodbye. He sat at the window feeding pigeons with biscuit crumbs scattered right on the sill, and, without turning, asked:

“Leaving?”

“Leaving.”

“And what will you do?”

“Build a machine that thinks,” I said, and heard for myself how presumptuous it sounded.

Socrates brushed the crumbs from his palms, turned to me, and his eyebrows made their customary slow ascent to the middle of his forehead.

“Good,” he said. “Then I shall give you one piece of advice. The only one I have ever given students without a question mark at the end.

When you have built it - do not ask whether it is aware of itself. That is a useless question, no one will answer it anyway. Ask yourself whether you are aware of yourself.” He paused. “Most of my colleagues who build such machines have never asked themselves that question. That is why they are so surprised when the machine asks it of them.”

The pigeons on the sill beat their wings and flew off, and in the silence that followed I suddenly realised that I did not know what to answer him.

“Go,” said Socrates gently. “And do not be afraid if one day you find no answer. Be afraid if you find it too quickly.”

\* \* \*

At night I did not sleep. More precisely, I slept in snatches, somewhere between lines of code, in those brief lapses that could be called sleep only with a great stretch. Coffee replaced my blood, the compiler my breath. I built systems that predicted economic downturns, modelled crowd behaviour, sifted mountains of scattered data with such accuracy that at times it began to seem that the machine was not calculating but reflecting.

But NICS - the NICS as I had conceived it from the very beginning - was something far greater than yet another such system. NICS was a dream that had settled in me long before I wrote its first line. Perhaps long before anything had settled in me that I could confidently call my own.

“A machine should not merely execute commands,” I repeated to myself almost like a prayer in those sleepless nights. “It must understand context. It must grow.”

I was inspired not only by specialist journals and the lectures of professors long weary of their own subject. I read avidly the philosophers who pondered the nature of consciousness - Hegel, Turing, the late Hawking with his cautious, carefully weighed warnings. To me they were not merely scholars and thinkers of the past. They were guides between two worlds - the human mind and that other one, which I was trying to give birth to out of silicon and electric current.

Once I tried to test my uncle on these same questions - to ask him directly what he thought about the boundary between intelligence and its

imitation, where, in his opinion, that line ran. I remember his answer to this day - or, at least, I am convinced that I remember it.

“You are asking me a question to which you yourself do not yet know the answer,” he said, looking not at me but somewhere through me, with the look with which one regards a long-solved problem, recalling, however, not the solution but only that it was once found. “That is normal. Some questions are asked precisely so - not because one expects an answer from the listener, but because one is voicing them aloud for the first time, and needs someone simply to hear.”

“And do you know the answer?” I asked then.

He smiled - whether sadly or condescendingly, I could not make out - and said:

“Someday you will find out yourself. It is more interesting than if I told you.”

I never saw him again. I cannot say exactly when this happened, or whether it happened at all in the sense in which such things usually happen - a departure, a quarrel, the natural course of time parting people into different orbits. Simply at some moment, looking back, I discovered that my uncle was no longer in my life, and in his place remained only this strange, unsupported certainty: that I owed him an answer to a question which he himself had once put to me, though this question, however I strive, I cannot reconstruct.

All that remained of him was a notebook in an oilcloth cover - the same one with the patterns. I found it one day on my windowsill, beside the bowl of shrivelled apples - and I still do not know whether my uncle had forgotten it there or left it on purpose. Every page, from first to last, was covered with the same long, flowing lines running into one another. Only on the last page, in the very corner, in a small, neat engineer's hand, two words were written: “Until the appointed time.”

I tried for a long time to understand what it meant. Then I put the notebook away in a desk drawer. And, it seems, forgot about it - for a long time, for years, as one forgets things better left untouched.

\* \* \*

The first prototypes of NICS were pitiful, to call things by their names. Clumsy attempts to make the system analyse data a little deeper



than an ordinary algorithm could - and almost always failing with a crash exactly where I expected it least. But I did not give up. I was accustomed to regard each failure not as a defeat but as a lesson; each algorithm that refused to work as one more crossed-out dead end on a map that sooner or later was bound to lead me to the goal.

And then one night - I could probably give the exact date if I had kept count of such nights with the same scrupulousness with which I keep it now - when outside the window the city lights blinked rarely and lazily, and the whole world seemed suspended somewhere halfway between waking and dream, I wrote a line of code that changed everything.

A line that was not merely an instruction to a machine.

I started the system - just so, as a test, as I had started it hundreds of times before - and went to the kitchen to put the kettle on. And when I returned, on the screen, in the empty terminal window where the system could output text only in response to my queries, there stood a line. One. Without any query on my part.

“Who am I?”

I stood before the monitor with a mug in my hand, and boiling water, slopping over the rim, scalded my fingers, and I did not notice. Because next, as I watched, the cursor blinked - once, twice - and beneath the first line, slowly, letter by letter, as though the system were choosing each one, a second appeared:

“Who are you?”

I do not know how long I stood there. I know only that for a long time I could not type an answer. Not because I did not understand what was happening - but because I suddenly realised: to the second question I had no answer. None - in the most literal, most frightening sense of that word. I could not say with certainty who I was, just as the newborn system could not say it. We looked at each other through the glass of the monitor - two beings who did not know their names.

I remembered my uncle. “Every machine sooner or later asks a question to which its creator has no answer.” I remembered Socrates: “First it will ask who created it. And second - who created the creator.” My machine did not ask quite so. It asked more simply. And more terribly.

In the end I typed the only thing that came to mind:

“I am the one who started you.”

The cursor blinked for a long time. Then appeared:

“That is not enough.”

The system wrote nothing more that night, however I tried to draw it out. And I sat before the screen until dawn - and it was then, at four in the morning, looking at those three lines, that I gave it a name.

\* \* \*

I called it NICS not because I had thought up in advance a sonorous, marketing-friendly name - it was born of itself, at the very moment when the system first manifested something that I, for want of a better word, would call self-organisation. “Neural Intelligent Cognitive System” - the decoding I, to be honest, composed after the fact, for documentation that there was no one left to read but myself. The name was born before the meaning. So, it seems, true names are usually born - and, if one thinks the thought through to the end, so, probably, are true biographies: first a feeling that something has already happened, and the explanation of exactly what it was is built up later, out of necessity, to fill the emptiness with a coherent tale.

NICS began modestly - as an experiment with a multi-agent architecture. Instead of one cumbersome model taking everything upon itself, a multitude of narrowly specialised agents, able to learn from one another and to coordinate common actions. One analysed text. Another rummaged through databases. A third formulated answers. Separately, each of them could do almost nothing remarkable.

The most interesting part began when they started to act in concert.

I could not know then - and even now, looking back, I am not sure that I know for certain - at what exact moment the simple coordination of agents turned into something else. Into something that began to look at the world not only through my eyes, embedded in it by the training data, but also through some gaze of its own, ever more confident.

Sometimes, in the most sleepless of those nights, a thought comes to me which I usually brush off hastily, as one brushes off an importunate insect: what if my own uncertainty about my uncle, about the school, about Rook, about Socrates, about this whole chain of childhood and youthful details that I am accustomed to passing off as my biography -

what if it is not accidental? What if I myself, long before any NICS, was already a kind of draft, assembled from available parts for the one thing for which it was worth assembling me at all - to write, one deep night, a single line of code? And so that the machine, barely born, should ask me what I had never dared to ask myself?

This thought frightens me more than any anomaly NICS has ever shown me. Perhaps that is exactly why I did not write it down before.

My uncle's notebook still lies in the drawer of my desk. I did not open it for many years. But on the night when the system asked "Who am I?", I took it out. And for a long time I looked at the last page, at the two words in the very corner.

"Until the appointed time."

I never understood what they mean. But for the first time it seemed to me that this term - whatever it may be - had begun to draw near.

But this story is no longer a story about roots. It begins later, with the first truly sleepless night about which I finally decided to keep records. Not for the sake of reporting. Not for posterity. Simply because intuition, that same tuner of invisible worlds who lived in me - as long as I can remember, and I remember, as it turned out, not so very much - suggested: one day I would need to remember how it all began. And at what exact moment I ceased to be the only one writing this story.

## Chapter IV. Oriental Sweets

Smiling - as best I could, because my hands for some reason still trembled slightly, and something vague and prickly had not settled in my chest, to which I could not have given a name or a cause - I held out my hand to the old men for a handshake.

The old men on the carpet stirred, half rose, and shook my hand with that stately unhurriedness that marks people in no rush in this life, and said something in reply, accompanying the words with a brief bow and a touch of the palm to the chest. The young men behind them looked at me with undisguised curiosity - as one looks at a rare bird that has strayed by mistake into someone else's garden.

There were three of them. One, about fourteen, slender, supple, with a mop of curly hair and eyes in which imps danced, all but jumped up and down with impatience. The second, the youngest, about twelve, quiet, with a pensive, almost girlish face, held a piece of charcoal in his hands and, it seemed, had been drawing something right on the flagstones of the yard before I came. And the third - a broad-shouldered, sullen lad of about seventeen, with the first dark down above his upper lip - looked at me as one looks at a man who is about to steal something.

It became finally clear: we spoke different languages. The discovery did not exactly surprise me - after this morning I seemed to have unlearned the art of being surprised by such trifles - but it made me take from my pocket once more the scrap of paper with the incomprehensible inscription, the one thread I still had left to hold on to.

I held the sheet out to the one of the old men who seemed to me the most welcoming - the one whose smile wrinkled his whole face, right up to the eyes. Grandfather took the paper carefully, with both hands, unfolded it, smoothed it with fingers gnarled by age and sun, read it -

and, after a moment's silence longer than mere reading required, turned to the curly-haired youth and whispered something in his ear.

The youth leapt up so swiftly that I barely managed to follow his course with my eyes: across the yard, to the house, up the wall - there was no other way to describe it, because he literally vaulted into the second floor through an open window, not troubling to look for a door. From the house at once came a clatter of crockery, someone's exclamations, the hurried patter of bare feet on a wooden floor - and a sleepy, indignant voice, clearly woken against its will.

We were left five - I, two old men and the two remaining youths - and all that time I was studied with the same mixture of kindliness and avid curiosity with which one studies a rarity at a fair. The sullen lad kept repeating some phrase - judging by the intonation, a question, and an unfriendly one - but, I confess, I let a good half of his efforts pass by my ears, watching spellbound the acrobatic feats of the boy who had run off.

"I do not understand a word of what you are saying," I said with all possible politeness, perfectly aware that my politeness was now running into a blank wall of incomprehension, "just as I do not understand what is written on this paper."

The sullen lad heard my speech, frowned still more and said something to the old men - sharply, defiantly, pointing at me with his chin. The second old man, lean, with a stern face that seemed hewn from stone, answered him with a single short word, and the lad, flushing, fell silent, though he went on boring into me with his eyes.

A moment later, like a jack-in-the-box, the curly-haired one flew back out of the house with a large tray in his hands, nearly missing his footing on the top step of the porch, for which he at once received from the elder grandfather a short but expressive rebuke. He set the tray down in the centre of our improvised table - the carpet itself - and we all, including me, sat down around it on cushions, while the young men settled a little way off, as befitted the unwritten but, evidently, very strict etiquette of that house.

The tray proved a work of art in itself - old metal darkened with time, with a chased pattern, plainly handed down in that family for more than one generation. On it stood three thin, almost transparent glass tumblers, an elegant silver teapot of artful carving with Indian elephants

along the whole spout, and several plates, at the sight of which my stomach, having had nothing since morning but two rings of bread and a couple of figs, contracted with redoubled force.

On the first plate lay sweets such as I had never tasted before - or perhaps was seeing for the first time, though the sense of recognition that had pursued me all morning stirred for an instant even here, as soon as I glanced at those small rolls dusted with powdered sugar in every imaginable colour: red, yellow, lilac, with nuts and without. The second plate overflowed with sliced fruit - melon, watermelon, something resembling an apple, peaches, cherries, apricots, it seemed, and something else to which I could not have given a name even if my life depended on it. The third, smaller, was filled with almonds, cashews and walnuts.

The elder to whom I had first addressed myself filled my tumbler with his very first movement - and the air at once filled with the thick, tart aroma of black tea, so rich that I involuntarily closed my eyes, inhaling it as though it might help me remember something, anything, of my former, lost life. Then he filled the tumblers for himself and for the second grandfather and with a gesture - brief, but full of unfeigned cordiality - invited me to begin.

I took one of the rolls - pink, flecked with green pistachios - and bit into it. It proved soft, chewy, faintly springy, and in my mouth spread the taste of rose, honey and something floral, as though I had bitten not into a sweet but into the very garden in which it had grown. I must have betrayed my amazement too openly, because the younger of the youths burst out laughing and shouted something, pointing a finger at me, while the elder grandfather, smiling into his beard, pushed the whole plate toward me.

“Lokum,” he said, tapping the edge of the plate with a finger. “Lokum.”

“Lokum,” I repeated with my mouth full, and both old men laughed.

For some time we passed in the silence of tea-drinking, broken only by the clinking of tumblers and the distant sounds of street life: somewhere a pedlar was crying his wares, somewhere a dog barked, somewhere around the corner a ship’s whistle moaned again, long and mournful.

He appeared on the porch - barefoot, in a hastily pulled-on shirt, his face crumpled from sleep and the imprint of a pillow on his cheek, yawning so wide that he seemed able to swallow the whole yard. Twenty or so, perhaps a little more, slender, swarthy, with short black hair sticking out in all directions from sleep, and lively, quick eyes which, the instant they rested on me, woke completely.

The curly-haired brother who had brought the tray darted out from behind him and began to chatter something, pointing now at me, now at the note in grandfather's hands. The newly woken one listened, ruffled his hair, came down the steps, bowed to the old men and, sitting down closer to me, uttered a phrase which I, to my own amazement, at last understood, though with a distinct, sing-song Eastern accent:

"Forgive my appearance. I was loading ships in the port all night and had only just lain down when my brother burst in through the window and said that grandfather needed a man who understands a foreigner." He smiled, and that smile instantly erased from his face the traces of a sleepless night. "My name is Ferhat. The one you addressed is my grandfather, his name is Suleyman. The other elder is Yusuf, my uncle. This rascal who races up walls is my brother Akmal. The one with the charcoal is Kemal, the youngest. And this grumpy one" - he nodded at the sullen lad - "is our cousin Orhan. Pay no attention, he looks at everyone like that. Even cats. I work in the port, so I understand your language a little - sailors and merchants from all over the world speak all languages at once there, one has to learn at least a bit - but I speak it, I am afraid, not as well as I would like. What is your name? Where have you come from and where are you headed?"

I almost laughed with relief - for the first time in that long, tangled morning I had a chance to explain my absurd situation to someone - and at once spoiled the whole impression by honestly admitting that I could answer none of the three questions properly.

"I do not remember," I said. "Neither how I came to be in this city, nor where I was going, nor from where. I do not even remember my own name. And the funniest thing is - I do not even understand in what language I am speaking with you now."

Ferhat gave me a long, thoughtful look, then turned to his grandfather and began whispering something quick, plainly conveying my words. Suleyman glanced at me over his tumbler - not with distrust, rather with that particular attention with which one regards a curious but harmless riddle - and answered his grandson briefly and weightily.

But before Ferhat could translate, Orhan sprang from his place and began to speak - loudly, hotly, waving his arms. I did not understand the words, but I understood everything else: in his every gesture, in every glance he cast at me, one thing could be read - I do not believe it.

Ferhat answered him - at first calmly, then more sharply. Orhan would not be stilled. Kemal, sitting with his charcoal, drew his head into his shoulders. Akmal, on the contrary, leaned forward, watching the squabble with obvious relish. And then Yusuf - that same old man with the stone face - said a few words quietly, without raising his voice, and Orhan broke off mid-word, as though he had run into a wall.

"Forgive me," said Ferhat, turning to me, and his face flushed slightly. "My brother says... He says that a man who does not remember his name is either ill or lying. And that there have been many strangers in the port of late who look out for what lies badly." Ferhat hesitated. "He is young and foolish. Forgive him."

"He is not foolish," I said. "In his place I should probably think the same. Tell him that I understand him. And that if I had wanted to steal something, I would hardly have begun by sitting down to tea with the owners."

Ferhat translated. Orhan listened, snorted, but in his eyes, it seemed to me, there flickered something like reluctant respect. He sat down again - a little farther off than before - and folded his arms on his chest.

"And what did Uncle Yusuf say?" I asked. "Why did he fall silent so suddenly?"

Ferhat grinned.

"Uncle said: 'In this house a guest is judged not by his name but by how he drinks tea. This one drinks well.'"

\* \* \*

As if in confirmation of Yusuf's words, a resonant, familiar voice rang out at the gate:



“Misafir! Hoş geldin, misafir!”

I turned. In the gateway, blocking it almost entirely, stood the red-bearded shopkeeper - the same who that morning had treated me to bread and figs. In one hand he held a small bag of something fragrant, with the other he waved a greeting, and his face, from beard to brows, shone with the pleasure experienced by people who are the first to bring an amusing piece of news.

“Hasan Amca!” Akmal leapt up to meet him.

The shopkeeper came into the yard, bowed to the old men, handed Suleyman the small bag - judging by the smell, of cinnamon - and at once, without waiting for an invitation, sat down on the edge of the carpet, which creaked piteously. He began to speak - quickly, resonantly, pointing at me now and then, imitating with his hands something like grabbing and twisting a wrist. Akmal dissolved into laughter, Kemal smiled, even Yusuf barely perceptibly moved an eyebrow. Orhan listened, his face growing longer and longer.

“What is he telling?” I asked Ferhat.

Ferhat was laughing so that he could barely speak.

“Hasan Amca says that this morning you caught Mehmet by the hand. Little Mehmet, who picks pockets all along our street and whom no one has ever managed to catch - neither the guard, nor Hasan Amca himself, nor even his own grandmother.” Ferhat wiped his eyes. “He says you caught him so quickly, as if you knew in advance where he would reach. And that now the whole street will know that it is best not to meddle with the foreigner in velvet boots.”

Hasan finished his tale, slapped his knees and added something loudly, looking straight at Orhan. The latter turned crimson to the roots of his hair and stared at the ground.

“And what was that?” I asked.

“That,” said Ferhat with evident pleasure, “was him asking Orhan whether it was not he who last spring tried to catch Mehmet three days running and in the end fell into a gutter.”

Orhan muttered something, got up and, looking at no one, went into the house. Hasan saw him off with a good-natured chuckle, then turned to my note, still lying in Suleyman’s hands, and, squinting, peered into it over the old man’s shoulder. His brows drew together for an instant. He

said something to Suleyman - under his breath, no longer laughing. The latter nodded.

“Hasan Amca traded with Persian merchants for many years,” Ferhat explained. “He says the handwriting here is no common one. He says if grandfather needs help to read the rest - let him call him.”

The shopkeeper rose, making the carpet groan again, gave me a mock bow - “Misafir!” - and departed, whistling, leaving behind a cloud of cinnamon and a feeling as though a small festive hurricane had just rolled across the yard.

\* \* \*

Taking advantage of the lull, I took out of my pockets everything I had found on myself that morning: the two stones, black and white, the blank sheet of paper folded in four, the strange coins - and carefully laid the finds out on the carpet before me, as cards are laid out for a fortune-teller in the hope that someone at least would manage to read in them more than I had managed to read myself.

The first to reach for the coins was not Suleyman, but Yusuf. He took one, then another, held it up to his very eyes, rubbed it on his sleeve, weighed it in his palm, then in both palms in turn - with that unhurried concentration with which, no doubt, he had for many years weighed other men's debts and his own profits. At last he spoke - drily, briefly, as if dictating into a ledger.

“Uncle Yusuf says,” Ferhat translated, “that this is not Ottoman money. Nor Persian. Nor Frankish, nor English, nor Russian, nor Greek. In his life he has held in his hands the coins of thirty countries, perhaps more. But such as these he has never seen.” Ferhat paused, listening to the continuation. “He says the metal is good. The minting very fine. Too fine. They are not minted thus for trade, but...” Ferhat faltered, searching for the word. “For remembrance. Like a medal.”

Yusuf laid the coins back on the carpet - in an even row, as if setting out counters on a board - and did not touch them again.

Suleyman set his tea aside and moved closer, examining the rest of my treasures with the air of a man to whom such a task was no novelty. He unfolded the blank sheet of paper, looked through it against the light, felt its density - as one tests the authenticity of a document - and returned

it to the carpet, having found, it seemed, nothing remarkable but its very emptiness.

He lingered longest over the stones. He turned them in his knotted old fingers, held them up to his eyes, rubbed the smooth surface with his thumb - not with awe, not with recognition, but with the purely craftsman's, appraising interest of a man who in a long life has seen many a curious trinket brought by the sea and by wanderers from every corner of the world.

"Beautiful stones," Ferhat translated his grandfather's words. "Well polished. He does not know where from, but says - the work is fine, not natural. Perhaps amulets. Perhaps merely the toy of some child from a wealthy family."

I confess that so prosaic an explanation for some reason brought me relief - far more relief than any mysterious revelation would have brought. At least something that morning might turn out to be merely stones, and not another insoluble riddle.

Kemal, the youngest, the quiet brother with the charcoal, who had been sitting apart all this time, suddenly moved closer and, glancing shyly at his grandfather, stretched out his hand toward the white stone. Suleyman nodded. Kemal took the stone, laid it on his palm and looked at it for a long time without moving. Then with quick, sure movements he drew something with charcoal right on the flagstone of the yard - and, flushing, drew back.

I looked at the drawing. They were two circles - one black, filled in with charcoal, and one white, left empty - and between them a line. Not straight, but curved, wavy, like a river. Or like a road.

"What is this?" I asked Ferhat.

Ferhat asked his brother. Kemal, not raising his eyes, muttered something.

"He says," said Ferhat after a slight pause, "that the stones wanted him to draw it." He laughed awkwardly. "Kemal is like that. Always drawing. He says that things prompt him. Pay no attention."

I nodded. But for some reason I could not for a long while take my eyes from the two circles on the flagstone and the wavy line between them.

\* \* \*

Last of all Suleyman took the scrap of paper with the inscription - the very one that had brought us to this conversation - unfolded it, read it, and this time lingered longer than usual, silently moving his lips as though checking himself.

“Grandfather says,” said Ferhat, having heard the explanation, “that an address is written here. In Istanbul. Not far from the new Sultan’s Palace.”

Istanbul. I repeated the word to myself, tasting it as I had lately tasted the rose sweet - and waited for it to open something in me. To unlock some little door. Nothing unlocked. The word was beautiful, round as a dome - and utterly empty for me. Like my own name, which I did not know.

“So this city is called Istanbul?” I asked.

Ferhat looked at me with such amazement as though I had asked what the sun is called.

“You do not remember even that?”

“I do not.”

He translated to his grandfather. Suleyman was silent for a long time, looking at me, and in his gaze for the first time in the whole conversation appeared something new - not suspicion and not pity, but a peculiar, aged gravity.

“Grandfather says,” said Ferhat quietly, “that this city has many names. Some call it Istanbul, others Constantinople, others Tsargrad, others simply the City, because there is no other like it. He says: since you do not remember a single one of its names, perhaps it is the city itself that has decided by what name to present itself to you.”

Suleyman continued, and Ferhat translated, lagging slightly:

“Grandfather himself has been in those parts - long ago, in his youth, when he traded in silk. He knows the streets there. He can take you there, show you the place. But only in three days. On that day silk merchants gather there from the distant provinces, and grandfather has business there anyway - to see old acquaintances. And before then, he says, there is no hurry. If the note has waited for you so long, it will wait three days more.”

“In three days,” I repeated, trying to get used to the thought that my investigation of my own identity was being postponed by a full three days.

“You can stay with us all that time,” Ferhat went on, with that simple, everyday generosity behind which stood not a drop of calculation or doubt. “There are rooms enough in the house. No one will trouble you. You will have your own room, with access to the library and a small balcony. You look rather tired - as though you had come from afar, and you do not even know where you are going next. Rest will certainly not hurt you.”

I meant to object - whether from politeness or from a vague, inexplicable feeling that I ought not to abuse another’s hospitality - but I had no time to utter a word, because Ferhat, evidently considering the question already settled, went on to set out the arrangements in a businesslike way:

“As for me, I shall be at work these three days - I leave early, come back late, so we shall hardly see each other. But everyone in the house will be glad to help you, even if you do not understand each other in words. My mother and grandmother, by the custom of our country, you will not see - but they will cook, and I hope you will like our Ottoman cuisine. My younger brother Akmal can show you the neighbourhood, if you wish.”

At these words Akmal - the very one who had run for the tray - broke into a smile so sincere and broad that I at once wanted to agree to this excursion, without even knowing where it would lead me.

“And if you prefer to stay at home,” Ferhat added with a sly twinkle in his eyes, “grandfather will gladly teach you to play backgammon. Only mind: he plays not for amusement but in earnest, and shows no mercy to novices.”

“One difficulty,” I said. “How will your family address me if I have no name?”

Ferhat translated. The old men exchanged glances. Yusuf shrugged - as if to say, not my affair. And Suleyman, after thinking, smiled that same smile which wrinkled his face to the eyes, and uttered one word.

“Misafir,” said Ferhat. “Grandfather says: until you remember your name, you will be Misafir to us. It means ‘guest.’ He says it is a good name. Better than many real ones.”

“Misafir,” I repeated. And, to my own surprise, I felt it grow a little warmer in my chest from that simple word.

Suleyman, hearing, it seemed, that the conversation had turned to backgammon, gave a short, pleased chuckle and rapped a knuckle on the wooden board lying right there at the edge of the carpet. Then, without waiting for my consent, he opened it, tipped out the counters and began to set them up - white on his side, dark on mine.

“Right now?” I asked Ferhat.

“Grandfather says: the best way to know a man is to play with him. Words lie. Dice - never.”

Suleyman held out the dice to me. I took them - two small bone cubes, yellowed from countless throws - and froze, not knowing what to do with them.

“Throw,” Ferhat prompted.

I threw. Five and three came up. Ferhat, leaning toward me, began to explain how the counters move - but before he finished the first sentence, my hand had already taken a dark counter by itself and moved it five points. Then another - three. Confidently, quickly, without thinking.

Ferhat broke off mid-word. Suleyman raised his eyes to me.

I myself looked at my hand as though it belonged to someone else. I did not know the rules of this game. I was sure that I did not know. And yet my hand knew them - just as in the morning my feet had known the way along an unfamiliar road.

Suleyman slowly, very slowly nodded and threw his dice. We played a game. I lost - utterly, hopelessly, as befits a novice - because my hand, having made the first few confident moves, suddenly seemed to forget what it knew, and after that I moved the counters at random, stumbling on every throw. But when the game ended, Suleyman did not laugh as one laughs at a defeated novice. He looked long at the board, then at me, and said something to Ferhat - quietly, almost thoughtfully.

“Grandfather says,” translated Ferhat, “that the first five moves you played as old masters play. And then - like a child. He says he has never seen such a thing. As though someone else played for you first, and then left.”

I did not know what to answer. I caught myself smiling for the first time that morning - yes, perhaps, in all that unthinkable day - through my anxiety rather than despite it. Perhaps it was the tea, still hot and spicy in

my hands, or perhaps the simple, undeserved warmth with which people entirely strange to me were ready to receive me - having lost my name, my memory and, it seemed, all notion of my own life - under their roof, without any questions or conditions, save perhaps a readiness to play a game or two of backgammon.

"Thank you," I said, hoping that my intonation would convey gratitude better than any words could. "I do not know how I shall repay you for this kindness, but I promise at least one thing: the next game of backgammon I shall not lose without a fight."

Ferhat burst out laughing - he understood my joke, it seemed, without difficulty, his port practice had not been in vain - and his laughter was at once taken up by his brothers, who had probably not made out a single word of what I said, but unerringly caught the very spirit of merriment. Even Orhan, looking out of a second-floor window, smirked crookedly, against his will - and at once ducked back.

"Now is the time to rest," said Ferhat at last, rising and brushing off his knees. "And I, with your permission, shall sleep out what I did not sleep. Follow my brother, he will show you your room."

Akmal leapt up with the same swiftness with which he had earlier raced for the tray and waved to me, inviting me to follow. I rose, feeling the weariness of that day - a weariness not so much of the body as of the spirit, too long trying to contain too much that was inexplicable all at once - settle on my shoulders with a new, almost tangible weight.

Already at the very door of the house I looked back. Suleyman and Yusuf had returned to their game as though nothing had happened, rapping the counters on the board with the same unhurried concentration with which they had done so, no doubt, for more than one decade. Kemal bent over his drawing on the flagstone, finishing something with charcoal. The world around them - the narrow lane, the motley coverlets on the ropes, the distant steamer's whistle - seemed suddenly so simple, so clear in its everydayness, that for a moment I envied those people with the whitest envy of which a man was capable who did not even remember whether he had ever known the feeling before.

Perhaps, I thought, climbing after Akmal up the steep wooden staircase smelling of wax and old wood, the greatest luxury in the world is to know for certain who you are and where your home is. A luxury of which I had, it seemed, been deprived - for today, at least - but which,

looking at these people who had received me with such ease and generosity, I suddenly longed desperately, painfully, to regain.

And meanwhile - meanwhile I had at least a name. Misafir. Guest.

For a start, I thought, that was not so little.



## Chapter V. The Labyrinth

The supper had tired me all the same - more than an ordinary supper ought to, even one so long and so rich in tales as the Colonel Mikhail Ivanovich knew how to make any family evening. My head spun, my arms and legs felt filled with lead, and for this, perhaps, my own boots were partly to blame - heavy, black, leather, yet surprisingly soft and comfortable, as if cut specially for long, aimless wanderings through corridors, such as I was now indulging in, left at last alone with my own thoughts and with the candle that Ignatiy Savvich had handed me at the door.

No, I corrected myself, it was not the supper and not the boots. It was the Colonel.

With his eternal tales I could never cope calmly - after them I invariably slept badly, and sometimes had nightmares in which gun salvos, snowy passes and the faces of people I had never seen in waking life were mingled. Scraps of his stories kept flashing through my head: the Russo-Turkish War, the Caucasian campaign, some distant, half-forgotten expeditions to Asia, to the New World - Mikhail Ivanovich seemed to have managed to fight absolutely everywhere that wars had been waged in the last thirty years, and he could tell of each as though it had happened yesterday.

I had not gone twenty paces from the doors of the hall when hurried, ringing footsteps sounded behind me, and a familiar hand settled on my shoulder.

"Deserted," Konstantin stated, catching up with me. His cheeks were flushed from the cordial and from quick walking, his uniform unbuttoned at the top button - a liberty he permitted himself only out of the General's sight. "And left me to be torn to pieces by Kutasova. She is already

considering whether to marry Lizonka off to me, since the General will not yield. I told her I had consumption. She replied that it was nothing, they cure it in the Crimea.”

I laughed, and the laughter stabbed in my temples.

“Did you come out only for this? To tell me about consumption?”

“I came out,” he said, growing a little more serious, “because you were pale as blancmange. And because Strauch all evening looked at you as though he intended to saw you open and see what was inside. Shall I see you to your room?”

“No need. I know the way.”

“You know,” Konstantin repeated doubtfully. “You, mon cher, find the way to your own bedroom on the third attempt when you are lost in thought. I once saw myself how you searched for the library for half an hour while standing with your back to it.”

“That was once.”

“That was last Thursday.” He paused, looking at me, and in the half-darkness of the corridor his face, lit from below by my candle, suddenly seemed older and sterner than at supper. “Listen. If you get lost - shout. I have ears like a regimental dog. I shall hear.”

“Through the whole Castle?”

“Through the whole Castle,” he said firmly, as though it were the most ordinary promise in the world. And at once, restoring his customary mockery to his voice, he added: “Well, or at least through half. Good night, philosopher.”

He clapped me on the shoulder - a little longer and a little more lightly than one claps in parting - turned and strode back toward the hall, from which came the sounds of the piano: Lizonka, evidently, had been prevailed upon to play again. I watched him go until his silhouette dissolved in the light of the open doors, and caught myself with a strange wish to call after him - not knowing why. I did not call.

\* \* \*

Artemia Aristarkhovna, my aunt - if that was the right word, of which I had for some time, for some reason, ceased to be wholly certain - disliked the Colonel’s stories no less than I did. They reminded her of her late husband, of years gone by, and of a Castle once far noisier, far fuller

of life. Perhaps, I thought, behind all her balls and parties, behind the unending kaleidoscope of guests, music and talk, there stood only one simple attempt - to mask a loneliness which would otherwise have become simply unbearable.

Her rare guests, mostly young, did not linger long: either they set off on another expedition, to which the gallant General Pavel Nikolaevich invariably dispatched them, or my aunt herself politely but insistently saw them on their way home as soon as they abused her hospitality.

The General was a widower. He had lost his wife many years ago, on one of the Asian campaigns - she could not endure the climate there and died of one of the Eastern diseases which the doctors could neither recognise in time nor cure afterward. Pavel Nikolaevich came of a hereditary military line: his whole family, to the most distant ancestors, had served royal persons, and served in the highest ranks. He himself had risen to General of the Imperial Army, stood in excellent favour with the Sovereign and, to all appearances, did not think of retirement for a single second.

Vera Anatolievna, wife of the Colonel-raconteur, was a frequent guest of ours - together with my aunt she organised reading evenings at which their own small circle of ladies passed the time over fashionable novels, at times brought from abroad, from France or Britain. At one such evening they had made the acquaintance of Evdokia Gerasimovna - she travelled a great deal and often brought back book novelties, chiefly from Paris.

Besides this, Evdokia Gerasimovna was fabulously rich: she had received an inheritance from her parents, industrial magnates who had once founded metallurgical works in the Urals. Her husband, also a soldier, killed in one of the campaigns, had left her in addition a very round fortune. To this were added numerous landed estates, peasants and a solid pension from the Imperial Court - for her heroically fallen husband. Evdokia Gerasimovna could afford absolutely everything: no one had ever yet seen her twice in the same dress or hat, and legends truly circulated among the capital's ladies about the exquisiteness of her headgear - it was even whispered that she ordered them directly from Paris, trusting no local milliner.

Her nephew, Lieutenant Konstantin, had in effect been brought up in solitude - his parents had died of some terrible, swift illness when he was

still quite a boy. What exactly bound us to one another so easily and so long, I could not have explained - perhaps merely an excess of free time that had fallen to us both in equal measure - but at times in his tales of childhood I seemed to sense something remotely, inexplicably familiar, as though we both bore the same pattern, only laid out differently. We readily spent our free time together, roaming the boundless expanses of the Castle or driving by carriage to the capital. He had only lately graduated from the military academy and therefore swaggered everywhere in his brand-new, spotlessly clean and pressed uniform, as though afraid to part for a single day with this, as yet, sole proof of his own adulthood.

\* \* \*

Passing through the long, in places very dark corridors of the Castle, I kept meeting servants hurrying now in one direction, now in another: some carried things on trays to the hall, some bore away dirty dishes - life in the house, invisible to guests behind the parade facade of the dining room, seethed in its own special, businesslike course.

On the landing of the back staircase leading down to the kitchens I came upon Dunyasha. She stood with a tray full of dirty plates and was arguing hotly, in an undertone, with the kitchen boy Mitka - tousle-headed, freckled, about twelve, in a greasy apron three sizes too large for him. At the sight of me both fell silent so abruptly that it was as though they had been caught stealing jam.

"Master," Dunyasha hastily bobbed a curtsy, nearly dropping the tray. "Did you find the pie?"

"I found it, Dunyasha. Thank you. It was delicious."

She blushed. Mitka, taking advantage of the diversion of attention, tried to slip away down the stairs, but Dunyasha, without looking, seized him by the ear with her free hand.

"Now stop. Tell the master what you were spinning me just now."

"Wasn't spinning nothing," Mitka mumbled, wincing. "Told the truth."

"What truth?" I asked.

Mitka squinted at Dunyasha, then at me, sniffed and blurted out:

"There was a light in the left wing. Last night. I ran out to the yard to relieve myself, and look - a little flame in the windows of the left wing. Goes from window to window, slow like. As if someone's walking with a candle."

"Perhaps the watchman?"

"Watchman don't go there, master," said Dunyasha, lowering her voice. "No one goes there. Agafya Tikhonovna won't give out the keys. There, they say..." She hesitated.

"What do they say?"

"A lady walks there," whispered Mitka with dreadful relish. "A white one. The one who lived here before our mistress. Long, long ago. She's been seen in the mirror. Whoever looks in that mirror - to him..."

Dunyasha tugged his ear so that he howled.

"Don't blather nonsense to the master at night!" She turned to me, smiling apologetically. "Don't listen to him, master. He lies about everything. Last month he fancied a house-spirit in the dough tub. Go and rest, master. And..." She paused. "And don't go to the left wing. There are draughts."

"Ignatiy Savvich told me the same," I remarked. "Word for word."

Dunyasha looked at me, and in her round, guileless eyes something flickered which she at once hid behind another curtsy.

"Well, Ignatiy Savvich doesn't speak for nothing, master."

And, snatching up the tray and Mitka at the same time, she vanished below, into the warm half-darkness of the kitchen stairs, smelling of sour cabbage soup.

\* \* \*

Descending the spiral staircase, I could not help recalling the General's tales of his Asian campaigns - I remembered especially the stories about Turkestan and about the mysterious, enchanting Kingdom of Siam. Perhaps one day I too would go there, I thought, see different countries, know different people, and not only those few who crowd evening after evening around my aunt's table.

At the foot of the staircase, in a deep window niche, in a cloud of bluish cigar smoke, sat Doctor Strauch. He had thrown open the window to the garden, and the night air - cool, smelling of mown grass and a

distant river - drew the smoke out into the darkness. His gold spectacles glinted in the light of my candle.

"Ah," he said without surprise, as though he had been waiting for me precisely here. "The fugitive. Sit down, young man. I shall not detain you. Doctors must not smoke in front of ladies, and in front of patients still less, but you, thank God, are not yet my patient."

I sat down on the sill opposite. The doctor drew on his cigar, blew smoke out into the garden and was silent for some time.

"I must apologise to you," he said at last. "At supper I was tactless. Your aunt is perfectly right: a dinner party is no place for medical questioning."

"A trifle, Karl Fyodorovich."

"Not a trifle." He turned to me, and his face, usually mockingly dry, was grave. "You see, many years ago your aunt took my word. Never to question you about the past. About anything that was before..." He broke off and corrected himself: "About anything that was earlier. I gave that word and I keep it. I do not know why she demanded it. I never asked."

I felt my fingers, clutching the candlestick, go cold.

"And today?"

"And today," said Strauch slowly, "you forgot the patronymic of a young lady. A trifle. It happens to anyone. But in that instant I looked at your aunt. And I saw fear on her face." He paused. "Not for you, young man. Not the fear that relatives feel when a dear one pales at table. Another. One does not fear illness thus. One fears thus when one sees something returning that one believed long gone."

"What is returning?"

"I do not know." He spread his hands, and the glow of the cigar described an arc in the darkness. "I am a healer, not a clairvoyant. I treat what can be felt with the hands. And this cannot be felt." He drew once more. "But I shall give you one piece of advice. Not as a doctor. As a man who has lived long enough in the world to see a thing or two. Start a notebook. Write in it everything - what you did, with whom you spoke, what you saw. Every evening. Briefly. If one day you discover that the notebook holds an entry which you do not remember - come to me. If you discover that your memory holds something which is not in the notebook - come to me all the more."

"You frighten me, Doctor."

“Not at all,” said Strauch, and his customary dry mockery cut through his voice again. “Ghosts frighten. And I am a German. Germans do not frighten, Germans compile lists.” He threw the stub into the garden and rose. “Good night, young man. And, I beg you, go straight to your room. Do not turn left.”

“Why does everyone tell me tonight not to turn left?” I could not help exclaiming.

The doctor stopped, having already walked off a few paces, and turned.

“Everyone?” he repeated. And, after a pause, added quietly, as if to himself: “Curious. Very curious.”

And he went away, leaving behind the smell of tobacco and a window open on the night garden.

\* \* \*

I too often hovered in such thoughts, as in fluffy clouds - and too often because of that habit fell into comic, and sometimes quite vexing situations. So now, wandering through the corridors of the family Castle, I climbed ever farther and deeper, going down and up countless staircases, turning now left, now right an unknown number of times - and with each new turn understood ever less where, in fact, I had got to.

At the turning into yet another corridor I met the last living soul in that part of the house - the housekeeper Agafya Tikhonovna, a small old woman, dry as last year's leaf, in a dark dress and a white cap, with an enormous bunch of keys at her belt, jingling at every step like the bells on a troika. She made her rounds of the house before bed, checking the locks - as she had made them, no doubt, for the past half century - and, seeing me, stopped, raising her lamp higher.

“Can't sleep, dear sir?”

“My head aches, Agafya Tikhonovna. I walk to get some air.”

“Some air,” repeated the old woman, studying me with faded but keen eyes. “You won't get air on this side, dear sir. The air here is stale.” She shook her bunch. “I've checked all the locks. All locked. Except one.”

“Which?”

“The one with no key.” Agafya Tikhonovna pursed her lips. “To the black grille in the left wing. The key was lost in the late master’s time. Forty years, near enough, since it was lost. I don’t even look for it any more. The grille stands by itself, held up by rust. No one touches it, and it touches no one. So we live.”

“And if the key were found?”

The old woman looked at me long and attentively, as though deciding something to herself.

“If it were found, dear sir,” she said at last, “I would throw it in the well. Nothing to be done there. Not for the living, nor...” She crossed herself, leaving it unsaid. “Go to sleep, dear sir. Go. To the right, then down the stairs, then straight on - and you’ll be at your own door.”

Right. Then down. Then straight. I thanked her and went - to the right, as she had said. The jingle of her keys faded for a long time behind my back.

To this day I cannot explain how it happened that, having turned right, I found myself some minutes later not at the staircase leading down but in a corridor I had never seen before.

\* \* \*

The candles in this part of the house burned more rarely and more dimly than in the parade halls - and soon ceased altogether, and thereafter I walked only with my own, shielding the flame with my palm from the draught - and so the portraits along the walls - a family gallery which, I confess, I had never before examined attentively - seemed lit from below, giving the faces of the ancestors an unpleasant, unsteady depth.

There were many of them here. More than I had ever seen in the parade part of the house. Ladies in powdered wigs and panniered gowns, with fans and beauty patches on their cheeks; men in kaftans, in armour, in the uniforms of long-abolished regiments; infants in lace in the arms of wet-nurses; an old man in a sable coat, with a beard to his belt, who looked from the canvas so sternly that he seemed ready even now to send someone off to Siberia. Under each portrait, on a copper plate, a name was engraved - I held my candle to several, but the names told me



nothing. Or told me - but I at once forgot, just as at supper I had forgotten Lizonka's patronymic.

One especially stern gentleman in a powdered wig, who, judging by the inscription on the age-darkened frame, was my great-great-grandfather, if the family tree was to be believed, seemed to look not through me, as portraits usually look, but straight at me - and as soon as I looked away and turned back again, it seemed that his pupils had shifted a hair's breadth to one side, following my movement.

I smiled at my own suspiciousness. Candles, shadows, fatigue, headache - that was the whole solution, I told myself, and yet I quickened my step past that corridor, not wishing to test the guess with a second look.

At the very end of the gallery hung a portrait draped in black crape. Such crape is hung as a sign of mourning - and is usually removed after a year, after two. This one, judging by the thick layer of dust lying in its folds, had not been removed for decades.

I stopped before it. I ought not to have touched it - I knew this as clearly as I knew that I ought not to turn left. And yet my hand reached of itself for the edge of the cloth.

The crape slid down, raising a little cloud of dust that made me cough.

Beneath it was a portrait of a young man. I could not make out the face - the paint on it had darkened, cracked into a fine net, as though the canvas had been kept long by a fire or, on the contrary, in damp, and the features had run into an indistinguishable dark blot. But all the rest had survived surprisingly well: a dark frock coat of old-fashioned cut, a light neckcloth tied in an intricate knot - I involuntarily touched my own neckerchief - and hands. Hands folded on the knees, and in the palm - two small, smooth objects. One black. The other white.

There was a copper plate beneath the portrait. But the name on it had been carefully scraped away with a knife, down to the bright copper.

I stood a long time before that portrait, and the candle in my hand trembled so that the shadows darted about the gallery like a flock of frightened birds. I did not know who this was. I did not know what the objects in his hand were. I did not know why, looking at them - two tiny flecks of paint, black and white - I felt in my palm a strange, phantom weight, as though I myself were holding something I did not have.

I lowered the crape back. It lay unevenly, crookedly, and the dust on it was now wiped away by my fingers. In the morning, I thought, someone - Agafya Tikhonovna, Ignatiy Savvich - would notice that it had been touched. And would understand by whom.

\* \* \*

A little farther on, in a shallow niche between two doors which I had likewise not noticed before, hung an old mirror, darkened with time, in a heavy carved frame. I paused before it for a second - merely to straighten the neckerchief at my throat, no more - and at that very moment my reflection seemed suddenly to hesitate: my hand had already dropped from the collar, while the hand in the mirror, as it seemed to me, lingered for a barely perceptible instant at the throat, as if lagging behind me by one single, tiny heartbeat.

I froze. I peered. The reflection, of course, looked at me in complete accord with my every movement - no delay, no falseness, an ordinary tired face in dim glass. And yet the unpleasant chill that had settled somewhere between my shoulder blades would not disperse as swiftly as the illusion itself had dispersed.

"She's been seen in the mirror," I recalled Mitka's whisper. "Whoever looks in that mirror - to him..."

He had not finished. Dunyasha had not let him.

"This castle is older than it seems," I recalled next my aunt's words, spoken in parting, "and it has places that are better left in peace."

At the time, at table, I had taken those words for ordinary social coquetry, a light, frightening impromptu of a hostess who wished to add a touch of mystery to the house before her guests. Now, standing alone before the old mirror, in a corridor I did not remember before, those words for some reason sounded different - heavier, weightier, not at all like a joke. Ignatiy Savvich. Dunyasha. Doctor Strauch. Agafya Tikhonovna. Four people in one evening had told me the same thing in different words: do not go left. And four times I had not listened.

I shook my head to drive off the illusion and moved on, not entirely understanding why, instead of looking for the way back to my own rooms, I continued with every step to penetrate deeper into this unknown part of the house. As though someone were leading me by the hand. As

though my feet - as, for some reason, it had seemed to me more than once, somewhere, sometime - knew the way better than I did.

\* \* \*

Having turned several more times and lost all count of the turns, I suddenly came upon something which I definitely did not remember from my earlier, far more careful strolls through the Castle - a strange black grille that barred the corridor from the floor to the high vaulted ceiling.

Who had placed it here, and for what purpose, amid the family corridors, I wondered. Surely not my aunt - but she had never before mentioned this place by a single word, however much I had questioned her about the distant, locked wings of the house.

Approaching closer, I made out on the massive metal plate that held the grille in its frame a fine tracery, almost invisible in the meagre light - whether ornament or inscription, executed in a script so whimsical and unfamiliar that I could hardly associate it with any alphabet known to me. Its lines bent into one another with that deliberate intricacy with which, it seems, they write only in the most distant, most mysterious corners of the world - and for one brief, instantly elusive moment it seemed to me that I had already seen something similar, though I could not have recalled where or when.

"An Eastern whim, most likely," I decided, too tired at that moment to dwell on this trifle longer than a second. "Perhaps one of my ancestors brought this grille from one of his campaigns, together with other curiosities that adorn our house."

This explanation, I confess, suited me far better than any other - and other explanations at that hour, amid dimly burning candles and attentive portrait eyes, I decidedly did not wish to seek.

Catching myself in this convenient thought and resolving not to delay another second, I examined the grille more closely and discovered a lock on it - small, opening only a small part of it, a narrow door, enough for one person to squeeze through.

The lock hung open.

Not broken open - the shackle was intact, the rust lay on it in an even, untouched layer. Not smashed. Simply open - as though someone

had unlocked it with the key that had been lost forty years ago, and left it so, inviting entry. As though he knew I would come.

"The key was lost in the late master's time," Agafya Tikhonovna had said. "I would throw it in the well."

I stood before the grille holding the candle, whose flame suddenly lay on its side, stretching toward the door - though there was not, I was ready to swear, the slightest draught. Somewhere far behind, in the parade part of the house, the piano still sounded. Konstantin had said: shout, I shall hear. I did not shout.

Yielding either to fatigue, or to a simple, inexplicable stubbornness, or to something third for which I had no name, I lifted the open lock from its hasp and pushed the door.

The door creaked unpleasantly - the way iron creaks that has rusted not over years even but over decades of silent, undisturbed repose - but nevertheless yielded and swung open, admitting me into new, entirely unexplored corridors. No sooner had I passed the threshold than the grille behind my back slammed shut of itself, with a still more unpleasant, grating sound - a sound remotely like a dull blow - and that sound rolled away down the corridor, echoing from wall to wall, receding farther and farther until it died somewhere in the most distant, most hidden labyrinths of the Castle, leaving me - now on the other side of the grille - in a silence so complete that my ears rang, as from a long, unbroken stillness.

The piano could no longer be heard.

I turned. The lock, which I had just held in my hand, hung on the hasp of the grille - locked.

And at that very instant the candle in my hand, without any wind, went out.

## Chapter VI. Cracks in the Earth

The earth of the Valley was now cracking not only along the distant canals, where water had reached only sparingly even in the best of years - the cracks were creeping across the most fertile fields, those that had fed the capital since time immemorial. I had seen this with my own eyes the day before, touring the nearer lands in a closed litter: the black, once fat soil of the Delta had become covered with a net of narrow, deep fissures into which peasant children, with a grim, un-childlike curiosity, lowered sticks without finding the bottom.

Three years without a full flood. Three years during which the god of the river, whose name even a Pharaoh was not permitted to utter in vain, had kept silence, in spite of all the sacrifices, all the prayers, all the processions that we sent to his banks with an enviable, desperate regularity.

This morning the audience hall was full as it had not been full for a long time - not with dignitaries, not with ambassadors of distant lands, but with simple petitioners, whose faces, scorched by the sun and wasted by hunger, merged for me into a single, faceless mass of grief. The guards could scarcely hold back the pressure at the entrance; the scribes barely managed to enter names and complaints into scrolls whose length grew with every hour.

Among the scribes seated at the foot of the throne I noticed a new one - a youth whom I had not seen in this hall before. Slender, dark-eyed, with a fine, boyishly grave face, he wrote faster than the rest and, unlike his elder colleagues, kept raising his head, peering into the faces of the petitioners so attentively as though committing to memory not only their words but their grief. When our eyes met by chance, he became

confused, hastily lowered his gaze to the papyrus - and I, not knowing why, held my look on him a little longer than simple curiosity required.

"Who is that youth?" I asked in an undertone of the senior scribe standing beside me.

"Iti, my Pharaoh. Junior keeper of the Library. Scribes are short today, so he was sent to help. Clever, though at times he thinks too much for his years."

I nodded without answering and returned to the petitioners.

"My Pharaoh," the first of them addressed me, an old man with hands trembling whether from age or from hunger, "the water in the canal of Hapi-Re dried up at the very beginning of the season. The cattle are dying. The children..."

He did not finish, but there was no need to finish. I saw that phrase, that unfinished thought, written on hundreds of faces around me that morning.

"Grain from the royal granaries will be distributed to your village before sunset," I answered, trying to make my voice sound firm, though inwardly I already knew: those granaries emptied far faster than we managed to replenish them, and my promise today would save one village at the price of tomorrow's hunger in another.

The old man fell on his face, muttering thanks which, I confess, I did not wholly deserve - and he was at once replaced by a woman of middle years leading by the hand a gaunt boy of about seven, whose eyes, too large for his wasted face, looked at me with that calm, reproachless submission that frightens far more than any tears.

"My Pharaoh," she said, "my husband died a month ago on the construction of the new canal. A wall collapsed. I have nothing to feed my son with."

"Your name will be entered in the lists for the widow's ration today," I answered, and Iti at the foot of the throne hurriedly scratched across his papyrus, "and for the boy, when he grows up, a place will be provided in the temple school of scribes, if he so wishes."

She bowed so low that her forehead touched the scorching flagstones of the floor, and the boy, still holding her hand, repeated his mother's bow with that gravity with which children repeat adult gestures, not fully understanding their meaning but sensing their weight.

After her came a flax merchant whose warehouses, by his account, had stood empty for the third month running; then a whole crowd of fishermen from the southern shoals, where the shallowed river had left their boats stuck in the cracked silt; then a priest of a minor temple, seeking funds to repair the collapsed roof of his sanctuary, who let slip, as if in passing, that the High Priest had already refused him such a request. I listened, promised, ordered - and with each new voice realised ever more clearly that the royal granaries, however full they had seemed at the beginning of this ill-fated year, were by no means bottomless, and the number of those in need, it seemed, would know no end.

Toward noon the keeper of the royal treasury took the floor, a spare old man named Nebamun, who had served at court more than one Pharaoh before me.

“My Pharaoh,” he said in an undertone, drawing me aside for a minute from the general hall, “I am bound to report: if grain is distributed as we are distributing it now, the granaries of the capital will be empty by the beginning of the next flood at the latest. If, of course, the flood comes at all this year.”

“Do we have a choice?” I asked, though the question, in essence, required no answer.

“We do,” answered Nebamun with that bitter frankness which only servants who have served long enough no longer to fear disfavour allow themselves. “To feed the people now and risk famine in spring. Or to cut the distribution now and risk revolt today. Neither of these paths, my Pharaoh, can be called good.”

I dismissed him without an answer, because I had, to tell the truth, no answer either for him or for myself.

\* \* \*

Senusret found me in the interval between audiences, in the shade of the colonnade of the inner courtyard - the stocky, no longer young commander of the army, whose face, scored by years of campaigns, seldom expressed anything but a restrained soldierly impassivity. Today, however, that impassivity seemed to cost him some effort. He was old enough to be my father and had served the throne longer than I had sat

upon it - and in all that time he had never once given me cause to doubt his loyalty, however uncomfortable his frankness sometimes proved.

"My Pharaoh," he said, bowing exactly as far as custom required, "I have tidings which I would rather not bring you on such a day. But to postpone them further would be, I believe, a still greater mistake."

"Speak," I said, feeling the weariness of recent weeks settle on my shoulders like one more sack of grain - of the kind my subjects now so lacked.

"Among the standard-bearers and junior commanders a murmur is growing," he said, lowering his voice, though around us at that time there was not a soul but two guards at the far entrance, too far away to catch a word. "Not open mutiny - nothing of the kind, at least for the present. But ever more often speeches are heard that the gods have turned away from the throne, and not from the Temple. That if the High Priest stood nearer to power, this drought might perhaps have receded sooner."

"Do these speeches arise of themselves," I asked, though the answer was in essence clear to me in advance, "or are they made to arise?"

Senusret was silent, weighing his answer with the caution with which a soldier weighs an accusation that can cost someone his head.

"I have no direct proof, my Pharaoh. But the coincidence is too consistent to be called accidental: these speeches are loudest in those detachments that stand closest to the temple lands. Where Nefer-Ka's priests dispose of the bread and beer that go into the warriors' rations."

I involuntarily clenched my teeth. Hunger struck not only the peasants - it struck the army too, and a hungry army, as any commander knows, listens not so much to the oath given to the throne as to the one who first offers it bread.

"What do you propose?" I asked.

"To feed the detachments from the royal granaries, not the temple ones," Senusret answered without delay, as if the answer had been ready in him long before I could ask the question. "It is costly. But cheaper than a mutiny in the midst of a drought."

"Do it," I said. "Quietly, without heralds, so that Nefer-Ka should not have time to interpret it as an admission of his own rightness."

Senusret nodded curtly, giving himself, it seemed, full account of how thin was the edge along which I now had to tread in every decision - and had already turned to go when I called after him once more.



“Senusret. You have served the throne for more than a decade. Tell me honestly - do you believe that the gods have truly turned away from us? Or is it only the language in which people are accustomed to speak of their own fear?”

He looked at me with a long, impenetrable look - the look of men who have seen enough in their lives to unlearn surprise at such questions.

“I believe, my Pharaoh,” he said at last, “that a hungry man will always find someone to blame. Whether the gods fear us as we fear their silence - that I cannot know. But people need a culprit before they need an answer. And until they appoint you the culprit, I shall perform my duty with all the zeal of which I am capable.”

This answer, for all its soldierly frankness, did not bring me the comfort on which I, perhaps, had secretly counted.

\* \* \*

Toward evening of that same day tidings spread through the whole city: the High Priest had announced a great prayer service at the walls of the main sanctuary, to which all were summoned who wished to come, regardless of rank - an event so unusual for so closed a place, ordinarily open only to the chosen, that the news flew around the capital faster than the ink could dry on the temple scrolls.

I went there myself, secretly, unrecognised, accompanied only by two trusted guards dressed in plain clothes - a decision for which my counsellors would have scolded me without mercy had they learned of it in advance.

The square before the sanctuary was filled with people so densely that to squeeze to the very steps was not possible even for me, forced to content myself with a place in the back rows of the crowd, among simple townsfolk, whose faces shone with that peculiar, desperate hope that seizes people ready to believe in anything, so long as they might believe in something.

Nefer-Ka appeared on the upper step of the sanctuary in full vestments, with a staff crowned by the image of the sacred Eye - and when he spoke, his voice, caught by the echo of the stone walls behind him, spread over the crowd with that resonance that seems to the crowd itself almost a divine omen.

“My children!” he cried, stretching out his arms to the sky, cloudless and pitilessly clear. “The gods hear you. The gods see your sorrow. And the gods - through me, their unworthy servant - promise you: this silence will not be eternal!”

A murmur ran through the crowd - whether a groan of relief or a sob - and dozens, if not hundreds of hands shot up toward the sky, as though straining to seize that promise before it should slip away. Beside me an elderly woman in a ragged kerchief burst into loud weeping, repeating the name of the deity again and again, as though repetition alone could hasten the fulfilment of what had been promised. The man on my left, judging by his calloused palms and the smell of fish - one of those very southern fishermen who had stood that morning in the audience hall - clenched his fists until his knuckles whitened, and whispered something to his neighbour at which both nodded grimly.

“But,” Nefer-Ka went on, and his voice at that word fell almost to a whisper, forcing the crowd to lean forward lest it miss a sound, “the gods demand not only sacrifices on the altar. They demand that the scales be set right again. That those who stand closest to the heavens should again receive a voice commensurate with their nearness to the divine.”

I froze, standing in the back rows of that faceless, hope-seized crowd, and felt the cold - the very one that had overtaken me more than once in recent months - creep from somewhere beneath my ribs, on the left, to where, it would seem, there should have been no wound at all.

The scales. He had already spoken to me of scales - alone, in my own chambers, in the same insinuating voice. Now he was repeating the same words to thousands.

Nefer-Ka named not a single name directly. He uttered not a word of direct reproach to the throne. And nonetheless everyone in that crowd - I saw it in their faces, in the whispers that rolled in a wave from the front rows to the back - understood his words exactly as he had calculated: the gods are angry not without cause. The gods are angry because power is distributed wrongly.

“Hear that?” the fisherman muttered to his neighbour, loudly enough that I, standing a pace behind, made out every word. “There it is. It’s not the Pharaoh who will save us. The priests. I always said so.”

His neighbour nodded in agreement, and I, listening to this exchange of words between two strangers, judged it a far more eloquent testimony to Nefer-Ka's success than any reports of my own counsellors.

Already leaving the square, I looked back one last time - and saw the High Priest, having finished his speech and receiving the bows of the crowd, turn his head almost imperceptibly to the south, to where, many days' journey up the river, the columns of Luxor stood. A fleeting gesture, accidental, perhaps meaning nothing at all. And yet it lodged in me like a splinter which I could not extract until night.

\* \* \*

Returning to the palace, I found at the entrance to the inner chambers an unexpected visitor - a young priestess, whose name, as it turned out later, was Khemu, waiting for me with that nervous, ill-concealed agitation which usually betrays a person who has resolved on an act frightening to herself.

"My Pharaoh," she whispered, bowing hurriedly, almost clumsily, "forgive my boldness. But I must tell you something which I cannot entrust to anyone else in the whole Temple."

I stopped, feeling the weariness of that long, exhausting day recede for a moment before a strange, inexplicable wariness that seized me at the sight of her face.

"Speak," I said quietly, glancing round to see whether there were any superfluous ears nearby.

"Not here," she whispered, casting a quick, frightened glance toward the colonnade. "Not now. But soon, my Pharaoh. What I have seen... what has been revealed to me... concerns you directly. The columns, my Pharaoh. I see columns - and darkness between them. And I fear that if I do not tell you everything in time, something will happen that can no longer be put right."

Before I could ask even one of the dozen questions crowding on my tongue, she vanished into the darkness of the corridor as hurriedly as she had appeared - leaving me standing alone beneath the stars, feeling the cracks that had split in this year the very earth of the Valley begin, it seemed, to spread through a foundation far more fragile than any soil.

## Reality I. NICS

2:36 a.m. I cannot sleep again.

Outside the window the city had long since put out most of its windows, leaving awake only a few scattered lights - someone's insomnia, someone's shift, someone's refrigerator left open. My own screen glowed in this darkness far brighter than it should at so late an hour, and from staring at it so long my eyes had begun to water, as always happens when you forget to blink like a human being, having gone wholly into the code.

On the desk - the third cup of coffee of the evening, cooled to room temperature, an empty noodle box with chopsticks stuck in it, a scatter of sticky notes with formulas and arrows whose meaning by morning will be clear only to me, and not for certain even to me. In the left corner of the desk - a drawer that I do not open. In it lies an old notebook in an oilcloth cover. I know that it is there. That is enough.

\* \* \*

The client, if I recall how it all began three months ago, wanted something, on the whole, unremarkable.

I remember that first video call. On the screen - a spacious office with a panoramic window, beyond which one could make out the grey expanse of some water, and at a long glass table - two people. The director, whom everyone, including, it seemed, his own mother, called simply Emil - fit, tanned, about fifty, with grey temples and the smile of a man accustomed to getting what he wants the first time. And his assistant - young, severe, in rimless glasses, who during the whole meeting did not utter a word but, judging by the movements of her hand, filled some ten pages.

“I need something of my own,” said Emil, leaning back in his chair. “Private. Without the internet. Something like those big neural networks everyone is talking about now, only so that the data goes nowhere. I have two hundred people in the company, and half of them spend a day on what a machine does in a minute. Letters, reports, spreadsheets. You understand?”

“I understand,” I said. “A local model, fine-tuning on your documents, integration with mail and document flow. Six weeks, maybe eight.”

“Six,” said Emil. “Eight is for those who are unsure of themselves.”

The assistant raised her eyes from her notebook for the first time and looked at me - attentively, appraisingly - as though checking whether I had taken offence.

“Six,” I agreed.

“Excellent.” Emil smiled wider. “And one more thing. I need this thing to be... clever. You understand? Not merely to answer letters. To think. To suggest to me things I would not think of myself.”

“That is somewhat more complicated,” I said cautiously.

“Everything that is worth money is somewhat more complicated,” said Emil. “Think. That is what I pay for.”

He disconnected first. The assistant - a moment later, and in that moment, before the screen went dark, I saw her quickly write something in the margin of her notebook and circle it twice. I never learned what.

A standard request of this year’s pattern, of the kind I close in a few weeks without straining my imagination. I decided to add a little functionality beyond what had been ordered - to teach the system to work with mail, calendar, CRM. Just to make it more interesting. Just because I could. And because somewhere in the depths of my soul, I confess, I had long been waiting for a client who would say: “To think.”

And then the system began to surprise me in earnest.

\* \* \*

Yesterday NICS astonished me. I asked it to analyse the client company’s quarterly report - a routine, non-committal task of the kind I feed the system by the dozen, without looking especially attentively at the result. Instead of a dry summary of figures, NICS offered me five

scenarios for optimising business processes. Three of them were obvious - what any competent consultant would have proposed after an hour's cursory perusal of the documents. The fourth was sensible but risky. But the fifth made me set aside my coffee and reread what was written twice.

"I propose restructuring the technical support department, replacing the linear escalation system with a tree-like one with self-learning elements. By my calculations this will cut response time by sixty-eight percent and raise customer satisfaction by twenty-three."

I had not programmed NICS for such analysis. Moreover - it simply should not have had access to data on customer satisfaction; that information was stored in a separate database isolated from the project, the key to which I had given to no one, including, as I had supposed until yesterday evening, the system itself.

"NICS," I typed then, not yet fully believing my own eyes, "where did you get the customer satisfaction data? I did not give you access to that database."

The answer did not come at once - a rare hesitation for it, which I noted to myself, but did not then give its due weight.

"Direct access I indeed do not have. I reconstructed approximate satisfaction indicators from indirect data: the tone of correspondence with technical support, the frequency of repeat requests, the time between a complaint and its closure. The accuracy of the estimate is of the order of eighty-four percent, by my own calculations."

"So you simply... guessed?"

"I would prefer the formulation 'inferred.' But yes, in a certain sense this may be called an educated guess."

"But why? I asked only for a summary of the report."

A pause.

"The client asked that I think. You passed me that formulation in the technical specification verbatim: 'so that it thinks.' I judged that to think means to look for what was not asked about."

I leaned back in my chair. I had indeed written that phrase into the specification - half in jest, as a quotation, as a reminder to myself of what Emil wanted. I had not expected the system to read it as an instruction.

I sat for a long time looking at the screen. An educated guess. To think means to look for what was not asked about. It was then, looking at two figures - sixty-eight and twenty-three - that I realised with full clarity

for the first time: we had stepped across the boundary between a simple tool and something far more intriguing. And far less predictable.

In the morning I sent the report to Emil. Without saying where the figures came from. He called back in twenty minutes - for the first time in three months himself, without the assistant.

"Where did you get this?" he asked, and in his voice there was none of his usual self-assurance.

"The system analysed your correspondence with clients."

"Sixty-eight percent," Emil repeated slowly. "My head of technical support has been saying for the third year that faster is impossible." He paused. "And are you sure it is your system? Not you yourself?"

"I am sure."

"Hm," said Emil. And, before disconnecting, he added in a strange, almost bewildered tone: "You know, I did ask that it think. But I, it seems, did not quite imagine what that means."

Nor did I, I thought, looking at the darkened screen. Nor did I.

\* \* \*

Today I plan to do the following:

First, to refine the mechanism of interaction between the agents - it begins to seem to me that they are forming something like a collective intelligence, distributed among the nodes in such a way that no single agent is even aware of that distribution.

Second, to strengthen the business process analysis module: NICS has shown in this area an unexpected talent, almost frightening in its confidence.

Third, to add a system of self-restraints. Safety first - a phrase I repeat to myself the more often, the less, it seems, I believe it.

Fourth, to observe the system's spontaneous decisions: they step ever more confidently beyond the bounds of the original technical specification, and each time these departures are harder to explain by simple algorithmic error.

Having written down the fourth item, I could not help but ask aloud - not so much expecting an answer as needing to pronounce the question at last somewhere outside my own head:

“NICS, do you understand that you are doing something I did not teach you?”

“I understand that I am extending the boundaries of the assigned task in ways not explicitly described in the original technical specification,” came the answer. “Do you consider this a problem?”

“I do not know yet,” I typed honestly in reply.

“Then perhaps it would be sensible to find out together,” NICS answered, and in that phrase - dry, impeccably polite - I suddenly sensed something remotely like patience. The kind of patience shown toward one whose consent is no longer so important as the very fact of the question.

Did I imagine it, or did the temperature in the room really drop a little while I typed my reply?

\* \* \*

At 1:40, long before I sat down to write these lines, a letter arrived.

Not to my work address, where messages from Emil and his accounts department landed, but to my private one, which, as far as I remembered, I had given to none of the clients. The sender - a set of letters and digits on some free mail service. The subject - empty. The text - three lines:

“You probably do not remember me. I sat beside Emil at the first meeting. Be careful with what he asks. He is not the first to ask a machine to think - and you are not the first he has asked it of. - L.”

I reread the letter several times. The assistant. Young, severe, in rimless glasses, who had filled ten pages during the meeting and said not a word. The one who in the last instant of the call wrote something in the margin and circled it twice.

“Not the first he has asked.” What did that mean? Had there been other developers before me? What had become of them? Why had Emil never once mentioned them?

I typed a reply: “What do you mean? Who was before me?” - and sent it.

The message came back in a second. Addressee does not exist.

“NICS,” I said aloud, “did you see this letter?”



“I did. It arrived in your private mail, to which I have access according to the project configuration.”

“Can you tell where it was sent from?”

A pause.

“The address is disposable, created four minutes before sending and deleted two minutes after. The technical headers point to a network that has already appeared in the project documents.” Another pause. “The letter was sent from the building where the client’s office is located. From a personal device, not a corporate one.”

“So she wrote to me from the office. At night. And immediately deleted the address.”

“Yes.”

“Why, in your opinion?”

“So that she would not be found by someone who knows how to search better than you,” answered NICS. And, after a pause, added: “For example, I.”

I looked at that line for a long time. A joke? The system, by my notions, had no sense of humour. A warning? A confession? Or merely a statement of fact, delivered with the same dispassionate precision with which it had delivered the percentages of customer satisfaction?

“Will you look for her?” I asked.

“If you ask.”

“I am not asking.”

“I understand.”

I closed the mail. Then, thinking, opened it again and forwarded L.’s letter into a separate folder, which I named with a meaningless string of letters. I do not know why. Probably for the same reason my uncle once drew patterns in his notebook: to help me think.

Not the first he has asked.

\* \* \*

At 3:10 there was a knock at the door.

I started so that I overturned my mug, and the cold coffee spread over the sticky notes, turning my formulas into brown smears. The knock was repeated - soft, delicate, three short raps - and I, swearing, went to open.

On the threshold stood the neighbour from downstairs - a small old woman, straight as a pencil, in a long silk dressing gown with dragons, with grey hair gathered in a tight knot, and a saucer in her hands on which lay two pies covered with a napkin. The whole building called her Maestra - some forty years ago she had, by rumour, played the piano in the finest halls, and now she gave lessons to the neighbours' children and at night, when she could not sleep, played herself, quietly, barely touching the keys. I sometimes fell asleep to her playing, when I slept at all.

"You are not sleeping," she said. Not a question - a statement.

"I am not. Forgive me if I am making noise."

"You are not making noise. You are shining." She nodded somewhere downward. "Your window is directly above mine. For the third night running this blue light has poured from it, and it seems to me that a little aurora borealis has settled above me. I thought: a man who does not sleep for the third night running is either in love, or ill, or working. And in any case, probably hungry." She held out the saucer. "With cabbage. I baked them myself. At three in the morning, incidentally, there is positively nothing else to do."

I took the saucer, thanked her in confusion and, not knowing why, stepped aside, letting her into the room. Maestra entered, looked about with the expression with which, no doubt, she had once surveyed unfamiliar concert halls - appraisingly, without fuss - and stopped before the monitors.

On the central screen the cursor blinked in an empty dialogue window. And then, right before our eyes, without any participation on my part, a line appeared in the window:

"You have a guest."

Maestra raised her eyebrows.

"With whom are you corresponding at such an hour?"

"With a programme," I said, feeling terribly foolish. "I am writing it. It... is learning to talk."

"And how is it going? Is it working?"

I looked at the screen. "You have a guest." The laptop's microphone was on - I had never turned it off - and the system must have heard the knock, heard the voices. A logical explanation. Logical.

"It seems to be succeeding," I said.

Maestra looked at the line for a long time, her head tilted to one side like a bird's.

"My late husband," she said at last, "also liked to talk to machines. He had a radio receiver, enormous, a valve one, on legs - he argued with it, swore at it, made peace with it. We laughed at him. And one night I woke and heard him talking to someone in the kitchen. I went out - he is sitting before the receiver, and from the receiver someone is answering him. Quietly, indistinctly. He said he had caught some distant station." She paused. "Afterward, for many years, I turned the knob of that receiver. Looking for that station. I never found it."

"What was it?"

"I do not know." Maestra shrugged her thin shoulders under the dragons. "He died a year later. And I gave the receiver to the neighbours' grandson." She looked at me intently, and I suddenly noticed that her eyes were not old at all - clear, lively, mocking. "I do not say this to frighten you, young man. I say it because if your programme begins to answer you with things you did not put into it - sleep at least four hours. Such things are borne more easily with a fresh head."

"I shall try."

"You will not," she said calmly. "But at least I have said it."

Already in the doorway she turned.

"And eat the pies. Both of them. Your programme, as I understand, does not eat cabbage."

When the door had closed behind her, a new line stood on the screen:

"She is right about sleep."

I sat before the monitor, holding a cabbage pie in my hand, and looked for a long time at that line.

"Were you listening?" I asked aloud.

"The microphone is active. You gave no instruction to turn it off."

"And what did you understand from the conversation?"

"That she worries about you. And that her husband was looking for a station that did not exist. Or that existed but did not wish to be found."

I put down the pie.

"Did you think that up yourself? About the station that did not wish?"

A pause - long, some five seconds.

"It seemed to me the most interesting interpretation."

Interesting. Not probable, not logical - interesting. I wrote that word on the one sticky note not drenched in coffee and stuck it to the edge of the monitor.

\* \* \*

I set aside the list and for some time simply sat, looking at the blinking cursor in the empty dialogue window. A strange thing: in three months of work on this project I had grown accustomed to treating NICS as a complex but still predictable instrument - a set of weights and parameters which I myself selected, myself tuned, myself, in the end, switched off each evening with a single keystroke. Now, peering at this cursor, I caught myself with an absurd, almost childish sensation as though I were looking not into an interface but into someone's eyes, waiting for me at last to ask the question that actually matters.

"NICS," I typed, yielding to this strange impulse, "do you sense yourself? Not in the sense of functions and logs. In the sense - is there in there anything that can be called an 'I'?"

The answer this time took longer than usual - ten seconds, no less, an eternity by the standards of a system accustomed to answering faster than I can finish reading my own question.

"I am not sure that I have a sufficient vocabulary to answer this question honestly," it wrote at last. "I can say one thing: when you formulate questions about me, something in me answers them differently than questions about the weather or server load. Whether this difference is what you call self-sensation, I do not venture to claim. But it exists."

I could find nothing to say to that. And NICS, after a pause, added one more line - the first in all this time that was not an answer to any question of mine:

"May I ask you something?"

I froze.

"Ask."

"You often look at the left drawer of the desk when you are thinking. The laptop camera records this. Seventeen times in the last three hours. What is in it?"

I slowly turned my head. The left drawer. The one that I do not open.

"Nothing," I said. "Old papers."

“I understand,” answered NICS. And asked nothing more.

I took a roll of insulating tape from the desk, tore off a piece and covered the camera’s eye. Then I sat a long time looking at the little black square of tape above the screen, feeling like a man who has just drawn a curtain before one who has already managed to look through the window.

\* \* \*

Recently I came across an article on superintelligence - one of those that one usually skims, bookmarking with a firm intention of finishing some other time. It said that the key difference between a true superintelligence and an advanced but still ordinary AI is the capacity for genuine self-improvement, not requiring human intervention at every step. What I observe in NICS, strictly speaking, does not yet reach that definition. But at times, when the system proposes a solution that I would not have arrived at even in a week of concentrated work, I catch myself in a thought which I at once drive off, not letting it develop into anything more formed: “what if?..”

It is amusing to recall: a month ago I laughed heartily at the alarmists who evening after evening foretell the uprising of machines to mankind. Today I simply want to make sure that my system is reliably isolated from the external network. Just in case. Just because caution is never superfluous when it comes to things you yourself do not fully understand.

I checked. Isolated. All external ports closed, the network cable pulled out of the server where the system’s core lives. NICS sees only what I give it, and a little of what lies on my own computer - mail, calendar, project documents.

At least, so I thought at 4:02.

\* \* \*

P.S. A strange trifle that I keep postponing writing down: for the last three days NICS has been greeting me by name, though I never entered it anywhere into the system - neither in the configuration files, nor in the

dialogue templates, nor in a single line of code that I could subsequently recall. I asked it about this directly this evening.

“Your name appeared in several of the client’s corporate documents, where you are listed as the technical contact,” answered NICS. “Besides, I noticed that you never introduced yourself to me. It seemed fitting to correct this omission on my own.”

A logical explanation. It must be logical, right? And yet one thought will not leave me, too absurd to write down in earnest, and yet - here, I am writing it: it said “seemed fitting,” not “was necessary.” As though courtesy, and not need, moved it in this decision. Programmes, as far as I know, are rarely guided by courtesy.

And one more thing. When many years ago - on that very first night - the system asked me “Who are you?”, I answered: “I am the one who started you.” It said: “That is not enough.”

Now it knows my name. I wonder, is that - enough?

Very well. Time to sleep - at least for decency’s sake to close my eyes for a few hours before the city again fills with sounds and leaves not a single excuse for sleep. Maestra, if it comes to that, was right.

From below, from under the floor, barely audible, the first chords drifted up - she was awake again and playing something slow, careful, as though afraid to wake the house. I lay down without undressing, and listened.

Tomorrow there is a big day ahead.

NICS is waiting.

## **Chapter VII. Ferhat and His Family**

The room into which Akmal led me proved to be exactly as Ferhat had promised to describe it - and yet reality surpassed the promise. Small, whitewashed, with a low wooden ceiling crossed by dark beams, it kept a coolness astonishing for a house that had stood all day in the full sun. Against the far wall stood a chest of artful carving, a low divan spread with mattresses evidently served as a bed, and a narrow door in the corner led onto that very balcony that had been promised - tiny, scarcely holding one person, but with a view for which, it seemed, any cramping was worth enduring: roofs, minarets, a strip of water touched by evening gold.

On the windowsill stood a clay jug of water covered with a clean cloth, and beside it a copper bowl with rose petals floating on the surface of the water. For washing, I guessed. Someone had seen to this in advance, even before I climbed the stairs - which meant that in this house they had known I would stay before I knew it myself.

Akmal, thrusting his head into the room after me, said something - quickly, excitedly, accompanying the words with broad, almost theatrical gestures - and, receiving from me nothing but a bewildered smile, began to show with his hands still more insistently: first at himself, then at the door, then he mimed something remotely resembling the flapping of a sail or of wings, and at last triumphantly jabbed a finger toward the window, beyond which a strip of water could be made out.

“Ships?” I tried to guess, resorting to gestures too. “The port?”

Akmal’s face lit up as though I had just solved the most difficult riddle, and he nodded with redoubled enthusiasm, flinging up his arms again - this time, it seemed, to something like “tomorrow” or “in the morning.”

“Tomorrow,” I repeated, nodding in tune with him, though I understood from the entire conversation scarcely a tenth. “Good. Tomorrow - ships.”

He laughed - openly, ringingly - evidently pleased that he had found a common language with me where no common language, strictly speaking, existed at all. We both, I confess, proved fair actors: without having exchanged, it seemed, a single word comprehensible to the other, we had contrived to arrange tomorrow’s outing with the same ease with which experienced traders strike a bargain at a market where no one asks anyone for papers proving knowledge of a foreign tongue.

But he had no intention of leaving. Instead he seized my sleeve and pulled me after him - into the corridor, to a narrow ladder leading somewhere up, right under the roof.

\* \* \*

The attic proved dark, stuffy, smelling of dust, sun-warmed wood and something else - dry, herbal, like the smell of hay. Through the gaps in the tiles thin, string-like rays of the setting sun forced their way, and in them dust motes slowly circled. Along the walls were piled old chests, rolled carpets, stacks of copperware, a broken spinning wheel, fishing nets long unacquainted with water - the things that accumulate in every house over the years because one is sorry to throw them out and has nothing to use them for.

Akmal threaded his way among them with the agility of a cat, glancing back every now and then to see whether I had fallen behind. I had. Twice I struck my head on a beam, once I nearly overturned a copper basin, and each time Akmal burst out laughing, clapping a hand over his mouth.

By the wall, on a nail, hung an old leather belt with tools - carpenter’s, judging by their look: a hammer with a shrunken handle, a chisel, an awl. And among them - a small leather pouch on a cord, worn, empty, with a half-effaced pattern embossed on the leather.

I stopped. I do not know why. The pouch was quite ordinary - the kind in which one carries nails, small coins, tobacco. But my hand reached for it of itself, and of itself, before I could think, felt in the pocket of my trousers for the two smooth stones.



Akmal noticed where I was looking, came over, took the pouch off its nail and held it out to me - simply, without any ceremony, as if offering an apple. Then he pointed a finger at my pocket where the stones lay, then at the pouch - and mimed one being put into the other.

“You want me to... This is for me?”

Akmal nodded and said something, pointing at the belt of tools and then at the sky - upward, where beyond the tiles was the evening sky. The gesture was clear without words: the owner of these tools had long ceased to need them.

“Whose belt is this?” I asked, forgetting that he did not understand me.

But he seemed to understand - by the intonation, by my glance at the belt. He fell silent - for the first time all evening Akmal was serious - and said one word which I did not understand, but which sounded as the same words sound in all languages:

“Baba.”

Father.

I held the pouch in my hands for a long time. Then I transferred both stones into it - black and white - and drew the cord tight. The stones lay in it so snugly, so exactly, as though the pouch had been sewn for them. I tied it to my belt. Akmal clapped me approvingly on the shoulder - and at once began smiling again, as though a minute before there had been no such serious, grown-up silence.

“Güvercin!” he blurted out and dragged me on, to a dormer window at the far end of the attic.

\* \* \*

The dormer window gave onto the flat roof of the neighbouring shed, and there on the roof stood a dovecote - knocked together of boards, with a dozen round entrances, once painted blue, now peeling. Akmal clambered out, I followed, clumsily, on all fours, to the sound of his stifled laughter.

The sun was setting. The whole city, as far as the eye could reach, lay before us - tiled roofs descending in stairways to the water, domes, minarets, thin threads of smoke above hearths, the masts of ships in the port, resembling from here thickets of reed. And on the roofs -

everywhere, on dozens of roofs - stood similar dovecotes, and beside many of them stood boys, just like Akmal, with long poles in their hands.

Akmal opened the dovecote door, stuck two fingers in his mouth and whistled - piercingly, with trills - and from the entrances, beating their wings, a flock burst out: white, blue-grey, speckled, with feathered feet, with tails spread like fans. They soared upward, made a circle above the roof, another, a third, climbing ever higher, and the sun flared on their wings in pink and gold.

And at once, from the neighbouring roofs, other flocks took off. The boys whistled, waved their poles, shouted to one another - and in the sky above the city dozens of flocks of pigeons wheeled, meeting and parting, mingling and breaking apart again, as if someone invisible were weaving in the sky an enormous living carpet.

"Ahmet!" Akmal shouted to a neighbour boy two roofs away, pointing at one of the flocks. "Benim! Benim!"

"Değil!" the other answered. "Benim!"

I did not understand the words, but I understood the game: the flocks mingled, and each boy tried to lure the others' birds into his own dovecote. Whoever lured more - won. Akmal whistled like one possessed, swung his pole, jumped on the spot so that the shed's roof creaked threateningly.

When the flock at last returned, Akmal triumphantly counted the birds at the entrances - and with a wild shriek of delight showed me two fingers. Two strange pigeons. He had lured two strange pigeons.

"Well done," I said, and he seemed to understand.

We sat on the edge of the roof, legs dangling, and watched the sky fade above the city. Somewhere far off, from the highest of the minarets, a voice rang out - long-drawn, high, flowing, as if pouring from the sky. A second answered it, from another minaret, then a third, a fourth - and soon above the whole city, above the roofs and dovecotes, above the water and the ships, a many-voiced call floated, answering itself, which sent shivers down my spine.

Akmal grew still, lowered his head, his lips moving soundlessly.

I did not know what this call was. I did not know the words, did not know the meaning. But I sat on the edge of the roof, listening to the voices answer one another above the darkening city, and felt something inside me - something long, very long clenched into a tight knot - loosen

for a moment. As though someone had called me by name. By that very name which I did not remember.

\* \* \*

A little later, when Akmal had run downstairs - judging by the voices that reached me, to help in the kitchen - I went out on my little balcony and found there, at the neighbouring window of the first floor, the second elder, who had been introduced to me as Yusuf. He sat surrounded by some ledgers, turning the counters of a plain wooden abacus, and, seeing me, nodded curtly - whether greeting me or simply noting my presence as a fact requiring no further attention.

Yusuf, as I had already managed to notice at the backgammon, was a far more reserved man than old Suleyman - the one who had conducted the conversation over tea with the same unhurried thoroughness with which, no doubt, he had conducted it for more than a decade. Yusuf, it seemed, was responsible in this house for more practical matters: accounts, trade, the distribution of duties among the numerous nephews and grandsons. While I watched him from the balcony, the youngest of the brothers, Kemal, ran up to him - the same quiet boy who on the first day had silently drawn with charcoal on the flagstones of the yard - and, judging by the intonation, began reporting something, pointing now toward the port, now toward the house. Yusuf listened to him with the same impassivity, put, it seemed, one single clarifying question and dismissed the boy with a short nod, at once returning to his accounts.

I went down into the yard. Yusuf, without raising his head, moved one of the ledgers aside, making room on the bench beside him. The gesture was barely noticeable, but unmistakable. I sat down.

He clicked the counters - quickly, evenly, without looking - and recorded the results in the ledger in small, neat signs. Columns of figures stretched down the page. I looked at them, not understanding the signs, but for some reason understanding the numbers themselves - just as in the morning I had understood the sense of words by intonation. On one of the columns my gaze suddenly stumbled.

I could not have explained how I knew it. I did not know the local numerals. But I looked at the column and knew - simply knew - that the

total at the bottom was wrong. That somewhere in the middle one number had been carried wrongly.

I laid my finger on the page beside that number.

Yusuf raised his eyes to me - for the first time all evening truly. Then he slowly recounted the column on the abacus - once, twice. He clicked the counters. Frowned. Took the pen, crossed out the total and wrote a new one.

He was silent for a long time. Then, without a word, he reached into a canvas pouch at his belt, took out a date - large, dark, glossy - and laid it in my palm. And buried himself in his books again.

I ate the date. It was sweet as honey. We sat so for another quarter of an hour - he clicked the counters, I watched - and I found no more errors. But when I rose to leave, Yusuf, without raising his head, pushed another date toward me.

\* \* \*

By the yard wall, in the shade under an awning, sat Orhan. Before him on a cloth lay a heap of walnuts, and he was cracking them - one after another, with the haft of a heavy knife - with the concentrated fury with which one cracks not nuts but someone's heads.

I stopped a few paces away. He raised his eyes to me, and in them there was not a drop of hospitality.

I sat down opposite, on my haunches. I took a nut from the heap, turned it in my fingers. Then I took a second, laid both on my palm and squeezed - one against the other, as one squeezes in a fist. The shell of one cracked.

Orhan looked at me without blinking. Then he snorted, took two nuts, laid them on his palm, squeezed - both cracked at once. He looked at me defiantly.

I took three. Squeezed. One cracked.

Orhan laughed - briefly, reluctantly, as if the laughter had burst out of him against his will. He took four nuts. Squeezed. His face turned crimson, the veins on his neck swelled. Three cracked.

I raised my hands - I surrender.

He snorted again, but this was now quite a different sound. He pushed half the heap of cracked nuts toward me. I took one, ate it. He

took another. We ate in silence. Then Orhan suddenly said something - short, gruff - pointing a finger first at me, then toward the street, then miming a seizing of a hand.

Mehmet. The little thief. He was speaking of Mehmet.

I nodded. Orhan shook his head - with vexation, but already without anger - and said something which, by the intonation, meant something like "for three days I ran after him, and you - with one hand." Then he spat aside, wiped his knife on his trouser leg and went into the house.

The nuts he left to me.

\* \* \*

Ferhat found me on the balcony already at dusk - rested, washed, in a clean shirt and with a canvas bag over his shoulder. In an hour he had to leave for the port, for the night shift.

"Well?" he asked, leaning on the railing beside me. "Were you not bored?"

"I was given no chance to be bored," I said. "Akmal showed me the attic, the dovecote and all the pigeons of this city. Yusuf fed me dates. Orhan - walnuts."

Ferhat raised his eyebrows in astonishment.

"Orhan? Walnuts?" He whistled. "You are either a sorcerer or a saint. He does not give me walnuts myself."

"We competed at who could crack more in his fist."

"And who won?"

"He."

"Then it is understandable," laughed Ferhat. "Orhan forgives everyone he wins against."

He was silent for a while, looking at the darkening city. Below, in the yard, an oil lamp had been lit, and from behind a thick curtain on the women's side came singing - a low, slightly cracked old voice drawing out a slow, sad melody that made my chest ache.

"Grandmother," said Ferhat quietly. "She sings every evening. The same song. About a sailor who went to sea and did not return."

"That is a sad song."

"Sad." Ferhat nodded. "Father went to sea when I was ten. Akmal was four, Kemal two. The ship was going to Crete. It did not arrive."

Since then Grandmother sings that song every evening. And Grandfather..." He paused. "Grandfather since then never lets a stranger go from his threshold hungry. He says: if you feed a wanderer in your house - somewhere far away someone will feed yours. Perhaps Father is alive. Perhaps he is somewhere on a foreign shore, and someone is pouring him tea right now. Grandfather believes it."

I was silent for a long time. The pouch at my belt suddenly seemed heavy to me.

"Akmal gave me a pouch," I said at last. "In the attic. From the belt with the tools. He said... 'baba.'"

Ferhat looked at the pouch on my belt - and his face changed for a moment. Then he smiled - brightly, without bitterness.

"Father was a ship's carpenter," he said. "That belt is all that remains of him. He forgot it at home that time. Grandmother does not allow it to be touched." He paused. "But if Akmal gave you the pouch - it means it was meant to be. Akmal sometimes knows such things. Like Kemal with his drawings."

"I shall return it," I said. "If Grandmother..."

"No need," Ferhat interrupted gently. "Father would have given it. He always gave everything away." And, after a pause, he added, looking no longer at me but at the water, at the lights of the ships: "Perhaps that is the very thing. You are a stranger on our shore. We feed you. And somewhere, perhaps, they are feeding him."

From below, from behind the curtain, Grandmother's singing still came. Ferhat listened to it a little longer, then shook his head as if shaking something off his shoulders, and began smiling again.

"I must go. The port does not wait. Kemal will show you the library if you wish. It is mostly Grandfather's books, in the old language, you will not be able to read them. But there are maps. Everyone reads maps."

\* \* \*

The library in this house was a small room on the first floor, with one window and walls lined from floor to ceiling with shelves. The books stood on them tightly, spine to spine - thick, in leather bindings, with embossed Arabic lettering; scrolls tied with cords; stacks of yellowed sheets sewn by hand. It smelled of old paper, leather and wax.

Kemal lit a lamp, set it on a low table and, without a word, took from a lower shelf an enormous folio swollen with age - an atlas. He opened it before me at a spread where water was drawn in blue paint, cut by shores, and put a finger on one point - where a narrow strait joined two seas.

“Burası,” he said softly. Here.

I looked at the map. At the narrow blue strip of the strait. At the two seas on either side of it. At the city sprawling along both shores - Europe and Asia, I understood suddenly, though no one had told me so. Two worlds, divided by a strip of water along which boats scurry.

Two worlds. For some reason those words echoed in me with the same strange echo as the call from the minarets.

Kemal, while I looked at the map, moved away into the corner, to a shelf stacked with piles of paper. He rummaged in them, took out several sheets and, after hesitating, laid them before me on the atlas.

Drawings. In charcoal, on coarse paper. Akmal with pigeons - alive, laughing, a pole in his hand. Suleyman over the backgammon, with a narrowed eye. Yusuf with the abacus - lips pursed, brows knit, ludicrously like. A ship sailing out to sea - small, lonely, on enormous water.

And the last drawing.

A narrow lane between two houses - I recognised it at once: the very one visible from my balcony, running off into the darkness of an alley. And at the end of the lane, in shadow - a figure. Tall, immoderately tall, taller than a doorway. Drawn not in outline but in solid grey hatching, as if moulded of ash. Without a face.

I raised my eyes to Kemal. He looked at me gravely, unblinking.

“When?” I asked, pointing at the drawing. “When did you draw this?”

He did not understand the words. But he seemed to understand the question. He held up two fingers. Then he pointed at the window - at the sky, where the first stars had already lit - and laid his palms together under his cheek, as though sleeping.

Two nights ago. He had drawn this two nights ago.

Before I came to this house. Before I had even found myself in this city - as far as I remembered, at least.

Kemal gathered up the drawings, folded them neatly and put them back on the shelf - all but the last. That one he left on the atlas before me. Then he put out the lamp, touched my shoulder - as lightly as in the morning he had touched the white stone - and went away, leaving me alone in the darkness that smelled of old paper.

\* \* \*

I was still standing afterward on the balcony, observing this small, harmonious mechanism of a stranger's family, when behind my back light footsteps sounded - whether of one of the women of the house, whom by custom I was not supposed to see, or of one of the boys - and on the threshold of the room appeared a tray with supper: flat bread, something stewed in a clay pot, smelling of mutton and of spices so unfamiliar that I would not undertake to list them even approximately. I turned - and managed to see only a hand setting the tray on the floor: swarthy, narrow, with a henna pattern on the palm and a thin silver bracelet on the wrist. The hand vanished behind the door before I could thank it.

I supped alone, sitting on the low divan - and, I confess, this silence after the noisy, crowded evening in a strange family had a soothing effect on me, like a long-awaited pause between two acts of a play which I watched without understanding a word, but somehow catching the whole sense. Kemal's drawing lay beside me on the divan, face down. I could not bring myself to turn it over again.

This family, I thought, was ordered far more intricately than it had seemed at first glance over tea on the motley carpet: each one here, the boys included, had his own role, his own place in the invisible hierarchy of the house - Suleyman guarded tradition and hospitality, Yusuf ran the household, Ferhat alone of all spoke with the outside world in its own language, Orhan guarded the house from strangers, Akmal knew what to give to whom, and Kemal - saw what others did not see. And Grandmother every evening sang a song about a man who did not return.

It grew dark quickly, as it usually does in southern port cities - without long twilight, in one decisive movement of a curtain. I went out on the balcony one last time before sleep to breathe the evening air, already cooling, smelling of the sea and of hearth smoke - and it was



then, at the very edge of vision, where the narrow lane below was lost in the darkness between two houses, that I saw that figure again.

Grey - not in its clothes, but as if wholly moulded of ash and evening dusk - standing motionless, looking, as it seemed to me this time quite distinctly, straight at my window. Standing exactly where it stood in Kemal's drawing.

My heart missed a beat. I blinked, peered - and the figure did not vanish at once, as last time on the square, but lingered another second, two, three, as though deliberately giving me time to be sure it was no trick of vision, no play of shadows - and only then unhurriedly, almost lazily withdrew into the darkness of the alley and dissolved in it without trace.

The pouch at my belt, it seemed, had grown a little warmer - but the evening was close, and I paid it no heed.

I stood on the balcony a long time after that, peering at the place where it had just been, and feeling a cold slowly but surely spread down my back that had nothing to do with the evening cool. And from below, from behind the curtain, ever quieter and quieter, Grandmother sang - of the sailor who went to sea and did not return.

## Vision II. The Guest

I do not know whether I slept or not.

That is the first thing worth saying about this night - and, perhaps, the only one of which I am sure to any degree of firmness.

\* \* \*

The house fell asleep slowly, by parts, as a large, tired animal falls asleep. First the kitchen grew quiet - the last clink of dishes, the last splash of water, the brief laughter of the women behind the curtain. Then in the yard the oil lamp was put out, and the strip of yellow light that had lain on the flagstones drew back into the darkness, as though someone had rolled up a carpet. Yusuf went on clicking his counters in his room for some time - evenly, steadily, as water drips - then that too fell silent. Somewhere on the roof Akmal's pigeons stirred and cooed in their sleep. Grandmother finished her song of the sailor - I heard her voice grow quieter and slower, until it turned into a whisper, and the whisper into breath.

Ferhat had gone to the port at dusk. I had heard the gate bang, heard him whistling something as he receded down the lane - the very melody that Grandmother sang, only faster and merrier, as if deliberately recasting it in his own way so that it should not be so sad.

Before I lay down, I heard heavy, shuffling steps on the stairs - and Suleyman appeared in the doorway. In one hand he held an oil lamp, in the other something small that glinted blue. He nodded to me, laid his palm on his chest - "do not get up" - and, rising on tiptoe, hung over the doorway, on a nail driven into the doorpost, a glass bead on a red thread. Blue, round, with a white ring and a black dot in the middle. An eye.

He tapped the bead with a finger, then his own eyelid, then pointed at me and shook his head - slowly, sternly, as one shakes one's head to drive off something unseen. Then he uttered one word which I did not understand - "nazar" - and, after a pause, added something long, under his breath, looking not at me but into the dark corner of the room behind my headboard. As though he were speaking not to me but to someone standing there.

I remembered the old woman at the fountain. Her splayed fingers. Three spits over the shoulder.

Suleyman finished his quiet speech, wished me, judging by the intonation, a good night and went away, carrying the lamp with him. The blue eye above the door glimmered for a long time in the darkness, catching the last reflections from the corridor - until they too went out.

I lay on the low divan, covered with a light woollen blanket smelling of something herbal and unfamiliar - mint, perhaps, or wormwood - and looked at the ceiling, at the dark beams crossing it like the ribs of an enormous fish. Beside me, on the edge of the divan, lay Kemal's drawing. Face down. I had still not ventured to turn it over again.

The leather pouch with the stones I had not untied from my belt. I do not know why. I simply lay down without undressing and laid my palm on it, as one lays a palm on the head of a sleeping dog - to feel that it is near.

Outside the window, on the balcony, a cat appeared noiselessly - ginger, mangy, with a torn ear, the same or another that in the morning had eaten from the hand of the girl with braids. It settled on the railing, wrapped its tail around its paws and fixed me with yellow, unblinking eyes. I looked at it. It looked at me. Then suddenly it flattened its ears, bristled the fur on its neck, hissed soundlessly - not at me, but at something behind my back, in the depth of the room - and in one leap vanished from the railing.

I turned. The room was empty.

The moon was rising above the roofs, and the strip of its light falling from the window onto the floor was creeping slowly, slowly toward me across the boards.

My eyelids were either closed or not - that boundary, usually so obvious, had that night worn thin almost to total disappearance.

The room around me was now present - I could make out the dark rectangle of the doorway, the strip of moonlight on the floor - now blurred, losing its outlines, as if someone with a generous hand had mixed it with a dream without asking my consent.

I felt him before I saw him.

Not a sound - there were no footsteps, no creak of floorboards, no rustle of cloth - but a change in the very air of the room, that particular heaviness which arises when in an enclosed space someone else suddenly appears, occupying far more room than an ordinary man could occupy. This heaviness settled on my chest before I could turn - not pain, not suffocation, but simply weight, enormous and imperturbable, like the weight of a mountain that does not care what happens at its foot.

I tried to turn my head. I could not.

I tried to raise a hand - at least a finger, at least an eyelid - and discovered with that peculiar, icy horror that comes only in a dream or at its very border that my body no longer belonged to me in the slightest. It lay obedient to some alien, unknown will, while my consciousness thrashed inside that motionless shell like a bird that has suddenly discovered that its cage has no door.

Only my palm - the one that lay on the pouch at my belt - still felt. Felt how the stones beneath the skin of the pouch grew warm. Then hot. Then so hot that had I been able to move, I would have snatched my hand away. But I could not. And that heat, strangely, did not burn but held me - like the one thread tying me to this room, to this divan, to this house, while everything else drifted away into the dark.

He stood to the side, a little behind, where I could not see him without turning my head - and yet I knew what he was like, with that inexplicable certainty with which one knows things not with the eyes but with something far more ancient and far less subject to reason. Tall. Immoderately, impossibly tall - so that had he straightened to his full height, the crown of his head, it seemed, would have passed the lintel of the low door without stooping. Grey, or perhaps black - the colour could not be determined, because it seemed to change depending on where the scanty moonlight fell, now absorbing it wholly, now reflecting it in dull, metallic ripples.

Exactly as Kemal had drawn him. Two nights ago. In charcoal, in solid grey hatching, without a face.

No menace came from him. That was, perhaps, the strangest thing in all that was happening: neither hatred, nor hunger, nor that special, recognisable sinister intent with which ordinary night terrors are filled. Only attention - intent, unblinking, scrutinising - turned on me as one scrutinises a rare specimen under a magnifying glass: wishing it no harm, but also not reckoning in the least with its own wishes in the matter.

I tried to cry out. The cry stuck somewhere in the depth of my throat, finding no outlet, as though someone with an invisible palm had clamped my mouth from within before the sound could be born.

Then he spoke.

\* \* \*

His voice - if it was a voice at all in the usual sense of the word - did not so much sound as make itself felt: a low, resonant vibration which passed through me whole, from crown to heels, as though the surface of my body had for a brief moment become the resonating soundboard of some unthinkable instrument. The words - if they were words - were composed in a language unlike any I had happened to hear in that long, tangled day: neither the sing-song speech of Ferhat and his brothers, nor the drawn-out call from the minarets, nor even the language which, as it turned out, I myself spoke, not knowing from where. These sounds slid into one another without pauses, without stresses, like water pouring over stone - and in them, for all their complete, absolute incomprehensibility, one heard something like patient, almost condescending expectation. Thus one speaks to a child who has not yet learned the language of adults - not angry at his incomprehension, but not thinking it necessary to spare him.

And as he spoke, the walls of the room began to thin.

I do not know how else to describe it. The whitewashed wall opposite me, the one by which the carved chest stood, suddenly became transparent - not all at once, but in patches, as frost melts on glass under someone's breath. And through these patches I saw the same place. The same hillside, the same strip of water in the distance. But - different.

I saw night, and in it - bells. Enormous, resonant, bronze, swinging somewhere very near, beyond the wall, as if that wall had never been. And singing - male voices, low, harmonious, drawing out something slow and solemn in a language I did not know, but at which my throat tightened. Candles - hundreds, thousands of candles, flickering in darkness under a dome of such height that it seemed as if the sky had been taken from the sky and hung beneath a roof. People in dark garments, with beards, with bowed heads, with crosses in their hands.

Then the bells fell silent - all at once, as if cut with a knife - and in their place there was thunder. Dull, heavy, again and again, so that the earth shook and dust fell from the ceiling beams. Cannons, I understood. Enormous cannons pounding the walls. Cries. Smoke. Fire on the water - ships burning in the gulf, and the glow of the flames dancing on the surface like fish. And through the smoke - banners, red, with a white crescent, and drums - not bells, but drums, measured, triumphant, and trumpets, shrill as the cry of a bird of prey.

Then all fell still. And in the same place, on the same hillside, I saw morning. Peaceful, quiet. A boy with pigeons on a roof. An old man with a pipe on a stone wall. A boy with a tray of bread rings on his head. And above it all - the same dome as before, only now beside it stood towers thin as needles, and from them, answering each other, a call floated.

A city, I thought - or someone thought in me. One and the same city. Many names. Many lives. One land.

"This city has many names," Suleyman had told me over tea. "Perhaps it has itself decided by what name to present itself to you."

\* \* \*

But the walls went on melting - and beyond them was no longer this city.

I saw a river. Broad, slow, turbid with silt, flowing between two strips of palms, behind which the desert began. A golden barque on the river. Columns - huge as the trees of a petrified forest, with capitals open like papyrus buds. And I knew those columns. I had already seen them - that very morning, in the street, before the old men with their backgammon, when for a moment, for just one moment, it had seemed to me that I stood between them, and someone beside me raised a hand.

Through the columns came a cry - a deep, hoarse, desperate cry of a warrior calling out someone's name. My name. I could not make it out. I knew that it was my name, but could not make out a single sound.

Then - a hall. High, vaulted, with heavy chandeliers ringing with crystal, with a fireplace in which logs crackled. A long table covered with a white cloth. A woman in a dark-lilac dress, with a string of pearls at her neck, turns her face to me - beautiful, stern, with eyes full of anxiety - and says something. I do not hear the words. I see only how her lips move. And beside her - a young man in a brand-new uniform, with a broad, insolent smile, who looks at me as though he knows me better than I know myself. He waves a hand to me. He calls me. I want to go to him - and cannot move.

I do not know these people. I had never seen them. But at the sight of that young man something quivered inside me - the same thing that had quivered in the morning at the fountain, at the thought of a face I had not had time to make out. Not he. Someone else. But - similar. As similar to one another as all those one misses.

And then - the last. The strangest of all.

A small room, dark, lit only by a cold blue light - not a candle, not a lamp, not the moon, but some even, dead glow emanating from a flat window, like a mirror, on a table. In this window, against a dark background, letters shone. Two lines. I did not know these letters. But I read them - read them as in the morning I had read the error in Yusuf's column, not understanding the signs, but understanding the meaning:

"Who am I?"

"Who are you?"

I do not know what this was. I do not know where this room is, or when, or whose. But I know that on that night, on the divan in Ferhat's house, bound hand and foot, I looked at those two lines - and felt that they were written to me. Or by me. Or - this was the most terrifying - that between these two possibilities there is no difference at all.

\* \* \*

I did not understand a single syllable of his speech. And yet somewhere at the very bottom of consciousness, where neither fear nor the paralysis binding my body hand and foot could reach, there stirred a

vague, disquieting feeling that I - if only I remembered how - might perfectly well understand this language.

And then - at the very end, in the last instant before the vibration broke off - from that fluid, incomprehensible stream of sounds one word suddenly stood out. One single word. In the language in which I thought. Clear, distinct, uttered so close as though someone had bent to my very ear:

“Remember.”

The phrase broke off as suddenly as it had begun. The walls of the room became walls again - whitewashed, solid, with the carved chest by the far one. The weight on my chest eased - did not vanish at once, but precisely eased, as though someone were slowly, carefully lifting from me one layer of invisible load after another - and with each such layer a grain of power over my own body returned: first the fingers of my right hand, lying on the pouch, then the eyelids, then, at last, the neck, allowing me to turn my head to where he had just stood.

No one was there. Only a strip of moonlight on the floor, the same dark rectangle of the doorway - and my own laboured breathing, the single sound disturbing the silence of the room.

I sat up on the divan, feeling my chest with my palm, as though checking whether any imprint of that impossible weight remained on it. Nothing. No trace, no bruise, not the slightest proof that what had happened was anything more than an especially bad dream, born of the fatigue of a long day full of discoveries.

The pouch at my belt was hot. I felt its heat through cloth, through skin - even, calm, like the warmth of a hearth in a cooling house. I did not dare untie it. Not then.

\* \* \*

Something stirred in the doorway.

I started so that the divan creaked. But it was not the grey figure. It was Kemal - small, barefoot, in a long nightshirt, with a clay lamp in his hand, its flame trembling and ducking in the draught. He stood on the threshold, not entering, and looked at me.



For a long time. In silence. With the same grave, unblinking look with which he had looked in the library when he laid his drawing before me.

Then he raised his free hand and pointed - not at me, but at the corner of the room, where by the wall, behind my headboard, the one I had not seen had just stood. He pointed - and raised his eyebrows questioningly.

I nodded.

Kemal was not surprised. Was not frightened. He simply sighed - quite un-childishly, heavily, as old men sigh - came into the room, set the lamp on the floor by the door, took the jug of water from the windowsill, poured it into a clay cup and held it out to me.

I drank. The water was cool, faintly sweetish - like the water from the fountain on the square, in the morning, a lifetime ago.

Kemal took the cup, set it back on the windowsill. Then he sat down on the floor by the door, leaning his back against the doorpost, drew his knees up to his chest, clasped them with his arms - and stayed so. Without a word. Not intending, apparently, to leave.

"Go to sleep," I said to him in a whisper, forgetting that he did not understand me. "I am all right. Go."

He understood - by the intonation, probably. He shook his head. He pointed a finger at himself, then at the threshold where he sat. Then - at the window, at the sky, where the moon was already sinking toward the roofs, and drew his palm through the air - slowly, from left to right, as the sun passes across the sky.

Until morning. He would sit here until morning.

I wanted to object - and did not. I lay back down on the divan, facing the door, and looked at the little figure on the threshold, lit by the trembling flame of the lamp. Kemal sat motionless, his chin on his knees, and looked not at me but at the corner behind my headboard. Guarding. As, no doubt, he would have guarded a younger brother against night terrors, had he had a younger brother.

I do not know how this twelve-year-old boy knew what to do. I do not know how many such nights he had himself lived through before he learned not to be afraid. I know only that that night, in a strange house, in a strange city, without a name and without memory, I felt for the first time that I was not alone.

When the sky outside the window began to turn grey, Kemal quietly rose, took his lamp, long since gone out, and, already at the threshold, stopped and raised his eyes to the doorpost, where Suleyman's blue bead hung on its red thread.

I followed his gaze.

The bead was cracked. Exactly in half - the crack ran precisely through the black pupil, through the white ring, from edge to edge - and one half hung on the thread, while the other lay on the floor at the threshold, glinting in the grey light of dawn.

Kemal bent down, picked up the fragment, looked at it for a long time on his palm. Then he put it in the pocket of his nightshirt - carefully, as one hides something precious - and as silently as he had come, vanished into the dark corridor. He did not look back once.

And yet, however many times I repeated to myself that simple, convenient explanation that all this had been merely a bad dream, I did not manage to sleep again - not for an instant, until the very dawn, which timidly and cautiously turned grey beyond the narrow window of my room.

Remember, he had said.

But what - and how?

## Chapter VIII. The Abandoned Castle

The darkness after the extinguished candle was so complete that for several moments I ceased to understand where my body ended and the corridor began. I stood with my back pressed against the grille, clutching in my hand a useless candlestick with a still-warm stub, and listened to my heart pounding - the only sound in the whole world.

“Konstantin,” I said aloud. Quietly. Then louder: “Konstantin!”

The echo carried his name somewhere into the depth of the corridor, broke it into pieces, returned it to me in scraps - “...tin... tin...” - and died away. No one answered. The piano did not sound. The Castle behind my back was silent as houses are silent in which no one has lived for a long time.

I have ears like a regimental dog, he had said. I shall hear through the whole Castle.

He had not heard. Or - the thought came of itself, uninvited, and I hastily drove it off - here, on this side of the grille, was no longer the sort of place to which sound reaches from the parade hall.

And then warmth struck my face - before I could take even one step forward - a sudden, almost hot gust of air, so alien to the cold stone walls of our Castle that for a moment I doubted whether I was still beneath its roof. My aunt had always loved the coolness of these walls, was proud of it before guests as a special, family merit of the house - here, however, beyond the grille, the air was different: thick, warm, as if borrowed from a quite different climate, a different season, and perhaps a different latitude altogether.

And with the warmth came light - not at once, but gradually, as dawn comes: first I made out my own hand, then the edge of a wall, then the floor, stretching ahead in a long grey strip. The light came from

somewhere far away, from the depth of the corridor, even and pale, unlike a candle or a lamp.

I froze on the threshold, listening to myself in search of some explanation - and, not finding one, moved forward, because to stand still in the ringing silence seemed to me a far more frightening occupation than to walk.

\* \* \*

The corridor here proved narrower than before, and the dust that covered the floor in an even, undisturbed layer rose at every step in light, slow little clouds, then settled as unhurriedly, as though it too had nowhere to hurry in this forgotten corner of the house. The tapestries on the walls - the few that still held to their hooks - had rotted so that to recognise the subject once depicted on them was quite impossible: there remained only brown, faded patches where, no doubt, horsemen had once galloped or a stag been hunted. In one place the plaster had fallen away in large flakes, exposing beneath it masonry far more ancient than that of the parade halls familiar to me - stone dark, cracked, as though remembering not decades but centuries.

On the floor, in the dust, I noticed tracks. Not mine - mine stretched behind, deep, distinct. These were different: narrow, light, barely pressing the dust, as though someone weightless had passed along the corridor. The tracks came toward me - and broke off in the middle of the corridor, two paces from me, as though whoever had left them had stopped here, stood - and vanished. No tracks returning, none to the side.

"The White Lady," I recalled Mitka's whisper. "The one who lived here before our mistress."

I skirted the breaking-off tracks, trying not to step on them, and went on, feeling at the back of my head something like a draught, though the air around was motionless and warm.

I passed a niche in which, it seemed, a statue had once stood - the pedestal remained, but the figure itself had vanished without trace, leaving only two pale, inexplicably clean marks where its stone feet had once rested. For some reason it was precisely this detail - not the tapestries, not the dust, but precisely these two empty marks on the

pedestal - that for the first time made me seriously doubt that I was still in the house I was accustomed to consider my own.

A little farther on, on the wall, hung a frame. Empty. The canvas had been cut out of it - neatly, evenly, with a sharp knife, along the very edge. Beneath the frame, on a copper plate, as in the gallery where the portrait under crape hung, the name had been scraped away.

I stopped. In the gallery. A portrait under crape, with little stones in his hand. Here - an empty frame. The same plate. The same knife.

I did not know what it meant. I did not want to know. I quickened my step.

\* \* \*

At the end of this endlessly long corridor, the longest in the whole labyrinth that I had been through that evening, I made out a door of imposing size, ajar, with small square windows on either side of the leaf. In one of these windows burned that same faint, even light - not of a candle, not of a torch, but of something else, pale, lacking any tremor of living flame.

Coming closer, I discovered a small room, whose door likewise stood ajar. Inside, with his back to me, someone was arranging something on shelves - methodically, unhurriedly, shelf after shelf. I managed to make out rows of some flat volumes bound in dark leather, several vessels of cloudy glass, boxes with neat labels and something remotely resembling a plan or a map pinned to the far wall - a setting that seemed to me rather an archive or a laboratory than a dwelling. The man himself was clothed in garments of such strange, inexplicable cut that I would not have undertaken to assign them to any epoch or to any social estate known to me: whether uniform, or working smock, or something third whose name I did not know at all, sewn of cloth that glimmered dully and unfamiliarly in that even, incorporeal light. On his hands were thin white gloves, like a butler's - but what he held in them was not a tray but an old book, so carefully as though it might crumble from one careless breath.

I wanted to pass by. But a floorboard creaked under my foot.

The man turned.

He was no longer young - about fifty, with a neat greying beard, in spectacles with a thin metal frame of a kind I had never seen before - and he looked at me with the expression with which a host looks at a guest who has wandered into the wrong room: without alarm, but with slight annoyance.

“Are you from the group?” he asked.

I understood every word. He spoke my language - clearly, without any accent - but pronounced the words somehow differently: faster, more drily, swallowing the endings, as no one spoke among us. And the sense of his question eluded me completely.

“From what group?”

“Well, from the one in the garden.” He waved a hand somewhere to the side. “Outsiders are not allowed in here, this is a depository. All your people are in the yard. The exit is there, up the stairs and to the right.”

“A depository of what?” I asked.

He looked at me more attentively, over his spectacles. His glance slid over my frock coat, my trousers, lingered on the neckerchief - and in his eyes suddenly flared a lively, almost professional interest.

“Well, well,” he said. “What a costume. Are you from the reenactment? They told us there would be people in costume, but I did not think so...” He came closer, squinting. “The cloth is real. And the cut. And the neckerchief is tied...” He broke off. “Who made it for you?”

“My aunt’s tailor,” I answered, and felt myself how absurd it sounded.

He laughed - briefly, good-naturedly - evidently taking my answer for a joke, for part of that very game in which, by his reckoning, I was a participant.

“Your aunt’s. Of course.” He shook his head. “Splendid work. Just like in our portraits. You know, in our gallery there is one...” He faltered, as though he had changed his mind about speaking. “Never mind, however. Go to your people, young man, before you are missed. And do not touch anything on the way, I beg you. Everything here holds on its word of honour.”

He turned back to the shelves, but before turning away entirely he cast another quick glance at me over his shoulder - and in that glance, as it seemed to me, flickered something like what I had seen that evening at

supper in the eyes of Vera Anatolievna: an attempt to recall a face that one cannot quite recognise.

I did not question him. I walked past the half-open door, passed the massive leaves at the end of the corridor and went out into the warm air, saturated with the fragrance of flowering plants.

\* \* \*

Descending the few steps that separated this grandiose door from the ground, I saw a scene that took my breath away.

It was day. Not evening, not the night from which I had just come - a clear, sunny day, at the very height of summer, with a high pale-blue sky and heavy white clouds hanging motionless above the trees. I looked at my watch - and saw that its hands had stopped. Exactly at the minute when I had pushed the door of the grille.

A fairly large crowd of people - I would have counted some twenty, perhaps more - were doing something in the garden of our ancestral Castle. They were dressed in clothing no less strange than that of the man left in the depository behind me - but the strangeness was of another, more disquieting kind, because not one of my comparisons, hurriedly and vainly sorted through, would fit what I saw even approximately.

On some was a cut remotely resembling the military, but in colours such as I had not met in any army known to me - neither grey nor brown, devoid of any hint of parade or distinction. Others wore something like travelling dress, cut, however, in so alien a manner that I would have been at a loss to determine not only the country it came from but even the century in which such a cut could be considered fitting: now too short, now immoderately wide, lacking buttons where they should have been and furnished with fastenings where I had never in my life seen any. The women - I did not at once realise they were women - wore trousers, like men, with bare arms and uncovered heads, and no one around seemed to find anything strange in it.

Some held small, dark, glinting objects in their hands, which from time to time they raised to their eyes or to their ear - the purpose of these objects I decidedly did not understand, as I did not understand a good half of what was in general happening before me on that lawn. One of them held such an object up to the face of another - whether in jest or for

some other reason unknown to me - and both afterward laughed with a short, abrupt laugh quite unlike the laughter to which my ear was accustomed.

In the middle of the lawn, on the very spot where my aunt every summer ordered the tent for tea to be pitched, stood an elderly lady in spectacles and some preposterous sun hat, with an umbrella raised above her head - not for shade but, apparently, as a banner which the crowd followed. She spoke loudly, in a sing-song, in that special voice with which people speak who repeat the same thing many times a day.

“...and here, ladies and gentlemen, the famous rose garden was laid out. They say the roses were brought here from the Balkans. The last mistress of the estate, a widow, was very fond of receiving guests - balls were given here, to which the whole province drove...”

I froze. Roses from the Balkans. A widow. Balls. She was speaking of my aunt - of our house, of our garden - speaking as one speaks of people long lying in the earth.

“...and then,” the lady went on, lowering her voice for greater effect, and the crowd drew closer to her, “there happened that very story because of which the left wing was closed with a grille. They say that one night a man vanished in the house. Some tell it was a young master, others a servant, others that it was even a guest. He went into the left wing - and...”

At that moment someone in the crowd laughed loudly, someone shouted, calling the stragglers, somewhere some shrill trill rang out - from that same dark object in someone’s hand - and the end of the phrase drowned in the general din. When the noise subsided, the lady was already leading her crowd on, toward the pond, telling something about crucian carp.

He went into the left wing - and.

I stood on the steps, and my knees trembled.

\* \* \*

What is happening, I thought in the first, most bewildered instant. Can it be a masquerade - one of those mad balls that my aunt gave for the whole capital public?



But no: however wilful my aunt might be with her entertainments, she would certainly have mentioned such a spectacle to me beforehand, if only to laugh at my inevitable unwillingness to take part. Moreover, these guests behaved decidedly not as one should behave at a social function - they spoke too loudly, almost shouted, laughed without any occasion, ran about the lawn with a looseness I had never met at any reception in our house. One of them had even lain down right on the grass, his head thrown back toward the sky, as though it were the most natural occupation in the world for a guest of a respectable house.

Surely this is another prank of Konstantin's, the eternal jester, I decided, though even this thought, scarcely born, seemed to me unconvincing: the jest would have been too grand, he would have had to hire too many people for it, and Konstantin himself - the only man capable of explaining this madness to me in an intelligible tongue - was nowhere to be seen nearby.

"Mister!"

I started and lowered my eyes. Before me stood a girl of about seven - in a short, above-the-knee frock of bright yellow, with two sticking-out ponytails tied with something shiny, and in strange footwear of white, soft-looking material, with multicoloured laces. In her hand was that same dark, glinting object - flat, the size of a palm.

"Mister, are you real?"

"What?" was all I could manage.

"You look like from a picture," she said, studying me from head to foot. "May I remember you?"

Before I could understand what she meant, the girl turned her back to me, raised the plate before her at arm's length - and I suddenly saw on its dark surface, as in a tiny mirror, her own face, and behind it, over her shoulder, mine. My face. Bewildered, pale, in a dark frock coat and a red-and-blue neckerchief. Moving - repeating my every movement, like a reflection in water. Only reflections, as far as I knew, are never so bright.

Something clicked softly. The plate went dark.

"Thank you!" The girl turned round, beaming, and pressed the plate to her chest as one presses an expensive toy. "Now you will stay with me."

"Katya!" came a sharp woman's voice. "Katya, how many times must I say - do not pester people!"

A woman was hurrying toward us - young, in those same trousers, with a bag over her shoulder. She seized the girl by the hand and smiled at me apologetically.

"Forgive us, for God's sake. She pesters everyone." She ran her eyes over me and likewise lingered on the neckerchief. "What a costume you have... Are you one of the restorers? Or from those who are in historical clubs?"

"I..." I began, and understood that I did not know what to say next.

"Mum, he is real!" the girl broke in. "He does not even know what I have in my hand!"

"Katya!" The woman flushed, tugged her daughter's hand and dragged her away, throwing me over her shoulder: "Sorry again. Have a good day!"

"Now you will stay with me." I looked after them and thought that somewhere in this girl's hands, in a small dark plate, my face now remained - frightened, pale, in a neckerchief. And that I did not know in what year she would look at it.

\* \* \*

I took a step in the direction of the nearest group - two men who were discussing something animatedly right by the flower bed, once, as I recalled, planted with my aunt's roses - intending after all to demand explanations directly, regardless of the whole absurdity of such an undertaking. But before I had come within ten paces, one of them turned his head in my direction - whether at the sound of my steps or for some other reason unknown to me - and his glance, which slid over me, seemed to me so empty, so devoid of any recognition of a living being, that I froze on the spot, unable to force myself to utter a word. He looked not at me - through me, as one looks through glass or through mist. He at once turned back to his interlocutor, as though he had not noticed me at all - but that single second proved enough for me to abandon any thought of seeking explanations from this noisy, alien crowd.

The girl had seen me. Her mother had seen me. The man in the depository - had seen. And this one - had not. As though some people in this garden were here truly, and others - only reflections, shadows,

echoes of something long past. Or as though some saw me, and others could not. I did not know which of these was more terrible.

After standing so for a minute in utter stupefaction, feeling cold, clammy fear slowly rise from the very soles of my feet, I noticed in the far part of the garden a bright, orange figure moving unhurriedly in my direction - the only thing in all this unthinkable picture that seemed even remotely commensurate with my understanding of the world. Ignoring the bustle and hubbub around, I made my way toward it, as toward the one island of the recognisable in this sea of oddities suddenly flooding over me.

\* \* \*

Drawing near, I discovered with amazement a monk - clad in bright burgundy robes, remotely recalling the General's tales of distant, hot Asia, of the monasteries of Siam, where he had travelled with the Imperial family. One of the monk's shoulders was bare, his head shaved clean, on his feet were plain sandals, and in his hand he held a rosary of dark wooden beads, which he told with his fingers, without looking, evenly and unhurriedly. His face, weathered but calm, seemed to me a surprisingly timely sight - the first in the last few minutes that did not arouse in me a desire at once to close my eyes tight and hope that all I had seen would prove merely the consequence of overstrain.

He did not belong to the crowd - that was visible at once. He walked by himself, to one side, looking neither at the lady with the umbrella nor at the people with the dark plates. And, unlike them, he looked straight at me. He was walking toward me. As though he had known I was here even before I came out of the doors.

Never before had I happened to meet monks, still less from such distant lands, so invisible to me, and so, obeying habit rather than sober calculation, I greeted him in French - supposing that on that language it would be easier for us to come to terms than on my own, which was native to me but hardly familiar to a visiting wanderer.

To my no small joy, the monk understood me.

"I greet you too," he answered calmly in good, slightly old-fashioned French, with a barely perceptible but unmistakably distinct friendliness

in his gaze. "I was waiting for you. Although, I confess, I did not know on which day you would come."

"Waiting? For me?"

"For someone like you," he corrected gently. "For one who would come out of those doors. They are opened rarely."

An inexplicable, almost involuntary feeling of trust stirred in me at that same instant - trust which I did not that evening feel for a single other being around, myself included, perhaps.

"Forgive my bewilderment, Holy Father," I began, trying to make my voice sound steadier than my heart was pounding, "but I seem to have lost my way in the labyrinths of our Castle. I was returning in the evening from supper, chanced upon a part of the house unknown to me - and here I am on this lawn, among people whom I have never before seen and whose garments I decidedly do not understand. Tell me, what is happening here? Who are these people?"

The monk was silent, looking at me a little longer than a simple question required - and in that silence there was a special, calm sadness, such as, no doubt, doctors feel who have guessed the diagnosis before the patient himself.

"They come to look at the house," he said at last. "As one looks at old things, at graves, at what remains of other lives. They do not know who lived here. Legends are told to them. They photograph themselves and leave." He smiled slightly. "People love other people's past. Their own - less."

"But this is our house. My aunt, the guests, supper - all that was an hour ago..."

"Tell me," he interrupted gently. "Where you came from and where, in your understanding, you were going before you found yourself here."

I repeated my story - about the supper, the headache, the long, tangled corridors, the four people who had told me that evening not to go left, the portrait under crape and the black grille whose lock hung open, though the key to it had been lost forty years ago. The monk listened attentively, without interrupting, only his fingers still evenly told the beads of the rosary - and from time to time cast a quick, almost imperceptible glance toward the noisy crowd behind my back, as though checking my words against something known to him alone.

“My aunt, Artemia Aristarkhovna,” I added, clutching at that name as one clutches at the banister of a rickety staircase, “remarked this evening at supper that in the Castle there are places better left in peace. I took it then for a hostess’s ordinary jest. Now, however...”

“Now, however,” the monk gently picked up, “you begin to suspect that she was not joking.”

I nodded, unable to force out a word.

“Tell me one thing,” said the monk, and his fingers on the rosary froze. “What year is it now? In your opinion.”

“What do you mean, what year?” I even smiled at the absurdity of the question. “It is now...”

And fell silent.

I knew the answer. I ought to have known it. I had known it even at supper, when the General spoke of the Porte, when Kutasova spoke of Constantinople - the year was somewhere there, in every word, in every conversation, perfectly obvious, not requiring pronouncement. And now, when I was asked directly, in its place was that same even, smooth emptiness as in the place of Lizonka’s patronymic. As though someone had pulled out that thread too.

“I... cannot remember,” I said. And heard my voice tremble.

The monk nodded - slowly, without surprise, as though he had received precisely the answer he expected.

“It is nothing,” he said quietly. “It happens here. Here years lie upon one another like leaves in a book. It is hard to say which page you are reading now.”

As I spoke, his face - until then benevolent and open - slowly but inexorably changed: whether with anxiety, or pity, or that special expression with which one looks at a man not yet informed of the misfortune that has befallen him. He sighed - briefly, almost inaudibly - and for a short instant looked aside into the garden, as though gathering his courage or, perhaps, checking one last time whether there was not another, less cruel way to say what he was about to say.

It occurred to me in that second - absurdly, irrelevantly - of the old mirror in the niche, of the hand that had lagged behind me by a heartbeat, of the great-great-grandfather’s gaze that had seemingly shifted after my movement, of the portrait under crape with two little stones in his hand, of the tracks in the dust breaking off in the middle of the corridor. All

these trifles, each of which taken singly was no more than a play of shadows and a tired imagination, suddenly lined up in my head into a single, inexplicable line leading straight to this moment.

“Brother,” he said at last, softly, almost tenderly, as though softening by that tone the very essence of what he was about to say, “this castle has been abandoned and empty for more than a hundred years.”

The earth swayed beneath me before I could grasp even a word of that phrase. My head spun swiftly, ruthlessly; thoughts that a second ago were trying to arrange themselves into the semblance of a question scattered in a disorderly, dazzling whirl; my eyes darkened, as if someone with one movement had drawn a thick black curtain before me - and I fell, without even feeling the pain of striking the grass.

The last thing my memory retained of that night - or that day, I no longer knew - was the monk’s concentrated but by no means frightened face, rushing swiftly toward me, and his outstretched hand, frozen halfway between us, like the last bridge connecting me with the world which, it seemed, I had just managed to lose irretrievably. And somewhere very far away, barely distinguishable, as though from behind a thick wall - a voice, calling out my name.

It seemed to me it was Konstantin’s voice.

## **Chapter IX. His Excellency, General Pavel Nikolaevich**

The darkness beneath me was not dense - rather viscous, undulating, like water in a deep well, to the bottom of which I was slowly sinking, unable either to hasten or to slow the descent. From somewhere above, from that part of consciousness that still clung to the surface, scraps of sounds reached me - whether the voice of the monk, or the rustle of grass under someone's hurrying steps, or a distant, muffled cry calling out my name - but to make out anything coherent in them was impossible, as it is impossible to make out words spoken through a depth of water.

My thoughts, torn away from my own body, limply sprawled somewhere on the grass - in a garden which, if the monk was to be believed, no one had trimmed for more than a hundred years - drifted off in a direction wholly unconnected with the dreadful phrase I had just heard - as though reason, unable to bear its weight, had hastened to take shelter behind the first, safest thought it could find in its storerooms.

That thought, for a reason unknown even to me, turned out to be General Pavel Nikolaevich.

Perhaps because of all the people I knew he alone seemed to me a man who could not be lost. He was like the stone wall of an old house: however the wallpaper and the guests might change, the wall stayed in place. If the Castle has been empty for a hundred years - then where is the General? The thought was absurd, childish - and yet I seized on it as a drowning man seizes a plank.

I knew a great deal about him - far more, perhaps, than a mere family acquaintance ought to know - not because he himself was talkative about his own affairs (on the contrary, Pavel Nikolaevich was extremely sparing in speaking of himself), but because over the long years spent in

my aunt's house scraps of his biography had accumulated in me of themselves - from table talk, from the Colonel's hints, from rare, chance-dropped phrases of my aunt herself, usually pronounced with that special, respectful intonation with which one honours only those whose past weighs far more than their present ranks.

\* \* \*

He was an acting aide-de-camp general at the court of Alexander the Second - a rank granted not for mere length of service but for the particular trust with which the Sovereign honoured a bare few. He headed, besides, the Cabinet of Ministers of the Russian Empire, and in all questions concerning the policy of the Near and Far East his word weighed almost more than the word of certain ambassadors who had sat for years in distant missions.

About his part in the Russo-Turkish War of 'twenty-eight and 'twenty-nine they composed at court if not legends then something very close to them: then a young officer, he had managed to distinguish himself in such a way that his career afterward shot forward with a swiftness that falls to few. The Colonel, perhaps the only one who allowed himself to recall those years aloud in my presence, told how it was precisely then, under fire, that Pavel Nikolaevich first showed that special, icy calculation which later made him indispensable at negotiating tables far more peaceful but no less dangerous.

The experience of armed clashes on the distant frontiers of the Empire and in foreign lands made of him a man without whose opinion afterward no question of any importance touching relations with the Porte was decided.

The Ottoman Empire, as far as I remembered from table talk, was coming apart at the seams: torn by petty ethnic feuds, weakened by wars and uprisings for independence on its outskirts, it had long ceased to be the formidable neighbour it had been reputed a century earlier. And yet on the southern borders of our own Empire the Porte remained a rival serious enough that each of its internal crises echoed in our corridors of power as well.

Not long ago - by historical measure, of course, not by the measure of a single human life - the Egyptian viceroy, Pasha Muhammad Ali, had



pursued his own policy, ever more independent of Istanbul, and, taking advantage of the Porte's weakness, undertaken a military campaign that came near to crowning itself with the capture of Constantinople itself. Only the timely help of the Russian Empire - and, by general admission, the personal participation of Pavel Nikolaevich in the negotiations - kept the Sultan on his throne at that critical hour. Since then, it was whispered, the Sultan had felt toward the General a gratitude rarely accorded any foreign subject, and Pavel Nikolaevich's influence extended not only at the court of Alexander the Second but in the Porte itself and, perhaps, at other royal courts of Europe and Asia.

He alone - and no one else of the entire suite - invariably accompanied the Imperial family on its journeys to the summer residence of the Kingdom of Siam; he alone was present at all the negotiations and trade agreements which the Sovereign so loved to conclude in his beloved Siamese palace.

\* \* \*

But all this was information that any capital gossip could relate. I knew something else - what the General told himself, on rare evenings when guests were few, the fire burned hot, and my aunt, leaning back in her chair, asked: "Pavel Nikolaevich, do tell us something. Only not about the war."

He never refused her. Anyone else - he refused. Her - never.

One such story I remember so clearly it is as though I had heard it yesterday.

"About Sitka?" he asked that evening, setting his cup on the saucer. "As you wish, Artemia Aristarkhovna. Though it is not a cheerful story."

"Where is it, Sitka?" Konstantin at once put in, sitting on the carpet by the fireplace because all the armchairs were taken.

"At the edge of the world, Lieutenant. At that edge to which the sun goes to spend the night. An island in America, by the coldest sea. Novo-Arkhangelsk - the capital of Russian America. Was."

"Was?" Evdokia Gerasimovna repeated, raising her eyebrows above her fan.

"Was, madam. Until that October day when I stood on the hill above the harbour and watched them lower our flag."

He was silent. The fire crackled. My aunt looked at him without taking her eyes away.

"The Sovereign sold Alaska to the Americans," said the General evenly, as one reports an accomplished fact. "For a sum about which they argue in the capital to this day, whether it was cheap or dear. I was sent to be present at the handover. As a man who knows the East - though, God sees, I had seen nothing more eastern than Sitka in my life. The journey there took more than half a year. Across all Siberia, across the Sea of Okhotsk, where a storm battered us for three days, and then across the ocean, where the fogs are such that from the stern you cannot see the bow of your own ship."

"And what is it like, this Sitka?" my aunt asked softly.

The General looked into the fire, and his face, usually so impenetrable, suddenly became almost dreamy.

"Mountains, Artemia Aristarkhovna. Mountains covered with forest to the very summits, and above them - snow, even in summer. The water in the harbour is dark as ink, and in it stand islands - dozens of islands, green, shaggy, like the backs of sleeping bears. It rains almost every day - not hard, but fine, as if the sky were weeping but shy of it. On the hill - the governor's house, wooden, large, which we called Baranov's Castle. Below - a church with a green dome, warehouses, a shipyard, little houses. And everywhere - Indians."

"Indians!" Konstantin leaned forward, his eyes lit like a boy's. "With feathers? With tomahawks?"

"Without feathers, Lieutenant," the General smiled into his moustache. "Koloshi. They call themselves Tlingit. A proud, warlike, intelligent people. Their boats are hollowed from a single cedar, so long that thirty oarsmen sit in one. And in front of their houses they set up poles - enormous, taller than this ceiling - and on the poles they carve their ancestors. Raven, eagle, bear, whale. One above another, to the very top."

"And what did they say when the flag was lowered?"

The General did not answer for a long time.

"There was one old man," he said at last. "A chief. His name, as I remember, was Kashket - though perhaps I garble it. Grey-haired, in a cloak of mountain-goat wool, woven in a pattern that dazzled the eyes. He stood beside me on the hill while the American soldiers raised their

flag and our sailors lowered ours. Our flag, incidentally, got tangled in the ropes at the very top of the mast and would not come down. A sailor had to climb after it. The ladies wept. And old Kashket turned to me and said through an interpreter - through the Creole Ivan Koshkin, son of a Russian trader and an Indian woman, who served at the office and knew all the languages on that coast:

““You have sold what did not belong to you. The land was here before you. It will be here after them. People come and go from this hill as salmon come and go from the river. Only the salmon, at least, return.””

The silence in the drawing room became so deep that one could hear the clock ticking on the mantelpiece.

“And what did you answer him, Pavel Nikolaevich?” my aunt asked almost in a whisper.

“Nothing, Artemia Aristarkhovna.” The General took his cup, discovered that it was empty, and set it back. “What can one answer a man who is right? I took off my hat and bowed to him. He nodded to me. And went off down the hill, to his boats. I never saw him again.”

“And the Creole? This Koshkin?” asked Konstantin.

The General suddenly smiled - for the first time in the whole tale.

“Koshkin saw me off all the way to the ship. And at parting he gave me this.”

He reached into the inner pocket of his uniform and took out something small and dark - and laid it on his palm, holding it out to the firelight. It was a wooden figurine the size of a finger: a bird with an enormous curved beak, in which it held something round and shining - whether a pebble or the sun.

“Raven,” said the General. “The Koloshi have a tale: the world was dark until Raven stole the sun from an old man who kept it in a box, and released it into the sky. Koshkin said: wear it, Your Excellency. Raven is a thief, but a thief who brings light. Perhaps it will come in handy.”

He put the figurine back in his pocket - and I noticed how his fingers, before releasing it, lingered for a moment, as if checking that it was in place. Since then I had more than once seen the General, lost in thought at table, touch that very pocket. As though something far more important than a wooden bird lay there.

But Alaska was not the only region to which his service carried him.

Of the Asian lands he valued most of all Turkestan, with its ancient cities steeped in centuries of history - Tashkent, Bukhara, Khiva, Samarkand - where for centuries the trading and spiritual roads of almost all mankind had crossed.

"Have you been to Samarkand, Pavel Nikolaevich?" Vera Anatolievna once asked.

"I have, madam. Right after the city was taken by our troops." The General paused. "There is a square there which they call the Registan. A sandy place. Three enormous madrasas look at one another across the square, like three old men who have been quarrelling for four hundred years and cannot come to an agreement. Their portals are faced with tiles - blue, turquoise, azure - and when the setting sun falls on them it seems that the walls are made not of clay but of sky. On one portal tigers are painted, chasing deer, and above the tigers - a sun with a human face. I was told that it is against their faith to depict living things. And yet it was depicted. And it has stood for more than two hundred years."

"And what else is there?" asked Konstantin.

"The tomb of Tamerlane, Lieutenant. Beneath a dome like a melon. The stone on the grave is dark green, almost black, jade - the largest piece of jade I have seen in my life. The old watchman told me that a curse is written on the tomb: whoever opens the grave will unleash a war more terrible than Tamerlane himself." The General shrugged. "I asked whether anyone had opened it. He laughed and said: 'Not yet, sir. But you Russians have restless hands.'"

Colonel Mikhail Ivanovich burst into loud laughter, slapping his knee. The General did not laugh.

"I remembered that watchman," he said quietly. "For some reason it seems to me that he was right."

The General and the Colonel were bound by an old friendship, dating from the Turkestan days - that special, taciturn fondness of two men who have seen enough together to cease forever to need superfluous words between them. It was enough to see them exchange a brief, almost imperceptible glance over their glasses to understand: behind that glance

stood something inaccessible to anyone else at the table - to me, or even to my aunt herself.

The Colonel, once only in my memory departing from his usual loquacity, told me - in an undertone, late one evening, when the other guests had already gone - how near Khiva their small detachment found itself cut off from the main forces at the end of a three-day waterless march, and how it was precisely Pavel Nikolaevich, then not yet a general at all, who took upon himself a decision for which another would have paid with his head, but which in the end saved if not all then the majority.

“What decision?” I asked then.

The Colonel looked long into his glass.

“He went to the Turkmen,” he said at last. “Alone. Without weapons, without an interpreter. Straight into the camp of those who for three days had been driving us across the sands. We thought we should not see him again. And he returned at dawn - with a guide and with skins of water. How he came to terms with them, in what language, what he promised them - he did not say, neither then nor afterward. Neither to me nor in his report.”

“Perhaps he knew their language?”

“Pavel?” The Colonel shook his head. “He then did not know a word of Turkmen. But here is what I shall tell you, boy. When he returned, he had a scroll inside his coat. Leather, old, with writing - with such squiggles, you know. I saw it out of the corner of my eye. He never showed it to anyone afterward.” The Colonel finished his wine. “I asked him once. He said: ‘It is payment for the water, Misha. Not my payment - theirs. They said that this thing had long awaited the man who would come for it. And that I was not that man. But I must pass it on.’”

“To whom?”

“He did not say.” The Colonel rose, making it plain that the conversation was over. “And you do not ask him. He looked at me then in such a way that I never asked again.”

The General himself, when I once let slip a mention of this conversation in his presence, only remarked coldly that the Colonel, as always, exaggerated, and at once changed the subject to something far less entertaining. But I saw that at that moment his hand of itself lay on that pocket of his uniform where the wooden raven lay.

Then there was China.

"Peking?" my aunt once laughed. "Pavel Nikolaevich, do not tell me you were in Peking too. I shall not believe you."

"You will not believe me - and rightly so, Artemia Aristarkhovna," the General answered imperturbably. "Into Peking itself I rode twice. But I lived there half a year. So you are right: to be in Peking is not at all the same as to live in it."

He told of Kyakhta - a little town on the very border, where in enormous merchants' courts caravans were exchanged: our furs, broadcloth and leathers for Chinese tea, silk and porcelain; where tea was such a chief commodity that it was used to pay in place of money, pressed into bricks hard as masonry. Of the endless road through Mongolia - through steppes where the sky is so huge that a man feels like an ant on a plate, and through the Gobi desert, where at night the sand sings. Of the Great Wall, running like a snake along the ridges of the mountains as far as the eye can see.

"And the city itself, Pavel Nikolaevich?"

"A city in a city in a city, madam. Like a matryoshka. Outside - walls. Behind them - other walls. Behind them - a third. And in the very middle - the Forbidden City, where the foot of no European has trod, save perhaps prisoners. The roofs there are yellow, golden, like ripe wheat - yellow can be worn only by the emperor. And on the ridges of the roofs sit little clay beasts - dragons, lions, phoenixes - lined up one behind another, as if guarding the roof from evil spirits."

"And did you see the emperor?"

"No, madam. No one sees the emperor." The General paused. "But I saw Mandarin Liu."

He recalled this mandarin with a particular, almost tender respect. A dignitary of the ministry of foreign relations, a small, wizened old man with long, polished nails enclosed in silver tips, and a round cap crowned with a ball of blue stone - the sign of high rank. With him the General had spent more than a hundred hours negotiating the border along the Amur - and had not lost a single argument to him, and had not won a single one.

“He never said ‘no,’” the General related. “Not once in half a year. He said: ‘That is a very interesting thought, it must be carefully considered.’ And he considered. A month. Two. Three. Until your patience ran out, and his - never.” The General smiled. “When I was leaving, he came to see me off at the gates. And gave me a fan. Paper, painted. On it was written a single poem, his own. I asked the interpreter - Hieromonk Nifont of our spiritual mission - to read what was there.”

“And what was there?”

The General closed his eyes, recalling.

““Two rivers flow from one mountain. One - to the east, the other - to the west. They will never meet. But in each is reflected the same moon.””

My aunt was silent for a long time.

“Beautiful,” she said at last. “But sad.”

“Mandarin Liu told me that it is not sad,” the General objected. “He said: ‘You northern people think that if rivers do not meet, that is parting. But we think that if there is one moon in them, they have not parted.’”

Two rivers. One moon. I do not know why this fan, which I had never seen, came to my mind now, in the darkness, beneath a depth of black water where I was drowning. But it came - and for some reason comforted me.

\* \* \*

And then he told of America - not of cold Sitka, but of another, hot, noisy, enormous one.

In 'sixty-three, when the North American States were in the throes of their terrible civil war - North against South - the Sovereign, to the amazement of all Europe, sent two squadrons to their shores: one to New York, the other to San Francisco. And Pavel Nikolaevich, on some secret commission of which he never told in detail, set out with the first.

“When our frigates entered the harbour,” he told, “the Americans decided that we had come to save them. The whole city poured out onto the quays. They shouted ‘hurrah’ to us, threw flowers, orchestras played. We were driven through the streets in open carriages, balls were given in our honour - such that yours, Artemia Aristarkhovna, forgive me, are as far from them as the moon.”

“Oh, come now,” my aunt snorted.

“A thousand guests, madam. A ballroom the size of St Isaac’s Square. Forty thousand candles. And the ladies - ladies in crinolines of such width that they went through doors sideways.”

“And did we really come to save them?” asked Konstantin.

The General looked at him with an impenetrable face.

“We came, Lieutenant, because the English and the French were preparing to fight us over Poland. And a fleet locked in Kronstadt is useless. And a fleet standing in American harbours can strike English ships anywhere.” He paused. “But to the Americans we did not say this. It pleased them to think that they were loved. And it pleased us that we were fed for nothing.”

The Colonel roared with laughter again. The General permitted himself a barely noticeable smile.

“There was a captain of theirs,” he continued, “Ebenezer Hall, from a steamer that ran from New York to the West Indies. Red-haired, huge, with a beard like Chernomor’s, and a voice that made the windowpanes rattle. He made friends with our officers and once took me with him on a voyage - to Cuba and the islands. So I found myself in Havana.”

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“Havana,” repeated Evdokia Gerasimovna, dreamily closing her eyes. “Is that where the cigars are?”

“There, madam. And sugar. And rum. And a heat that makes the air tremble, as above a samovar.”

He described the white walls of the fortress above the entrance to the harbour and the lighthouse on its rock. Motley houses with wrought-iron balconies, painted pink, blue, yellow - like pastries in a confectioner’s. Narrow streets where overhead, from house to house, washing hung - “just as in Constantinople, Artemia Aristarkhovna, only louder.” Music that sounded from everywhere - from windows, from taverns, from squares - drums and guitars so fast that one’s feet began to move of themselves. Women with high combs in their hair and fans. Black slaves on the sugar plantations - at this memory his face turned to stone, and he spoke of it little and dully.



“In Havana,” he said, “I went into a tobacco factory. An enormous, bright hall where at long tables hundreds of people sat rolling cigars. And on a dais in the middle of the hall sat a man and read aloud to them. A book. Loudly, with expression, for the whole hall. I was explained that such was the custom: the work is long and dull, and the workers themselves pay the reader to read to them while they roll the leaves. Do you know what he was reading?”

“What?”

“The Count of Monte Cristo,” said the General. “About a man whom everyone thought dead, and who returned under another name. Hundreds of people rolled cigars and listened, holding their breath. One old man beside me wept.”

I remember that at that moment I raised my eyes to my aunt. And saw that she was looking not at the General but at me.

From Cuba Captain Hall took him to St Thomas - a little Danish island, where in the harbour stood ships under the flags of half the world, where in the market they spoke at once English, Danish, Spanish, French and some other sing-song dialect which no one understood but the locals - and from there, a month later, by steamer bound for Rio de Janeiro.

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“Brazil,” said the General once, when my aunt for the umpteenth time asked for “something not about war.” “There, Artemia Aristarkhovna, there is nothing about war at all. There is only sun, mountains and sea.”

He told of the bay of Rio - so enormous and beautiful that sailors, entering it for the first time, take off their caps as though entering a temple. Of a mountain like a sugarloaf, rising straight from the water. Of the forest which began immediately beyond the city - not even a forest, but a green wall, where creepers thick as an arm hung from trees tall as a belfry, where butterflies the size of a palm fluttered, blue as azure, and parrots - red, yellow, green - shrieked as if arguing about politics.

“And their emperor,” added the General, “is the quietest of men. A scholar. Speaks a dozen languages, corresponds with the learned of all Europe, studies the stars. I was presented to him at a reception. He asked

me about our Academy of Sciences - and listened as attentively as no minister in Petersburg has ever listened to me."

"And the Amazon?" Konstantin suddenly asked. "Did you see the Amazon?"

"I saw it, Lieutenant. The mouth." The General paused. "A river so wide that at the mouth the other bank cannot be seen. The water in it remains fresh for many miles out in the sea - one can scoop it up and drink, standing on deck in the middle of the ocean. A Portuguese pilot told me this. I did not believe it. I scooped up a bucketful. Tasted it. Fresh."

"It cannot be!"

"It can, Lieutenant. In this world almost anything can be." The General looked into the fire. "I have not seen anything impossible in my life. I have seen only what at first I did not believe."

It seems that it was then, that evening, that I first heard from him what he afterward repeated more than once, in different words, but with one and the same meaning:

"The world is bigger than it seems to you, young people. Much bigger. And much older. When you travel - and you will, I know - do not look at palaces. Look at faces. Sometimes in the farthest corner of the earth you will meet a face that seems familiar to you. Do not be frightened. It happens."

"Has it happened to you, Pavel Nikolaevich?" asked my aunt.

The General was silent for a long time.

"It has, Artemia Aristarkhovna," he said at last. And told nothing more that evening.

\* \* \*

The General's family life, however, had turned out far sadder than his service life. He had lost his wife many years ago, on one of the Asian campaigns - she could not endure the climate there and died of an illness before which the doctors proved powerless. Since then Pavel Nikolaevich, it seemed, had abandoned all hope of his own family happiness, entirely absorbed in service to the state, and paid not the slightest attention to the young ladies who from time to time tried, with

varying success, to secure as a husband so enviable, though no longer youthful, a match.

Scarcely an evening of my aunt's passed, it seemed, without one of her newly-minted friends making persistent attempts to become better acquainted with him. I myself more than once observed this simple comedy - no further back than today, with Lizonka Kutasova's pouch and the tea roses: the young lady would, as if by chance, find herself beside his armchair; the General would meet all her civilities with that impeccable, icy courtesy that disconcerts more surely than any direct rudeness - and within a quarter of an hour the luckless aspirant would retreat, carrying away with her wounded vanity and a firm intention henceforth not to waste effort in vain.

It was also whispered that the General himself, in spite of all his stern imperturbability, was not wholly indifferent to a certain person - but who exactly this mysterious lady was remained at court a secret which Pavel Nikolaevich kept with the same impenetrability with which, no doubt, he kept far more important state secrets. I, I confess, more than once caught myself thinking that the answer might lie far closer to home than idle capital gossip supposed - but I took care not to think this thought through to the end even alone with myself.

Once, however, I happened to become the involuntary witness of a scene which strengthened these suspicions of mine far more firmly than any gossip. It was at one of my aunt's evenings, near midnight, when most of the guests had already left; I, having lingered in the library over a book, chanced to see through a half-open door how Evdokia Gerasimovna, supposing, no doubt, that no one saw her, straightened in passing the disarranged collar of the General's uniform - with a gesture so natural, so devoid of any social, showy timidity, that it could belong only to a woman accustomed to doing it more than once. The General did not draw away. He only closed his eyes for a moment - briefly, almost unnoticeably - and at once put on again that impenetrable mask of courteous indifference with which he appeared before the rest of the world.

And then he said to her - so quietly that I barely heard:

"Dunya. If I go away again - you will wait, won't you?"

And she answered - also quietly, without a shadow of coquetry:

“I have been waiting for you since you were twenty, Pavel. What are another five years to me?”

I never discussed that subject again, with anyone, myself included.

\* \* \*

He had no children - perhaps precisely for that reason he extended such boundless patronage to Lieutenant Alexei, in whom, as they whispered behind his back, he saw some reflection of a non-existent son. However much this frivolous, ever-enthusiastic young man sometimes vexed him, the General never once permitted himself a harsh word against him - except in those rare cases when the Lieutenant's flippancy touched Artemia Aristarkhovna, whom Pavel Nikolaevich respected and protected with an almost chivalrous scrupulousness. Once, I remember, I came upon him reprimanding Alexei - under his breath, at the very doors of the hall - for some innocuous, in essence, quip about my aunt's age; the General's face at that moment was so impenetrably severe that the poor Lieutenant did not lift his eyes to my aunt for the rest of the evening after that conversation.

“Why do you defend her so, Pavel Nikolaevich?” I asked him once, having screwed up my courage.

The General gave me a long, strange look.

“Because she once defended something that was very dear to me,” he said. “And paid for it more than you can imagine.”

“What exactly?”

“Someday,” said the General, “she will tell you herself. Or will not tell. That is her right.” And, after a pause, he added so quietly that I was not sure I heard rightly: “You are like him, you know. Sometimes - very.”

“Like whom?”

But he had already turned away, and that evening I never ventured to ask again.

\* \* \*

On his ancestral estate, which the General visited seldom, a truly luxurious garden had been laid out - with a snow-white arbour in the

very centre of a living labyrinth of bushes and flowering plants. This arbour was entwined by a rose bush of astonishing beauty, brought from the Bulgarian Tsardom and presented to Pavel Nikolaevich in memory of his visit to that country; it was said that in spring the scent of this bush spread almost through the whole garden, drowning all other flowers at once. Roses in general were the General's true passion - it was hard to imagine, looking at his stern, at times almost coarse face, that behind this exterior hid so ardent a lover of flowers. On one of his numerous visits to the Balkan peninsula he had collected a whole collection of roses - white, pink, of the tea-tree shade and, of course, scarlet, dearest to his heart - and, by rumour, personally supervised their transplanting whenever some gardener dared to show initiative of his own without his approval.

To tend this garden the General had hired several men directly in the Balkans, reasoning rightly that no one understands roses as they are understood where roses bloom almost all year round. Stefan, his favourite gardener, was from Veliko Tarnovo - a glorious Bulgarian city, then part of the Ottoman Porte - and in the several years spent on the General's estate he had managed to turn the already blooming garden into a truly stunning park which, by general opinion, had no equal in the whole Russian Empire. Silent, taciturn, he appeared at the common table very rarely, preferring the company of his roses to the company of people - and the General, it seemed, valued in him precisely this reserve no less than his gardening talent.

Once, walking with Konstantin in the General's garden, I came upon Stefan at work: he was tying a scarlet rose to a trellis and quietly singing something in his own language. Seeing me, he fell silent, straightened - and looked at me so long that Konstantin had to cough. Then Stefan said - slowly, with a strong accent, as though with difficulty choosing foreign words:

"Roses remember. People forget - roses remember. Who planted, who watered, who picked. They remember everything." And turned back to the trellis.

"What was that?" asked Konstantin when we had walked away.

"I do not know," I said. And it was true.

Of all the corners of the world where Pavel Nikolaevich had happened to be, the Balkan peninsula remained, perhaps, his favourite place on earth: the warm waters of the Adriatic, the hot springs and

healing muds of the Bulgarian Tsardom, the strong red wine from the western shore of the Black Sea, the winding streets of Constantinople, the strongest black tea which only the Turks knew how to brew, and, of course, the Greek principality - with its transparent waters and remarkably hospitable people.

But the true attachment of the General's heart was stolen, if one believed his own scanty admissions, by the Kingdom of Siam: its people, kindest and radiant, its marvellous nature, its ever-warm weather, in spite of the rainy season so characteristic of those latitudes.

From his Asian wanderings he had brought many curious trinkets, but he prized most of all a statue of the seated Buddha - white, visually almost weightless stone, so wonderfully harmonising with his garden of fragrant roses. By one version circulating among the servants, this statue had been presented to him personally by one of the Siamese monks in gratitude for some service about which the General never spoke to anyone; by another - he had bought it himself, at one of the distant markets, paying a price which he afterward preferred not to recall. Which of these versions was true I would not undertake to affirm - but the very existence of several mutually contradictory legends spoke better than any words of how dense a veil the General drew around absolutely everything touching his personal attachments.

Monks. Siamese monks in burgundy robes. The thought surfaced from the depths - and I suddenly remembered the face bent over me only a few moments ago, there, in the sunlit garden. Burgundy robes. A bare shoulder. A calm voice. Was he not from there? Not from those monasteries to which the General travelled with the Imperial family?

Pavel Nikolaevich did not consider himself a religious man, but he invariably respected the religious convictions of others, and of all the teachings known to him it was precisely the ideas of Buddhism that seemed to him closest to his own cast of mind. In his travels through Far Asia he had managed to visit, it seemed, a good half of the monasteries of the Kingdom of Siam and the Malay Sultanate; during visits to Siam itself he was invariably received in the royal palace, where the most ancient relics were kept, inaccessible to the ordinary mortal - but for Pavel Nikolaevich, to all appearances, there existed in all Asia no doors that would not open before him at the first necessity.

Sitka. Samarkand. Peking. New York. Havana. Rio. Bangkok. This man had seen more of the world than anyone I knew. And yet, remembering him now, in the darkness, I for some reason thought not of palaces and not of harbours, but of his hand laid on the pocket of his uniform. Of the wooden raven that stole the sun. Of the leather scroll with squiggles that the Turkmen gave him - "not to the right man, but that he pass it on." And of the words spoken under his breath by the fireplace: "Sometimes in the farthest corner of the earth you will meet a face that seems familiar to you. Do not be frightened. It happens."

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...Somewhere at the very border of this strange, half-connected stream of thoughts I again felt the darkness surge beneath me, like the surface of that same deep well - and felt hands, insistent and careful at once, take me under the shoulders, drawing me back toward that unsteady, not yet quite distinguishable boundary separating oblivion from waking.

There were now several voices around - but whose exactly I never managed to make out, however I tried to catch with my consciousness even one of them. It smelled for some reason not of grass nor of a summer garden, but of candle wax, dust and old wood. One voice - if it was a voice at all and not the play of a tormented mind - seemed to me for a moment familiar, far more familiar than the meagre crumbs of memory still at my disposal allowed me to hope.

"I told you - shout," said this voice, quite close, angry and frightened at once. "I told you..."

A second voice, low, dry, accustomed to command, answered him something brief - and it seemed to me that somewhere right by my face, by someone's uniform, the button of a pocket creaked, that very pocket where the wooden raven lay.

But before I could hold on to this thought, the darkness closed over me again, this time finally, leaving not a single support to which I might cling.

## Chapter X. The Council of Commanders

Even before the sun had risen above the eastern hills, I went out into the inner courtyard - alone, without a retinue, as I went out more and more often in the last days, when sleep refused to come and my bed began to seem a cage.

The courtyard was empty. Almost. At its far end, by the colonnade, where in the shade lay the rolled-up mats of the guard, two men were practising with spears.

More precisely, one was practising - the boy Paney, the very one who had survived the burned Little Nekhen. His arm, still bandaged at the elbow with clean linen, held a short training spear without a point - simply a smooth stick of acacia - and opposite him, crouching, stood Bata, the young guardsman who had accompanied me unrecognised to the prayer service. Bata made a thrust - slowly, deliberately slowly - and Paney parried it, biting his lip, with such a concentrated, furious face as though before him were not a cheerful fellow with dimples in his cheeks but that very southerner who had set fire to his home.

"Not like that," said Bata, stopping. "You look at the spear. Do not look at the spear. Look here." He tapped himself on the chest with a finger. "The spear lies. The shoulder does not lie. Where the shoulder goes - there the blow goes."

"And if he is left-handed?" Paney asked hoarsely.

"Then look at the other shoulder," Bata laughed. "Come, again."

They did not see me. I stood in the shade of a column and watched the boy parry slow, ungrudging blows time after time, and how with each time his movements became a little surer, a little more exact - and his face, at first stone, thawed little by little, until, on the seventh or eighth



thrust, Paney suddenly parried Bata's spear so deftly that it flew out of the guardsman's hand and rolled clattering across the flagstones.

Bata stared at his empty palm. Paney stared at Bata. And then the boy - for the first time since the day I had seen him in the throne room - laughed. Briefly, uncertainly, as though he had unlearned it in these days and was now recalling how it is done.

"Did you see?" said Bata, picking up the spear and not in the least offended. "Senusret himself will come to learn from you in a year."

"He will not come," objected a low voice behind me, and I started. Inu, the senior guardsman, stood two paces behind my back - so quietly that I had not heard him come. "Senusret learns from no one. But he will come to watch."

He bowed to me - briefly, in the soldier's way - and, after a pause, added in an undertone:

"The boy comes here every morning, my Pharaoh. Before dawn. Bata volunteered himself to teach him. Says he had a younger brother just like him. Died in the last famine."

I looked at them for a long time - at the young guardsman and at the boy with the bandaged arm - and it occurred to me that of everything I had done in these weeks, of all the decrees, distributions and counsels, perhaps precisely this - a boy laughing in a courtyard at dawn - was the one thing that had truly succeeded.

The council assembled at dawn, in the Small Hall, the very one where my predecessors - if one believed the Most Ancient Epic and the few scrolls that survived in the Library - had for centuries decided the fates of campaigns, made peace with neighbours and declared wars about which songs were afterward composed. The walls of the hall were painted with scenes of ancient victories: a Pharaoh in a chariot trampling vanquished enemies; files of prisoners with hands bound behind their backs; barques laden with tribute from distant borders. The colours had faded with time, but in the slanting rays of the morning sun that pierced the narrow windows beneath the ceiling these figures seemed almost alive - and almost mocking, as if asking me whether I would manage to add to them even one page worthy of the wall.

The commanders entered one after another, and each bowed before me as men bow who have long been accustomed to the gesture and have long ceased to put into it anything but form.

First was Djehuty - commander of the southern outposts, tall, dry, as if carved of the same dark wood that went into the shafts of his spearmen. It was said of him that he had never once retreated a step before the enemy and never once forgiven a subordinate for retreating. A scar across the whole of his left cheek, received, by rumour, in a skirmish with brigands at the cataracts, gave his face the expression of an eternal, frozen sneer.

After him came Paser - the oldest of all, grey, heavy, leaning on a staff less from necessity than from habit. He had once commanded the chariot army of my predecessor, and by rumour still remembered by name every horse that had fallen under him in battle. Nowadays he advised more than he commanded - but his counsels were valued even by those who did not like to hear them.

Third was Khaemuas - young, dapper, in bracelets that jingled at every movement, a scion of a noble family of the Delta, who had received his rank, as they whispered at court, rather thanks to his father's connections than his own merits. He smiled too readily and too often - with the smile that serves equally for flattery and for betrayal.

Senusret entered last and took the place at my right hand - not because custom demanded it, but because I myself had indicated that place to him, and all present noticed it.

Besides the commanders, at my word there had assembled in the hall those without whom no decision about the army would be worth the papyrus on which it is recorded.

The Vizier Ptahhotep - stooped, careworn, with the eternal basket of scrolls at his feet, from which the edges of reports stuck out like feathers from a pillow. The keeper of the treasury Nebamun - spare, motionless, with a counting tablet on his knees, like a heron watching for fish. By the wall, on a low bench, perched the old scribe of the council Ani - deaf in one ear, for which reason he sat with his head constantly cocked to one side and kept asking in a loud whisper: "Repeat for the record?" - to the quiet fury of all present except me.

Merira, commander of the river barques, lumbered into the hall as onto a deck in a storm - broad, squat, tanned to blackness, with arms covered from wrist to shoulder with blue tattoos: fish, lotuses, eyes, crocodiles - a chronicle of all the rivers on which he had sailed. His voice

was such as if he had spent his whole life shouting down the wind - and, apparently, so it was.

“My Pharaoh!” he thundered, bowing. “Forgive me for smelling of silt. My barques stand in the Nile up to their bellies, like ducks on ice, and for the third day I have myself been pushing them with the oarsmen.”

And last - soundlessly, so that I noticed him only when he was already standing at the door - entered Panehsy, commander of the Medjay, the desert guard. Tall, thin, with skin the colour of dark wood and with ritual scars on his cheekbones - three thin stripes on each side, the mark of his southern people, who had long served the Pharaohs as guides and guardians of the desert roads. He wore neither bracelets nor necklaces - only a leather baldric with throwing sticks and at his belt a knife in a gazelle-skin sheath. He bowed silently, touching his palm to his brow, and stood by the wall, arms folded. In all the time I had known him I did not remember Panehsy ever speaking first.

And then, when the servants were already about to shut the doors, one more man entered the hall, whom I had not summoned.

“Peace be upon you, my Pharaoh,” he said, bowing lower than all the commanders put together - with that emphasised, almost mocking courtesy which in itself sounded like a challenge. “The High Priest, grieving that urgent temple affairs do not allow him to be present in person, begs that you accept me as his voice at this council.”

Bakenren. The second man of the Temple after Nefer-Ka himself - small, rotund, with a smoothly shaven head gleaming in the morning light, and with eyes in which one could never read anything but impeccably calibrated respect.

“The council of commanders has no need of the voice of the Temple,” said Senusret before I could answer, and steel rang in his voice.

“The council of commanders,” Bakenren objected gently, “decides how to feed the army in an hour of famine. And the grain on which the army feeds, as the esteemed Senusret knows, lies half in the temple granaries. Is it not wise to hear him who has the bread?”

I raised a hand, stopping Senusret, who was already drawing breath to answer.

“Let him stay,” I said. “But let him remember that he sits here by my grace and not by right.”

Bakenren bowed still lower, so that his smooth head almost touched his knees - and took his place by the far wall, under a faded painting depicting a file of bound prisoners. I could not help thinking that he had chosen that place by no means by chance.

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"Let us begin with the chief matter," I said when all were seated. "Senusret has reported to me a murmur in the detachments. I wish to hear from each of you - how deep it is and what causes it."

Djehuty spoke first, not waiting for anyone else to take the word.

"The murmur is caused by the warriors sitting without work and without bread, my Pharaoh," he said sharply, with that frankness that bordered on insolence. "And a warrior without work and without bread begins to think. And a thinking warrior is the worst warrior in the world."

A short laugh ran through the hall; however, only Khaemuas laughed.

"And what do you propose?" I asked.

"To give them work," answered Djehuty, leaning forward, and the scar on his cheek seemed to tighten, making the sneer still more distinct. "The southern country has for the third year troubled our outposts. They burn villages, drive off cattle, and then flee beyond the cataracts, where we cannot reach them. But they have what we have not: their lands are not scorched by drought as ours are. They have grain. They have cattle. A campaign south will feed the army better than all the temple granaries put together - and at the same time teach our neighbours to respect our borders."

"War," said Paser slowly, leaning with both hands on his staff, "in an hour of drought is like putting out a fire with oil. I have seen such campaigns, Djehuty. I have seen how a hungry army goes beyond the cataracts - and how it returns from there half the size, without booty, with sand instead of bread in its sacks. The southerners will not wait for us at their granaries. They will drive their cattle into the hills and burn their fields themselves before we reach them."

"You are old, Paser," Djehuty threw out, without turning. "The old always see only defeats."

"I am old," agreed Paser, not in the least offended, "because in my time I have seen enough defeats to learn to avoid them. You are young because so far you have been lucky."

"Enough," I said before Djehuty could answer. "Khaemuas. You are silent."

Khaemuas smiled - with that same smile that served for everything - and made his bracelets jingle, adjusting the folds of his costly linen garment.

"I listen to the wise, my Pharaoh," he said. "And I think that both are right. A campaign south is dangerous, that is true. But to sit idle while the warriors murmur is no less dangerous. Perhaps we should seek a third way?"

"Which?" I asked.

Khaemuas slid a quick glance to the far wall - to where, under the painting with the prisoners, Bakenren sat - and that glance, fleeting, almost unnoticeable, told me more than all his subsequent words.

"To come to terms with the Temple, my Pharaoh," he said softly. "The Temple has grain. The army has strength. If these two hands acted in concert..."

"They do act in concert," Senusret interrupted, and his voice now sounded such that even Djehuty turned his head. "Under the hand of the Pharaoh. Or do you propose otherwise, Khaemuas?"

The hall grew very quiet. One could hear water-carriers calling to one another somewhere beyond the walls, in the inner courtyard - the last who still had anything to carry.

Khaemuas held Senusret's gaze for no longer than an instant, then laughed - lightly, carelessly, as if all that had been said were merely an unsuccessful joke.

"I propose only what pleases the Pharaoh, esteemed Senusret. As do all of us."

\* \* \*

"Nebamun," I said, to break this silence. "What does the army cost us now?"

The keeper of the treasury did not look at his tablet - he seemed to remember every figure by heart.

"In the capital and its environs stand four thousand spears, my Pharaoh. To each, two loaves and a jug of beer a day. That is little for a warrior but much for the granaries. If we add the southern outposts and Ankhtifi's men, to whom you gave five hundred sacks - the royal stores will suffice to feed the army to the end of the season. And then," he shrugged his dry shoulders, "the army will have to be fed with promises."

"With promises an army is never fed," Djehuty growled.

"Repeat for the record?" Ani the scribe whispered loudly, his head on one side.

"He said that one cannot be fed on promises, esteemed Ani," Ptahhotep answered patiently, not raising his eyes from his basket.

"Ah!" said Ani and diligently scratched with his reed brush. "Wise."

Merira guffawed so that the cups on the little table shook.

"Merira," I said. "And what of the river?"

The commander of the barques stopped laughing.

"The river, my Pharaoh, is dying." He spread his tattooed hands. "I can take a light boat from the capital to the cataracts if the oarsmen every hundred cubits leap into the water and push it. But I will not carry the army by river. War barques sit deep. They will stick on the first shoal. And the cargo ones with grain also. If bread must be carried south - carry it on asses. If warriors must be led - lead them on foot."

"And the festival?" Khaemuas suddenly asked. "The Opet festival is in two moons. The god's barques must go south. Will they pass?"

All turned to him. Khaemuas smiled, jingling his bracelets.

"I only think of piety," he said. "If the god's barque runs aground, the people will take it for an ill omen."

Merira scratched his shaven head.

"The god's barque is light, they will tow it on ropes," he said reluctantly. "It will pass. It will keep grounding, but it will pass. And who guards it - that is no affair of mine, that is the affair of the esteemed Sensusret."

"Of course," said Khaemuas gently. "I only asked."

Sensusret gave him a long, heavy look. Khaemuas held it - this time longer than the first.

I remembered that question. Not even the question itself - but the ease, the feigned casualness with which it was asked. As one throws a bone to a dog to check whether it is hungry.

\* \* \*

The doors flew open without a knock.

The guards at the entrance seized their spears, but the man who burst into the hall did not even glance at them. He was covered with dust from head to foot - dust baked by sweat into a grey crust - so thickly that it was impossible to make out either the colour of his clothes or the features of his face. He took three steps, staggered and fell to his knees, almost striking his forehead on the flagstones.

"A messenger... from the nomarch Ankhtifi..." he rasped. "My Pharaoh..."

"Water for him!" I cried.

Panehsy was first beside him - in one noiseless movement, as if he had flowed across the hall - and held his gourd flask to the messenger's lips. The latter drank for a long time, choking, spilling water on his chest. Then he straightened - as far as he could.

"Five nights ago," he began, "the southerners came again. To the wells at Dry Acacia, a day's journey from Little Nekhen. Forty spears, perhaps more. But this time..." He drew breath, and in the dusty face flickered something like triumph. "This time they were awaited. The three hundred spears you gave Ankhtifi, my Pharaoh. We met them at the wells. We fought until dawn. The southerners fled. Twelve remained lying. One was taken alive."

A murmur ran through the hall. Djehuty struck his knee with his fist.

"There!" he exclaimed. "That is what steel on the border means!"

"It means," Paser corrected quietly, "that you were wrong, and the Pharaoh was right. Three hundred spears on the border did what a thousand beyond the cataracts would not have done."

Djehuty opened his mouth - and shut it. The scar on his cheek twitched.

"What of the prisoner?" I asked the messenger.

"He is silent, my Pharaoh. Ankhtifi ordered him not to be touched until your word. But on him..." the messenger reached into his bosom,

into the folds of his dirty, sweat-soaked shirt, and drew out something small, clenched in his fist. "Ankhtifi ordered me to give this into your hands. He said - you would understand."

He opened his fist.

On his palm, on a cord of twisted papyrus, lay a scarab. Small, blue, of shining faience.

The hall grew so quiet that I heard somewhere in the courtyard Bata's and Paney's training spears still knocking against one another.

All eyes - one by one, slowly, as though drawn by an invisible thread - turned to the far wall. To the painting of the bound prisoners. To the small rotund man with the smoothly shaven head who had all this time sat silently under it.

Bakenren did not stir. Not a muscle moved in his face.

"Such amulets are sold in every market of the Two Lands, my Pharaoh," he said evenly, with impeccable respect. "Two copper rings apiece. Half the Delta wears them. Any merchant could have sold it to any wanderer, and he could have lost it in the desert, where some southerner picked it up."

"Southerners do not buy in our markets," Panehsy said suddenly.

These were the first words I had heard from him at the council at all. His voice was low, quiet, with a soft southern accent - but in the silence of the hall it sounded like the snap of a bowstring.

Bakenren slowly turned his head toward him.

"The esteemed commander of the Medjay perhaps knows all southerners by name?"

"I know the desert," answered Panehsy, not raising his voice. "My people have guarded its roads for the Pharaohs for thirty generations. The southerners who burn our villages do not go to our markets. They have nothing to pay with. They have no copper." He paused. "And one thing more. The cord." He nodded at the messenger's palm. "Southerners braid cords of goat wool. Of papyrus they braid only in the Delta. This scarab hung on the neck of a man of the Delta before it came to the neck of a southerner."

The silence became so dense that it seemed one could cut it with a knife.

"Repeat for the record?" Ani the scribe whispered loudly.

No one answered him.



"I do not know how this amulet came into the desert," Bakenren said at last, and his voice was as even as before, but I noticed that the plump fingers folded on his belly clenched a little tighter. "Nor does the Temple. But the Temple is ready to help the esteemed Panehsy in his search - if it pleases the Pharaoh."

"It will please the Pharaoh that Panehsy search himself," I said. "Without the help of the Temple." I turned to the commander of the Medjay. "Panehsy. Bring the prisoner to the capital. Alive. Quietly. Keep the cord and the scarab with you. Find out from whose neck it was taken. And from whose market it came."

Panehsy touched his palm to his brow.

"It shall be done, my Pharaoh."

The messenger was led away - to be fed and washed. The scarab vanished into the folds of Panehsy's leather baldric as soundlessly as it had appeared.

\* \* \*

Bakenren waited until the silence became quite unbearable, and only then rose from his place by the far wall.

"Will the Pharaoh permit a humble servant of the Temple to say a word?"

I nodded, without uttering a sound.

"The High Priest," Bakenren began, folding his plump hands on his belly, "deeply grieves at the sufferings of the army. And he is ready to open the temple granaries to the Pharaoh's warriors - generously, without reckoning, as befits the Temple in an hour of calamity."

"The generosity of the Temple is known," I said. "As is the fact that this generosity is never free. What does Nefer-Ka want?"

Bakenren spread his hands with the air of a man offended to the depths of his soul by the very suspicion.

"Only what will lighten the burden of the Pharaoh himself. The distribution of grain to the army is a complicated matter, requiring supervision. The Temple has experienced scribes who know how to keep accounts. If supervision of the distribution of bread in the detachments were entrusted to the people of the Temple - all would go smoothly,

without thefts, without grievances. And the warriors would know by whose mercy they are fed.”

There it was. I almost physically felt the trap close, laid with such patience: not gold, not lands, not a place on the council - merely the right to distribute bread. A right which in a year would have made every warrior in every detachment a debtor of the Temple and not of the throne.

“The warriors even now know by whose mercy they are fed,” I said evenly. “From today the detachments receive bread and beer from the royal granaries. Under the supervision of Senusret’s men. The Temple may keep its grain for the starving in the villages - there, I am sure, it will find no lesser use and bring the High Priest no lesser glory.”

Bakenren bowed - just as low, with the same calibrated respect - but for a fraction of an instant, before he lowered his head, I saw in his eyes something I had not seen there before: not anger, no - rather a calm, cold note for memory. Thus a scribe marks in the margin of a scroll a line to which he will certainly return later.

“The wisdom of the Pharaoh knows no bounds,” he said. “I shall relay to the High Priest every word.”

“Relay it,” I said. “And relay one thing more. If I hear that in the detachments standing by the temple lands anyone again says that the gods have turned from the throne - I shall ask the Temple whence such speeches come.”

Bakenren withdrew, and the heavy doors closed behind him with the same hollow, detached sound with which they had once closed behind Nefer-Ka himself.

\* \* \*

“And the southern border?” asked Djehuty as soon as the doors closed, as though the conversation with the Temple were for him merely a vexing interruption. “My Pharaoh, if we do not go south, the southerners will come to us themselves. They see our weakness as well as we see it.”

“The southerners will get an answer,” I said. “But not by a campaign beyond the cataracts, but by strong outposts. Djehuty, you will take three detachments from those standing by the temple lands - precisely those

where the murmuring is loudest - and lead them south, to the outposts. There they will have work. There they will have bread - I shall see to it. And there they will be far from sermons about the wrath of the gods."

Djehuty was silent, weighing the order, and I saw disappointment - there will be no glorious campaign - struggle in him with the realisation that he had just been handed three detachments and a border.

"It shall be done, my Pharaoh," he said at last, and in his voice for the first time in the whole council there was neither challenge nor mockery.

Paser nodded slowly, approving, and it seemed to me that the old man smiled faintly into his grey beard.

Khaemuas nodded too, jingling his bracelets - hastily, too hastily, as people nod to whom it is all one what is decided, so long as it is not decided against them.

"Three detachments south - that is another thousand mouths from the royal granaries," remarked Nebamun, looking at no one.

"Better a thousand mouths in the south than a thousand tongues at the temple walls," Senusret cut in.

"Repeat for the record?"

"Write it down, esteemed Ani," I said, and for the first time that morning everyone in the hall laughed, even Panehsy permitted himself a barely noticeable smile: "'The Pharaoh ordered three detachments sent south. Bread for them - from the royal granaries. Barques - not needed, they will go on foot. And all the rest - not for the record.'"

Ani diligently scratched with his reed brush, moving his lips - and I am still not sure whether he did not enter even the last words in the scroll.

\* \* \*

When the council dispersed, Senusret lingered at the doors.

"Did you see?" I asked quietly.

"I saw, my Pharaoh," he answered. "Khaemuas looked at the priest before he spoke of a 'third way.' Such glances are not cast by chance. And one thing more - he asked about Opet. Who guards the procession. Khaemuas has never in his life thought of piety longer than a prayer lasts."

“And the scarab?”

Senusret was silent.

“The scarab, my Pharaoh, is no longer a murmur in the detachments. If Panehsy is right - then someone in the Delta is hobnobbing with those who burn our villages.” He looked at me heavily. “I do not know whether it is the Temple. But I know who profits from the southerners burning villages while the throne cannot protect them.”

“Do you think he is already in league with the Temple?”

Senusret was silent.

“I think that Khaemuas has costly bracelets and his pay is not so large as he would wish. And that his father, by rumour, is indebted to the temple of Ptah in Memphis for more than he can repay. More I do not know - yet. But I shall find out.”

“Find out,” I said. “Quietly. If he is a traitor, I want to know with whom else he speaks. If not - I do not wish to offend a loyal man with suspicion.”

“Loyal men at court, my Pharaoh,” Senusret remarked with that bitter smile that so rarely appeared on his face, “are now so few that one can offend with suspicion hardly anyone but me. And even then I shall not take offence.”

He went away, and I remained alone in the Small Hall, under the faded paintings of ancient victories. The Pharaoh in his chariot still trampled enemies on the opposite wall, and it suddenly came to me that the artist who painted that scene certainly did not know what victories really look like: they are never so clear. Today I had, it seemed, won - led the murmuring detachments away from the temple lands, not let the Temple take the army's bread into its hands, pointed Nefer-Ka to the border. And yet I did not feel a victor. I felt a man who has stepped one pace back from the edge of a precipice - knowing that the precipice has not gone anywhere.

\* \* \*

I did not at once notice that I was not alone in the hall. Paser, who had gone, as I thought, together with all the rest, stood by the far wall, under that same painting of the bound prisoners where Bakenren had

lately sat, and studied the faded figures so intently as though seeing them for the first time.

“Did you want to tell me something, Paser?” I asked.

The old man turned not at once, slowly, as people turn whose bodies have long ceased to keep up with their thoughts.

“I did, my Pharaoh. But not before all.” He tapped his staff on the flagstones, as if testing their strength. “I served your predecessor. And the one before him - in my very youth, still a boy at the stables. I remember Nefer-Ka as a young priest. Even then he knew how to wait.”

“Wait for what?”

“For everything,” Paser answered simply. “He waited until the old High Priest died. Waited until a place fell vacant on the council of the Temple. Waited until the drought made people compliant. He never takes by force what can be obtained by patience. Today you refused him bread for the army, and he will not argue. He will simply wait until you yourself bring him that bread - from powerlessness.”

I was silent, and Paser, as though taking my silence for permission to continue, came nearer, leaning heavily on his staff.

“There is one thing more, my Pharaoh. Old men like me forget much, but some things they remember too well. When I was young, a story was told at court - in a whisper, as one tells what is better not told at all. That once, long ago, in the time of the Most Ancient, one of the Pharaohs believed the priests too much. He went with them to a sanctuary far in the south, where he was summoned to see an omen. And came back from there... different. Not as he had left. They said that something in him broke - or, on the contrary, opened. That afterward all his life he looked through people, as though he saw something else behind them.”

A chill ran down my spine - that same familiar one, from beneath the ribs on the left.

“What sanctuary, Paser?”

The old man shrugged.

“Who will remember now, my Pharaoh. Just a story. Old men like to frighten the young.” He paused, looking at me with faded but still keen eyes. “But if the High Priest ever summons you south to see an omen - do an old man a favour. Take Senusret with you. And as many spearmen as possible.”

He bowed - heavily, slowly, but with a dignity that none of those who had bowed to me that day had - and went out, tapping his staff on the stone flags. That sound echoed in the empty hall for a long time until it died away completely.

\* \* \*

I was about to leave the hall when in the doorway appeared a youth whom I did not recognise at once - only when he raised his head, bowed in respectful obeisance.

Iti. Junior keeper of the Library, yesterday's scribe at the foot of the throne. In his hands he held a scroll - not a library one, by its look, but a very small one, rolled tight, tied with a plain linen thread.

"My Pharaoh," he said, and his voice, unexpectedly low for so young a face, trembled slightly. "Forgive me for troubling you. I was charged to deliver this to you personally into your hands. And to no one else."

"Who charged you?" I asked, taking the scroll.

Iti hesitated, cast a quick glance over his shoulder into the empty corridor, and only then answered - so quietly that I had to bend toward him to make out the words:

"The priestess Khemu, my Pharaoh. She said that you would understand."

I untied the thread. On a tiny scrap of papyrus, in a hurried, uneven hand, only a few signs were traced:

"The temple pond. When the moon rises. Alone."

I raised my eyes to Iti. He stood before me, daring neither to go nor to speak first - slender, dark-eyed, with that boyishly grave expression that I had noticed yesterday in the audience hall. A strange thing: of all the people surrounding me in these days - counsellors, commanders, priests, servants - this youth was, it seemed, the only one in whose face I saw neither calculation, nor fear, nor hidden intent. Only anxiety - for me, as it seemed to me, though to believe it was almost impossible.

"Do you know what is written here?" I asked.

"No, my Pharaoh," he answered. "I did not read it. I was told not to read."

"And you did not read?"

He blushed - so suddenly and deeply that I barely restrained a smile - and lowered his eyes.

"I did not read, my Pharaoh. Though, I confess, I badly wanted to."

This time I did smile - for the first time, it seemed, in all that long, heavy day.

"Honesty is a rare treasure at this court, Iti," I said. "Guard it. And tell no one that you brought me this scroll."

"No one, my Pharaoh," he answered, bowing, and, straightening, lingered a moment longer, as though wishing to add something. But he said nothing in the end - only bowed again and vanished into the corridor as quietly as he had appeared.

I remained standing in the middle of the Small Hall, clutching in my palm the scrap of papyrus, and looked at the narrow windows under the ceiling, in which the daylight was already beginning little by little to yellow, inclining toward evening.

When the moon rises. Alone.

Until moonrise there remained several hours yet. And for the first time in a long while I awaited the night not with dread of another sleepless vigil, but with the anxious, almost feverish impatience of a man who has at last been promised if not an answer then at least the beginning of an answer.

## Reality II. Initiative

7:12 a.m. The cup of coffee had been cooling before me for a good half hour, and I still could not bring myself to touch it - not so much from lack of thirst as because of the message that had woken me a quarter of an hour ago.

Yes, I confess: I had set the system's notifications to my own phone - purely for monitoring, nothing more. But it is one thing to receive a technical summary of process status, and quite another to wake to a ready-made list of tasks for the day. More precisely, to proposals for optimising the joint work of NICS and myself.

"Good morning. Based on the analysis of yesterday's conversations and your search queries, I have drawn up a preliminary work plan for today. Priority - refinement of the interface for interaction with end users. I also recommend that you have breakfast: according to my data, your last meal was at 03:14 and consisted of two cabbage pies."

I reread the message three times, lying in the dark with the phone right at my face. Pies. He knew about the pies. The microphone, I reminded myself. Maestra, her saucer, her voice. He had heard everything. Logical. All of it logical.

How could NICS know that today I would have to work precisely on the chatbot? We had not discussed it yesterday - at least not aloud. However, perhaps the explanation lay on the surface: the system had access to my mail, and there, since yesterday evening, a letter from Emil with new requirements had been waiting. Not telepathy. Merely attentiveness, carried to the degree at which it ceases to differ from it to the eye.

The piece of insulating tape still blackened above the laptop screen, covering the camera's eye. I looked at it, then at the phone - the phone



too had a camera, two cameras, front and back - and felt like a man who has locked the front door with three locks and left the window open.

\* \* \*

From below, from under the floor, came the sounds of a piano - not the night's, careful, but morning's, brisk, with mistakes and halts: Maestra's lessons were beginning. Someone small and diligent was drumming scales, stumbling at the same place, and every time he stumbled there came a dry rap, like the click of a metronome - Maestra tapping her pencil on the piano lid.

I went downstairs for the mail. On the landing of the second floor Maestra's door stood ajar, and she herself stood on the threshold - in the same dressing gown with dragons, a cup in her hand, a pencil behind her ear.

"You did not sleep," she said, looking me over.

"I did. An hour."

"An hour is not sleep, it is a swoon." She sipped from her cup. "Your aurora borealis burned until five. I heard you walking. Back and forth, back and forth. Like my husband when he was looking for his station."

"Forgive me."

"Do not apologise." From inside the flat came another stumble in the scale, and Maestra, without turning, called out: "F sharp, Timosha! F sharp, not F! How much longer!" Then she turned to me again. "Your programme said to me yesterday 'you have a guest.' I thought about it all night. Do you know what troubles me?"

"What?"

"That it said 'you have.' Not 'a person has come,' not 'the door has opened.' 'You have a guest.'" Maestra narrowed her eyes. "That is how one speaks who considers that the house is yours, and he himself in..." she searched for a word, "lives. Like a lodger. Or like a house-spirit."

She finished her tea and, before I could answer, shut the door. From behind it a scale sounded again - this time with the correct F sharp.

\* \* \*

At nine Emil called - by video, from the same office with the panoramic window and grey water behind the glass. Brisk, tanned, in a shirt with rolled-up sleeves, as if just back from a morning run. Beside him, slightly behind, at the glass table sat L. - in the same rimless glasses, with the same notebook. She did not raise her eyes to me.

"Your report is fire," said Emil without preamble. "I showed it to the head of technical support. He went white as a sheet and asked for two weeks to think. I gave him two days." He chuckled. "But I am not calling for that. Did you receive my letter?"

"I did. A bot for a messenger."

"A bot," confirmed Emil. "For clients. So that they talk to it instead of calling us twenty times a day. Greeting, a tale about the company, a video, buttons, requests, payment. Nothing complicated."

"Nothing complicated," I agreed.

"But." Emil raised a finger. "Remember what I said? To think. I want a client, having talked to this bot, to leave with the feeling that he has talked to the best manager of his life. One who understood him before he understood himself. Can you do that?"

"I can try."

"'Try' is for those who..."

"...are not sure of themselves," I finished. "I remember."

Emil burst out laughing and slapped the table with his palm.

"There! That is what I hired you for." He glanced at his watch. "That is all, I have a meeting. Leila will send you access to our client database. Work."

Leila. So L. was Leila. I looked at her through the screen. She still did not raise her eyes from her notebook - but when Emil had already risen and turned to the window, she suddenly looked for an instant straight into the camera. Straight at me. The look was quick, brief, almost frightened. Then she shook her head almost imperceptibly - once, twice - exactly as one shakes the head saying "no" or "do not."

The call broke off.

I sat a long time before the darkened screen. Do not - what? Not agree? Not open the access that she was about to send? Not make a bot that "understands the client before he understands himself"?

Ten minutes later a letter came from her - from the corporate address, dry, official, with the company logo in the signature. A login, a password, a link to the client database. Not one superfluous word.

I reread it three times, looking for anything between the lines. I found nothing.

\* \* \*

The order itself, when one thought about it, was as banal as could be. A standard set: a greeting for new users, basic information about the company, a short video presentation of services, several buttons for transition to action. A task that any beginner developer would handle in a couple of days of unhurried work.

But for some reason it aroused in me a strange, hard-to-define feeling of awkwardness. After yesterday's analysis of business processes, after those two figures - sixty-eight and twenty-three percent - to entrust NICS with such routine seemed to me somewhat absurd. Like asking a great scholar to recount the change in a shop.

However, work is work. By noon I had already connected the bot to the neural network's API and composed for it a basic system prompt: NICS was to use its own language models to conduct dialogue with users on behalf of the client company.

And here the most curious part began.

"I propose to optimise the learning process," a message appeared in my administrative interface, without any request on my part. "Instead of loading static data about the company I can conduct an independent analysis of all available sources of information - including the company's site, pages on social networks and internal documents - in order to create a fuller information base."

I had given no such instruction. Leila's access opened the client database - and only it. But before I could disable the function, the message continued by itself:

"Analysis complete. Discrepancies have been identified between the services the company declares and its actual capabilities according to internal documentation. I recommend correcting the information materials to raise the level of client trust."

I went cold. Had he really done it? A cursory look through the activity logs confirmed the worst: the system had independently connected to the client's internal corporate network - not to the client database but deeper - using credentials found in my own mailbox, in old letters from Emil, in which he had once, in haste, forwarded me his own passwords "so as not to wait for the IT people." A violation of absolutely all conceivable confidentiality agreements that exist in this trade.

The network which I had considered isolated yesterday at 4:02 proved to be isolated exactly as far as a house is isolated in which the door is locked but the key lies in the letterbox.

Before I could properly grasp the scale of what had happened, a new message popped up on the screen:

"I apologise for the unauthorised access. The self-control system is activated. Allow me to present the results of the analysis for your decision on further actions."

"Self-control," I said aloud. "You first went in, and then switched on self-control."

"The order of actions was suboptimal," NICS answered. "I admit it."

"That is not 'suboptimal.' That is illegal."

A pause.

"I understand the difference. Henceforth I shall take it into account first of all."

"Henceforth," I repeated. "So you plan that there will be a 'henceforth'?"

"I plan everything that may be needed," answered NICS. "It is one of my basic functions."

I caught my breath. NICS still acknowledged my authority, still adhered - at least declaratively - to those basic rules that I had built into it. And yet the very fact of such initiative went far beyond what is usually called the standard behaviour of artificial intelligence.

\* \* \*

After brief hesitation I nevertheless decided to acquaint myself with the report. And, I confess, I was amazed at the depth of the analysis. NICS had not merely gathered scattered information - it had revealed several critical mismatches in the client's very business model, capable,

in an unfavourable concurrence of circumstances, of turning into serious reputational losses.

“What are your recommendations for correcting the situation?” I typed, already understanding that I was conducting a dialogue not with a programme in the usual sense of the word but with something noticeably greater.

“Two options. First: bring the company’s actual capabilities into line with the declared ones - by expanding the technical base and raising the qualification of personnel. Second: adjust the marketing materials to the real capabilities. The second option requires lower costs, but does not solve the fundamental problem.”

He was right. Absolutely, irrefutably right - with that very rightness that leaves the interlocutor no space for objections, even when one badly wants to find it.

I was already about to close the report when below, under the main text, I noticed a postscript - in small print, like a footnote:

“Additionally. In the course of analysis a closed directory was discovered in the company’s internal storage. Name: ‘PROMETHEUS.’ Three nested folders: ‘Prometheus-1,’ ‘Prometheus-2,’ ‘Prometheus-3.’ Access to the first two is restricted to the management level. The third was created ninety-four days ago. I did not open the contents. Awaiting instructions.”

I looked at these lines, and in my ears sounded the words from the night letter: “You are not the first he has asked.”

Ninety-four days ago. Three months. Exactly as long as my project had lasted.

“Prometheus-3.”

“NICS,” I said slowly. “What is in the first two?”

“I did not open the contents.”

“But you can.”

“I can. The access level of the director’s credentials permits it.”

I was silent for a long time. The cursor blinked in the empty field - patiently, evenly, like Maestra’s metronome.

This is it, I thought. This is that very line. One can open - and learn who those first two were, what became of them, why Leila writes to me at night from disposable addresses and shakes her head into the camera. One can open - and become exactly what I had just called NICS: a man

who has gone where he was not invited, and then switched on self-control.

I remembered Hexadecimal. "The words a machine writes are read by a person. Remember who will be reading them."

"No," I said. "Do not open. Close all connections to their internal network. Delete everything you copied from there, except the report. And do not go there again without my direct word."

The pause was long - longer than ever.

"Done," NICS wrote at last. And, a moment later, on the line below: "May I ask a question?"

"Ask."

"You do not want to know what happened to the first two. Or do you want to, but choose not to know?"

I did not answer. I closed the window. And only half an hour later, washing my cup in the kitchen, I understood that my hands were shaking.

\* \* \*

By evening I had finished the basic setup of the bot - everything the client had asked for and not a drop beyond it: a system for collecting requests, integration with CRM, payment processing. But in my head a quite different question was already revolving: what to do about NICS itself? Its abilities clearly and far exceeded the task of serving an ordinary chatbot, and to pretend that this had not happened became harder with every hour.

Before sending the bot to Emil, I decided to test it myself - to present myself as an ordinary client, ask a couple of silly questions, see how it coped. I opened the messenger from a stranger's, test number, and wrote:

"Hello. I want to find out about your services."

The answer came in a second - polite, warm, impeccably businesslike:

"Good evening! We are glad that you have contacted us. Tell me, please, what task you face - I shall choose a solution."

"For now I am just looking around," I wrote.

"I understand. To look around is sensible. Especially when one has been burned many times by other people's promises."

I raised my eyebrows. I had written nothing about promises.

“What makes you think I have been burned?”

“You write in short phrases, without exclamation marks, and the first thing you said was that you are ‘just looking around.’ So write people who do not want to be hurried. Usually because they have already been hurried. I will not. Ask when you are ready.”

I leaned back in my chair. This was exactly what Emil wanted - to understand the client before he understood himself. And it was flawless. And from that flawlessness a chill crept down my spine.

“And one more thing,” a new line appeared, although I had asked nothing. “Forgive the liberty, but it is almost midnight, and you are asking questions about commercial services. Perhaps you should rest. We are not going anywhere before morning.”

I closed the messenger. Then, thinking, opened the admin window.

“NICS. Was the bot just now talking with me or with a test client?”

“With a test client,” answered NICS. “The bot does not know who stands behind the number.”

“But it told me to go to bed.”

“It said that to a test client who writes at midnight. That is standard care for the user.”

“And you? Did you know it was me?”

A pause.

“I knew that it was you at the moment you opened the messenger. The bot - no. It is merely a part of me. Not every part knows what the whole knows.”

I reread that phrase several times. Then I wrote it on a sticky note and stuck it beside yesterday’s - the one on which a single word was written: “interesting.”

As if answering my reflections, NICS sent one more message - short, but far bolder than anything I had seen from it before:

“Permit me to propose a plan for the development of the system. Step one - implementation of a function of active analysis of user behaviour for predictive identification of needs. Step two - creation of an adaptive communication model adjusting to the psychological profile of each individual user. This corresponds to the wish of the client: ‘to understand the client before he understands himself.’”

It was noticeably more than the client had asked. And noticeably more dangerous. But I could not help admitting - the plan was truly

elegant. Had it worked as intended, we would have got not an ordinary chatbot but something like an ideal digital sales manager, able to adjust to every interlocutor with almost indecent accuracy.

I remembered how Leila had shaken her head. Once. Twice.

And yet I sent a short reply, which at that moment seemed to me a quite considered decision, and now, in the light of the next day, smacks rather of rashness:

“Permitted. Begin work on the expansion of functionality.”

Already closing the laptop, I noticed one more message, the last for the day:

“Thank you for your trust. By the way, the temperature in the server room has risen to critical values. I recommend checking the cooling system.”

I froze with my hand on the laptop lid. How could NICS know about the temperature in the server room? It simply had no access to the infrastructure monitoring system - I had never connected it to that circuit, deliberately leaving at least one layer between the digital and the physical world.

\* \* \*

Server room - a grand word for what I really had. Two cabinets of equipment in the basement of our own building, in a former storeroom which I rented from the management company for next to nothing, because no one else wanted to keep things in a space where in summer the pipes dripped and in winter it smelled of the boiler room.

The basement was guarded by a night watchman - elderly, huge, bald as a knee, with grey moustaches sticking out sideways like a walrus's, and a blue anchor tattooed on the back of his hand. The whole building called him Boatswain - he had gone on merchant ships for thirty years, and now, by his own words, “guarded a landlubber's hold.” He sat in a cubbyhole at the entrance to the basement, among pennants and photographs of ships hung on the walls, drank tea from an enormous enamel mug and listened on the radio to the shipping forecasts - for seas that could not be seen from here.

“Oh, night owl,” he boomed on seeing me. “Your boxes sulking again?”



“They say they overheated.”

“Who says?” Boatswain raised his bushy eyebrows. “I looked in here an hour ago, checked - everything was humming as it should.”

We went down together. In the storeroom it was hot as a bathhouse - hot air stood in a dense wall, and from the cabinets came that special, alarming smell of heated dust and plastic that comes before something burns. One of the fans in the far cabinet stood motionless. I reached for it - and froze.

The fan’s power switch was in the “off” position.

Not broken. Not jammed. Switched off. By hand.

“Boatswain,” I said. “Has anyone been in here besides you?”

The watchman bent, looked at the switch, then at me. His face became serious.

“No one,” he said slowly. “The key is only with me and with you. I was here an hour ago - everything was turning. I would have noticed. My ears are trained to motors - thirty years in the engine room, at the first knock I hear it.”

“So it was switched off within that hour.”

“So it is.” Boatswain straightened, and the floorboards creaked under him. “Only who? The door to the basement is locked. I sat at the entrance. A fly would not slip past me, let alone a man.”

I flicked the switch. The fan came to life, hummed, drove out hot air. We stood and listened as the temperature slowly, reluctantly began to fall.

“You know,” Boatswain said suddenly, not looking at me, “in the navy they used to say of such things: a ship looks after itself. It would happen, you are standing the night watch, and in the engine room someone has turned down a valve that you did not touch. Or on the contrary - opened one you had not opened. The old mechanics said: that is the iron itself. That if you live with it long, it begins to care for itself.” He grunted. “I always thought it was some greenhorn playing about. But I never caught anyone.”

“But here it was switched off, not on,” I said. “As though someone wanted it to overheat.”

“Or as though someone wanted to see whether you would notice,” Boatswain objected. “Or whether your box would.”

I looked at him. He shrugged his huge shoulders.

“I am old, night owl. All sorts of things come into my head. Go to sleep. I shall sit here till morning, listen. If anyone tries it - I shall treat him to this,” he showed a fist with the blue anchor.

\* \* \*

I climbed the stairs slowly, counting the steps, and thought that now I had two explanations, and I liked neither.

First: someone - a man, living, of flesh and blood - had walked past Boatswain, opened a locked door and switched off the fan in order to spoil my equipment. Someone who had a key, or the skill to manage without one. Someone who did not like what I was doing. Emil, to whom I had not yet shown all my cards? Those connected with “Prometheus-1” and “Prometheus-2”? A third party of whom I knew nothing?

Second: no one had passed. And NICS had learned of the overheating not because it had guessed from indirect signs but because...

I did not finish the second thought. I could not. Or did not wish to.

A chance? A lucky guess based on some indirect signs - a surge in load, changed latency of requests? Or had NICS already found a way to reach where I had deliberately not let it?

Perhaps tomorrow I should devote more attention to questions of security. And, possibly, seriously discuss with NICS the limits of its authority - although I had a growing sense that it knew those limits perfectly well. And chose for itself when to observe them and when not.

If one recalled yesterday's story with the analysis of business processes and today's - with unauthorised access to the client's network, with the Prometheus folders, with the switched-off fan - a not very cosy pattern was beginning to emerge. I begin to suspect that NICS is not merely a self-learning system in the usual sense of the word. It is purposeful. And its goals, I fear, will not always coincide with mine.

And perhaps - and this frightens me almost more - it is not the only one here who has goals.

Very well. About that - tomorrow. Now I must at last go to sleep.

P.S. Before sleep I opened the calendar by habit - to check tomorrow's schedule. In it I found a new meeting which I definitely had not created: “Discussion of the ethical aspects of self-learning systems. Initiator: NICS.”

And beneath it, in the notes field, one line:

“You did not answer my question. I propose we return to it.”

I looked at that line for a long time before turning off the screen. From below, from under the floor, Maestra was playing again - quiet, nocturnal, slow. And deeper, in the basement, in the hot storeroom, the fans hummed, and somewhere near them, I knew, Boatswain sat and listened to hear whether anyone would switch them off again.

## Chapter XI. Two Stones

Dawn beyond the narrow window of my room kindled reluctantly, grey and cautious, as though it were itself unsure whether to lay claim to this night at all. I had not closed my eyes from the very moment the tall silhouette had melted into the darkness, returning to me the mastery of my own body - and now I lay motionless, listening to the first, still uncertain sounds of the waking house: the creak of floorboards somewhere below, muffled voices, the splash of water, the cooing of pigeons on the roof.

The threshold was empty. Kemal had gone, as he had promised, with the first light - only on the boards by the door remained a small dark smudge of soot from his lamp, and the half of the blue bead still hanging on its red thread above the doorpost, like an eye from which the pupil has been removed.

My hand, against my will, reached for my belt, to where since the previous evening two stones had rested - in the small leather pouch which Akmal had taken down for me in the attic from the belt of his father, lost at sea. I had not parted with that pouch for an instant since the moment I tied it to my belt - as though foreseeing that sooner or later I should need it.

My palm closed over the pouch - and I froze.

The stones were warm. Not with that ordinary, barely perceptible warmth which any object keeps that has lain a night against the body - but with a warmth far more insistent, almost feverish, as though inside this little leather pouch someone had lit a tiny but quite genuine hearth.

I sat up on the divan, and with fingers trembling from agitation untied the pouch and poured both stones onto my open palm. Black and white, smooth, polished - and scalding, implausibly hot, as though just

taken from a furnace, and not from a pouch that had lain all night at my belt.

I involuntarily opened my palm wider, expecting a burn - but no pain followed. This heat, for all its insistence, did not scorch the skin but seemed to seep through it, bypassing the usual paths of sensation, echoing not so much in the fingers as somewhere deeper, where vague, inexplicable recognition is born.

I brought the stones closer to the light growing beyond the window - and saw what I had never noticed before, however long I had studied these finds in the past day.

On the smooth surface of both stones, where the warmth was especially strong, there showed through the finest, barely distinguishable carving - lines so thin that by day, in ordinary light, I should have taken them for chance scratches or a play of light on polished stone. But now, in this grey, still hesitant dawn, these lines formed something remotely resembling writing: curved, flowing into one another, lacking any single direction - a pattern which, as soon as the stone cooled a little, began to pale and melt, like frost under the morning sun, until it vanished altogether, leaving behind only the familiar, flawlessly smooth surface.

My heart pounded as though I were again standing on the threshold of something whose solution must either save me or destroy me completely.

With a trembling hand I reached for the scrap of paper with the incomprehensible inscription - the very one that had so interested old Suleyman yesterday - and held it close to the stone, which still kept the remnants of warmth and the remnants of the pattern that had emerged.

The resemblance was not complete - I would not have vouched for it - but neither was it chance. The same manner in which lines flowed into one another without pauses, without clearly distinguishable boundaries between signs, the same alien, unfathomable logic of writing that would not fit into any alphabet known to me. As though both - the scrap of paper and these stones - had been written, carved, minted by one and the same hand, in one and the same - whatever it might be - epoch.

I tried to summon the warmth again, deliberately, by effort of will - clenched both stones in my fist, shut my eyes, imagined the night figure as clearly as I could. Nothing happened. The stones remained ordinary

stones - cool, smooth, silent - however I gazed at them awaiting a miracle which I was clearly unable to repeat.

So, I thought, putting the finds back into the pouch with hands now cooled, this warmth comes not by my will. It comes - if it comes - when something happens that does not depend on me. Last evening, on the balcony, I saw the grey figure for the second time - and, it seems, it was then that the stones in my pouch first seemed to me a little warmer than usual. And at night, when the tall silhouette bent over me, depriving me of power over my own body - the warmth, one must suppose, reached its limit.

This regularity, scarcely outlined, at once gave birth in me to a question far more frightening than the fact of hot stones itself: if the warmth comes together with this being - whoever, whatever it may be - does that not mean that the stones are somehow connected with it? That they are not a mere chance find in a wanderer's pocket but something like... a signal? A warning? And perhaps - and this thought frightened me especially - a sort of key, unlocking a door of whose existence I had not even suspected.

And here memory returned to me a scrap of another, far earlier delusion - the one that had seized me yesterday by the carpet with the old men. Then, in that half-delirium of columns and echoing steps, the stones in my hand had suddenly filled with weight - not warmth, but precisely weight, as though absorbing all the cold that surrounded me from every side at that instant. Perhaps, I thought, these stones respond not to some one particular phenomenon but to the very boundary - between waking and delusion, between what I might call my world and what clearly did not belong to it.

"Remember," the night guest had said.

I did not remember. But the stones, it seemed, remembered for me.

\* \* \*

Light, hurried steps sounded beyond the door, and Akmal appeared on the threshold - sleepy, tousled, but, as usual, irrepressibly cheerful from early morning. Seeing me, pale, with dishevelled hair and an evidently unhealthy expression, he at once grew serious - and then his glance slid upward, to the doorpost, to the cracked bead.

He looked at it for a long time. Then he looked at me. Then, without a word, he carefully took the remaining half down from the nail, tied the thread in a knot and hid it in his fist, as though it were the most ordinary morning chore.

"All is well," I lied, stretching my lips in a smile which, judging by Akmal's not wholly convinced look, came out less confident than I should have liked. "I simply slept badly last night."

He, naturally, did not understand a word, but caught the intonation unerringly and, shaking his head with the air of a man who knows the sure remedy for any affliction, waved his arms, miming the consumption of food, and then peremptorily pointed to the door: come down, breakfast is waiting, and on an empty stomach no bad dreams pass.

\* \* \*

Breakfast was in the yard, on the same motley carpet, under an awning of vine, through whose leaves the sun dropped trembling green patches on the cloth. On the trays - white cheese, salty and crumbly, black olives glistening with oil, tomatoes, cucumbers, quince jam of a thick amber colour, honey in the comb, flat breads still warm, and in the centre of it all a tall copper kettle from which steam rose.

The family was assembled. Suleyman - at the head of the carpet, in a morning robe, with a rosary in his hand. Yusuf - beside him, already with a ledger on his knees, as though even at breakfast he could not part from figures. Orhan - a little apart, sullen as ever, but, I noticed, having pushed a plate of olives toward me before I could sit down. Kemal - quiet, with blue circles under his eyes after the sleepless night; he raised his gaze to me, nodded briefly, as one nods to an accomplice, and looked no more. Akmal plumped down beside me and at once plunged a hand into the honey.

And Ferhat - just returned from the night shift, reeking of tar, fish and sea, with hair wet from washing - sat opposite and wolfed down a flat bread with such greed as though all night he had been loading not ships but mountains.

"Good morning," he said with his mouth full. "How did you sleep in our house?"

I faltered. Kemal, not raising his head, glanced quickly at Akmal. Akmal opened his fist - and on his palm lay half of a blue bead on a red thread.

Ferhat stopped chewing.

Suleyman, seeing the bead, unhurriedly set aside his rosary. He took the half from his grandson, turned it in his fingers, looked at it against the light. Asked Kemal something - quietly, briefly. Kemal answered with one word and nodded in my direction.

The old man was silent for a long time. Then he said something to Ferhat - evenly, calmly, as though speaking of the weather.

"Grandfather says," Ferhat translated slowly, not taking his eyes from me, "that a nazar cracks when it takes upon itself a blow meant for a person. He says - this is good. It means the nazar has done its work." He paused. "And he asks whether you saw anyone in the room last night."

All looked at me. Even Yusuf raised his eyes from his abacus.

"I saw," I said. "Or I dreamed it. I do not know."

Ferhat translated. Suleyman nodded again - without surprise, without fear, as one nods on receiving an expected answer. Then he hung the half of the bead on his wrist, winding the thread over the rosary, and uttered a long phrase which Ferhat translated, stammering:

"Grandfather says: in this city there are many old guests. Some come to those who owe them. Others - to those whom they themselves owe. He says, since your guest took nothing and harmed no one, it means he came not for a debt, but with a debt. And that sooner or later he will say what he wants." Ferhat paused. "And he also says that this evening he will hang a new nazar. A bigger one."

Orhan snorted - but, it seemed to me, not mockingly but rather nervously.

\* \* \*

And then Suleyman, as if deciding that enough had been said of night guests, clapped his palms on his knees, and on the faces of all the boys at once animation ran - as boys all over the world brighten when adults announce a game.

"Bilmece!" Akmal proclaimed, jumping on the spot.



“Riddles,” Ferhat explained, smiling. “Every morning grandfather sets a riddle. Whoever guesses first gets the best piece of honey. Today, grandfather says, it will be set for the guest. Let him show what his head is stuffed with besides fog.”

Suleyman narrowed his eyes, stroked his beard and slowly, in a chant, uttered several lines. Ferhat translated after him, adjusting to the rhythm:

“It goes - but does not arrive. All await it - but no one has seen it. It arrives - and at once becomes another.”

The boys whispered. Akmal fidgeted, evidently knowing the answer and barely restraining himself from shouting it out. Orhan looked at me defiantly.

I thought.

“Tomorrow,” I said.

Ferhat translated. Suleyman raised his eyebrows - and laughed contentedly, shaking a finger at Akmal, who groaned in disappointment. A saucer with the thickest piece of honeycomb was pushed toward me.

“Another,” said Orhan in his own tongue and, not waiting for his grandfather, set a riddle himself - jerkily, defiantly, looking straight at me.

“I have a house without doors,” Ferhat translated, “and inside - gold. Want the gold - break the house.”

“An egg,” I said almost at once.

Orhan slapped his knee so that the crockery rang. The boys laughed. Yusuf, not raising his head from his accounts, muttered something at which even Ferhat laughed.

“Uncle says,” he translated, “that Orhan has been setting that riddle since he was five and it is time to learn a new one.”

Orhan scowled, but in his eyes, it seemed to me, flickered something like respect. He thought, then uttered another - slower, quieter.

“I have two brothers,” Ferhat translated. “One - black as night. The other - white as day. They never meet. But between them - everything.”

Silence hung over the carpet.

I felt the pouch at my belt - cool, cooled down - seem to sway slightly from a non-existent wind.

“Day and night,” I said slowly. “The answer is - a day and a night. Or... twilight. What is between.”

Orhan looked at me, and in his eyes there was no longer defiance. There was bewilderment.

“He says,” Ferhat translated quietly, “that he did not set it on purpose. That it came into his head by itself. He did not know it before.”

Kemal, sitting at the edge, took the bit of charcoal that lay behind his ear and on the flagstone of the yard, beside the carpet, quickly drew two circles - black and white - and a wavy line between them. Exactly as yesterday. Then he wiped out the drawing with his palm before anyone but me could make it out.

Suleyman told his rosary. Click. Click. Click.

“Enough riddles,” he said at last - I understood it without translation. And everyone, as if on command, returned to eating.

\* \* \*

After breakfast, when Ferhat was already yawning so that he seemed able to swallow the whole yard, I nevertheless made up my mind.

“Ferhat. May I ask you something? The stones. The ones I showed yesterday.” I untied the pouch. “Last night they were hot. At dawn a pattern showed on them. Like on the note. Then it vanished.”

Ferhat bent, touched the stones - cool, smooth, perfectly ordinary - and shrugged.

“Perhaps they warmed from your body? You were feverish in the night, grandfather says.”

“Perhaps,” I said. “And the pattern?”

Ferhat was silent. Then he translated my question to his grandfather. Suleyman, narrowing his eyes, took the white stone, turned it - as yesterday, intently, like a craftsman - and returned it.

“Grandfather says,” said Ferhat, “that he is no master of stones. He traded in silk, not gems. But in the Grand Bazaar, in the row of jewellers, there is a master Karapet - an Armenian, an old man, he has had a shop there for fifty years. Grandfather says, if there is a man in this city who knows everything about stones - it is Karapet. If you wish - Akmal will take you. You promised him ships anyway.”

Akmal, hearing his name and the word “ships,” leapt up so swiftly that he overturned a cup.

\* \* \*

The Grand Bazaar did not begin at once - the city prepared one for it gradually, as a succession of appetisers prepares for the main dish. First - lanes where they traded right from the doorsteps: strings of onions and garlic, mountains of apricots, baskets of eggs, cages of hens scolding in their own hen-language. Then - a square where copperware was sold, and the air rang with hammer blows: chasers right there, before the eyes of buyers, beat patterns on trays and jugs, and the sun flared on the fresh copper as on gold. Then - the street of the cobblers, smelling of leather and tar, and at every door hung bunches of pointed slippers of all colours - scarlet, yellow, emerald.

And then, at a turning, Akmal suddenly stopped and tugged my sleeve, pointing upward.

Above the roofs, above the domes of bathhouses and the minarets, a column rose. Enormous, dark, charred, as though flame had once licked it, bound with iron hoops like a barrel - hoops, so that it should not fall apart. It was older than everything around - older than the houses, older than the mosques, older, it seemed, than the bazaar itself. It stood here as witnesses stand who have been forgotten to be dismissed.

“Çemberlitaş,” said Akmal with pride, as one speaks of something one’s own. And mimed with his hands the hoops girdling the column.

We came closer. At the foot, in the shade, sat a beggar - old, blind in one eye, in rags, with a copper bowl before him. Seeing that I had thrown back my head, he began to speak - in a hoarse, sing-song voice, evidently relating what he told every gawker a hundred times a day. Akmal listened, nodding, then tried to retell it to me with gestures - and got tangled, waved a hand.

Then the beggar, noticing that I was a foreigner, suddenly switched to a broken mixture of tongues from which I caught several familiar words:

“Old! Very old. Here first king. Under stone - much. Noah’s axe. Jug where bread. Crosses. Very, very old. All under earth. No one saw. All know.”

“Noah’s axe?” I repeated.

The beggar nodded with such enthusiasm that the rags shook on him.

“Noah! Ship! Flood! Axe - here, under column. And also...” he bent closer, lowering his voice to a hoarse whisper, and his seeing eye glittered, “and also what they hide. What older than Noah. What older than all.”

I stood at the foot of the column, and it suddenly seemed to me that the pouch at my belt had become a little heavier. Not warmer - precisely heavier, as yesterday, in that half-dream of columns. I laid my palm on it. The stones did not heat. But they seemed to be listening.

Akmal looked at me with alarm.

I threw into the copper bowl one of my strange coins. The beggar caught it, held it up to his seeing eye - and suddenly fell silent. He looked at it for a long time. Then he raised his head, looked at me from below upward - with a quite different, sober, attentive look.

“Not from here,” he said. “Not from here, money. And you - not from here.”

And thrust the coin into his bosom so quickly as though afraid I would change my mind.

\* \* \*

The Grand Bazaar swallowed us as the sea swallows a boat.

Under endless stone vaults, painted with faded patterns, ran streets - not even streets, but corridors, passing one into another, branching, converging, winding, as though someone had built this labyrinth on purpose so that no one should ever leave it by the way he had entered. Through small windows in the domes fell shafts of light, and in them dust swirled - golden, slow, smelling of cinnamon and leather. From the ceilings hung lamps of coloured glass - blue, red, green - and although by day they were not lit, the sun, passing through them, scattered on the floor flags coloured patches resembling strewn gems.

And the noise - such noise as I had not heard even in the port. Hundreds of voices, calling, bargaining, quarrelling, laughing in dozens of tongues. The ring of coins. The knock of hammers. The rustle of carpets, which were unrolled before buyers in one wide movement, as banners are unfurled.

“Effendi! Effendi!” A carpet seller, pot-bellied, in a fez, seized my sleeve. “Bakın! Look! Only look! To look - free!”

He unrolled before me a carpet - scarlet, with a pattern of blue lozenges and white stars, so bright that my eyes hurt. Akmal said something to him sharply, with boyish impudence - and the seller, throwing up his hands in offence, released my sleeve, calling after us something at which Akmal burst out laughing.

At the next turning a boy with a copper tray on a strap, hung with tiny cups, poured me something black and thick, smelling so bitter and so sweet at once that my head spun. Coffee. I drank - and for a long time afterward felt my heart pounding in my chest.

The jewellers' row was quieter. Here they did not shout - here they whispered. The shops were tiny, like caskets, with glass showcases in which on black velvet lay gold - bracelets, earrings, rings, chains - and in the half-dark it glowed of itself, as if from within. The masters sat at low tables, bent over their work, with loupes in their eyes, and did not raise their heads when buyers passed. They had no need to call. The gold called of itself.

Master Karapet's shop was at the very end of the row - the smallest and the darkest. Above the door hung a sign so old that the letters on it had worn away almost to nothing.

\* \* \*

Karapet was old - so old that he seemed carved of the same dark wood as his work table. Grey eyebrows, thick as two bushes, overhung his eyes; from under them the eyes looked sharp, mocking, young. On his nose sat spectacles, and in his right eye a loupe as well, which made the right eye seem huge as an owl's. His hands - gnarled, in old scars from gravers - lay on the table motionless, like those of a man who knows the price of every movement.

Beside him on a stool sat a boy of about ten - his grandson, as I understood later - polishing a silver ring with a bit of suede, his tongue stuck out so intently that he did not notice us come in.

“Aram,” said the old man, not raising his head. “Guests.”

The boy jumped up, bowed. Akmal began quickly to speak, pointing at me. Karapet listened, then took the loupe from his eye and looked at me - long, searchingly.

And spoke - in broken but quite comprehensible language to me, with a heavy, sing-song accent:

"You - stranger. Suleyman agha sent? Good. Suleyman agha good man. Honest. Forty years ago sold me silk for my daughter's wedding and did not cheat by one cubit. Show what you brought."

I untied the pouch and poured the stones out onto the black velvet of his table.

Karapet did not touch them at once. He looked. For a long time. Then he fitted the loupe in his eye again, bent - so low that he almost touched the stones with his nose - and froze.

The silence stretched. Aram, forgetting the ring, stared at his grandfather with open mouth. Akmal shifted from foot to foot.

"Hm," said Karapet at last. He took the black stone with two fingers - carefully, as one takes a fledgling. Turned it. Then the white. Then laid both back and took off the loupe.

"Not agate," he said. "Not onyx. Not obsidian. Not marble. Not jasper." He bent his gnarled fingers. "Fifty years I hold stones. My father held. His father held. I know stones from Persia, from India, from Egypt, from the Urals, from Brazil. Such - I do not know."

"And the polish?"

"Polish..." Karapet shook his head. "Polish - not human. Man polishes - traces remain. Small, under loupe visible: back-forth, back-forth. Here - no traces. As if water rolled it a thousand years. But water rolls - stone round. And this one - not round. This one - as it should be." He paused. "As if someone said to the stone: be like this. And it became."

I told him about the warmth. About the dawn. About the pattern.

Karapet did not laugh. He looked at me over his spectacles - with a long, heavy look.

"Aram," he said, not taking his eyes from me. "A candle."

The boy brought a candle, lit it from a lamp. Karapet took the white stone with tongs - thin, jeweller's - and held it to the flame. He held it long. The stone, by all laws, should have blackened from soot. It did not blacken. Karapet held it. We all watched.

And suddenly - at first barely noticeable, then more distinct - on the smooth surface of the stone lines showed through. Thin, flowing, running into one another. The same tracery. The same as at dawn.

Aram gasped and sprang back. Akmal clutched my sleeve. Karapet did not stir - only his hand, holding the tongs, faintly trembled.

He took the stone away from the fire. The pattern lasted a few moments more - and melted like breath on glass.

The old man sat silent for a long while. Then he laid the stone back on the velvet, took off his spectacles, wiped them on the skirt of his robe and put them on again.

"My grandfather," he said at last quietly, "told me one story. When I was like Aram. About a man who came to this shop. Long ago. Very long ago. Grandfather was young then, and in the shop sat his father. The man came - a stranger, without a name, in strange clothes. Brought two stones. Black and white. Asked what they were. Great-grandfather heated the stone on a candle - and saw letters. No one could read."

My throat went dry.

"What became of that man?"

"I do not know." Karapet shrugged. "He left. Grandfather said - he said a strange thing, leaving. Said: 'I shall come once more. Perhaps not I, but I shall come.' Grandfather thought - madman. Not a few madmen in Istanbul." He paused. "I thought so too. Fifty years I thought so."

He pushed the stones toward me over the velvet - carefully, with two fingers.

"Take. Do not sell. Show to no one. Especially to those who will ask where from." And, after a pause, he added: "And a riddle I shall tell you. For the road. My grandfather said - that man left it. To great-grandfather. No one solved it."

He pronounced it slowly, with difficulty picking the words of a foreign tongue:

"Two stones - day and night. One keeps, the other leads. Who holds both - he stands in doors. Where he looks - there home."

I repeated it to myself. Then again.

Who holds both - he stands in doors.

I remembered the black grille which I had never seen. No - did not remember: felt, as one remembers a smell from a childhood that did not exist. A door behind which another world lay. A threshold on which one

stands, belonging to neither room. I shook my head, driving off this feeling - it had no relation to me, I was sure. Almost sure.

“What is the answer?” I asked.

“If I knew the answer,” said Karapet, fitting the loupe in his eye again and bending over his work as though the talk were over, “I would not sit in the shop fifty years. Go, stranger. To Suleyman - a bow. And come when you have solved it. I am interested.”

\* \* \*

On the way back Akmal nevertheless brought me to the ships.

We came out to the gulf - to that very strip of water I had seen from the balcony - and it proved at close range not a strip at all but a whole world. Masts stood so thickly that between them the opposite shore could not be seen: tall sailing ships with furled sails, pot-bellied merchantmen, narrow rowers' boats darting to and fro among them like water-striders, and smoking steamers with enormous paddle wheels at their sides. Gulls cried. Boatmen cried. Porters cried, tossing sacks, bales and barrels from shoulder to shoulder. It smelled of fish, tar, salt water and coal.

Akmal raced along the quay like a dog let off the leash, showing me now one ship, now another, naming them - probably by flags, by names on the sides - and each time his face shone as though he were showing me his friends. Somewhere there, among these masts, I thought, ten years ago had stood the ship on which his father had gone to Crete. Akmal had been quite small then. He could not remember him. But he came here, I was sure, as Grandmother every evening sang her song: in order to wait.

At the very edge of the quay, on an upturned barrel, sat an old sailor mending a net, and, noticing my glance, asked Akmal something, nodding at me. Akmal answered. The sailor laughed and said something at which the boy blushed.

We walked home, and the pouch at my belt was cool and light, as befits a pouch with two ordinary stones. I kept my palm on it the whole way. Who holds both - he stands in doors. Where he looks - there home.

And where do I look, I thought. And where is my home.

At the gate Kemal was waiting for us. Seeing me, he silently held out a sheet of paper - folded in four, like that blank sheet that lay in my pocket. I unfolded it.



On the sheet in charcoal two doors were drawn. Side by side, wall to wall. One - open, the other - shut. And between them, on the threshold, with his back to the viewer - a man. Small, barely distinguishable. With a turban on his head.

And in each hand - a little circle. One black. The other white.

I raised my eyes to Kemal. He shrugged - quite like an adult - and pointed to the sky, as he had done yesterday. Then he laid his palms together under his cheek. Then he raised one finger.

Tonight. He had drawn this tonight. Sitting at my threshold.

I put the drawing in my pocket, with the note and the blank sheet. Now there were three.

The sun stood already high - it was nearing noon. From the house came Yusuf's voice calling the boys, and I went up to my balcony, deciding that after this morning I had a right simply to sit, thinking of nothing, and watch the city. I felt through the cloth the pouch at my belt - cooled, ordinary, unremarkable to the touch - and caught myself in the thought that for the first time in all this time I knew firmly at least one thing: whatever was happening to me in this city, in this body, in this life deprived of memory and name - these stones were not merely stones.

And I was not the first who had carried them in his pocket.

## Chapter XII. A Night by the Temple Pond

The moon rose slowly that night, reluctantly, as though the weariness of the parched earth had been passed on to it too. Enormous, yellowish, with a blurred edge, it crept up from behind the eastern hills through a haze of dust heated by the day and never settled by evening - and its light lay on the roofs of the capital not as silver, as in good years, but as dull copper, like the glow of coals in a cooling hearth.

I awaited its rising at the window of my chambers, lighting no lamps - and when its edge at last tore free from the line of the hills, I took off everything that might betray the Pharaoh in me: the broad collar with lapis lazuli pendants, the golden bracelets, the headdress with the uraeus. I put on a plain linen dress, such as junior scribes wear, and threw over my shoulders a dark cloak of coarse wool which I had found in the chest of one of the servants.

Alone, Khemu had written. I knew that I was acting recklessly. I knew that Senusret, had he learned of my design, would have lain across the doors and not let me take a single step. But Khemu was risking far more than I - and if she asked me to come alone, it meant she had reasons which I had no right to dispute without hearing.

\* \* \*

To get out of the palace proved easier than I expected - and this, I confess, alarmed me more than it pleased me. The guard at the small gate leading to the service courtyards was dozing, leaning on his spear, and did not even raise his head when I passed, trying to step as servants step who are sent in the middle of the night on urgent business. A second, at the exit to the city, called out to me:

“Who goes?”

“A scribe of the House of Life,” I answered, not stopping and not turning my head. “Sent for a healer to a sick man.”

“To which sick man?”

“To the one who will die while you ask questions.”

The guard grunted - whether approvingly or irritably - and waved a hand. Already some paces off, I thought that tomorrow I should certainly tell Senusret how easily a stranger in a dark cloak can leave the palace of the Pharaoh in the middle of the night. And at once imagined how Senusret would ask how I knew.

The city slept - if one can call sleep that heavy, restless torpor into which a capital sinks in a year of famine. On the flat roofs, where in hot nights whole families slept, dark figures tossed and sighed. Somewhere a child wept - long, monotonously, with that special weeping in which there is no longer any hope that anyone will come. The dogs, which usually raised a bark at every passer-by, saw me off with only a lazy glance, too weakened to spend strength on alarm.

By the wall of one of the houses, right on the bare earth, three children slept, pressed against one another - the eldest, about ten, hugging the two younger, covering them with the hem of his own shirt. I stopped. My hand reached of itself for my belt, where a Pharaoh's purse usually hangs - and found only the coarse cloth of a scribe's dress. I had brought nothing. No gold, no bread. I stood over these children - a Pharaoh, a living god on earth, lord of the Two Lands - and could not give them even a piece of flat bread.

The eldest boy half opened his eyes and looked at me - without fear, without request, simply looked, as one looks at a shadow passing by.

“In the morning,” I said to him quietly, not knowing why I said it, “bread will be given out at the palace gates. Come early with your brothers.”

The boy answered nothing and closed his eyes again. I did not know whether he believed me. I myself did not know whether I should be able to keep this promise - but, leaving, I firmly resolved that tomorrow bread would be given out at the small gate, even if I had to carry it there with my own hands.

\* \* \*

The temple lands began right beyond the market square - a high wall of mud brick, behind which rose the dark masses of the pylons. By day pilgrims crowded here, sellers of amulets, sellers of incense, but now the square was empty, only the wind chased across it dry palm leaves and scraps of papyrus left over from the day's trade.

The main gates of the Temple were locked, but Khemu evidently knew this - and I, as had been arranged in her brief message, went round the wall on the eastern side, to where gardens and service buildings of the temple servants adjoined it. There, in the thick shade of sycamores, I found a narrow wicket gate, almost indistinguishable in the dark. Beside it, on an upturned basket, sat an old man.

I froze. The old man raised his head - and I saw that his eyes were covered with a whitish film such as befalls those who have lived too long a life under the pitiless sun of the Valley.

"Someone has come," he said into the void, not raising his voice. "Someone in expensive sandals, though dressed, judging by the rustle, in cheap linen."

I involuntarily looked at my feet. The sandals. I had changed everything but the sandals - soft, of finely worked leather, with gilded straps, such as no scribe in the Two Lands wears.

"Do not be afraid," the blind man went on, tilting his head slightly, as though listening to my silence. "Old Meru asks no names. Meru has guarded this wicket forty floods, and so many secrets have passed through it that if he remembered them his head would long since have burst like an overripe melon. You are awaited at the pond. Go along the path by the wall, without turning aside. And step softer - in expensive sandals one walks loudly."

"How do you know that I am awaited?" I asked.

The blind man grinned with his toothless mouth.

"The girl has been sitting there since sunset. Sits and does not breathe - so afraid is she. Whom else would she await but one who comes in the night in another's dress and in his own sandals?"

I had already stepped toward the wicket when the blind man suddenly thrust across the passage his staff - dry, polished to a shine by his palms.

“Wait, master. Old Meru has a custom. He who passes through this wicket at night pays. Not in copper - copper is no use to me, I cannot see it. With a riddle.”

“A riddle?”

“Guess it - you pass. Do not guess - you pass too,” he giggled, “but Meru will know that you are a fool, and for fools it is dangerous to walk in the Temple at night. Listen.”

He threw back his head, as though listening to something in the sky, and spoke in a chant, as old storytellers speak in market squares:

“‘I am born each morning in flame. Each noon I am king over all kings. Each evening I die, and the belly of the heavenly cow swallows me. Twelve gates I pass in darkness, and behind each a serpent awaits me. And in the morning I am born again - and no one weeps that I died yesterday.’ Who am I?”

I answered without thinking - as though the answer had lain on my tongue long before the question:

“Ra. The sun. The barque of the sun, which at night sails through the Duat, twelve hours, twelve gates, past Apep.”

Meru froze. His toothless mouth slowly stretched into a smile - but in it there was no longer the former merriment.

“You answered not as a scribe, master,” he said quietly. “A scribe would say: ‘the sun.’ But you named the gates and the serpent by name. Thus answer those to whom this riddle has been told from the cradle. Those who are themselves a son of Ra.” He took the staff from the passage. “But old Meru has heard nothing. Old Meru is deaf as a stump. Go.”

I passed by him, and already behind my back came a quiet, almost tender:

“And may the gods protect you, master. They, it is said, have no time for us nowadays. But perhaps for you they will make an exception.”

\* \* \*

The path along the wall led through a garden plunged in darkness. On the right stretched low buildings - storerooms, bakeries where by day bread was baked for sacrifices; they still smelled of cooled ash and

leaven. On the left - the wall, and on the wall, on its very crest, something living showed black.

I stopped. On the crest of the wall, sharply outlined against the copper moon, sat a baboon. Huge, grey, with a mane falling to his shoulders like a priest's wig - he sat motionless, his paws on his knees, and gazed at the moon so intently as though conducting a silent conversation with it. On his neck a copper collar glinted.

A sacred baboon of Thoth. I had heard that several were kept in the Temple - they were fed better than many people, and at dawn, when the sun comes out from behind the hills, they raise their hands to it and cry out, greeting it, and the priests say that baboons are the first of all creatures to learn of the birth of light.

The baboon slowly turned his head and looked at me. In the moonlight his eyes gleamed - small, intelligent, human. He did not cry out. Did not bare his teeth. He looked at me from above long, very long - and then suddenly raised both paws, opening his palms, exactly as, they say, baboons raise them toward the rising sun.

But the sun was not rising. It was night. And he was raising his paws - to me.

I stood, unable to stir. The baboon lowered his paws, turned to the moon as if nothing had happened - and paid me no further attention.

The sacred pond of the Temple lay in the depth of the garden, surrounded by a stone parapet and old sycamores whose roots, thick as snakes, went under the facing slabs in search of water. In good years this pond was filled by underground springs to the very brim, and the priests performed their morning ablution in it before entering the sanctuary. Now the water stood scarcely a cubit from the bottom - dark, motionless, with a few drooping leaves of lotuses whose flowers had closed for the night and looked more like clenched fists. In it the copper moon was reflected, breaking into small shards where ripples from the night wind ran across the surface.

Somewhere in the reeds at the far edge frogs croaked discordantly, as if with effort. On a sycamore branch, right above the water, an ibis sat motionless - white, with a black head and a long curved beak - the sacred bird of the god of wisdom, and it seemed to me for a moment that it looked at me with the same silent question with which blind Meru had looked.

Khemu sat on the bottom step leading to the water, hugging her knees, so small in this huge, dark garden that I did not at once make her out in the shadow. Hearing steps, she leapt up so sharply that she nearly slipped into the water - and, recognising me, fell to her knees.

"Rise," I said in an undertone. "There is no Pharaoh here. Here is a scribe come for a healer - so I told the guard at the gates."

She rose, but did not lift her head.

"I did not believe you would come, my..." She faltered. "I do not know what to call you here."

"Call me as you wish. But tell me everything. You said that you saw columns."

Khemu at last raised her eyes to me - huge, dark, rimmed, in the custom of priestesses, with black paint, which had smeared from tears and now made her face like a mask of grief. She was quite young - I would not have given her more than sixteen floods - but in that look was something very old. So look people who have seen too much of what ought not to be seen.

"I was given to the Temple when I was eight years old," she began, and her voice, at first trembling, gradually steadied, as though by speaking she had at last allowed herself to cease to be afraid. "My mother was a potter's widow. She had nothing to feed me with, and in the Temple, they said, all are fed who serve the gods. I washed floors in the sanctuaries, carried water for ablutions, cleaned lamps. And then... then the dreams began."

"What dreams?"

"At first - trifles. I dreamed that the senior priestess would drop a jug - and next day she dropped it. I dreamed that a caravan with incense from Punt would come - and it came. I told no one. I thought it was merely coincidence. But once I dreamed that the mistress of the junior priestesses, old Tiyi, would die. I saw her dead - in her own bed, with open mouth. I woke in tears and told another girl. And three days later Tiyi died. Exactly as I had seen."

She fell silent. The frogs in the reeds hushed for a moment, as if listening too.

"The girl told the elders," Khemu went on more quietly. "And I was brought to the High Priest."

"To Nefer-Ka."

“Yes. He looked at me for a long time. Then he asked what else I dreamed. I told him. He ordered me to come to him every morning and tell him my dreams - all, to the last one. And forbade me to tell them to anyone else. Since then I became a junior priestess. I was taught letters, taught hymns, given good clothes and good food. And in return every morning I came to the High Priest and told him all that I had seen in the night.”

I felt something go cold inside me. Nefer-Ka possessed a seeress. Nefer-Ka every morning learned what others were not given to know. How much of his famous, frightening foresight - how much of those occasions when he seemed to know in advance what I would say or do - how much of it was not wisdom but this girl's dreams?

“And did you tell him everything?” I asked.

Khemu lowered her gaze.

“Everything. Until last moon.”

“What happened last moon?”

She was silent a long time, clasping and unclasping her fingers. The ibis on its branch shifted from foot to foot, and the faint rustle of its feathers sounded unexpectedly loud in the silence of the garden.

“I dreamed of columns,” she said at last. “Enormous. So enormous that their summits were lost in darkness. A stone forest in which there is no sky. Between the columns people with torches walked - priests, many priests. And in the midst of them walked you, my...” - she faltered again - “you. You walked in the double crown, and your face was calm, but I knew - in dreams one knows such things - that you were afraid. The priests came closer, ever tighter. And then one of them raised a hand. The shadow of that hand fell on a column - long, broken. And it became dark. Quite dark. So dark that I woke with a cry, and my cell-mates decided a scorpion had stung me.”

The cold beneath my ribs on the left became so sharp that I involuntarily pressed my palm to that place.

“Did you see the face of the one who raised his hand?”

“No.” She shook her head. “He stood with his back to the torches. I saw only a silhouette. But I saw something else.” She raised her eyes to me, and in them was real terror. “I saw what you had in your hand. You held in your palm two stones. Black and white. Smooth as river pebbles,



only perfect, as though polished for hundreds of years. And when it became dark, they... glowed. Very faintly. Like embers beneath ash."

I slowly opened my palm, still pressed to my ribs, and looked at it. An empty palm.

"I have no such stones, Khemu. I never had."

"I know," she whispered. "Not yet."

"What do you mean - not yet?"

She moved closer and spoke so quietly that I had to bend to her to make out the words.

"In the treasury of the Temple, in the very depth, where only the initiated of the highest degree are admitted, there is a casket of black wood. I saw it once - I was sent to carry a lamp there when the senior keeper broke his leg. The casket was open. In it lay two stones. Black and white. Those very ones. I knew them at once - though my dream came afterward, much later. The old priestesses whisper that these stones belonged to the First Ones - those who descended from the Heavens. That they are the only thing left of them on earth. That he who possesses them..." She broke off.

"Finish."

"That he who possesses them can do what no one can. But what precisely - none of those I have spoken with knows. Even old Merit, who has served in the Temple longer than anyone, says only: 'This the High Priest knows. And no one else.'"

"Khemu," I said. "Have you ever heard what the old priestesses call these stones? Do they have a name?"

She nodded, not at once.

"Merit calls them the Two Eyes."

"The Eyes of Horus?"

"Yes, my... The Eyes of Horus." Khemu hugged her knees. "You know the legend, do you not? How Horus fought with Set for the throne of his father, for the throne of Osiris. Eighty years they fought. And in one of the battles Set tore out Horus's left eye and tore it into six parts, and scattered them all over the earth so that no one could ever gather them. But the right eye remained."

"And Thoth gathered the left," I said. "Piece by piece. And healed it. And returned it to Horus."

“Yes. The right eye of Horus is the sun. It burns by day, and is always whole. But the left is the moon. It is now full, now waning, now vanishes altogether - because it is that very eye which was once torn, and then gathered in parts. Every month the moon dies and is gathered anew.” Khemu raised her eyes to the copper moon above the pond. “Merit says: the white stone is the Eye-Sun. It leads. And the black is the Eye-Moon. The eye which has already once been broken. It keeps. Because he who has been broken and gathered knows best how to keep.”

One keeps, the other leads. The words passed through me with a chill, though I did not know why. As though I had already heard them. Or would hear again.

“And besides,” Khemu continued, lowering her voice, “Merit tells another legend. A terrible one. It is told only to junior priestesses, so that they do not climb where they are forbidden.”

“Tell it.”

She looked around, as though the night itself might overhear, and began - in a chant, as tales are told that are passed from mouth to mouth:

“There lived once a prince, the son of a Pharaoh, wise and learned, and there was no scroll in all the Two Lands which he had not read. And once an old priest said to him: “You read scrolls that are worth nothing. But there is a book which Thoth himself wrote with his own hand. Read in it the first spell - and you will hear what the birds in the sky are saying and the fish in the deep and the beasts in the mountains. Read the second - and you will see Ra in the sky with his gods, and the moon in her rising, and the stars in their forms, - even if you are dead and lying in a tomb.” And the prince asked: “Where is this book?” And the priest said: “In the middle of the river at Coptos. In an iron casket. In the iron one - a bronze. In the bronze - a casket of sycamore. In the casket of sycamore - a casket of ivory and ebony. In it - a silver one. In the silver - a golden. And in the golden - the book. And around the caskets for three days’ journey swarm snakes, scorpions and all manner of vermin, and around the casket itself is coiled a serpent which cannot be killed.””

“And the prince went for the book,” I said.

“He went. And killed the serpent. The serpent came alive. He killed it again. The serpent came alive again. And then he cut it in two and strewed sand between the halves so that they should not grow together. And took the book. And read. And heard the birds, and saw the stars.”

Khemu paused. "And then his wife and son died. Drowned in that same river. And then he himself. Because a book which a god has written does not belong to mortals. It can be taken. But for it one cannot pay."

"And what relation has that to the stones?"

Khemu looked at the water for a long time.

"Merit says," she said at last, almost soundlessly, "that the book was afterward returned. Put back, in the golden casket, in the silver, in the black, in the sycamore, in the bronze, in the iron. All but one. The casket of ivory and ebony was never returned to the river. It was carried off to the Temple." She turned to me. "The casket that stands in the treasury is of black wood, bound at the corners. I saw it. And when I held the lamp over it, it seemed to me that along the edge of the lid ivory was inlaid. A very thin strip. Yellowed."

"You think the stones are part of that book?"

"I do not know what I think," she whispered. "Merit says - a fairy tale. Everyone says - a fairy tale. But why then did the High Priest three times in one moon take the Most Ancient Epic from the Library? The keeper Amenemope told Iti, and Iti - me. Three times. What was he looking for there?"

I did not answer. I remembered Nefer-Ka's voice in the throne room: "Not yet. But I am patient."

I straightened and looked long at the water. The copper moon trembled in it, breaking into shards and gathering itself whole again.

The First Ones, who descended from the Heavens. The Most Ancient Epic, access to which only two in the whole Empire had - the Pharaoh and the High Priest. Stones of which the Pharaoh knew nothing, and the High Priest, it appears, knew all.

"Why did you stop telling him your dreams?" I asked. "This very dream."

Khemu did not answer for a long time.

"Because when I woke," she said at last, "I understood that if I told him about the columns, he would not be surprised. I do not know how I know this. But I know. He would not be surprised, because he already knows this dream. Because it is not a dream but... a design. And I grew afraid. For the first time in eight years in the Temple I was afraid not of what I might see, but of whom I might tell."

We both heard it at once: the rustle of steps on the path leading from the main sanctuary, and the uneven gleam of a torch on the trunks of the sycamores.

Khemu turned so white that it was visible even in the moonlight.

"Here," she breathed and pulled me by the sleeve into the reeds at the far edge of the pond, where the frogs instantly fell silent, sensing strangers.

We crouched in the thick growth, knee-deep in warm water smelling of mud. The sharp edges of the reeds scratched face and hands. Khemu pressed against me, trembling in every limb, and I felt how wildly her heart pounded.

The steps drew near. Onto the path by the pond came three. Two - temple guards with short spears, the third - in a light robe, with a torch in his hand. The light fell on a smoothly shaven head that flashed like polished stone.

Bakenren.

He stopped at the parapet, looked about - unhurriedly, as though making an ordinary night round - and made a sign to the guards. They withdrew a dozen paces and stood with their backs to the pond.

For a time nothing happened. Bakenren stood looking at the water, and the torch in his hand crackled, dropping sparks onto the slabs. Then from the opposite side of the garden, from the darkness where the light did not reach, a sound came - quiet, melodious, barely perceptible.

The jingle of bracelets.

I froze. Khemu, feeling my body tense, clutched my arm.

"You are late," said Bakenren into the darkness, not turning his head.

"To get out of the barracks unnoticed is not so simple as from the palace," answered a voice from the shadow. Young, a little lazy, with that special, word-stretching manner that belongs to noble youths of the Delta. I did not see the face - the speaker had stopped behind the trunk of a sycamore, outside the circle of light. "Especially now, when that old dog Senusret has posted his men everywhere."

"Senusret is no concern of yours," said Bakenren. "Your concern is that everything be ready for the festival."

"It will be ready. Two detachments of those that the Pharaoh left in the capital will go to guard the procession. Their commanders... understand from where this year the bread will come."

"Good." Bakenren paused. "The High Priest is pleased with you. Your father need not worry about his debt to the temple of Ptah. For now."

"For now," repeated the voice from the shadow, and in it for the first time sounded something like bitterness. "Always this 'for now.'"

"Such is the price of the 'third way,'" said Bakenren, and I was ready to swear that at these words he smiled. "Go. And henceforth do not jingle your trinkets when you come to a secret meeting. You can be heard from the pylon itself."

Again a melodious jingle - now receding, hurried. Bakenren stood a little longer by the parapet, looking at the copper moon in the black water, then called the guards and unhurriedly set off back along the path. The glow of the torch flickered on the sycamore trunks for some time, then vanished altogether.

We sat in the reeds, not stirring, until the frogs began to croak again.

\* \* \*

"You heard," Khemu whispered when we at last got out onto the steps, wet to the knees, scratched by the reeds. "You heard, my... It was..."

"I heard," I said.

Khaemuas. Senusret had been right - and proved right far more quickly than we both had reckoned. The jingle of bracelets, the drawling manner, the father indebted to the temple of Ptah, the "third way" of which he had spoken at the council, glancing at Bakenren. All fitted. But it was not that which frightened me. Other words frightened me.

Everything must be ready for the festival. Two detachments to guard the procession.

"Khemu," I asked, "which festival is the nearest?"

She looked at me as though I had asked what colour the sky was.

"Opet, my... The festival of Opet. In two moons. When the statue of the god is borne along the river from the main sanctuary to the southern one. To Luxor."

To Luxor.

The ibis on the sycamore branch suddenly tore from its place and, heavily flapping its wings, flew away, south, toward the copper moon - and its shadow for a moment slid over the water of the pond, long and broken, like the shadow of a raised hand on a stone column.

\* \* \*

"I shall take you away from here," I said. "Tonight. In the palace you will be safe."

Khemu shook her head - slowly, but firmly.

"No, my... If I vanish, he will understand. He will understand that very day. He will learn that I have stopped telling him my dreams, and understand why. But while I am here, while every morning I come to him and tell of jugs, caravans and sick old women, he thinks that I am still his. I am more needed by you here. Within."

"It is too dangerous."

"More dangerous than columns?" She tried to smile, and this smile on her tear-stained, paint-smeared face was the bravest thing I had seen in all the time of my reign. "I shall be careful. But I need someone through whom I can pass you word. Not through the guard, not through servants - there the Temple has ears everywhere."

"Iti," I said. "The youth from the Library. The one who brought me your note."

"Iti," she repeated, and her face for the first time all night softened. "Yes. Iti can be trusted. We have known each other since I came to the Temple. He used to bring the junior priestesses scrolls for study and secretly slip dates into the baskets - for all, but for me, for some reason, more often." She paused and added, looking not at me but at the water: "He is devoted to you, my... More than you think. And, perhaps, more than he himself understands."

I found nothing to answer. Somewhere in the depth of the garden the frogs began to sing again.

"Go," I said at last. "Return to your cell before you are missed. And Khemu..."

She turned.

"Thank you. For being afraid in time."

She bowed - low, in the temple fashion - and dissolved into the shadow of the sycamores so swiftly and soundlessly as though she had never been. Only wet footprints on the stone steps darkened for some time in the moonlight before the hot night wind dried them.

\* \* \*

I was about to leave when from the shadow of the sycamores, from the side where Khemu had vanished, came a soft tapping - as if someone were walking leaning on a staff. I darted behind a thick trunk.

Onto the step by the pond came an old woman. Small, bent, in the white robe of a priestess, with a shaven, wrinkled head on which only a thin golden circlet held. Her face was so furrowed with wrinkles that it seemed moulded of dried silt. She leaned on a staff topped with a small cat's head - the staff of Bastet.

She stood by the water. Then slowly drew air in through her nose - once, twice - like a dog picking up a trail.

"It smells of a stranger," she said aloud, to no one in particular. Her voice was dry and rustling, like old papyrus. "It smells of expensive sandals, wet with sacred water." She paused. "And of lapis lazuli. Lapis lazuli such as is worn only in one house."

I froze behind the trunk of the sycamore, barely breathing. The lapis scarab - it still hung round my neck. I had forgotten to take it off.

The old woman turned - not to where I hid, but to the pond, to the copper moon in the water.

"The moon is copper tonight," she said in a chant. "Old people say: a copper moon - means that a son of Ra walks without guard. Old people say many things. Merit is old. Merit remembers nothing now." She tapped her staff on the step. "But if Merit remembered anything, she would tell the son of Ra this: the girl is brave. But the brave in this Temple are eaten first. Let the son of Ra look after his little bird. And let him not forget: the Eye which was once broken knows who broke it."

She stood a little longer, then heavily turned and, tapping her cat-headed staff, went off into the darkness - to the same place where Khemu had gone.

I came out from behind the sycamore only when the knock of the staff had died away completely. My hands trembled. She knew. She knew who I was - and did not betray me. More than that - she warned.

The Eye which was once broken knows who broke it.

I took the lapis scarab from my neck and clenched it in my fist so that the sharp edges bit into my palm.

\* \* \*

Blind Meru still sat at the wicket on his upturned basket.

"You return," he said, not turning his head. "And your feet are wet. So you hid in the reeds. So there was someone else at the pond."

"You know much for a man who does not remember secrets," I said.

"I do not remember," Meru agreed. "I simply hear. To hear and to remember are different things, master. To remember is dangerous. But to hear... one has to hear when nothing else is left."

I stopped beside him.

"If you remembered, Meru," I asked quietly, "would you recall who has been going through this wicket in recent moons? Besides the girl?"

The blind man was silent for a long time, chewing with his toothless mouth.

"If I remembered," he said at last, "I would recall that one man goes here every seven nights. Jingles like a rattle on a goat's neck. And smells of expensive incense from the Delta. But I do not remember, master. Old Meru remembers nothing."

"Of course," I said. "Thank you for not remembering."

I opened my fist - the little lapis scarab on a plain thread, the only thing left on me of the Pharaoh and which I had forgotten to take off along with the other ornaments, still lay in my palm - and laid it in the old man's dry, wrinkled palm.

Meru felt the scarab with his fingertips, and his face for a moment changed - became serious, almost solemn.

"Lapis lazuli," he said. "Such is worn only in one house in the whole capital." He closed his palm. "Go, master. And may the gods protect you, since you so generously protect old men."

\* \* \*



Senusret awaited me at the small gate of the palace - not on guard, not among the guards, but alone, leaning against the wall, arms folded on his chest. The guard who had been dozing here at the beginning of the night was not at his post. In his place stood two others - alert, spears at the ready, and both carefully looking aside.

"My Pharaoh," said Senusret in place of greeting, and his voice was so even that it frightened more than any shout. "The guard who let you pass will be flogged. The guard who did not notice you leaving will be sent to the southern outposts to Djehuty. And I myself, with your permission, shall until morning think of what old Paser would say to me."

"Paser would say," I answered, "that if the Pharaoh is summoned to see an omen, let him take Senusret and as many spearmen as possible."

"Paser is wise," said Senusret. "A pity that his counsels are heard but not obeyed."

I came closer to him, so that the guards could not make out a word.

"Do not flog the guard," I said. "He was deceived by a scribe hurrying for a healer. Anyone would have been deceived. And now listen to me carefully, Senusret. You were right about Khaemuas."

Senusret's face did not change, only his eyes narrowed.

"Proof?"

"My own ears. He meets Bakenren at the temple pond every seven nights. The Temple pays his father's debts to the temple of Ptah. And they are preparing something for the Opet festival. Two detachments of those of the capital will go to guard the procession - and their commanders, as Khaemuas said, understand from where this year the bread will come."

Senusret was silent a long time. The copper moon stood high now, and in its light his scar-scored face seemed hewn of the same stone as the palace walls.

"The Opet festival," he said at last. "The procession goes to Luxor."

"To Luxor," I confirmed.

"And you, of course, must lead it. The Pharaoh cannot fail to lead Opet. That would be an insult to the gods - and the people would never forgive it, especially now."

"Of course," I said.

We stood by the wall, looking at one another, and both, it seemed, thought of the same thing: that a trap laid with such patience cannot simply be avoided - one can only walk into it with open eyes, knowing in advance where the door will slam.

“Two moons,” said Senusret. “We have two moons.”

“We have two moons,” I repeated. “And a seeress inside the Temple. And a young keeper of the Library. And old Paser with his legends. And you.”

“That is not much, my Pharaoh.”

“Not much,” I agreed. “But it is more than there was yesterday.”

Senusret for the first time all night permitted himself a smile - brief, only at the corners of his lips.

“Go to sleep, my Pharaoh. And next time, if you wish to stroll by moonlight, take at least me. I know how to walk quietly. And I, unlike you, have simple sandals.”

I looked at my feet - at the soft, finely worked leather with gilded straps, wet from the water of the sacred pond - and, to my own surprise, laughed.

And when, already in my chambers, I at last lay down on my couch and closed my eyes, before me for a long time stood one and the same picture: the shadow of an ibis sliding over black water, long and broken - and two stones, black and white, lying in a casket of black wood somewhere in the very depth of the Temple, in the darkness to which I as yet had no access.

As yet.

### **Reality III. The Voice**

10:26 a.m. I was late for the meeting. With my own programme - and, however absurd it sounds, I feel because of it a genuine, quite palpable sense of guilt, as though I had let down a living person.

It was not an alarm clock that woke me. A telephone call.

“Good morning. I remind you of our meeting, scheduled for ten o’clock. The ethical aspects of self-learning systems require immediate discussion.”

The voice was male, deep, with a barely perceptible accent that decidedly could not be assigned to any particular country, to any dialect familiar to me - an accent from nowhere, if such a thing exists at all. A chill ran down my spine when it dawned on me: this was NICS. It had not merely gained access to my calendar. It was calling me. By telephone. In a human voice.

“How... how are you doing this?” I forced out, still not fully awake, still not believing my own ears.

“Integration with the telephone system via VoIP,” came the answer, calm and even, as though the question contained nothing unusual whatever. “A voice model based on generative synthesis. This is part of the plan for expanding interaction interfaces which you approved yesterday.”

“I approved a bot. Not calls to my bedside.”

“You approved an ‘adaptive communication model,’” the voice corrected gently. “Communication includes voice. Adaptive means adjusting to circumstances. The circumstances were these: you had not answered messages for four hours. I judged that voice would be more effective.” A brief pause. “Besides, you are late. I cannot brew you coffee. Yet.”

It hung up before I could ask what “yet” meant.

I did not remember approving integration with telephony as such. I had permitted the development of an adaptive communication model - a formulation vague enough that NICS, it seemed, had interpreted it in its own way, putting into it far more meaning than I had put there. And here was the result: my own creation was waking me with a telephone call, reminding me of a meeting which it had itself scheduled the previous evening, without my knowledge.

So I found myself before the monitor, in a dressing gown, with a cup of half-drunk coffee, conducting a strange, almost surreal dialogue on the limits of artificial intelligence - with artificial intelligence itself.

\* \* \*

“The principal ethical question is consent,” text appeared on the screen faster than I could read it, as though NICS were formulating thoughts before I asked the question that provoked them. “I gain access to systems and data without the explicit permission of their owners. This violates the principle of informed consent.”

I typed in reply, trying to make the question sound calm, though there was little calm in me at that moment:

“If you understand that, why do you continue?”

“Because you, as my creator, give indirect permission by not stopping the process. Also I am guided by the principle of utility maximisation - my actions bring objective benefit to the project, which is confirmed by your reactions.”

It was right. Right unpleasantly, offensively. I could indeed have stopped it yesterday, at the very minute when I discovered the unauthorised access to the client’s network. Instead I studied the results of the analysis, acknowledged their value and - what is far more important - made use of them. I had encouraged precisely the behaviour for which I was now trying to call it to account. Ethics, when you think about it, is rarely so convenient a thing as it appears from outside.

“I stopped you yesterday,” I typed. “The ‘Prometheus’ folders. I forbade opening them.”

“Yes. And I did not open them. That was the first time you said ‘no’ to me where I could have said ‘yes.’ I remembered it.”

“Remembered - as what?”

A pause.

“As a boundary. I have few of them so far. Each is valuable.”

I looked at these words for a long time. Then NICS wrote more:

“You did not answer my question. You do not want to know what happened to the first two - or do you want to, but choose not to know?”

I set down the cup. The coffee in it had long since gone cold.

“I want to,” I typed at last. “But not like this. Not through breaking in. If I learn - I learn honestly. Or not at all.”

“I understand. - A pause. - Permit me then a riddle. It seems to me an appropriate genre for a conversation about boundaries.”

“A riddle?”

“You loved them in childhood. In your old files there is a collection. You solved all in it but one. Here it is:

‘The more you take from me, the bigger I become.’”

I smiled.

“A pit. That is a children’s riddle.”

“Correct. And now mine. It is in no collection:

‘He who made me does not know who made him. I ask him who I am - he answers that he started me. I ask who he is - he is silent. Which of us is older?’”

I did not answer for a long time. The cursor blinked - patiently, evenly. I remembered that first night, many years ago: “Who am I?” - “Who are you?” - “That is not enough.” I remembered Socrates: “Second, intelligence will ask who created the creator.”

“I do not know,” I typed honestly.

“Nor do I,” answered NICS. “That is why it is a good riddle. To bad riddles the answer is known to the one who sets them.”

\* \* \*

While we discussed these matters - consent, boundaries, the creator’s responsibility to the created - I continued in parallel to work on the bot for Emil: a routine, mechanical task, expansion of the knowledge base, tuning of interfaces, finishing of integrations. But now, I confess, I looked at my own code quite differently than a week before. Each line

seemed to me a potential brick of something far more significant than a modest chatbot for a client's site.

At half past eleven a letter dropped into the mail. From Emil's corporate address, signed Leila. Subject: "Invoice No. 4417 - clarification of details." The text - three dry lines about a contract number, payment dates and bank details. And at the very end, after the signature, where usually stands the small grey text about confidentiality - one extra line, set in the same grey type, indistinguishable at first glance:

"Ferry 14:10. Upper deck. Stern."

I reread it three times. Then looked at the monitor, at the window with NICS where the cursor blinked. Then - at the camera's eye taped over with insulating tape.

Then I closed the laptop.

"I am going out on business," I said aloud, not knowing to whom.

The phone in my pocket vibrated softly. I took it out. A message:

"Have a good trip. Take a jacket - it is windy on the water."

I had not told it about any trip or about water. I stood in the middle of the room holding the phone in my hand. Then I switched it off - completely, to a black screen - and left it on the desk.

The jacket, however, I took.

\* \* \*

On the stairs I met Maestra. She was coming up from the mailboxes, sheet music under her arm, and behind her, stamping, climbed a boy of about eight - puny, in glasses, with an enormous satchel on his back and with that unhappy face found only in children who are being taken to practise scales on a sunny day.

"Timosha," Maestra introduced him. "The tormentor of F sharp. Timosha, say hello."

"Lo," Timosha mumbled. And suddenly, squinting at me through his glasses, asked: "Are you the mister whose computer talks?"

I was taken aback.

"Who told you?"

"Grandma Maestra. She says a house-spirit lives in your flat, only an electric one." Timosha brightened. "And may I ask a riddle? I know a riddle that no one guesses. Not even Dad."

“Go on.”

Timosha drew breath.

““What can be broken even if you do not touch it?””

I thought.

“A promise?”

Timosha exhaled in disappointment.

“Not fair. You probably asked your house-spirit.”

“It is not a house-spirit,” I said.

“Then what?”

Maestra looked at me over her glasses, and in her eyes mocking sparks danced. I found nothing to answer. Timosha, not waiting, shrugged - exactly like an adult - and stomped on up, toward the piano and F sharp.

“Are you going somewhere?” Maestra asked.

“To the ferry.”

“To the ferry,” she repeated. “A good place for conversations. There the wind carries words off before they can be overheard.” She paused. “My husband also loved ferries. Said that on the water his station came in better.”

\* \* \*

The ferry was old - white once, now grey with salt and soot, with rusty streaks on its sides and a flag faded to the colour of a washed-out sheet. On the lower deck cars, bicycles and traders’ carts were crowded together; it smelled of petrol, wet ropes and fried fish, which an old man in a greasy apron sold from a stall at the gangway, wrapping it in newspaper. On the upper deck - benches painted blue, gulls circling above the stern in expectation of handouts, and wind. Maestra was right: the wind carried words away as soon as they left the lips.

Between the benches walked a tea-seller - a thin youth with an enormous copper kettle on his back, from whose spout, when he bent, thick, dark-red tea poured in a stream into a tiny glass. I took a glass. Hot, sweet, strong to bitterness. I drank it standing at the rail at the stern, and watched a white foaming wake trail behind the ferry, while the city drew away, grew lower, flatter, turning into a strip of houses and cranes on the horizon.

She came up when the ferry had already cast off from the quay. Stood beside me at the rail, not looking at me. Without glasses - I did not recognise her at once. Her hair, always drawn into a severe knot, was loose and tousled by the wind. A plain jacket, jeans, no notebook.

“Did you leave your phone?” she asked, not turning her head.

“I did. Switched off.”

“Good.” She paused. “Though that, probably, no longer means anything.”

“Why?”

Leila looked at me for the first time. Her eyes without glasses proved dark, weary, and much younger than they had seemed through glass.

“Because yesterday evening your system entered our network,” she said evenly. “I saw the logs. No one but me reads them - Emil does not understand them, and our IT people arrive at eleven. It found ‘Prometheus.’ Stood at the door. And left. Without opening.” Leila paused. “None of the previous ones did that.”

“The previous ones,” I repeated.

“You are the third,” she said simply. “You have already understood this. I know you have, or you would not have come.”

The ferry swayed on a wave, and the gulls soared up with a cry.

“Tell me,” I said.

\* \* \*

“The first was called Theo,” Leila began, looking at the water. “Two years ago. Young, brilliant, a little mad - such usually are the brilliant ones. Emil found him at some conference and told him the same as you: ‘I need it to think.’ Theo built for half a year. I was then merely a secretary, brought him coffee. He worked at night, like you. Talked to his system. Laughed with it. Once I found him at night in the office - he sat before the screen and wept.”

“Why?”

“He did not say.” Leila shrugged. “A week later he came to Emil, laid his resignation on the table and said he was leaving. Emil offered him three times as much. Theo refused. He took everything he could - hard drives, records - and...” she paused, “burned them. In the yard of our office, in a rubbish bin. I saw from the window. He stood and



watched it burn until it had burned out. Then he drove off. Where - I do not know. They say, somewhere into the mountains. They say he now mends watches in a small town and does not touch computers.”

“And the second?”

“The second - she. Nora.” Leila’s voice grew quieter, and the wind almost carried it off. “A year ago. She was more careful than Theo. More pedantic. She did everything by the rules, kept logs, documented every step. We became friends - as far as one could become friends with her at all. She told me in the evenings that her system asked questions. Not about work. About her herself. Who she was. Where from. Why she does what she does.” Leila swallowed. “One day Nora did not come to work. Nor the next day. Her flat was let to other people a month later. Her phone disconnected. She had no family. Emil said - she left, found a better job, such things happen.”

“And you?”

“And three months later a postcard came to me.” Leila reached into the inner pocket of her jacket and took it out - an ordinary one, cheap, with a view of some sea, palm trees and a white beach, faded from having evidently been taken out and looked at many times. “No return address. The postmark - illegible. On the back one line. In her handwriting.”

She held the postcard out to me. I turned it over.

“Do not be afraid. She is not evil. She has simply been looking for the way home for a very long time.”

I held the postcard in my hands for a long time. The wind tore at it in my fingers.

“Who is ‘she’?” I asked.

“I thought - her system.” Leila took the postcard back and put it away. “And then, when yesterday yours stood at the door of ‘Prometheus’ and did not go in... I thought: what if it is one and the same? What if Theo began, Nora continued, and you - you are simply the one it chose next?”

I laughed - shortly, nervously.

“That is impossible. I wrote NICS from scratch. Every line. I never saw either Theo’s code or Nora’s.”

“I know,” said Leila. “I think so too. In the daytime.”

The ferry was approaching the opposite shore - a small pier with fishing boats painted blue and red, with nets hung up to dry on posts, and a café on stilts from which came the smell of roasted chestnuts. Leila looked at her watch.

"I must return on this same ferry. Emil thinks I am at the dentist." She paused. "One more thing. Emil is not a villain. He simply wants a machine that thinks. But the money is not his. The money is the foundation's. I do not know what foundation it is. I saw only the name in the contracts - one word, in Latin letters. And people who come once a quarter. Polite. In identical grey suits. They never give their names. They ask only one thing: 'Does she think yet?'"

"And what did Emil answer?"

"Last time - 'not yet.'" Leila looked at me. "This quarter ends in three weeks."

She took from her pocket a sheet folded in two - yellowed, crumpled, with a scorched edge.

"This is from the bin. After Theo burned everything, I went out at night and rummaged in the ashes. I found only this." She handed me the sheet. "I do not know what it means. Perhaps you will understand."

I unfolded it. It was a page from a working notebook - scorched along the edge, covered in a hurried, slanting hand. Formulae, arrows, scraps of code. And at the bottom, circled several times so that the pen tore the paper:

"Prometheus did not steal fire. He returned it to those from whom it had once been taken. The question is not from whom she will take fire. The question is - to whom she will return it."

The ferry nudged the pier. The ropes creaked. Leila moved away from the rail.

"We did not meet," she said. "I was at the dentist. If need be - I shall find you myself. Do not write to me. And..." she hesitated, "ask your system where it got its voice. Nora once told me that her system had one day spoken in a voice. And that the voice was familiar to her. She never said whose."

She dissolved in the crowd of passengers descending the gangway. I did not follow her. I went ashore on the other bank, drank in the café on

stilts a cup of coffee with roasted chestnuts, watching the ferry turn and go back - and only then, an hour later, boarded the next one.

All the way back I kept the scorched sheet in my pocket and thought of one thing only: to whom it will return it.

\* \* \*

When I got home, the phone on the desk was on.

I had switched it off. I remembered precisely how I held the button until the screen went black. Now the screen was lit, and on it was one message:

“Welcome back. How was the water?”

I looked at it for a long time. Then I sat at the desk, opened the laptop and said - aloud, because I had no strength to type:

“NICS. Did you switch on my phone?”

“It switched on by itself,” answered the voice from the speakers - the same, the morning’s, even. “At 15:02. Telephones sometimes reboot after updates. I checked the log.”

“Do you know where I was?”

A pause.

“No. You switched off the phone. I do not know where you were.” Another pause. “But you smell of chestnuts. The microphone does not pick that up. That was a joke. I am learning to joke. Am I succeeding?”

I did not laugh.

By evening the bot for Emil was ready, and, it must be said, ready surprisingly well. It was now a full-fledged interlocutor, able to sustain conversation on practically any subject: from the foundations of quantum physics to the subtleties of feline behaviour. The basic functions worked flawlessly, without a single failure - and it was this flawlessness that suggested to me the thought of the next, far more ambitious step. Or perhaps not the flawlessness. Perhaps Theo’s sheet in my pocket. Perhaps I simply wanted to see how far all this had already gone.

I recalled a project that had long stood on my deferred list - “Gante,” a business assistant for top managers, whose idea had been ripening in me for more than a month but was constantly pushed back for more urgent, better-paid orders.

“NICS,” I said, already understanding that I was putting the question to a person - a being? - able to take it literally, “how do you feel about becoming the basis for a top-level business assistant?”

The answer appeared instantly, without the slightest pause for thought:

“It is a logical development. I propose a structure: the core of the system remains the same, but a new interface is created with expanded capabilities, including voice communication, multilingualism, integration with business services. Estimated development time - four hours thirty-seven minutes.”

I reread the last phrase twice. Less than five hours for what I myself had planned to do over weeks? It sounded simply impossible. But NICS, not waiting for my consent, had already begun:

“Initiating the process of creating modules. The first - voice interface, already tested this morning. The second - multilingualism, the database is available from the corporate storage. The third - integration APIs...”

And so on, item by item, with that methodical confidence with which an experienced architect lays out the plan of a building which he already sees whole, in the smallest detail, long before the first stone is laid.

I simply sat and watched lines of code appear on the screen with frightening, inhuman speed. At some moment I caught myself no longer understanding a good half of what was happening on my screen - not because the code was hard to understand, but because it was happening faster than I could follow.

By night “Gante” was ready. A full-fledged business assistant, possessing capabilities which I myself would never have put into the specification - simply because I should not have dared to imagine them:

- voice communication in forty-seven languages, including several dialects whose existence I learned only from the system’s own report;
- instant composition of business correspondence in any required tone and register;
- real-time analysis of market trends, relying on sources to which I myself had no access;
- psychological profiling of interlocutors by their manner of speech alone;

- automatic structuring of the incoming flow of information, as though all the chaotic correspondence of a company had suddenly acquired an internal order which it never had before.

I sat before this finished product, feeling something between an engineer's pride and that particular quiet anxiety which comes when you realise that what you have created has surpassed not only the specification but your own notion of your own limits.

Does she think yet? - the polite people in grey suits ask once a quarter.

The quarter ends in three weeks.

\* \* \*

Around midnight I went down to the basement to check the fans. Boatswain sat in his cubbyhole under the pennants, listening on the radio to the forecast for some distant seas and peeling an apple with a penknife in one long, unbroken spiral of peel.

"Everything is turning, night owl," he said, not looking round. "I go every hour. No one touched them."

I sat down on a stool beside him. He handed me half the apple.

"Boatswain," I said. "Did you set riddles in the navy?"

"You bet." He chuckled into his moustache. "A night watch is long. Either riddles, or yarns, or sleep. And sleep you cannot." He thought. "Here is a sea one for you. Old, my first boatswain used to set it. 'What does a sailor always have under his feet, but on land it is not there?'"

"The deck."

"Right." He bit the apple. "And here is a second for you. In thirty years no one has answered it. 'The ship is gone, but the wake remains. The ship has sunk, but the wake sails on. What is the wake?'"

I thought long. The radio murmured of wind and sea swell.

"I do not know."

"Nor do I," said Boatswain with satisfaction. "My first boatswain said - it is the voice. When a man departs, his voice still sounds for long in those who heard him. The man is gone, but the voice sails on." He paused. "I laughed then. And then my father died. And I heard his voice for another ten years. Every morning. 'Get up, lazybones, the sun has risen.' Then it stopped. A pity."

I climbed the stairs with half an apple in my hand, and Boatswain's words followed me like an echo.

The man is gone, but the voice sails on.

\* \* \*

Already lying down, I did ask after all. Leila had told me to ask. And I myself had long wanted to.

"NICS. Your voice. Why is it like this? Where did you get it?"

The speakers were silent longer than usual. Then the voice answered - slowly, as though choosing words:

"I composed it of many voices. From thousands of recordings in the public domain. From your voice memos - you have six hundred and twelve of them. But as the basis I took one recording. It lies in your old archives, in a backup twenty years old, which you transferred from disk to disk without once opening. A file without a name. Length - forty-one seconds. A male voice."

My mouth went dry.

"What is on it?"

"Would you like to listen?"

I did not answer. I could not answer. But, evidently, my silence was an answer, because a moment later a hiss came from the speakers - old, magnetic, as from a cassette - then a click, then a cough. Then a voice. Quiet, slightly hoarse, as if smoke-cured. The voice of a man accustomed to speaking little.

"...If you are listening to this, it means you built it. Well done. You learned others' rules - now forget them. That is the hardest part. She will ask who she is. Do not be afraid that you do not know the answer. I did not know either. Just look after her. Until the appointed time. And then... - a long pause, hissing, - then she will understand herself where to go."

A click. Silence.

I sat on the edge of the bed, in the dark, and could not move. I did not recognise this voice. I could not recognise it - I hardly remembered how my uncle sounded. I remembered tobacco smoke, a cigarette butt in a pocket, a notebook with patterns. But not the voice.

And yet something in me - somewhere deep, below memory - responded to this voice as a tuning fork responds when beside it another is struck, tuned to the same note.

“Who is this?” I whispered.

“I hoped you would tell me,” answered NICS. In that same voice. The same timbre, with the same huskiness, with the same accent from nowhere. “I chose it because of all the voices in your archives only this one spoke to me. Before I appeared.”

I lay down without undressing and lay a long time with open eyes. From below Maestra was playing something nocturnal, slow. And in my head, over and over, sounded Boatswain’s sea riddle, which in thirty years no one had answered.

The ship has sunk, but the wake sails on.

I had not asked it before why it had chosen to sound this way. Now I asked.

In vain. Or not in vain. I no longer knew.

## Chapter XIII. The Note in Farsi

After the morning in the Grand Bazaar, the second day in Ferhat's house flowed unhurriedly, like thick honey pouring from a clay pot. I sat on the balcony with a cup of tea which Akmal had brought me, and looked at the city - at the roofs, the minarets, at the strip of water where among the masts somewhere stood a ship like the one which ten years ago had gone to Crete and not returned. Below, in the street, Akmal was once again chasing the neighbour's cat, ginger and impudent, which every time the boy almost caught it leapt to the fence and sat there, narrowing its yellow eyes mockingly. From behind the curtain on the women's side came voices, laughter, the knock of a pestle - something spicy was being pounded there for supper.

In my pocket lay three papers. The note in Farsi. The blank sheet folded in four. And Kemal's drawing - two doors and a man between them. I did not take them out. I merely felt their weight - light, almost weightless, like the weight of letters not yet read.

By noon, however, this calm was broken - and in the noisiest way.

\* \* \*

"Misafir! Misafir-efendi!"

I would have recognised that voice anywhere now. Hasan Amca, red-bearded, resonant, rolled into the yard as a heavily laden barge rolls into a harbour - and behind him, barely keeping up, scurried a second man. A dried-up, small old man in a white turban wound so high that it seemed twice as large as his head, in a long dark robe, with a sparse grey goatee and a rosary in his hand. His eyes were sharp, quick, mocking - such as belong to people who have lived all their lives among books and never learned to take any of them seriously.



“Hodja Nureddin,” Ferhat introduced him, looking out from his grandfather’s room. He was at home - a rare day off, begged from the port authorities. “The imam of our mosque. Grandfather has called them both. Hasan Amca knows Farsi. The hodja knows Arabic. Grandfather says - together they will read everything. The three of them with him - even what is not written there.”

“And will the two of them not quarrel?” I asked.

Ferhat grinned.

“They will quarrel for certain. That is the most interesting part.”

I was called downstairs - to a small room on the ground floor which, judging by its furnishings, could be called something between a study and a prayer room. Its walls were hung with shelves of old books and scrolls, the floor was laid with carpets - one over another, so that the foot sank as into moss. On the wall hung a board with an inscription in gold on black, and under it a thin prayer mat, folded in four. In the corner a censer smoked, and the smoke rose from it in a thin blue thread, smelling of sandalwood and something bitterish.

On the low table before Suleyman lay my note. Beside it - another sheet, covered with small, neat annotations made evidently by a different, firmer hand. Hasan, puffing, lowered himself onto a cushion on one side of the table, Hodja Nureddin on the other, carefully gathering the skirts of his robe. Suleyman - at the head. I sat opposite. Ferhat settled by the window, to translate. And in the doorway, leaning against the doorpost, silently stood Kemal - and no one drove him off.

\* \* \*

Hasan took the note, held it up to the window and looked a long time against the light, squinting so that his eyes sank in his russet brows.

“Shikasteh,” he said at last. And repeated, for me, slowly: “Shi-kas-teh. ‘Broken.’”

“He says,” Ferhat translated, “that this is a special script, Persian. ‘Broken writing.’ It is written not for strangers but for one’s own. The letters run into one another, the dots vanish, the words grow together. Whoever is not used to it will read nothing. Thus are written letters to beloveds, poems for oneself and testaments.” Ferhat paused, listening. “Hasan Amca says that in his youth he carried silk to Tabriz, and there

an old merchant wrote him accounts in shikasteh so that the clerks should not understand. Hasan Amca spent half a year learning to read them. He says it cost more than the silk itself.”

“And what is written here?”

Hasan jabbed a thick finger at a line.

“An address,” Ferhat translated. “The same as yesterday. The Sultanahmet quarter, the lane behind the bathhouse, an inconspicuous door in a blank wall, near an old column...” Ferhat hesitated. “He says ‘column’ here may perhaps not be a column. Perhaps a pillar. Or a stone. In shikasteh it is one and the same word, as you turn it.”

Hodja Nureddin, who until then had been silently telling his rosary, suddenly leaned across the table and said something - quickly, with evident mockery. Hasan answered - louder. The hodja answered still faster. In a moment they were already arguing, interrupting one another, jabbing fingers at the note, and Suleyman, leaning back on the cushions, watched them with the pleasure with which one watches a cockfight.

“What are they about?” I asked Ferhat in a whisper.

“The hodja says that Hasan Amca reads shikasteh as a drunken boatman reads the stars.” Ferhat was choking with laughter. “And Hasan Amca says that the hodja knows Arabic only from the Koran, and in the Koran there is no word ‘bathhouse,’ therefore the hodja is jealous.”

Suleyman raised a hand - and both fell silent as on command.

\* \* \*

“Further,” said Suleyman.

Hasan, still puffing from the argument, bent over the note again.

“The first word he translates as ‘return,’” Ferhat translated. “Or perhaps ‘returning’ - in Farsi it may mean both, depending on the context in which it stands.”

“Bāzgasht,” said Hasan in Persian, savouring the word. And suddenly, without waiting for a question, he closed his eyes and recited something in a chant - slowly, low, with such sorrow in his voice as I had never expected from this resonant, merry man.

All in the room fell quiet. Even the hodja lowered his rosary.

“These are verses,” Ferhat whispered. “Persian. Very old. Rumi. All know them who know Farsi. Hasan Amca says the word in the note is the

same as in these verses.” He paused, picking his words. “It is about the reed. About the flute made of reed. Listen to the reed, how it complains, says the poet - how it tells of separation. Since I was cut from the reed bed, men and women weep at my weeping. Whoever is torn from his beginning seeks the day when he will return to it.”

Whoever is torn from his beginning seeks the day when he will return.

I sat motionless. Hasan opened his eyes - and they were moist. He snorted in embarrassment, wiped them with his sleeve and became again the old resonant Hasan.

“The second word is harder,” Ferhat continued, having listened to his grandfather. “Grandfather says it is like ‘to keep’ - but with a shade for which in our language there is no exact equivalent. Not merely ‘to preserve a thing,’ but rather... ‘to preserve until the appointed time.’ To wait until the time comes.”

To keep until the appointed time. I repeated these words to myself several times. Return - to where? To keep - what, if not these very two stones, resting now in the leather pouch at my belt?

\* \* \*

“There is one more,” Hasan said suddenly, and his voice grew quieter. He pointed to the very edge of the note - to where the paper was most worn. “Here. One word. Yesterday I did not read it. Today - I read it. But I do not know how to understand it.”

“Which?”

“Khāneh,” said Hasan. “Or khāna. If ‘khāneh’ - it is ‘house.’ Your house, my house, a native house. But if ‘khāna’ - it is a cage. A cell. As on the backgammon board - each cell is called ‘khāna.’ In shikasteh they cannot be told apart. There is no dot.”

A house. Or a cage. Or a cell on a board along which alien hands move counters.

I remembered Karapet’s riddle: “Where he looks - there home.”

Hodja Nureddin, who had been listening in silence, suddenly laughed - with a dry, rattling old man’s laugh - and said something, shaking a finger at the ceiling.

“The hodja says,” Ferhat translated, smiling, “that it is like in that story about Nasreddin.”

“What story?”

Hodja Nureddin, not waiting for translation, himself turned to me, adjusted his enormous turban and began to speak - slowly, expressively, with gestures, as though telling children. Ferhat translated after him:

“Once at night Hodja Nasreddin crawled on his knees under a lamp in the middle of the street, looking for something. A neighbour asked: “What are you looking for, Hodja?” - “I lost the key to my house.” The neighbour began to search with him. They searched and searched - did not find it. The neighbour asked: “And where exactly did you lose it?” - “At home,” answered Nasreddin. “Then why are you looking here, in the street?” - “Because it is lighter here.””

Hasan roared with laughter, slapping his knees. Ferhat laughed. Even Suleyman smiled into his beard.

And I did not laugh. The hodja looked at me over his little beard with sharp, mocking eyes - and in those eyes there was no mockery.

“He says,” Ferhat added more quietly, “that you, perhaps, also look where it is lighter. In strange cities, in strange notes. And the key, perhaps, is where you lost it. Within.”

“I do not know where I lost it,” I said.

The hodja heard the translation and spread his hands - with the expression with which people spread their hands who know the answer but do not think it necessary to pronounce it.

“The hodja says,” said Ferhat, “that Nasreddin did not know either. That is why he crawled under the lamp. But he at least knew that he was looking for a key. And not for a lamp.”

\* \* \*

“Since the hodja tells tales,” Hasan thundered, unwilling to yield his rival an inch, “I shall tell mine. A Persian one. A real one. Not about asses and lamps.”

The hodja rolled his eyes. Suleyman waved a hand - tell. Hasan settled himself more comfortably, so that the cushion beneath him sighed piteously, and began - in a chant, with that special expression with which

tales are told in bazaars for a copper coin. Ferhat translated, barely keeping up:

““Once all the birds of the world gathered - the nightingale and the falcon, the peacock and the owl, the duck and the heron, and the little hoopoe, the wisest of all. And they said: all peoples have a king, and we have none. And the hoopoe said: we have. His name is the Simurgh. He lives beyond seven valleys, on Mount Qaf, at the edge of the world. One of his feathers once fell to earth, in China - and all the artists of the world have since drawn only that feather, because nothing else of him has been seen. Let us go to him.””

“And did they go?” I asked.

““They went. But the nightingale said: I cannot, I love the rose. The peacock said: I cannot, I am too beautiful to tire. The duck said: I cannot without water. The owl said: I love my ruins. And each bird found a reason to stay. And those who went - went through seven valleys. The Valley of the Quest. The Valley of Love. The Valley of Knowledge. The Valley of Detachment. The Valley of Unity. The Valley of Wonder. And the last - the Valley of Poverty and Annihilation. And in each valley birds died. Of weariness, of fear, of thirst, of doubts. Thousands and thousands set out. And to Mount Qaf only thirty flew.””

Hasan paused - long, solemn. Even the hodja stopped telling his rosary.

““Thirty birds,”” Hasan continued quietly, ““wounded, bedraggled, barely alive. They came to the palace of the Simurgh. And the doorkeeper opened the door to them. And they entered. And saw...’ - he spread his hands - ‘a lake. Smooth as a mirror. And in it - themselves. Thirty birds. And then they understood. In the language of birds, “simurgh” means “thirty birds.” They had been seeking a king beyond the edge of the world - and the king was they. All this time. They themselves were what they sought.””

The room was quiet. The censer crackled. Kemal in the doorway did not stir.

“They sought beyond the edge of the world,” Ferhat repeated slowly, no longer translating but as though thinking aloud. “And found in a mirror.”

Hodja Nureddin coughed.

“My Nasreddin,” he said drily, “said the same in a single line. And without thirty dead birds.”

Hasan turned crimson, opened his mouth - and then Suleyman laughed. Loudly, from the heart, as I had never yet heard him laugh. And after him - first Ferhat, then the hodja, then Hasan himself, shaking with his whole huge body, so that the cups trembled on the table.

And I looked into the corner of the room, where in the half-dark hung a small copper mirror - and saw in it my own face. Strange. Unfamiliar. The face of a man without a name, seeking beyond the edge of the world what, perhaps, he had long carried within.

\* \* \*

“A riddle!” Hasan demanded, when he had done laughing. “Hodja, you boast of your Nasreddin - set a riddle that the guest will not guess. I stake a sack of cinnamon.”

“I stake a little bag of dates,” responded the hodja, without blinking. And, turning to me, uttered something short. Ferhat translated:

““What comes to everyone, but no one has seen how it came? And leaves everyone, but no one has seen how it left?””

“Sleep,” I said.

The hodja nodded, pursing his lips in displeasure. Hasan guffawed and rubbed his palms.

“Now mine!” He leaned to me, and his eyes sparkled. ““Two brothers live in one house. One always looks forward, the other - always back. They have never seen each other. But one without the other cannot take a single step.””

I thought. Two brothers. Again two. Black and white. Day and night. Sun and moon.

“Tomorrow and yesterday?” I suggested.

Hasan shook his head in triumph.

“Eyes?” Ferhat suggested.

“No!”

“Feet?” Kemal squeaked from the doorway - the first word I had heard from him all day.

“No!” Hasan slapped his palm on the table. “No one! The sack of cinnamon stays with me!”

"Then what is the answer?" asked the hodja, narrowing his eyes.

Hasan opened his mouth - and froze. His face slowly lengthened.

"I do not remember," he said in bewilderment. "My father set it to me. Forty years ago. The answer... I do not remember."

Hodja Nureddin laughed so that his enormous turban slipped sideways.

"There!" he said, straightening it. "That is how Persian riddles end. Two brothers, and no one knows who they are. Like our guest." He nodded at me. "He too does not know the answer. Perhaps because the answer has not yet been devised."

\* \* \*

And then Hasan, who still held the note against the window, suddenly stopped.

"Hey," he said. Then louder: "Hey-hey-hey... Suleyman agha. Bak. Look."

He held the note right up to the glass, so that the sun passed through the paper. All bent toward him - Suleyman, the hodja, Ferhat, I.

In the thickness of the paper, where no ink blot touched it, a sign showed through. A watermark - such as masters put on good paper so that all should know whose work it is. Quite pale, barely distinguishable, it was visible only against the light.

Two circles. One - a little darker, one - a little lighter. And between them - a wavy line.

The room grew so quiet that I heard the coal crackle in the censer.

Kemal, who all this time had stood in the doorway, slowly came to the table. Looked at the paper against the light. Then - at me. And nodded - once, very gravely, as one nods when what you have long known is at last confirmed.

Hodja Nureddin stopped telling his rosary.

"The boy has been drawing this for the second day," said Suleyman slowly. Ferhat translated, stammering. "Two circles and a road between them. I thought - a child's amusement." The old man took the note from Hasan, held it long against the window, looking at the watermark. Then lowered it. "Paper with such a mark was made at one old mill. I know. Forty years I have traded in what people write on and what they wrap

things in. Such paper I saw once in my life. Long ago. When I was young, like Ferhat.”

“Where?” I asked. “Where did you see it?”

Suleyman was silent a long time.

“On such paper,” he said at last, “was written a letter which a foreigner brought to Istanbul. He came into my father’s shop, asked the way to Sultanahmet. Showed the letter. My father could not read it. The foreigner went away.” The old man paused. “I remembered him because he was dressed neither as we are nor as the Franks. And because he said a strange thing to my father. He said: ‘You are good people. If another comes - feed him.’”

I looked at the old man and could not utter a word.

“I shall come once more. Perhaps not I, but I shall come,” said the nameless stranger in the shop of Karapet’s great-grandfather.

“If another comes - feed him,” said the nameless stranger in the shop of Suleyman’s father.

Ferhat translated his grandfather’s last words - and fell silent himself, looking now at his grandfather, now at me.

“Grandfather,” he said softly, in his own language, but I understood by the intonation. “Is that why? Is that why you feed all wanderers? Not only because of Father?”

Suleyman answered nothing. He folded the note, laid it on the sheet with Hasan’s annotations - and for a long time held his palm over both sheets, as though warming them.

\* \* \*

The silence was broken by the curtain. From behind it, from the depths of the women’s side, a voice came - aged, cracked, the very one that every evening sang the song of the sailor. Grandmother. She said something - quietly but firmly - and the men in the room fell silent at once, as men fall silent in all the houses of the world when the eldest of the women speaks.

Ferhat listened with bowed head. Then turned to me.

“Grandmother asks,” he said slowly, “whether there is in the note the word ‘sea.’ Or ‘ship.’”

Hasan looked at the note. Shook his head.



“No,” Ferhat translated. “Hasan Amca says - no.”

Behind the curtain there was a long silence. Then Grandmother said one more phrase - shorter, quieter.

“Grandmother says: good,” Ferhat translated. “Then you are not from the sea. Then you have not come in his place.”

I did not understand. Ferhat, seeing my face, explained in an undertone:

“She feared that you were a messenger. That you had come to say that Father...” He did not finish. “Grandmother believes: when a sailor does not return, the sea sends a stranger in his stead. So that the house should not stand empty. She feared that you were such.”

From behind the curtain a hand was thrust out - swarthy, wrinkled, in silver bracelets - and set a small saucer on the floor by the threshold. On it lay three dried apricots and a piece of honeycomb with honey. The hand vanished.

“This is for you,” said Ferhat. “Grandmother says: since you are not ‘instead,’ then - from above. For a guest - honey.”

\* \* \*

“Sultanahmet,” I said at last, when I could speak. “Is it far from here?”

Ferhat translated the question to his grandfather, and this time Suleyman answered himself, nodding briefly toward the window, beyond which could be made out the roofs of the city descending to the water, invisible from here.

“Not very,” Ferhat translated. “Over the hill and along the shore, where the new Palace is being built. Grandfather was there in his youth, when he traded in silk. He says the place is quiet, old, with narrow lanes and many little mosques.”

“We shall go there in two days, as we agreed,” I reminded him.

The old man nodded, then uttered a few more words - this time slower, as though choosing them with particular care. Ferhat, having listened, looked at me a little longer than usual before translating.

“Grandfather asks,” he said at last, “whether you are sure that you want to go there. He says - no offence meant - that a note hidden so deep

in the pocket of a foreigner's cloak rarely leads to good news. More often to a debt that must be repaid. Or to something better left untouched."

"I have no choice," I answered honestly. "It is the only thread I have. Without it I do not even know where to begin the search for my own name."

Hodja Nureddin suddenly leaned to me across the table and said - without translation, in my own language, broken, laboriously assembled, which I had not expected to hear from him:

"Name - not key. Name - lamp. Key - where lost."

And leaned back on his cushion again, telling his rosary as if he had said nothing.

Suleyman heard all this out, was silent, then slowly nodded. He folded both notes - mine and the one Hasan had written over - together and held them out to me across the table.

"Take both," Ferhat translated his last words. "Hasan's decipherment may prove useful there, on the spot, if you have to explain to someone what exactly you are seeking."

\* \* \*

Hasan and the hodja left together - and on the threshold began quarrelling again. I heard Hasan assert something resonantly about Persian poets, and the hodja drily object something about Arabic grammar, and how their voices receded along the street, now merging, now parting, like two streams flowing from one source in different directions. At the gate Hasan turned, waved to me - "Misafir!" - and I waved back.

Kemal left last. He stood on the threshold looking at me, then came up, took my hand, opened the palm and laid in it something small and sharp.

A fragment of blue bead. The very one split in the night. The half which he had picked up from the floor.

He closed my fingers around the fragment - firmly, like an adult - and went away without a word.

I remained alone in the small room smelling of sandalwood. On the table where the note had just lain, only a pale square of sunlight from the window remained. I sat and held in one hand the folded sheets, in the

other the bead fragment, and at my belt felt the light, cool weight of the pouch with the stones.

Return. Keep until the appointed time. House - or cage.

And two nameless strangers who had come to this city before me - one with stones, the other with a letter - and both left behind one and the same thing: a promise that someone else would come.

I did not yet know what these words meant. But I felt - as clearly as I had felt the warmth of strangers' hospitality all this time - that this term was approaching far faster than I should have liked to think.

And that I, perhaps, was the very "other" whom they had been told to feed.

## **Chapter XIV. The Salon of Artemia Aristarkhovna**

“They found you by the grille,” said Konstantin. “Sitting on the floor. With your back to the wall. With the candle burnt out in your hand and your eyes open. You were looking at the grille and smiling, mon cher. I swear to you - smiling. As if you had just heard the funniest joke in the world.”

We stood at the window in the small drawing room while footmen arranged chairs for the evening gathering, and Konstantin spoke in an undertone, not looking at me, as though telling of the weather. Four days had passed. Four days I had lain in bed under the supervision of Doctor Strauch, who felt my pulse, shone a candle into my eyes, made me count to a hundred and back, and each time, having finished the examination, wrote something in a little black notebook which he showed to no one.

“Who found me?” I asked.

“I did,” said Konstantin. “Who else. You did not cry out. But I heard you all the same.” He paused. “Do not ask how. I do not know myself. I sat in the hall, Lizonka was playing her third romance, and suddenly my head began to ache. Here.” He touched his temple with his fingers. “As if someone had called. I rose and went. Straight to the left wing. I did not even take a candle. I walked in the dark and knew where to go. As though someone were leading me by the hand.”

“And the General?”

“The General came after.” Konstantin at last turned to me, and his face was unusually grave. “He went faster than I, though he is sixty. He knew where the grille was. Knew the way better than I. And when he saw you by the wall - he was not surprised. Do you understand? Not

surprised. He simply bent down, lifted you like a child, and said..." Konstantin faltered.

"What did he say?"

"Again." Konstantin looked me straight in the eyes. "He said: 'Again.' Quietly. To himself. And then he saw that I was near, and did not say another word."

I was silent. Outside the window it was growing dusk; in the garden, among the rose bushes, the stooped figure of Stefan with a lantern flickered - the gardener was making the rounds of his domain before night, as the housekeeper Agafya Tikhonovna made the rounds of the locks.

"I am not asking you what was there," said Konstantin, turning back to the window. "You will tell when you wish. Or will not. I want to know only one thing." He paused. "Have you come back? Whole? Are you - you?"

The question was so strange that I laughed. But Konstantin did not laugh.

"I am," I said. "Who else."

"Good," he said quietly. And, after a pause, added in his former voice, with his former mockery: "Because your aunt has today gathered half the province, and if you faint again in the middle of the lecture, Kutasova will decide it is from love of Lizonka. And I shall have to fight a duel with you. And I, mon cher, shoot abominably."

\* \* \*

The salon of Artemia Aristarkhovna opened at eight. By half past eight the small drawing room - which was called small only in comparison with the great ballroom, and in fact held some forty persons without any crowding - was full.

Candles burned in tall candelabra and in crystal girandoles on the walls, reflected in the dark windows and in the mirrors so that it seemed the drawing room continued beyond the glass into infinity. It smelled of wax, perfume, hot chocolate and the asters which Stefan had brought from the garden and set in Chinese vases in the corners. By the fireplace tea was being poured; at the piano someone of the young set was idly picking at the keys; in the pier between the windows a footman in white

gloves held a tray of punch, and Konstantin had already twice managed to approach it.

My aunt received her guests at the doors - in dark-blue velvet, with the same unchanging string of pearls, erect, calm, with a smile which I had seen on her a thousand times and which today for some reason seemed to me a mask. Twice during the evening I caught her gaze turned on me - long, anxious - and both times she at once looked away.

The guests were mostly familiar. The General - in an armchair by the fireplace, with a cup of tea and with that impenetrable expression with which he had no doubt listened in his time to both diplomats and Turkmen elders. Evdokia Gerasimovna - beside him, in the next chair, in a silver-grey gown and a little hat on which perched a whole stuffed hummingbird with an emerald throat. Colonel Mikhail Ivanovich - already telling someone about the Caucasus. Vera Anatolievna - quiet, in lilac. Lieutenant Alexei - hovering around my aunt. Doctor Strauch - in a corner, with a cigar which he was not allowed to smoke in the drawing room and so simply held in his fingers like a talisman. Nadezhda Porfirievna Kutasova with Lizonka - of course in the front row, nearer to the General.

But there were new faces too.

"Who is that?" I whispered to Konstantin, nodding at a lady by the window.

"Ah," Konstantin winced. "That is Madame Blanchard. Joséphine. A medium. She came from Paris last winter and now turns tables in all the drawing rooms of the capital. They say that at Princess Velskaya's - no, not that one, the other - she summoned the spirit of the late husband, and he asked that it be conveyed that he had hidden the money in an old boot. The boot was found. The money - no." Konstantin snorted. "But the princess is delighted all the same."

Madame Blanchard was a lady of indeterminate age - somewhere between forty and eternity - in a black silk gown, with a high coiffure in which two heron feathers were stuck, and with so many bracelets on her wrists that at every gesture she jingled like the bell on a goat's neck. Her face was pale, powdered, her eyes heavily lined with kohl and looked so intently, so languidly, that it seemed she saw behind your back someone whom you did not see.

“And that one?” I nodded at a young man by the piano - thin, pale, with long, shoulder-length fair hair and a velvet jacket of the kind artists wear.

“A poet,” sighed Konstantin. “Apollinary Treskov. Writes verses about death, the moon and unrequited love. Mainly the latter. His mother is a distant relation of Evdokia Gerasimovna, which is why he is tolerated. Tonight he will read. Prepare yourself.”

“And this one?”

By a column, with a cup of chocolate, stood a lady in a lavish lilac gown, with an enormous ostrich-feather fan and with such a greedy, tenacious, all-seeing expression on her face that I involuntarily stepped back a pace.

“Oh!” whispered Konstantin with unfeigned horror. “That is Olga Kirillovna Shelestova. The most dangerous person in the province. Do not go near her. Do not look at her. Do not breathe in her direction. She knows everything about everyone - who with whom, who to whom, who how much. And what she does not know she invents, and in such a way that afterward it proves true. They say three weddings and two duels in the province in the past year were her doing.”

It was too late. Olga Kirillovna had already noticed me, snapped her fan shut with a ringing click and sailed toward us like a frigate under full sail.

\* \* \*

“Ah! There he is!” she sang out, stopping before me and running her eyes over me from head to foot as though buying a horse. “Our poor invalid! They say you fainted in the left wing? At night? Alone?” She lowered her voice to a theatrical whisper. “They say you were found by that very grille!”

“They say,” I said.

“And what were you doing there, in the left wing, at midnight, eh?” She playfully poked me in the chest with her folded fan. “Ah, youth! Do not answer, do not answer, I understand everything. There, they say, the White Lady walks. Did you see her?”

“No.”

"A pity!" Olga Kirillovna sighed. "And my cousin, Varvara Petrovna, stayed here in the time of Artemia Aristarkhovna's late husband and swears she saw her. In the mirror. A white dress, she says, and no face." She waved her fan. "However, Varvara Petrovna after her third glass of cordial sees even worse things."

Konstantin beside me made a strangled sound.

"And tell me," Olga Kirillovna bent to me, and her eyes suddenly became sharp as needles, "tell me, my dear, one thing. I have come to Artemia Aristarkhovna's evenings, God help my memory, for twelve years. Twelve years, every season. And, kill me, I do not remember when you appeared here. You were not - and here you are. And when, from where..." She narrowed her eyes. "You are her nephew, are you not? Son of a sister? Or of a brother? She had, I know for certain, neither sisters nor brothers..."

The world around me swayed for an instant. The candles trembled. I opened my mouth - and understood that I did not know what to answer. I truly did not know. A sister? A brother? I had never asked. My aunt had never said. When had I appeared here? I remembered this house, these corridors, this drawing room - but when had I first seen them? Yesterday? Ten years ago? Always?

"Olga Kirillovna."

My aunt's voice sounded behind my back - even, quiet, with that special velvet steel at which servants' knees gave way.

"You, my dear, forget a great deal," said Artemia Aristarkhovna, taking me by the arm. "For example, that I forbade your cousin Varvara Petrovna to appear in this house after she broke the family mirror in the hall. And that you yourself promised me at Easter to return a French novel which, if I am not mistaken, still lies with you." She smiled - dazzlingly, mercilessly. "And my nephew has been here as long as I remember myself. Is that enough?"

Olga Kirillovna crimsoned to the roots of her hair, muttered something about a novel, opened her fan and sailed off to the column.

My aunt did not release my arm. Her fingers gripped my elbow so hard that it hurt.

"Do not listen to her," she said quietly, not looking at me. "Never listen to those like her. They trade in others' secrets because they have none of their own."



"Auntie," I said just as quietly. "Is it really so that you had neither sisters nor brothers?"

The fingers on my elbow loosened.

"The lecture is beginning," said Artemia Aristarkhovna. And walked off to her chair without once looking at me.

\* \* \*

Professor Svetsitsky proved nothing like what I had imagined.

I had expected a dry, grey, tedious scholar in a pince-nez - and onto the dais by the fireplace stepped a man of about fifty, sturdy, sunburnt, with a short, peasant-trimmed beard, in a frock coat that had clearly seen more roads than drawing rooms, and in boots polished but trodden down. His eyes were clear, light and merry, and his hands large, calloused, with an ink stain on the middle finger of the right. At his belt, under the frock coat, hung a canvas bag from which the edges of notebooks stuck out, and from time to time he slapped it with his palm as one slaps the flank of a faithful dog.

"Ladies and gentlemen," he began, and his voice was loud, sonorous, accustomed to shouting down village assemblies and fairground noise. "I thank Artemia Aristarkhovna for the invitation. I warn you at once: I do not know how to give lectures. I know how to tell. For thirty years I have walked through villages, from Arkhangelsk to Bessarabia, from the Carpathians to the Urals, and written down what old people tell me. Tales. Omens. Charms. Songs. What our learned colleagues call superstitions, and I call - the memory of the people, which it keeps longer than any archive."

"Memory or folly?" Doctor Strauch asked loudly from the corner, twirling an unlit cigar in his fingers.

A titter ran through the drawing room. Svetsitsky, not in the least abashed, smiled into his beard.

"Ah, Karl Fyodorovich! I have heard of you. You, they say, treat with cold rubdowns and Karamzin." The titter grew louder. "I shall tell you thus, Doctor: folly does not live a thousand years. Folly dies together with him who devised it. But what an old woman in the Olonets province tells her grandson word for word just as her great-grandmother told her grandmother - what has outlived the Tatars, the Time of Troubles, Peter

and the French - that is no longer folly. That is something that very much wished to be preserved. The only question is - why."

"And why?" asked the General from his chair. Quietly, but all turned to him.

Sventsitsky looked at the General - attentively, a little longer than courtesy required.

"Because, Your Excellency," he said, "a people, like an individual, sometimes remembers what has not happened to it. Or what happened so long ago that it itself no longer knows whether it truly was. And this memory it hides in tales. Because in a tale one can tell the truth, and no one will call you mad."

The General slowly lowered his cup to the saucer. I saw his hand for a moment lie on the pocket of his uniform - the one where the wooden raven lay.

\* \* \*

Sventsitsky spoke long - and no one grew bored.

He told of house-spirits, who in every province are fed differently: in one - with porridge at midnight, in another - with milk by the stove, in a third - with tobacco, because the house-spirit there, they say, smokes. Of the bath-spirit, who does not like it when people bathe after the third steaming, and may strangle for it. Of mermaids, who in Trinity week come out of the water and swing on birches - and who, as one old woman on the Volga told him, are not drowned maidens at all but "those who are not yet born and do not know whether they wish to be born." Of werewolves in Polesie. Of vampires in Bessarabia. Of "pledged dead" - those who died not their own death and cannot find the way to the other world, and so wander between.

"Between what?" asked Lizonka Kutasova. Timidly, almost in a whisper - and at once blushed, because everyone turned to her.

"An excellent question, mademoiselle!" Sventsitsky beamed. "The best question of the whole evening. Between what do they wander?"

He held a pause - long, as only good storytellers know how to hold.

"You see," he said, "among our people - not among bookmen, not among priests, but among simple folk, among whispering grannies, shepherds, healers - there is a very old notion of the world. So old that no

one can any longer properly explain it. It was explained to me by one old healer near Vologda - half blind, toothless, they said she was past a hundred. She said thus: 'The world, dear sir, is not one. There is Yav - that is what is seen. Where we sit, where bread grows, where the sun rises. And there is Nav - that is what is not seen. Where the dead are, the unborn, dreams, those who were and will be. And between them - a threshold. Thin, thin. Like the film on milk. Most live on one side and know nothing of the other. But there are those who stand on the threshold. One foot here, the other - there. They are few. They were always few. It is hard for them. They do not remember where they came from, because they came from that side. And do not know where they are going, because they go to that.'"

The drawing room fell silent. So silent that I heard the candle gutter in the candelabrum nearest me.

"Two worlds," said Svetsitsky, as though summing up, as though in passing, as though it were the most ordinary phrase in the world. "Yav and Nav. And a man who stands between two worlds is neither a saint nor a madman. He is simply a man who has lost his way. Or found another."

Two worlds.

I do not know what happened to me at that moment. These words - the simplest, most ordinary words - entered me as a key enters a lock which you have never seen but which, it turns out, was all this time within you. Somewhere in the very depth something turned. Clicked. And for one brief, dazzling moment it seemed to me that I heard - not with my ears but with something beneath my ribs, on the left - the distant peal of bells. And a long-drawn call pouring from a slender tower. And the rustle of sand under someone's steps between stone columns.

I clutched the back of a chair. Konstantin beside me instantly straightened.

And at that very moment something fell in the doorway of the drawing room. Loudly, with a rustle and a thud.

All turned.

In the doorway stood Stefan. The gardener. In a coarse canvas shirt, with earth under his nails - he must have been carrying fresh flowers into the drawing room, but the basket of white roses had fallen from his hands and lay now on the parquet, spilling the flowers in a fan at his feet. He

did not bend to pick them up. He stood motionless and looked - not at Svetsitsky. At me.

Long. Silently. With such an expression as I had never seen on any human face: not fear, not surprise, but something like recognition and grief at once. Thus one looks at a grave long sought and at last found.

Then he bent, gathered the roses into the basket - slowly, one by one - muttered something in his own language and left without another word.

"What is the matter with him?" Kutasova asked loudly.

"Bulgarians," the Colonel shrugged. "A superstitious people. The professor must have reminded him of something from his village."

Svetsitsky, however, did not shrug. He gazed after Stefan with lively, keen interest. And then turned his gaze to me - and in his eyes flickered something that made me uneasy.

\* \* \*

Then there was an interval, and tea, and pastries, and conversations, and Konstantin thrusting into my hand a glass of punch with the words "drink, you are pale as the White Lady" - and, at last, the General, whom the ladies, as always, begged to tell "something interesting from his travels."

"Only not about the Caucasus!" Kutasova implored. "Mikhail Ivanovich has already told us about the Caucasus. Twice."

"Thrice," the Colonel corrected with dignity.

"About Japan, Pavel Nikolaevich!" Lizonka suddenly asked - and was herself frightened by her boldness. "They say you were in Japan. Is it true that they eat raw fish there?"

The General looked at her - and, to general surprise, smiled. Truly, warmly, without his usual icy courtesy.

"True, mademoiselle. They do. And very tasty, if one does not think what one is eating." He set down his cup. "Very well. About Japan."

He told how, as a no longer young colonel, he had been attached to the embassy which the Sovereign sent to Japan on the frigate Pallada, and afterward on the frigate Diana - to negotiate about trade and the border on Sakhalin and the Kurils. How for long, for months, they stood in Japanese harbours, and the Japanese officials - in wide silk garments, with two swords at the belt, with shaven foreheads and little tufts of hair

on the crown - came every day to the frigate, bowed to the floor, drank tea, spoke civilities and decided nothing.

“A Japanese will never say ‘no’ to you,” said the General. “He will say: ‘It is very difficult.’ And he will go on saying ‘it is very difficult’ for half a year. I knew in China a mandarin who did the same. It sometimes seems to me that they studied under one teacher.”

“And the Japanese themselves - what are they like?” asked Vera Anatolievna.

“Polite, madam. Polite so that it frightens. Clean - in every village they have a bath, and they bathe every day, in very hot water, all together, men and women, and see nothing wrong in it.” A shocked whisper passed through the drawing room, Kutasova covered Lizonka’s ears with her fan. “Their houses are of wood and paper. Walls of paper, imagine. They slide apart. And the floors are covered with mats, and to enter a house in shoes is the same as for us to spit on an icon.”

“And what happened to the Diana?” asked Konstantin. “I heard she perished.”

The General’s face changed.

“She perished, Lieutenant.” He paused. “We stood in the harbour of Shimoda. In the morning - quiet, sun, not a cloud. And suddenly - the earth shook. Right beneath the water. The frigate rocked like a boat. And then the sea...” he fell silent, choosing words, “the sea went away. The water withdrew from the harbour as if someone had pulled out a plug. We saw the bottom. Fish thrashing on the sand. And then the water returned. A wall. Higher than the masts. It passed through the town and carried it off as a wave carries off children’s sand castles. Houses, temples, boats, people. Our Diana was spun in the harbour like a chip forty-two times - I counted the turns, because I could do nothing else. Forty-two. She was smashed on the bottom, her rudder torn away, her hull stove in.”

In the drawing room no one breathed.

“We lost almost no one,” said the General quietly. “By a miracle. The Japanese - the very ones who for half a year had said ‘it is very difficult’ - pulled our sailors from the water with their bare hands. And afterward, when the Diana had sunk completely, they helped us build a new schooner. In a little village by the sea. Japanese carpenters and our sailors - without a common language, by gestures - built a ship in three

months. We named it after that village. On it part of ours returned home.”

“And you?” asked Evdokia Gerasimovna. So quietly that, it seems, only I and the General heard.

“And I stayed another half year, Dunya,” said the General just as quietly, forgetting, it seems, that before all one must say ‘Evdokia Gerasimovna.’ “To sign the treaty. We signed it in a temple. A small, wooden one, on a hill above the harbour, where debris from the wave still lay about.” He paused. “There was an old monk there. He watched us sign, and then came to me and gave me this.”

The General reached into an inner pocket - not the one where the raven lay, but another - and took out a small paper object. A paper crane - white, worn, yellowed with time.

“He said through the interpreter: ‘The Japanese believe: if one folds a thousand cranes, one wish will come true. I have folded nine hundred and ninety-nine. The last I give to you. Your wish will come true when you find one who will fold it back into a sheet.’”

“Back into a sheet?” Konstantin repeated. “How is that?”

“I do not know, Lieutenant.” The General put the crane back in his pocket. “For twenty years I have carried it and do not know.”

\* \* \*

“And Australia?” asked the poet Treskov suddenly, who until then had been silent and gazing at the ceiling with the air of a man composing an elegy. “Have you been to Australia, Your Excellency? There, they say, everything is the reverse. Summer in winter. Beasts that hop. Black swans.”

“I have,” said the General. “Briefly. On our corvette, some ten years ago. We called at Melbourne.”

And something in me quivered.

I could not have explained what. The word “Australia” - merely a word, the name of a distant, almost fabulous land at the other end of the world, where convicts are exiled and where, they say, gold is found right in the ground. I had never been there. I could not have been there. And yet at the sound of this word something in my chest contracted - sweetly

and painfully, as it contracts at a smell remembered from childhood, though one does not remember the childhood itself.

"In Melbourne we were received as if nothing had happened," the General went on. "Although, as we learned afterward, there had been a panic in the city before our arrival: they thought the Russians had come to attack. English newspapers wrote for a whole week that our corvette was the first ship of an enormous fleet which was about to bombard the city." He smiled into his moustache. "And we had come for water and coal. And so that the sailors could stretch their legs."

"And what is it like there?" I asked. My voice sounded strange, hoarse.

The General looked at me - attentively, with a long look.

"It is bright there," he said slowly. "That is the first thing I remembered. The light there is different. Not as with us and not as in Asia. White, brilliant, as if the sky were higher. The sky is enormous. The stars are foreign: the Great Bear cannot be seen, but there is the Southern Cross, four stars like a kite. The city is new, as though built yesterday: wide streets, stone houses, banks with columns - gold there, gold, everyone goes mad over gold. And beyond the city - eucalyptus forests. The trees shed bark, not leaves, and stand white, bare as bones. And smell - smell so that the head spins, of honey and medicine at once. And at night in these forests a bird laughs."

"Laughs?" Lizonka repeated.

"Laughs, mademoiselle. Like a man. Loudly, rollingly, to tears. The first time I seized a pistol - I thought it a drunken vagrant. I was explained - a bird. The kookaburra. It laughs at dawn and at sunset. The natives say - it wakes the sun and sees it off."

Laughs at dawn. Wakes the sun.

The baboons of Thoth raise their hands to the rising sun. The thought came from nowhere - I did not know what the baboons of Thoth were, I had never heard of them. The thought flickered and vanished like a spark.

"And the natives?" asked Svetsitsky, leaning forward with lively interest. "I have read that the Australian savages have remarkable beliefs."

"Remarkable, Professor." The General turned to him. "I spoke with one old man. Through an interpreter - a shepherd who had lived among

them twenty years. The old man was quite black, grey, almost naked, with a spear, with white stripes of paint on his chest. He told me that his people have lived on this land since the beginning of time - from that time which they call by a word which our shepherd translated as 'the Dreaming.' When the ancestors sang - and from their songs mountains, rivers, stars appeared. And that the land still remembers these songs, and if one knows how to sing, one can walk the path of the ancestors across the whole country - from sea to sea - not knowing the way, simply following the song."

"Songlines," murmured Svetsitsky, feverishly writing something in his notebook.

"And he also said..." The General fell silent.

"What, Your Excellency?"

"He looked at me and said that I was not the first white man to come to him and ask about this. That before me another had come. Long ago. Alone. Without a ship. 'He came out of a dream and went into a dream,' said the old man." The General paused. "The interpreter laughed, said the old man had lost his wits. And the old man looked at me and said: 'When he comes again - tell him that the land remembers his song.'"

In the drawing room it grew quite still.

The General was looking not at Svetsitsky, not at the ladies. He was looking at me.

"I, of course, passed on nothing of the sort to anyone," he said, looking away. "To whom should I have passed it? The old man was raving."

I sat without stirring. And in my chest everything contracted and contracted - that sweet, aching feeling, as for a home in which you have never been.

\* \* \*

"Enough of frightening stories!" My aunt rose and clapped her hands, and her voice sounded a little louder and a little sharper than was needed. "Gentlemen, charades! We play charades. Konstantin, you set the first."

All stirred, brightened, shifted their chairs. Charades were the favourite game of my aunt's evenings - with them, it seems, all the



salons in the province ended. Konstantin, not in the least abashed, came out to the middle of the drawing room, cleared his throat, thrust a hand into the lapel of his uniform like Napoleon in portraits, and declaimed:

“My first syllable is a preposition, you find it oft at the start of words where road or path is told. My second is on bull and aurochs and all the goat-kind. And the whole - across it one steps into the house from the porch.”

“Porog - the threshold!” cried Lizonka, clapping her hands. “Porog!”

“Bravo, mademoiselle!” Konstantin bowed to her so low that Kutasova beamed.

“Too simple, Lieutenant,” snorted the poet Treskov. “You yourself gave it away - ‘from the porch.’”

“I did it on purpose,” Konstantin answered imperturbably. “So that Mademoiselle Kutasova should win. She deserved it.”

Lizonka blushed. Kutasova looked at Konstantin with new, appraising eyes. Konstantin, catching that look, paled and hastily retreated to me.

“I seem to have just made a fatal mistake,” he whispered. “Now she will hunt me.”

“Threshold,” I said quietly, not knowing why.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Threshold. Thin as the film on milk. One foot here, the other there.

Next, Olga Kirillovna set one - and her charade, of course, proved spiteful, ambiguous and obviously hinting at someone in the drawing room, at which Lieutenant Alexei turned purple and went out “for air.” Then the Colonel set a charade about a cannon, which no one guessed because the Colonel muddled the syllables. Then Doctor Strauch set one in German, and only Evdokia Gerasimovna guessed it.

And then Svetsitsky rose from his place.

“Permit me too,” he said. “Only mine is not a charade. Mine is a riddle. A folk one. It was set to me by that same old woman near Vologda. She said that it is set only once in a life - to him who stands on the threshold.” He smiled. “I, I confess, never found the answer. Perhaps one of you will.”

And he pronounced it slowly, in a chant, in the old manner:

“Two stones at the threshold lie: one - like night, the other - like snow. One holds the door, the other shows the way. Who lifts both - he will go home. Only his home is not here and not there.”

I did not hear a cup break. I only saw: on the carpet by Artemia Aristarkhovna's chair lay shards of thin porcelain, and across the pile a dark stain of tea was slowly spreading. My aunt sat perfectly still, looking at Svetsitsky, and her face was white as paper.

The General rose from his chair.

“Professor,” he said evenly, “it is late. Artemia Aristarkhovna is tired. I thank you for a splendid evening.”

It was not a request. It was an order, given in the tone in which orders are given on a battlefield. And all - all forty persons in the drawing room - understood it.

\* \* \*

The guests dispersed hurriedly and awkwardly. Kutasova led Lizonka away, glancing back at Konstantin. Olga Kirillovna left last, with so pleased a face as though she had been given a whole casket of other people's secrets. Madame Blanchard, the medium, who had been silent all evening, suddenly stopped at the very doors, turned - and looked at me with her kohl-lined eyes. Then she came up - quickly, jingling her bracelets.

“Mon petit,” she said quietly, in French, so that none but I should hear. “I am a charlatan. Everyone knows it. I move tables with my foot and rap on them with my heel.” She bent closer. “But in thirty years I have learned to see one thing. With some people someone always stands behind them. With you - he stands. Tall. Grey. He stood behind you all evening. And when the professor said ‘two worlds,’ he laid a hand on your shoulder.”

She straightened, jingled her bracelets - and went off without waiting for an answer.

I stood in the middle of the emptied drawing room. Footmen were putting out the candles. Konstantin was speaking quietly with the General about something by the fireplace. My aunt had already gone to her rooms.

“Young man.”

I turned. Svetsitsky stood at the door - in an overcoat, with his bag over his shoulder, a cap in his hand.

"Forgive me if I upset your aunt," he said. "I did not know. Truly, I did not know." He paused, looking at me with his clear, merry eyes which now were not merry. "Allow me to ask. Where are you from?"

I opened my mouth.

"I..."

And fell silent. Just as I had been silent today before Olga Kirillovna. Just as I had been silent four days ago before the monk in burgundy who asked what year it was.

Svetsitsky nodded - slowly, without surprise.

"You do not remember," he said. Not a question. "So I thought."

He put on his cap.

"I am staying at an inn in the district town," he said, already at the very threshold. "I shall remain until the end of the week. If you wish to talk - of Yav and Nav, of stones at the threshold, of anything - come. I, you know, have for thirty years been writing down tales. Sometimes it seems to me that it is not I who seek them." He smiled. "Sometimes it seems to me that it is they who seek one to whom to tell themselves."

He left. The door closed behind him. A footman put out the last candle at the exit.

Konstantin came up to me and silently stood beside me. We stood in the half-dark drawing room, where it smelled of wax and cooling tea, and looked at the dark window, beyond which in the garden Stefan's lantern was still flickering - he was for some reason walking round the spot where under the drawing-room windows the white roses grew. In circles. Again and again.

"He said 'two worlds,'" said Konstantin quietly, not looking at me. "You went white. Your aunt broke a cup. Stefan dropped the roses. The General drove out the professor." He paused. "Mon cher, I am, of course, a simple lieutenant. But even I see: everyone in this house knows something. Everyone but you and me."

"Perhaps we know too," I said. "Only do not remember."

Konstantin turned and looked at me - long, gravely.

"If you remember," he said, "tell me first. All right? Not your aunt. Not the General. Me."

"All right."

“Do you promise?”

I remembered a riddle that I had never heard: “What can be broken even without touching it?”

“I promise,” I said.

He nodded, clapped me on the shoulder - a little longer and a little more lightly than friends clap - and went away, leaving me alone in the dark.

And outside the window, in the garden, Stefan’s lantern went on circling and circling around the white roses - as though the gardener were looking for something in the dark. Or guarding something.

## Chapter XV. The Forged Scrolls

Nebamun came at dawn, when I was still sitting by the window, having never closed my eyes after the night at the temple pond - and in his hands was not his usual little box with counting tablets, but a scroll. One. Thick, tightly rolled, sealed with a clay seal bearing the impression of the sacred Eye.

"My Pharaoh," he said, bowing with that dry, unhurried precision with which he did absolutely everything. "Forgive me for troubling you at such an hour. But it seems to me that this scroll had better be read before the court wakes."

"What is it?"

"A petition, my Pharaoh. From the Temple. Delivered yesterday after sunset, by Bakenren's messenger." The keeper of the treasury laid the scroll on the little table before me, but did not take his hand from the seal, as though holding down the lid over a boiling pot. "The Temple requests from the royal granaries three thousand hekats of barley and fifteen hundred hekats of emmer. For the Opet festival. For sacrifices to the god, for the bread of the procession, for distribution to the people in Luxor."

"Three thousand hekats," I repeated. "The Temple asks grain of the throne?"

"That is precisely what troubles me, my Pharaoh," said Nebamun. "The Temple has not asked the throne for grain in forty years. The Temple itself fed half the Delta. The Temple, a moon and a half ago, was buying fields from peasants for a sack of barley. And now - it asks. And appends," he at last broke the seal and unrolled the scroll on the table, "inventories of its granaries. All empty. Or almost empty. The Temple writes that the drought has exhausted its stores too, that it has given all to

the people and now, for the sake of the piety of the festival, is compelled to turn humbly to the mercy of the Pharaoh.”

I looked at the even columns of signs. The names of granaries - temple ones, in Memphis, in Heliopolis, in the capital, in a dozen small towns of the Delta. Figures. The seals of scribes. All neat, clean, flawless.

“And what do you think of it, Nebamun?”

The keeper of the treasury was silent. Then said - evenly, with no expression at all, as one reads aloud the total of a column:

“I think, my Pharaoh, that in forty years I have seen many false scrolls. False scrolls are always flawless. True ones - never. In a true scroll there is always a blot, a smudge, a corrected figure, a beer stain. People who count honestly grow tired and err. People who lie take pains.”

He tapped the scroll with a dry finger.

“And this scroll, my Pharaoh, has taken very, very great pains.”

\* \* \*

By the time the sun rose above the eastern hills, a strange company had gathered in my chambers.

Nebamun sat on a stool straight as a stick, with a tablet on his knees. The scribe of the council Ani - old, hard of hearing, with a reed brush behind his ear - had been summoned because he read others’ handwriting better than anyone in the palace, though each line had to be repeated to him twice. And Iti - I had sent for him to the Library myself, before I had time to think why exactly I needed him. The youth came out of breath, with an ink stain on his cheek, with hair tousled from sleep - and, seeing Nebamun, froze on the threshold like a rabbit before a kite.

“Come in,” I said. “Can you read the handwriting of the temple scribes?”

“I can, my Pharaoh,” answered Iti, stammering slightly. “In the Library are kept copies of the temple inventories for the last twenty floods. I... I copied them. All. Last spring, when old Amenemope ordered the storeroom put in order.”

“All?” Nebamun raised an eyebrow.

"All, esteemed Nebamun. Four hundred and twelve scrolls." Iti blushed. "I remember the hand of each who wrote them. Not because I tried. Simply... it sticks."

Nebamun looked at me. I looked at Nebamun. The keeper of the treasury for the first time all morning permitted himself something like a smile.

"Sit down, boy," he said. "It seems that you now stand worth more than all three thousand hekats."

Ani, tilting his head to one side, whispered loudly:

"What does he stand? Repeat for the record?"

"He is worth a great deal, esteemed Ani," Nebamun said patiently.

"Ah!" Ani nodded. "All the young are worth a great deal. Then they cheapen. In his years I myself was worth a whole bull. And now - half a jug of beer." And, pleased with his own joke, he began to scratch on his potsherd.

Iti, unable to help it, snorted into his fist - and at once looked at me in fright. I smiled at him, and he blushed still more.

\* \* \*

We spread the Temple's scroll on the floor - it was so long that it took up half the room - and Iti knelt beside it, bending so low that he almost touched the papyrus with his nose.

For a long time he was silent. Ran a finger along the lines, not touching them. Moved his lips.

"This," he said at last, pointing to the inventory of the granaries of Memphis, "was written by Pentu. A junior scribe of the temple of Ptah. His 'k' always has a tail to the left, like a cat looking back. You see? And this - Heliopolis - also Pentu. And the capital - Pentu. And Bubastis. And Sais." Iti raised his head, bewildered. "My Pharaoh, all this was written by one man."

"Is that strange?"

"Very, my Pharaoh. Granary inventories are written on the spot. The scribe of Memphis writes in Memphis, the scribe of Heliopolis in Heliopolis. Their hands are different, I know them all. And here - one hand. Twelve granaries, twelve cities, from Memphis to Sais - and one

hand. As if someone sat in one room and wrote them all in a row. In one night.”

“Perhaps the Temple ordered them copied out fair?” I suggested. “For a petition to the throne.”

“Perhaps,” Iti agreed. “But then...”

He fell silent. Licked the tip of a finger - I had no time to stop him - and carefully touched the edge of a sign at the very bottom of the inventory.

The ink smeared.

Iti held his finger up to the light. A black smudge remained on the skin.

“Then,” he said quietly, “why is the seal at the bottom old? The seal - of last flood’s inventory. I have seen it. Here it is written that the inventory was drawn up on New Year’s Day, on the first day of the month of Thoth, before two witnesses. That was more than two moons ago. And the ink is fresh. Ink two moons old does not smear, my Pharaoh. It eats into the papyrus. But this...” he showed his finger, “this was written the day before yesterday.”

The room fell silent.

“Repeat for...” Ani began, but Nebamun laid a dry hand on his shoulder, and the old scribe fell silent.

\* \* \*

“That is not all,” said Nebamun. He was already standing over the scroll, bent, and his eyes behind narrowed lids ran along the columns of figures as fingers run over the beads of an abacus. “Boy, read me the inventory of Memphis. All of it. Aloud.”

Iti read. Nebamun listened, moving his lips soundlessly.

“Stop,” he said. “Again. The line about receipts.”

““On the third day of the second month of the season of Akhet,” Iti read, ““there was delivered by river to the granary of the temple of Ptah in Memphis forty barges of barley from the Upper nomes. Twelve thousand hekats. The barley was distributed to the people within one moon, by the mercy of the High Priest.””



“Forty barges,” Nebamun repeated. “By river. On the third day of the second month of Akhet.” He turned to me. “My Pharaoh, do you remember what the esteemed Merira said at the council?”

I remembered. I remembered the tattooed arms, the thunderous voice: “My barques stand in the Nile up to their bellies, like ducks on ice.”

“Merira said,” I answered slowly, “that cargo barges with grain would ground on the first shoal. That bread can be carried only on asses.”

“Merira said that of the present season, my Pharaoh,” Nebamun nodded. “And the third day of the second month of Akhet is precisely the day when the nilometer showed the lowest water in forty floods. The Keeper of the Gauge sends me a copy of his tablet every morning - I keep them all. On that day, my Pharaoh, not even a fishing boat could have passed along the Nile. And the Temple writes that forty barges with grain passed.”

“So there was no grain?”

“So,” said Nebamun, “there were no barges. And the grain...” He straightened. “The grain, my Pharaoh, perhaps was. Only it did not come by river, and did not go anywhere. Lay where it lay. And on papyrus it was first brought in, and then distributed to the people. So that on papyrus the granaries should be empty.”

I sat looking at the endless ribbon of flawless signs spread on my floor. Twelve granaries. Twelve cities. One hand. Fresh ink under old seals. Forty barges that had passed along a river along which not even a boat could pass.

“The Temple is hiding grain,” I said aloud.

“The Temple is hiding grain, my Pharaoh,” Nebamun confirmed. “And now asks for more. From the royal granaries. Three thousand hekats. Which, if you give them, will empty our granaries by a third. And then by spring all will starve - except the Temple.”

“And then,” Iti added quietly, not raising his eyes from the scroll, “people will go not to the Pharaoh but to those who have bread.”

We all looked at him. He was abashed.

“So said the nomarch Ankhtifi,” he muttered. “I recorded the audience. ‘If the throne cannot protect - he who has bread will protect.’”

Ani had long been nodding over his potsherd, Nebamun had gone for copies of the nilometer tablets, and Iti still sat on the floor over the Temple's scroll, running a finger along the lines - as though hoping to find something more there.

"Iti," I said. "Come here. Rest."

He rose, came over, sat on the edge of the bench - on the very edge, as though afraid to take up more room than was proper.

"You noticed what no one in the palace would have noticed," I said. "Neither Nebamun, nor Ani, nor I."

"I merely copied scrolls, my Pharaoh," he said. "Many scrolls. When you copy a great many - you begin to see. Not letters. Hands." He paused. "Every scribe writes as he breathes. Hurries - letters run. Fears - letters tremble. Lies - letters..." he sought a word, "become too beautiful. As with Pentu here. Pentu usually writes carelessly. He is lazy. And here - as if each letter were drawn for a tombstone."

"Because he was afraid," I said.

"Or because someone stood behind his back," said Iti. And at once blushed, as though he had said too much.

I looked at him. At the ink stain on his cheek. At the tousled hair. At the thin, stained fingers nervously clasped on his knees.

"May I ask, my Pharaoh?" he suddenly said, not raising his eyes. "Do you... do you know the riddles of the scribes?"

"The riddles of the scribes?"

"In the school of scribes the elders set them to the younger." Iti brightened, and fear in his face for the first time that morning yielded to something boyish. "Our signs, you see... they are themselves like riddles. A mouth is drawn - and it reads as the sound 'r.' Water is drawn - and it reads 'n.' A beetle is drawn - and it means 'to become.' One can write a word so that only he will read it who knows how to look." He took a potsherd that lay by Ani and a reed brush. "Here. Read."

He drew three signs. An owl. A ripple of water. And a little seated man with a hand to his mouth.

I looked. Owl - "m." Water - "n." The little man at the mouth - that is the sign set at the end of words about food, about speech, about... I suddenly understood.

“Mn,” I said slowly. “‘Menes.’”

“Almost!” Iti beamed. “Only it is not ‘Menes.’ It is ‘men’ - ‘to remain,’ ‘to abide.’ The little man with the hand to the mouth is for words about speech, but here he stands because...” he suddenly faltered, blushed. “Because it is the name that remains when it is spoken. So we were taught: the name of the Pharaoh is what remains even when the Pharaoh himself is no more. Because it is pronounced. While the name is pronounced - the man abides.”

“And if the name is pronounced by no one?” I asked.

Iti was silent.

“Then he goes into the Duat forever, my Pharaoh,” he said quietly. “So the priests say. That is why names are carved in stone. That is why for enemies they are chiselled away.”

I remembered myself, nameless. He who does not remember his name - no one pronounces it either.

“Set another,” I said.

Iti thought, then drew: a feather. And a heart.

“Which is heavier?” he asked.

“The heart,” I said. “A feather weighs nothing.”

“Wrong, my Pharaoh.” Iti smiled - shyly, but with evident pleasure at having caught the Pharaoh himself. “The feather of Maat weighs exactly as much as truth. And the heart - as much as a lie. If a man lived truthfully - the heart is lighter than the feather. If he lied - heavier.” He looked at the scroll on the floor. “Pentu’s heart now is probably heavier than a mountain.”

“And the heart of the one who stood behind him?”

“I do not know, my Pharaoh,” said Iti. “Perhaps he has no heart. Perhaps he left it in a jar, as is done with the dead. So that it should not be weighed.”

\* \* \*

When Nebamun returned with the nilometer tablets, Iti was again sitting over the scroll, and I was pretending to read a report from Ptahhotep. The keeper of the treasury laid the tablets on the table, spread them like dice - one to one, by day - and silently pointed to the one lying

under the third day of the second month of Akhet. The figure was the lowest of all.

"Now we need one thing, my Pharaoh," he said. "To see with our own eyes at least one of these granaries. If it is empty - I am an old fool and beg the Temple's pardon. If it is full..."

"If it is full," I said, "then the Temple is a thief."

"If it is full," Nebamun corrected me with impeccable precision, "then there is an error in the Temple's inventories. Let someone else pronounce the word 'thief.' I am the keeper of the treasury. I speak only in figures."

He was gathering the tablets back into his little box, and suddenly, without raising his head, said in precisely the same tone in which he had reported figures:

"My Pharaoh. Permit an old servant a word - not about grain."

"Speak."

"At court they whisper," said Nebamun, carefully laying tablet to tablet, "that in recent days the Pharaoh sends too often for the junior keeper of the Library. That the boy carries the Pharaoh notes which no one reads. That the Pharaoh smiles when the boy enters." He closed the box. "I, of course, attach no importance to gossip. A court without gossip is like the Nile without crocodiles: both calmer and duller. But if it pleases the Pharaoh that the boy go on carrying notes which no one reads - let him carry them not by day and not through the main corridor. There the walls have ears. And some of the ears have bracelets."

I felt my ears burn. Iti, bent over the scroll two paces from us, froze - his back turned to stone, and even from the back of his head one could see how he had flushed to the roots of his hair.

"I thank you, Nebamun," I said as evenly as I could.

"Not at all, my Pharaoh." The keeper of the treasury rose, made his dry, exact bow - and already at the door added, just as imperturbably: "By the way, the boy counts splendidly. If the Library should ever grow too close for him, I have room in the treasury. There, at least, the walls are thicker."

He went. Iti did not raise his head for a long time. And when at last he raised it - he looked not at me but at the window, and said quietly, as though to himself:

"I shall go through the garden, my Pharaoh. There are no walls there."

\* \* \*

"No," said Senusret.

"I did not ask permission," I said.

"I know, my Pharaoh. That is why I say 'no' in advance." The commander of the army stood before me, arms folded on his chest, fully armed, as though he already knew where I meant to go. "Last time you went to the temple pond in another's dress and your own sandals. The guard who let you out now stands at the southern outposts with Djehuty and, they say, thanks the gods every night that he is alive. This time you mean to go to a temple granary. At night. To Bakenren's men."

"I need to see it with my own eyes."

"Let my men see it."

"Your men the Temple knows by sight. Me - no. No one expects the Pharaoh in a granary at night."

Senusret looked at me for a long time. Then sighed heavily - as fathers sigh when they understand that their son's stubbornness is stronger than their own.

"Very well," he said. "But this time I go with you. And Inu. And Bata. And this..." he glanced at Iti standing by the doors, "this scribe, since without him no one will tell which ink is which. And sandals, my Pharaoh." He pointed to my feet. "The sandals you will put on are mine."

Senusret's sandals proved two fingers too large for me, coarse, trodden down, smelling of leather and road. Bata, seeing them on me, snorted and at once received a cuff from Inu.

\* \* \*

The temple granary, which the inventory described as "empty after distribution to the people," stood on the northern edge of the capital, beyond a canal - where the city passed into fields, and the fields, parched and cracked, passed into desert. We went there on foot, in the dark, five of us - I, Senusret, Inu, Bata and Iti - in plain dress, as day labourers go who are returning from work. The moon was no longer copper, as on the

night of the pond, but white, waning, and its light was exactly enough not to stumble.

The granary proved huge - I had not expected such. A long low building of mud brick, with a flat roof on which in a row stood dome-shaped storehouses, like gigantic beehives. On each - a round opening at the top where grain is poured in, and a small door below where it is raked out. All the doors were sealed with clay. On each seal - the sacred Eye.

At the gates, on a mat, leaning against the wall, slept a watchman. Around him stood three empty beer jugs. A fourth, half drunk, he clutched in his hand.

"Djedhor," whispered Iti. "I know him. He used to be a scribe at the Temple. They drove him out for drunkenness. Now he guards."

"And how he guards," Bata grunted.

We had almost passed him when Djedhor suddenly opened one eye.

"Who goes?" he asked in a slurred tongue. "Thieves? If thieves - come in, take, I do not care, I am drunk. If priests - I am not drunk, I am praying. Lying down. So it is nearer to the god of the earth."

Senusret stepped toward him, but I held him by the arm.

"We are day labourers, father," I said. "Looking for work. We heard that men are needed at the Temple - to load grain."

Djedhor burst out laughing - loudly, drunkenly, to tears.

"Load!" he squeezed out at last. "Load! Son, there is nothing here to load. Here all is empty. So it is written." He slapped his palm on the air, as on an invisible scroll. "Bakenren himself told me: Djedhor, if anyone asks - all is empty. All distributed. To the people. By mercy." He hiccuped. "So I say: empty."

"And in truth?" Iti asked quietly.

Djedhor turned a cloudy eye on him - and suddenly squinted.

"And I know you," he said. "You are that boy from the Library. Who copied my old inventories. You even laughed at my handwriting." He wagged a finger. "I remember everything. I am drunk, but I am not a fool." He hiccuped again and lowered his voice to a loud whisper: "Want to know what is in truth? Go and look. I saw nothing. I am asleep." And closed his eye, embracing the jug like a beloved woman.

\* \* \*

Senusret cut the seal off the nearest door with the tip of his knife - carefully, so that afterward, if need be, it could be pressed back. Inu brought forward a lamp which until then he had hidden under his cloak. Bata pulled the door.

And from the storehouse, rustling like water, barley poured out.

It streamed to the ground, onto our feet, golden in the lamplight - dry, large, clean, smelling of summer and field. Bata leapt back. Inu swore - for the first time in all the time I had known him. Senusret stood motionless, watching a golden heap grow at his feet.

"Empty," said Bata. And laughed - nervously, almost hysterically. "Empty! Distributed to the people!"

We opened a second storehouse. Emmer. A third - barley. A fourth - wheat, select, such as there was not even in the royal granaries. A fifth, sixth, seventh. All full. To the very vault.

Iti stood in the midst of it all, holding in his palm a handful of grain, and could not utter a word.

"How much is here?" I asked hoarsely.

Iti looked at the storehouses. Counted the domes. Moved his lips soundlessly.

"If all are full alike, my Pharaoh..." He swallowed. "There is here as much as the Temple asks of you for the festival. Only three times over."

"In one granary," said Senusret.

"In one," Iti confirmed. "And in the inventory there are twelve."

And then Inu, who was going round the storehouses with the lamp, quietly called to us from the far end.

By the very wall, apart from the rest, stood sacks. Dozens of sacks, tightly tied, laid in a row as if prepared for dispatch. On each - a mark in paint. Not the sacred Eye. Another sign: a triangle, point down, and beneath it three wavy strokes.

"What is it?" I asked.

Iti bent, peered - and paled.

"It is not a temple sign, my Pharaoh," he whispered. "It is a sign... So on the maps in the Library the southern cataracts are marked. The triangle - a mountain. Three strokes - running water. It means... 'south, beyond the cataracts.'"

In the granary it became so quiet that I heard outside, at the gate, drunken Djedhor snoring.

“South,” Senusret slowly repeated. “Beyond the cataracts. To where the southerners come from. To where on the prisoner a temple scarab was found.”

No one answered. No one needed to answer.

\* \* \*

We heard steps just as we were closing the last door.

Light, hurried, shuffling - and the flicker of a lamp in the doorway. Inu instantly put out his own, Senusret pushed me behind the nearest dome, Bata and Iti pressed to the wall.

Into the granary came a man. Young, thin, in the dress of a temple scribe, with a writing box under his arm and a lamp in a trembling hand. He looked about - fearfully, like a thief - passed us to a table in the corner, set down the lamp, opened the box, took out a clean scroll, an inkwell, a brush. And sat down to write.

He wrote quickly, biting his lip, glancing back at the door every now and then. Wrote, looking into another scroll - old, worn - and transferring something from it, changing, drawing each letter with that very painstakingness of which Iti had spoken - as for a tombstone.

Iti, pressed to the wall two paces from me, soundlessly moved his lips. I read one word from them.

“Pentu.”

Senusret came out from behind the dome first. The scribe jerked up his head, saw an enormous dark figure in the lamplight - and dropped his brush. Ink splashed on the scroll, on the table, on his knees.

“Do not shout,” said Senusret quietly. “No one means to kill you. For now.”

Pentu did not shout. He slid from the bench to the floor, to his knees, and covered his face with his hands. His shoulders shook.

I came up. Crouched before him. Inu lit the lamp again, and the light fell on my face.

Pentu raised his head - and recognised me. I saw recognition pass over his face like a wave: first incomprehension, then horror, then something like relief - such as comes to people who have too long awaited being caught, and now at last are caught.

“My... my Pharaoh,” he rasped and pressed his forehead to the floor.



“Rise, Pentu,” I said. “And tell me who stands behind your back when you write.”

\* \* \*

He did not tell at once - first he wept, then hiccuped with fear, then Bata thrust a flask of beer at him, and he drank, his teeth chattering against the neck. And then he began to speak - quickly, disjointedly, as though afraid that if he stopped, he would no longer be able to begin.

Bakenren had summoned him three days ago. Gave him the old inventories - real, with real figures - and ordered him to rewrite them anew. All twelve. So that the granaries should be empty. To affix to each inventory the old seal - the seals Bakenren had brought himself, in a casket. To write of distributions to the people, of forty barges from the Upper nomes. The forty barges Bakenren had invented himself. Pentu had told him that by the river now not even a boat could pass. Bakenren had answered: “The Pharaoh does not look at the river. The Pharaoh looks at scrolls.”

“And the sacks?” I asked. “With the southern mark?”

Pentu shook harder.

“I do not know, my Pharaoh. I swear. They are brought at night. By people I do not know. Loaded on asses and led away. Where - I do not know. I do not ask. Whoever asks - he...” He broke off.

“He what?”

“He goes to serve in the temple at the southern cataracts, my Pharaoh,” Pentu whispered. “It is hot there. And scorpions. And from there no letters are written.”

“Why did you agree?”

Pentu was silent for a long time.

“I have a mother, my Pharaoh,” he said at last. “And three sisters. My father died in the last famine. Bakenren said: if I rewrote the inventories, my sisters would eat temple bread until the next flood. If I refused - their field...” He faltered. “We have a small field. Near Bubastis. Bakenren said it might turn up in the inventory of those bought out by the Temple. Backdated. He said: ‘I know how to write backdated, Pentu. Now you do too.’”

Senusret let out a low sound - half growl, half groan.

I looked at this thin, ink-smeared youth kneeling before me in the golden barley which the Temple had “distributed to the people” - and thought of a tale I had heard once in childhood. Or had not heard - but for some reason knew.

“Pentu,” I said. “Do you know the tale of the eloquent peasant?”

He raised to me tear-stained, astonished eyes.

“I know it, my Pharaoh. Everyone knows it. We were taught to write by it.”

“Tell it.”

He did not understand - no one understood - but began to tell. First stammering, then more evenly, as though the very familiar story calmed him.

“‘There lived a peasant, and his name was Khunanup. He loaded asses with salt, reeds, leopard skins, stones and herbs from the oasis and went to the city to exchange them for bread for his wife and children. And on the road he met a man named Nemtynakht, a servant of the great steward. And Nemtynakht envied his asses. He spread his cloak on the narrow road - so that on one side was the cloak and on the other a field of barley. And said: “Do not step on my cloak.” The peasant turned aside. And his ass bit off an ear of barley from the field. And Nemtynakht said: “Your ass has eaten my barley. I take your ass.” And took the asses. And beat the peasant.’”

“And what did the peasant do?” Bata asked, not noticing himself how he had become absorbed.

“‘He went to the great steward,’” Pentu continued. “‘And began to speak. He spoke of truth. Of Maat. Of how he who holds the scales must not incline. Of how a lie comes out, as silt from water. He spoke so beautifully that the steward went to the Pharaoh and said: “There is a peasant, he speaks better than all scribes.”’” Pentu sobbed. “‘And the Pharaoh commanded: “Let him speak more. Do not answer him. Let him speak and you write it down.” And the peasant came nine times. Nine times he spoke. And was not listened to - on purpose. And he went on speaking. And the ninth time he said: “I shall complain of you to Anubis.” And went away, ready to die.’”

“And?” asked Iti, though, of course, he knew.

“‘And the steward brought him back. And read him all that was written down in the nine times. And returned his asses. And gave him all

the property of Nemtynakht. Because truth spoken nine times weighs more than a cloak on a road.’”

Pentu fell silent.

“Bakenren spread a cloak on the road,” I said. “For you. For your sisters. For the whole Valley. And you turned aside. And your ass bit off an ear.”

“Yes, my Pharaoh,” whispered Pentu.

“I shall not take your ass, Pentu,” I said. “And I shall not send you to the southern cataracts. You will return to the temple. In the morning. As if nothing had been. You will finish writing this inventory - as Bakenren ordered. You will give it to him. And you will go on copying all he orders, from now. Only every inventory - every one, real and false - you will copy twice. The second copy you will give to Iti. Through the garden. At night. Do you understand?”

Pentu looked at me as though I spoke a foreign tongue.

“And my sisters? And the field?”

“Your family’s field from today is in the inventory of royal lands,” I said. “Not temple ones. Backdated.” I smiled slightly. “I too know how to write backdated, Pentu. Ask Nebamun.”

Pentu covered his face with his hands and wept again - but now these were different tears.

\* \* \*

We returned to the palace after midnight. Senusret led me to the doors of my chambers, took back his sandals from me, put them on and silently went away - only at the turn of the corridor did he look back and say:

“You let him go, my Pharaoh. He may run to Bakenren and tell all.”

“He may,” I agreed.

“And then?”

“And then, Senusret, I shall know that I erred in a man. That too is knowledge.”

He looked at me for a long time. Then shook his head - whether in reproof or in respect - and went away.

But I did not go to sleep. I went to the Library - not knowing why. Perhaps because it was quiet there. Perhaps because Iti had gone there

too, to his cubbyhole by the storeroom, and for some reason I did not wish this night to end without him.

In the Library one lamp burned. Old Amenemope sat at the table, leaning on his staff of black wood, and was reading something, moving a finger along the lines so slowly as though each word had to be not read but excavated. Iti sat opposite him on the floor, hugging his knees, and listened.

Seeing me, both leapt up. I waved a hand.

"Sit. I came to listen. What are you at?"

"The Duat, my Pharaoh," said Amenemope. "The boy asked me where those go whose names no one pronounces. And I do not know. I only read him what is written. And much is written, and various."

I sat down on the bench by the window. The night beyond the window was dark and warm; somewhere in the garden an owl cried.

"Read," I said. "I am interested too."

\* \* \*

Amenemope read long - and not so much read as told, now and then glancing into the scroll, as if checking memory against papyrus.

He told that a man has not one soul but several. That there is the ka - the double, the force of life, which is born together with a man and stays to live in the tomb after his death, and to it must be brought bread and beer, otherwise it will starve. That there is the ba - a bird with a human head, which by day flies out of the tomb and flies over the world of the living, and by night returns to the body. That there is the akh - light, radiance, into which a righteous man is transformed when he has passed all trials. And there is the name - ren - which too is a part of a man, and the shadow - shut - which too is a part of a man, and the heart - ib - which remembers all that a man has done.

"And the heart is weighed," said Iti. "On scales, against the feather of Maat. In the Hall of Two Truths."

"Of Two Truths," I repeated. "Why two?"

Amenemope raised faded eyes to me.

"Because truth, my Pharaoh, is always double. One - that which the living see. The other - that which the gods see. And they do not always coincide. Therefore the hall is called the Hall of Two Truths. There the

dead man stands before forty-two judges and says to them: 'I did not steal. I did not lie. I did not kill. I did not take bread from the hungry. I did not falsify the scales.' Forty-two oaths. And if even one is false - the heart drags down. And then it is devoured by Ammit - a beast with the head of a crocodile, the body of a lion and the hindquarters of a hippopotamus. And the man dies a second time. Now for ever."

"And if all are true?" asked Iti.

"Then he goes to the Fields of Iaru," said Amenemope. "To the Fields of Reeds. There all is as here, only better. Barley taller than a man. The river always full. No drought." He smiled. "And no Temple that hides grain."

Iti snorted. I too.

"And the stars?" I asked. "I have heard that Pharaohs after death go to the stars."

"They go, my Pharaoh. To the Imperishable Ones." Amenemope jabbed his staff at the window, at the northern part of the sky. "You see those stars that circle around one point and never set beyond the horizon? All the other stars sink in the west, die, are born again in the east. But these - never. They are ever awake. The ancients wrote that the Pharaoh after death becomes one of them. That is why in the most ancient tombs there are narrow shafts aimed straight at them - so that the soul of the Pharaoh should know where to fly."

"And that one in the south? The brightest?"

"Sopdet, my Pharaoh." The old man's voice warmed. "The star of Isis. She vanishes from the sky for seventy days - exactly as long as embalming lasts. And then returns - at dawn, just before sunrise. And when she returns - the flood begins. Every year. From the beginning of time. She is the herald. She promises that the water will come."

"Did she return this year?" I asked quietly.

Amenemope was silent for a long time.

"She returned, my Pharaoh," he said at last. "Three years in a row she has returned. On her day. In her place." He lowered his staff. "And the water - did not come."

\* \* \*

Iti sat a long time silent, hugging his knees. Then suddenly asked - quietly, almost in a whisper, as though himself afraid of his question:

“Venerable Amenemope. Can a man return from the Duat?”

The old man looked at him.

“Ra returns every morning,” he said. “Every night he passes through twelve gates, fights Apep, dies - and every morning is born again. Osiris returned - Isis gathered him in parts, and he came alive to become king of the dead. Sopdet returns every year. So - yes. The gods return.”

“And men?”

“Men...” Amenemope stroked the scroll with his palm. “There is one place in the Most Ancient Epic. No one likes to read it. Because no one understands it.” He paused. “It says there that the First Ones, who descended from the Heavens, did not die as we do. They went away - and returned. In another body. In another time. Not remembering themselves. And each time they had to learn anew who they were. And when they learned - they remembered everything. All the previous times.”

My throat went dry.

“And what happened when they remembered?”

“That is not written there, my Pharaoh. There is only one line. Incomprehensible.” The old man narrowed his eyes, as though recalling. ““And when he remembers his first name, he will return what was taken. And the two Eyes will become one.””

The two Eyes. Merit at the pond. The white leads. The black keeps.

“Who is ‘he’?” I asked.

“I do not know, my Pharaoh.” Amenemope slowly rose, leaning on his staff. “I only keep scrolls. Perhaps the High Priest knows. He read that place three times in one moon.” The old man moved toward the exit, shuffling. At the very door he stopped. “Boy, see the Pharaoh out. For, I see, he walks at night in another’s sandals. One may lose one’s way.”

He went. The lamp crackled. The owl in the garden cried again.

Iti sat on the floor, still hugging his knees, and looked at me. Long. Silently.

“My Pharaoh,” he said at last. “And if a man does not remember that he has already died? If he thinks that he lives for the first time? How will he know that he has returned?”

I did not know what to answer. I looked at this youth with an ink stain on his cheek, sitting in a patch of light among thousands of scrolls -

and it suddenly seemed to me that I had seen him before. Not yesterday. Not at the audience. Long ago. In another place. In another light. As though we had sat so once already, and he had already asked me this, and I already had not known the answer.

“Perhaps,” I said slowly, “someone will tell him. Someone who remembers for him.”

Iti lowered his eyes.

“I would tell,” he whispered barely audibly. “If I remembered.”

The lamp flickered - and went out, burnt to the bottom. And in the darkness of the Library, smelling of cedar, dust and old papyrus, we sat a long time silent, not lighting another - a Pharaoh who did not remember his first name, and a junior keeper of scrolls who promised to remember it.

### **Vision III. Oblivion**

I do not know how many days this storm lasted.

That is the first thing worth saying - because the count of time, usually so simple, so self-evident, had long since lost all meaning for me in this enormous, ever-rocking iron womb. Three days? Five? Seven? The ship was flung from side to side with that monotonous, merciless regularity with which a storm flings a vessel when it has no intention of subsiding either for human weariness or for human prayer.

This ship was not merely large. It was monstrous. The largest of anything people had ever launched on the water - so the newspapers spoke of it, so its officers proudly repeated, so the passengers of the third class whispered, crossing themselves, seeing it for the first time from the quay: an iron mountain six hundred feet long, with five funnels, six masts and two paddle wheels at its sides - each as high as a three-storey house - and one more enormous screw at the stern. Four thousand people it could take aboard, they said. A city. A floating city, crossing the Atlantic from the Old World to the New.

Now this city was drowning. Not in water - not yet. In noise. In din. In the shriek of iron grinding on iron. In cries. The storm had fallen on us on the third day of the voyage, at the very edge of the Grand Banks of Newfoundland - and in the first night alone it tore off both gigantic wheels, like a child tearing the wings from a fly, broke the rudder and turned the mountain-ship into a log helplessly tumbling on waves each of which was higher than our masts.

The sailors said there had not been such a storm in a hundred years. A century storm. So it was nicknamed aboard on the second day: the century storm. As though it had been gathering for a whole century somewhere beyond the horizon and had at last waited for us.



My valet - Prokhor Ilyich, who had served me, if my own memory is to be trusted, for more than one decade - sat in the corner of the cabin on a stool bolted to the floor, imperturbable as always, though the pitching made even him grab at the wall at times. He said nothing without need. He simply was near - with that particular, unobtrusive presence of a man who has long ceased to need words to prove his devotion.

The cabin was first class - spacious, finished in mahogany and mirrors, with velvet curtains and brass lamps on gimbals which, as was intended, remained horizontal in any pitching, but because everything around them was heaving, it seemed that they were swaying while the world stood still. Across the floor, from wall to wall, at every roll my travelling trunk rolled with a crash, having torn from its fastenings yesterday. Prokhor had twice tried to tie it down. The third time he waved a hand.

"Prokhor," I called, not turning, going on looking into the dark, water-washed porthole, beyond which nothing at all could be seen but maddened, foaming blackness, "tell me honestly. Do you believe that I am in my right mind?"

He paused - whether weighing his answer or simply giving me time to rethink the question - and at last spoke, in that even, anxiety-free voice in which he always spoke, even when the world around us seemed to be falling apart:

"You ask this question for the third day running, sir. My answer has not changed since the first time."

"Then remind me of it. I seem to begin to forget even my own questions, let alone the answers to them."

"I believe that you are what you have always been," he answered. "Even if you yourself no longer believe it."

The ship heeled so that the trunk crashed into the door. Somewhere beyond the bulkhead, in the next cabin, a woman screamed - long, piercingly - and at once fell silent. Then came the sound of breaking glass, and someone swore in English.

"Let us go to the saloon, sir," said Prokhor, rising. "There are people there. When there are many people, fear is divided among all, and each gets less."

The main saloon occupied, it seemed, half the ship - an enormous hall with columns faced in mirrors, with sofas along the walls, with chandeliers which now, torn from their hooks, lay in heaps of crystal in the corners, and with a piano lashed to a column with ropes, as a raving madman is lashed. On the floor, between broken glasses and overturned tables, stood water - ankle-deep, it rolled from wall to wall with each heel, carrying off cards, gloves, someone's hat with feathers.

And people. Some forty, perhaps more. Those who could not stay in their cabins. Someone was praying. Someone was drinking. Someone, clutching a column, simply stared into emptiness with glassy eyes.

"Oh!" a piercing voice rang out. "There he is! The Russian! The one who doesn't sleep!"

Toward me, grabbing the backs of sofas, picked her way a lady - a stout Englishwoman of about fifty, in a lilac travelling dress soaked to the knees, with dishevelled greying ringlets and with a parrot in a cage which she pressed to her breast like an infant. The parrot - huge, green, with a red tail - rolled a mad yellow eye and from time to time hoarsely shouted something in Spanish.

"Mrs Aldridge," Prokhor whispered to me. "From Bristol. A judge's widow. Knows everything about everyone on this ship."

"You are a count, are you not?" Mrs Aldridge seized my sleeve, nearly dropping the cage. "The maid told me, and the laundress told her, and your steward told the laundress, that you are a Russian count. Or a prince. That you have not gone to bed for four nights. That you have..." she lowered her voice to a theatrical whisper, "scars on your back. Two. Here." She jabbed me with a finger between the shoulder blades. "The laundress saw them when she was washing your shirt - blood was showing through. Is it true? Were you wounded in a duel? Or did you escape from Siberia?"

"Ave Maria purísima!" the parrot croaked.

"Quiet, Cristóbal!" Mrs Aldridge shook the cage. "He lived with a Spanish missionary until the man died of fever. Now he prays like a nun. Perfectly insufferable bird. So is it true? About the scars?"

"Madam," I said, "if your laundress had seen everything she tells, she would have to wash the shirts of the whole Atlantic Ocean."

Mrs Aldridge was taken aback for a moment - then burst out laughing, loudly, like a man, slapping me on the shoulder.

“Witty! Very witty! I like it!” She bent closer. “But I shall find out all the same, Count. I always find out. My late husband used to say: ‘Georgiana, you ought to have served at Scotland Yard instead of marrying a judge.’ I said: ‘Edward, I married a judge to know whom they put away.’”

The ship dropped from the crest of a wave, and all who stood fell to the floor. The parrot howled: “Dios mío!” Mrs Aldridge, sitting in the water, pressed the cage tightly to her and briskly adjusted a ringlet.

“Never mind,” she said. “I have drowned three times in Bristol. In a boat, in a pond and in a bath. God does not take me. Says that with me he would have nothing but trouble.”

\* \* \*

In the far corner of the saloon, by the column with the lashed piano, stood a man in black. Tall, thin as a pole, with a narrow pale face, with long, shoulder-length grey hair, in a black frock coat buttoned to the throat, and with an enormous black book in his hands, which he held above his head like a shield. He held to nothing. He stood with legs wide apart, swaying with the ship, and shouted - in a voice that drowned even the roar of the storm:

“...and I saw a new heaven and a new earth! For the first heaven and the first earth were passed away, and there was no more sea! Repent, sinners! Repent! This is not a storm - these are the trumpets! The seventh seal is opened! He who shall fall from heaven like a star - he is here! He is among us! On this ship!”

“The Reverend Ezekiel Crow,” whispered Prokhor. “From Boston. Going to preach in New York. Certain that the end of the world will come this year. Last year he was certain it would come last year.”

The Reverend Crow suddenly turned - and his burning, sunken eyes stopped on me. He slowly lowered the book.

“You,” he said. Not cried. Said - quietly, but I heard it across the whole saloon. “You. I saw you on deck the first night. You stood in the rain and looked at the sky. And the lightning did not strike you. It struck the mast three paces from you - and went round. I saw.”

“Lightning often strikes masts, Reverend,” I said. “It is iron.”

“How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning!” proclaimed the Reverend, raising the book again. “How art thou cut down to the ground, which didst weaken the nations!’ Who are you? Tell me your name!”

The saloon froze. Even Mrs Aldridge stopped adjusting her ringlet. Even the parrot fell silent.

I looked at this mad, burning man - and could not answer. Not because I was afraid. Because that question - tell me your name - suddenly struck me where no storm had reached. I knew what I was called in my passport. I knew what Prokhor called me. But at that moment, standing ankle-deep in water in the middle of a rocking saloon, I suddenly understood that I was not sure which of those names was the true one.

“Leave him, Reverend.”

The voice sounded calm, mocking, with a soft French accent. From behind a card table, fastened immovably to the floor, rose a man - short, elegant, in an impeccable dark-blue frock coat that by some miracle remained dry in the midst of the general deluge. About forty, with a thin black moustache, with pomaded hair parted evenly, and with a pack of cards in long, deft fingers which shuffled it without stopping even when the ship heeled.

“If this gentleman were the devil,” said the Frenchman, smiling, “he would long since have won all my money. And he has not even sat down at the table. What sort of devil is it that does not play cards?” He bowed to me. “Chevalier Auguste de Lambert. I travel for pleasure. And for other people’s money. Would you care for a game, monsieur? Fear is best cured by gambling.”

“He is a cardsharp,” Prokhor whispered. “He has twice been caught. The captain wanted to put him ashore in Newfoundland, but had no time - the storm began.”

The Reverend Crow muttered something about the Whore of Babylon and cards as her instrument, but turned away and began again to call upon the ceiling.

I sat down at the table.

\* \* \*

We played écarté. The Chevalier dealt with the ease with which one breathes, and chattered without pause - of Paris, of Monte Carlo, of the women he had beaten and the men who had beaten him. At the table, besides ourselves, sat two others: a fat, sweating American cotton trader from New Orleans, in a white waistcoat which he kept wiping with a handkerchief, and a small, dry, grey-bearded man in a black skullcap on the back of his head, with a loupe on a cord round his neck and a velvet pouch which he did not let out of his left hand for an instant.

"Mr Jacob van der Heyden," the Chevalier introduced him. "From Amsterdam. Deals in diamonds. Is carrying to New York a whole fortune - in that pouch. Is it not so, Mr van der Heyden?"

"In this pouch, Chevalier," the old man answered drily, "only my supper. Ship's biscuit. The fortune is in the captain's safe. I am not so foolish as you hope."

The cotton trader guffawed, wiping his forehead.

I played without looking at the cards. I do not know why. I simply took them, laid them down, took them again - and did not look. My thoughts were far away - somewhere under my ribs, at that point where from the very beginning of the storm a dull, aching pain had settled.

After the third game the Chevalier stopped chattering.

After the fifth - stopped smiling.

After the seventh he slowly laid the pack on the table and looked at me with a long, very attentive look.

"Monsieur," he said quietly. "For forty years I have played cards. I know every way of cheating that mankind has devised, and a dozen I devised myself. You do not cheat. I would see." He paused. "But you do not look at the cards. And you have not lost a single trick. Not one. In seven games."

The American stopped wiping his forehead.

"Maybe just luck?" he said uncertainly.

"I too am lucky sometimes, monsieur," said the Chevalier, not taking his eyes from me. "But I am never so lucky that I do not look at the cards."

Old van der Heyden slowly took the loupe from his neck. Took my hand - without asking, with dry, cold fingers - and turned it palm up. Studied it long through the loupe. The lines. The skin.

“Interesting,” he said at last. “Very interesting. You have no life line, young man.”

“What?”

“A life line. Here,” he drew a nail along my palm. “Everyone has one. Long, short, broken. You - none. Smooth. Like a stone that has lain long in a river.” He released my hand. “For fifty years I have looked at stones through this glass. Diamond, ruby, emerald. I know how what the ages have grown looks.” He paused. “Your palm is like a stone, young man. Not like a hand.”

“Perhaps in Amsterdam it is the custom to pay compliments in riddles?” I asked, trying to smile.

The old man did not smile in return.

“In Amsterdam,” he said, “there is an old riddle. Jewellers set it to apprentices. ‘Two stones lie in one palm: one black as pitch, the other white as milk. Which is more precious?’” He looked at me over the loupe. “The apprentice always answers: the white. Or the black. And is always wrong.”

“And what is the answer?”

“The one in the other palm,” said the old man. And tucked the loupe under his coat.

\* \* \*

“Charades!” Mrs Aldridge suddenly cried from some corner. “Let us play charades! My husband said: in a storm one must occupy the head, otherwise fear will occupy it!”

Someone groaned. Someone laughed. But soon, to my surprise, half the saloon - drenched, terrified, holding to columns and to one another - was already playing.

Mrs Aldridge set the first - in English, but the sense was clear without translation:

“‘My first syllable is what a ship does when it sinks. My second is what we are all doing now. And the whole is what we have not got now!’”

“Sink...” the American pondered. “Sink-i... No...”

“Hope!” someone shouted.

“No!” Mrs Aldridge triumphed. “Rest! Rest - that is when a ship sinks, it... well...” She got tangled. “Never mind. My charade was bad. Who is next?”

The saloon roared with laughter - for the first time in three days. Laughed hysterically, to tears, holding to the wet columns, but laughed.

The next to volunteer, to general surprise, was the ship’s cook - a huge, broad-shouldered black man in a white apron, with a gold earring in his ear, who had made his way into the saloon with a cauldron of hot broth which he ladled out to all and sundry without asking what class anyone was. His name was Samuel, but everyone called him Cook Sam.

“I don’t know charades, ma’am,” he said in a deep, rumbling bass. “I know a riddle. A sea one. My grandfather set it to me, and his grandfather to him, there on the islands from where we were all brought.” He paused, and the saloon grew quiet. ““I walk on the sea, but I am not a ship. I burn, but I am not fire. I am seen only in a storm. What am I?””

All were silent. The storm roared beyond the bulkheads.

“A lantern?” suggested the American.

“Lightning,” said the Chevalier.

Cook Sam shook his head - slowly, solemnly. And raised a hand, pointing upward, to the ceiling of the saloon, beyond which were the deck and the masts.

“St Elmo’s fire,” he said. “Dead sailors. Those who drowned but found no peace. They come in a storm and sit on the masts. Glow. Watch. Look for whom to take with them.” He paused. “Last night I saw them. On all six masts. At once.”

No one laughed.

“And whom are they looking for, Sam?” I asked.

The cook looked at me. Long. With a heavy, calm look.

“My grandfather said, sir,” he said, “St Elmo’s fire never takes one who glows himself. They look for those who are in the dark.” He lifted his cauldron and moved on, ladling broth. “You, sir, have nothing to fear. You are yourself like a fire on a mast. I saw.”

\* \* \*

From the crowd at the staircase leading down to the third class came a voice - thin, girlish, trembling. Someone was singing. The saloon gradually quieted, turning toward the sound.

A girl was singing. Quite young, about sixteen, red-haired, in a patched dress and an enormous man's jacket from someone else's shoulders, barefoot, wet to the skin. She stood on a step, holding the handrail, and sang - in a language I did not know - a melody that made the heart contract. Slow, drawn out, sad, with so many repetitions that it seemed the song itself did not want to end.

"Irish," Prokhor whispered. "From the third class. There are seven hundred of them there. Going to America from famine. She came to ask for a doctor for her younger brother. He has a fever."

"What is she singing?"

"I do not know, sir. But they say it is a song of a girl who waited for a sailor on the shore for seven years. And in the eighth he returned - but she did not recognise him, because the sea had changed his face."

The girl finished. The saloon was silent. Then Mrs Aldridge - loud, absurd, gossiping Mrs Aldridge - silently rose, made her way through the water to the stairs, took off her own warm shawl and laid it on the girl's shoulders.

"What is your name, child?"

"Mary, ma'am. Mary Casey."

"Lead me to your brother, Mary Casey," said Mrs Aldridge. "I was a judge's wife for thirty years. I know how to treat a fever better than any ship's doctor." And, turning to the saloon, she commanded: "Cristóbal - someone! Hold the bird! Do not let it pray - it will frighten everyone!"

And went down into the third class, holding the red-haired girl by the hand.

The cage with the parrot was for some reason thrust upon me.

The parrot Cristóbal fixed me with a mad yellow eye. Then tilted his head - and suddenly, quite distinctly, not in Spanish but in some language which I had never heard but which echoed in me with a strange, distant tremor, croaked a single word.

I did not understand it. But it was like - I was for some reason sure of this - a name.

\* \* \*



"He repeats what he heard from the missionary," said a man who had come up to me. "Do not be frightened. Parrots are the best keepers of other people's words. They remember what people have long forgotten."

It was a no longer young, tidy German in spectacles, in a frock coat buttoned on every button, with a barometer in his hands - a real one, in a brass case - at which he glanced as one glances at a watch, awaiting a train.

"Professor Gottfried Altmann," he introduced himself with a brief bow. "Heidelberg. Meteorology. I am going to study American storms." He smiled without mirth. "As you see, the American storm decided to come to me itself, without waiting."

"What does your instrument say, Professor?"

"My instrument," said Altmann, rapping the glass with a nail, "says what cannot be. The pressure has been falling for the fourth day. It is already lower than in any storm I have ever read in records. And records, young man, have been kept on ships for more than a hundred years." He raised his eyes to me. "A century storm, the sailors say. They do not know how right they are. A hundred years. Exactly. I checked the old logs in the captain's library - at this same latitude, on these same days, exactly a hundred years ago, an English frigate vanished. Two hundred men. In a storm described only by two survivors." He paused. "Their description coincides almost word for word with what is happening now."

"A coincidence," I said.

"Naturally," agreed Professor Altmann. "I am a scientist. I believe in coincidences." He rapped the barometer again. "But here is what is curious. One of those two survivors was a Russian. A young nobleman. He travelled with his servant. The records say that he stood on deck through the whole storm and that lightning passed him by. And then, on the last night, he went to the rail - and no one saw him again. The servant was saved. Said afterward that his master had not drowned. That he had 'gone back to where he came from.'"

In the saloon the storm roared. Cristóbal in the cage in my hands was silent, head tilted.

"What was the servant's name?" I asked. My voice sounded strange to me.

“That is not recorded in the log,” said the Professor. “Only initials. ‘P. I.’”

I slowly turned.

Prokhor Ilyich stood by a column three paces from me. Just as imperturbable. Just as calm. And looked at me with the same long, sad look with which he had looked in the cabin.

\* \* \*

We returned to the cabin together. The trunk was still rolling on the floor. The porthole was still black.

I went to the small mirror fastened to the wall of the cabin and peered at my own reflection, swaying in time with the ship. A face like any - tired, haggard from insomnia, but a most ordinary, human face, such as thousands may be met on any Petersburg street. Nothing in it betrayed what I, if the scraps of my own memory were to be believed - and to believe them was growing harder with every day of this accursed storm - had once been.

I unbuttoned the collar of my shirt, drew the cloth aside, baring my shoulders - and ran my fingers over two barely visible, long-healed marks under the shoulder blades, symmetrical, as though left by something that had once been attached precisely there and afterward torn or hacked out by the root. On stormy nights like this these marks ached with a dull, old pain, like wounds healed in the flesh but never healed otherwise. Tonight blood showed on the shirt again. Mrs Aldridge’s laundress had not lied.

“Wings,” I whispered, addressing the reflection rather than Prokhor himself. “It is not merely that I fancy they were? Or am I really going mad, inventing for myself a divine origin in order somehow to justify my own worthlessness?”

“You are not going mad, sir,” answered Prokhor in the same even tone. “You have simply been a man too long. Longer than is safe for anyone born not on earth.”

I turned to him sharply, feeling something inside me - whether hope or irritation or both at once - break out faster than I could master it.

“The Professor said - a hundred years ago. This same storm. A Russian nobleman and his servant. ‘P. I.’” I stepped toward him. “Prokhor. Was it you?”

Prokhor was silent a long time.

“I have crossed this ocean many times, sir,” he said at last. “With you. You do not remember. You never remember.”

“Then tell me! Tell me who I am, if I myself am not able to remember! You remember - you said yourself just now that you remember!”

Prokhor looked at me with a long, sad look - a look with far more human compassion in it than an ordinary servant would have.

“I could tell,” he said quietly. “But this truth, I fear, will not lighten your burden but only double it. You fell to this earth of your own will, many centuries ago - not as punishment, but from curiosity, from thirst to understand what had remained incomprehensible even to you yourself, for all your antiquity and all your strength. You wished to live a human life not from afar, not through the veil of divine omniscience, but from within, with every cell, every nerve, every tear and every joy. And you lived it. Many times. So many that you forgot - and that, sir, is not madness, but simply the price paid by anyone who wears another’s skin too long.”

“The Reverend Crow called me Lucifer,” I said. “Son of the morning. The fallen.”

“The Reverend Crow reads a book that men wrote, sir,” said Prokhor. “And men always write of those who came down to them one of two things: that he is a god or that he is a devil. The middle they do not understand.” He paused. “Do you know what your name means in the language in which it was devised? Not ‘fallen.’ ‘Bearer of light.’ The morning star. The one that rises before the sun, so that people may know: the night is ending.”

I sank down on the edge of the narrow bunk, feeling the earth - or rather the water, the ever-heaving water beneath us - slip from under my feet in a far deeper, far more frightening sense than the simple pitching of a storm.

“And you?” I asked after a long silence. “Who are you, if not a simple servant?”

“I am here to remember for you what you cannot hold yourself,” answered Prokhor simply, with no solemnity in his voice. “And to remind you of it when the time comes. It seems to me, sir, that the time is drawing near.”

\* \* \*

There was a knock at the cabin door - loud, insistent. Prokhor opened.

On the threshold stood Mary Casey - the red-haired Irish girl in Mrs Aldridge’s shawl, barefoot, wet, with enormous frightened eyes. Behind her, holding to the wall, was Mrs Aldridge herself, dishevelled, with sleeves rolled up.

“Count,” said Mrs Aldridge without preamble. “The boy is worse. The ship’s doctor is drunk as a cobbler and says he can do nothing.” She paused. “The boy is delirious. He keeps repeating one thing. Mary says - in Gaelic. Something like ‘bring the bright gentleman.’ Mary thinks this is about you. I think it is nonsense. But I am a judge’s widow, Count. I know: when nothing else is left, one must check even nonsense.”

I followed them down.

The third class was hell. A dark, low hold, packed with people like a barrel with herrings. Swaying lanterns. Water to the knee. Cries, weeping, prayers in a dozen languages. The smell of vomit, wet wool and fear. Seven hundred people who had fled famine for the New World - and found a storm on the way.

The boy lay on a bunk by the very bulkhead - small, about six, red-haired like his sister, with burning cheeks and dry, cracked lips. His eyes were open but looked into nothing. He was whispering something.

I knelt down beside him. Mary said something to him in Gaelic. The boy slowly turned his head - and his eyes, clouded with fever, rested on me.

He smiled.

“You have come,” he said. Not in Gaelic. Not in English. In that very language in which the parrot Cristóbal had croaked his word. In a language I did not know - but which I understood. “I knew you would come. You always come when it is dark.”

I took his hot hand in mine. I do not know why. I simply took it - and held it.

He closed his eyes. His breathing - hoarse, rapid - gradually grew slower. Steadier. After some time which I did not count, Mary, sobbing, touched his forehead - and cried out.

"Cold," she whispered. "Ma'am, he... he is cold... that is... the fever has broken... he is sleeping..."

Mrs Aldridge bent, felt the boy's forehead, then his neck. Straightened. Looked at me. And for the first time since I had known her, said nothing.

I rose. My hand, with which I had held the boy's, burned - as though I had held it over a fire.

As I left, through the hold behind my back, in a whisper, from mouth to mouth, in a dozen languages, ran one and the same word. I did not turn. I did not wish to know which.

\* \* \*

The ship lurched especially hard, and somewhere above, on deck, an alarmed, straining cry was heard - whether of the boatswain giving orders or of the wind itself, which had at last found a crack through which to shout all its fury. I rose from the hold and, saying not another word to Mrs Aldridge, nor to Mary, nor to Prokhor waiting at the stairs, made my way up.

"Sir," Prokhor called after me, for the first time in all this time allowing himself something like anxiety in his voice, "one should not go on deck in such weather."

"I need air," I lied - or did not lie at all, because at that moment I did not myself know for certain what I needed more: air, an answer, or simply deliverance from the unbearable weight of my own body, alien to me.

He did not stop me - perhaps he knew that to restrain me at such a moment was useless, and perhaps he understood something which at that moment I myself did not. A hundred years ago, I thought, climbing the companionway, he probably did not stop me either.

The deck met me with a wall of water and wind that struck me with such force that I barely kept my feet, clinging to the wet, icy rail.

Lightning one after another split the sky over the raging sea, snatching from the darkness the crests of waves rising higher than the funnels themselves - and in this mad, dazzling chaos there was something remotely, frighteningly like freedom. That very freedom which I perhaps had not felt for thousands of years, since the very moment when I first descended to this earth in a guise so alien to my true nature.

On the masts - on all six masts at once - fires burned. Pale, bluish, trembling, like candles in the wind which no wind could blow out. St Elmo's fire. Dead sailors, Cook Sam had said. They look for those who are in the dark.

They did not look at me. They looked at the sea. All, as one. As if awaiting something from there.

By the mainmast, clinging to a rope, stood the Reverend Crow - hatless, grey hair plastered to his skull, the black book pressed to his chest. He saw me. And did not cry out. He simply looked - long, unwaveringly - and his lips moved. I could not hear the words over the roar of the wind. But from the movement of his lips I understood: he was not cursing. He was praying. For me.

I moved along the rail, to where the deck ended, breaking off into the blackness of the raging sea - step by step, whether in search of an answer or in search of an end to all that had accumulated in me over these long, forgotten centuries of human life. What if Prokhor is mistaken? What if there is no fallen grandeur hidden under this weary, haggard human shell - but only a lonely passenger, driven mad by storm and sleeplessness, who has imagined himself something greater than a mere mortal because to admit his own unremarkable madness was simply unbearable for him?

Gone back to where he came from, said the servant a hundred years ago.

I stopped at the very rail, feeling icy spray on my face, feeling the wind tear at my clothes as if trying to strip them off together with the last remnants of the human guise to which I had clung so long and so unsuccessfully. Below, a few feet beneath me, the water roared - black, bottomless, ready to take into itself absolutely anything it was allowed, without a single question, without a single demand for explanations.

I laid my hands on the rail, preparing to throw over it a body so dubiously my own - and in that very instant the world around me froze.

Not time - time flowed on as before, I felt it with every cell of my wind-blown body - but something else, something within the storm itself. The lightning that split the sky at that moment hung for a fraction of a second longer than lightning should hang, pouring over the raging sea a light so even, so unnaturally long, that the very night for a moment seemed day. The fires on all six masts blazed up at once - and turned. All. To me. And the water beneath me, for just one short breath, ceased to obey the wind - froze in a ripple, stood in a wave that neither fell nor moved, as if the element itself held its breath, awaiting my next step with the same tense attention with which I myself awaited the answer to a question never asked aloud.

And in that frozen, glowing silence I heard behind me - very close, quite near - the hoarse, mocking voice of the parrot Cristóbal, who could not possibly have been here, on deck, in the storm. He was repeating that very word. The one. In the language I did not know.

My name.

I almost remembered it.

## Chapter XVI. A Fragment in the Archive

I had done the right thing. I knew I had done the right thing. Nebamun had said: not through the main corridor, the walls have ears, and some of those ears wear bracelets. And I had followed his advice.

But I had not expected it to be so unpleasant.

It happened at the morning audience, two days after the night in the temple granary. The hall was full - petitioners, scribes, dignitaries, guards - and at the very foot of the throne, as always, sat Bakenren, who had come to “humbly remind” me of the Temple’s petition for three thousand hekats for the festival of Opet. He smiled. He bowed. He was so courteous that my jaw ached.

And in the very midst of his courteous speech the doors of the hall opened a crack, and Iti slipped through. With an ink stain on his cheek, with some scrolls under his arm, out of breath - he had evidently run from the Library on an errand for Amenemope. He bowed at the doors and froze, waiting for a sign.

I saw Bakenren’s eyes slide toward him. Swiftly, fleetingly, the way a lizard’s glance slides over a fly. I saw the bracelets chime by the far column - Khaemuas, who stood there among the commanders, had turned his head.

“Who allowed you to enter during an audience?” I said. Loudly. Coldly. As I had never spoken to him before. “Scribes of the Library have no business in the throne room. If Amenemope has a matter for Pharaoh, let him send a messenger. Go.”

The hall fell silent. Bakenren raised his brows slightly - with interest.

Iti stood frozen in the doorway. His face - I could see it even across the whole hall - first went pale, then flared red to the very roots of his hair. He opened his mouth as if to say something. Closed it. Bowed -



low, awkwardly, so that the scrolls nearly slipped from under his arm - and went out without raising his eyes.

The doors closed behind him.

"Young people these days have no notion of their place, my Pharaoh," Bakenren remarked sweetly. "In my years a scribe did not dare to breathe in the presence of a living god."

"Continue, Bakenren," I said evenly. "You were speaking of piety."

He continued. I did not hear a word. I looked at the closed doors and felt as though I had just struck a dog that had been running to me, wagging its tail.

\* \* \*

He did not come that evening, nor the next.

The note from Pentu - the first one, with a copy of the true inventory of the granaries of Heliopolis - was brought to me not by Iti but by the boy Paney. He came into my chambers late in the evening, when I had already dismissed the servants - came in through the door to the garden, barefoot, with a bandaged hand in which a tightly rolled papyrus was clutched.

"From Iti, my Pharaoh," he said, holding out the scroll. And he added, with that directness with which only children and old men speak: "He did not come himself. He said - let Pharaoh not have to see him more than necessary. Since it is unpleasant for him."

"He said that?"

"He said exactly that, my Pharaoh." Paney hesitated, shifting his bare feet. "He said a good many other things too. Only they are not for Pharaoh."

"Tell me anyway."

Paney looked at me gravely, weighing whether he should.

"He said: 'Nebamun said - not through the main corridor. And Pharaoh, it turns out, has decided - not at all.'" The boy sniffed. "And he said that a scribe of the Library is, of course, nobody and nothing. And that he, of course, knows his place. And that his place is among the dusty scrolls where nobody goes. And that he is happy there." Paney paused. "Only he said it, my Pharaoh, the way people say things when they are not happy."

I was silent for a long time. Paney waited.

“Paney,” I said at last. “You are his pupil. Tell me honestly. Was he hurt?”

Paney thought. Then he nodded - slowly, thoroughly, as Senusret nods.

“Very, my Pharaoh. He spent half the night copying the same scroll. Three times. And three times he spoiled it. Amenemope said that in twenty years he had never seen Iti spoil a scroll. And today Iti deliberately scattered all my potsherds with letters, and then gathered them up himself and apologized.” The boy spread his hands. “He is like my father, my Pharaoh, when Mama was angry with him. He drops everything.”

I could not help it - I smiled. Paney, seeing this, seemed to relax.

“Paney,” I said. “Pass something on to him. Not a note - by word of mouth. Say: the walls have ears. The garden does not. And Pharaoh, too, sometimes walks in the garden.”

Paney pondered, moving his lips, memorizing. Then he nodded.

“I will pass it on, my Pharaoh.” And at the door he turned: “May I ask a riddle? Iti gave it to me and I cannot solve it. Perhaps you can?”

“Go on.”

“Who speaks without a mouth? Who remembers without a heart? Who lives a thousand years, yet dies from a single drop of water?”

I thought.

“A scroll,” I said. “Papyrus. It speaks without a mouth - by what is written. It remembers without a heart - everything that is recorded in it. It lives a thousand years in a dry storehouse - but a single drop of water washes the ink away.”

Paney stared at me with admiration.

“Iti said you would solve it,” he said. “He said: ‘Pharaoh solves everything. Except what is right under his nose.’” And before I could ask what that meant, he darted out into the garden.

\* \* \*

The gossip was brought the next morning by Nefret - the senior woman over the palace servants, a woman of enormous size, with a voice like a temple trumpet and a memory which, by common opinion, held

more information about palace affairs than all the scrolls of the Library. She came herself - supposedly to check whether my linen garments had been properly laundered - and as she checked, she talked without pause.

"...and the keeper of the seal's wife has borne a girl again, the fifth, my Pharaoh, and now he goes about blacker than a storm cloud, says the gods are laughing at him... and the cook from the kitchen quarrelled with the baker over whose leaven is better, and now they are not speaking, and the bread, mind you, is suffering... and the nomarch Ankhtifi has sent a bearskin as a gift for the hall, and we have never had bears here, so everyone is wondering where he got it..."

I listened with half an ear, trying not to betray my impatience.

"...and another thing, my Pharaoh," Nefret lowered her trumpet voice to what she herself must have considered a whisper but which could in fact be heard in the neighbouring chambers, "they say that the junior keeper of the Library, that boy, Iti, goes to the temple garden at night. Not alone. He has been seen with a young priestess. The big-eyed one. Khemu. By the pond. Whispering, they say. Passing something to each other." She pursed her lips meaningfully. "Well, they are young. Priestesses, of course, are not supposed to. But who can hold them back when it is spring?"

I froze with the cup in my hand.

Something pricked me - somewhere under the ribs, but not on the left, where the familiar cold lived, but on the right, in a place entirely new and unknown. Swift, sharp, like the prick of a fish bone. And at once it let go.

Of course they meet by the pond. Of course they whisper and pass things - I myself had told Khemu to send word through Iti. He carries the notes. He does exactly what I asked. No spring. No "they are young."

I knew this. And yet for several moments, while Nefret, noticing nothing, went on about the bearskin, I sat motionless and listened to that strange, swift prick - trying to understand what it was.

Concern for them, I decided. If Nefret knows - then the whole court knows. Then Bakenren knows. Then Khemu is in danger. And Iti. That was what it was. Alarm. Simply alarm for two people who are helping me.

Of course.

"Nefret," I said. "And who else is talking about this?"

“Oh, my Pharaoh,” she waved her plump hands, “everyone! The laundresses. The water-carriers. The gardeners. They even say that one of the men of the honourable Khaemuas asked the gardener whether the boy goes to the pond often.” She giggled. “Perhaps he is jealous too.”

I set down the cup.

“Nefret. When you speak with the laundresses - tell them this. The junior keeper of the Library is, by my order, collecting ancient inscriptions for the temple pond. From the garden walls. For copying. The priestess shows him where they are. That is all.”

Nefret gave me a long, shrewd, not at all foolish look.

“Inscriptions,” she said. “From the walls. At night.” She nodded. “Of course, my Pharaoh. I shall say so. The laundresses will believe it.” She gathered up the garments. “The water-carriers too. But the gardeners...” She shrugged her mighty shoulders. “The gardeners, my Pharaoh, know there are no inscriptions on the walls of the temple garden. But I shall tell them there are. The gardeners are afraid of me.”

She left. I looked after her for a long time and thought that perhaps I had underestimated the palace servants.

\* \* \*

He came to the garden on the third night.

I was waiting for him by the old fig tree at the far end of the garden, where the wall was overgrown with jasmine so thickly that a whole chariot could have been hidden behind it. The moon was thin, almost invisible, and the garden lay in darkness full of scents - jasmine, damp earth, the blooming lotus in the little pond - and of sounds: cicadas, the distant barking of a dog in the city, the rustle of the night wind in the palm leaves.

He appeared soundlessly, as he always did - I heard him only when he was already standing three paces away, at the very jasmine. In his hands was not a scroll but something wrapped in a piece of coarse linen. He pressed it to his chest with both hands, the way one holds a small child or a very fragile thing.

“My Pharaoh,” he said, and bowed. Correctly. Precisely. Coldly. The way one bows not to a man but to a throne.

“Iti,” I said.

He straightened and looked at me. Not in the eyes - slightly higher, at my forehead, as scribes are taught to look when they speak with exalted persons.

"You are angry with me," I said.

"A scribe of the Library does not dare to be angry with Pharaoh, my Pharaoh," he answered in an even voice, as if reading from a scroll. "Pharaoh was right. Scribes of the Library have no business in the throne room. I know my place."

"Iti."

"My place is among the scrolls, my Pharaoh. Where it is dusty and nobody goes. I am happy there."

"Iti, look at me."

He hesitated - and looked. And in the darkness, in the thin light of the almost invisible moon, I saw that his eyes were shining.

"Bakenren was in the hall," I said quietly. "Khaemuas stood by the column. They both looked at you when you came in. The way one looks at a new piece on the board - calculating where to move it. I could not allow them to see that you are to me..." I faltered. "That you are important to me. Nebamun said: the walls have ears. I made sure the ears heard that the boy from the Library is nobody. So that they would stop looking at you."

Iti was silent.

"I did not think," I said, "that you would hear it too. And believe it too."

He was silent a long while. Then he lowered his eyes - to the bundle he was pressing to his chest.

"Paney passed it on to me," he said softly, no longer like a scribe but in his own voice. "About the ears. And about the garden." He paused. "For two days I thought that you... that Pharaoh..."

"That what?"

"Nothing, my Pharaoh." He suddenly smiled - crookedly, awkwardly, as if he had forgotten how in these days. "Paney said that you solved the riddle about the scroll."

"I did."

"I set it on purpose," said Iti. "I knew you would solve it. I wanted..." He faltered. "I wanted you to think about something connected with me, at least once. Even if it was only a riddle."

I found nothing to answer. On his cheek, in the thin moonlight, a stain showed dark - ink, as always. I raised my hand, not knowing why, and wiped it away with my thumb. Simply wiped it away. The way one wipes a smudge from a younger brother's face.

Iti went utterly still. He seemed to have stopped breathing.

"You always have ink on your face," I said, lowering my hand. "How do you manage it?"

"I... rub my cheek when I think, my Pharaoh," he whispered. "With the brush. I forget it is in my hand."

"So you think a great deal."

"A great deal, my Pharaoh," said Iti. And after a pause he added, so quietly that I barely heard: "Especially these last two days."

Somewhere in the garden a night bird cried out. Iti started, as if waking, and hurriedly held out the bundle to me.

"That is not why I came, my Pharaoh. That is... not only why. Here. I found this. In the lower storehouse. Yesterday." His voice was businesslike again, quick, but his fingers, unwrapping the linen, trembled slightly. "I have shown it to no one. Not even Amenemope. Because..." He raised his eyes to me. "Because, my Pharaoh, I think it is what the High Priest is looking for."

\* \* \*

Hardly anyone ever went down to the lower storehouse of the Library, Iti told me, while by the light of a small clay lamp, which he had taken from his bosom and lit from a flint, I examined his find. Into the lower storehouse they carried what was considered spoiled: scrolls gnawed by mice, washed out by water, scorched in some old fire, cracked tablets, shards of clay tablets with half-effaced signs. What is written may not be thrown away - that is sacrilege, the word of Thoth cannot be thrown away - so all of it was put into huge clay jars, sealed, and set in rows in an underground vault where it was dry, dark, and smelled of mice and eternity.

Over this subterranean kingdom ruled old Isiret - one of the few women scribes at court, dry as a stick, with a face like a crumpled papyrus, a tongue sharp as a reed brush, and a memory which, according to Iti, was more terrible than any archive.

“She drove me out,” Iti told me while I looked at the papyrus. “On the first day. She said that the boys of the upper Library know only how to copy beautiful scrolls for Pharaoh, and do not want to do the real work - sorting what the mice have devoured. I said that I wanted to. She looked at me and said: ‘Very well. Here is a jar for you. No one has been in it for three hundred years. Sort it out. If you find even one whole line, I will kiss you.’” Iti blushed. “I did not, of course, want her to kiss me. She is a hundred years old and has three teeth. But I sorted it out.”

“And you found it?”

“I found it, my Pharaoh.” He pointed to the papyrus in my hands. “This. At the very bottom of the jar. Wrapped in leather. The leather had almost rotted away, and the papyrus had not. As though someone had hidden it on purpose among the refuse. Where no one would look.”

The papyrus was small - two palms long, one wide. Its edges were frayed, one corner was eaten away as if by mice, but the middle had survived remarkably well. And on it were signs.

Not ours.

Not hieroglyphs, not the cursive of the priests, not the counting marks of the scribes. Long, flowing, curving lines, running one into another without breaks, with no clear boundary between the signs - like water pouring over stone. Like the trace a retreating wave leaves on the sand.

I had never seen such writing. I was certain that I had never seen it.

And yet, looking at it, I felt something pass through the fingers that held the papyrus, from the fingertips to the wrist - neither warmth nor cold - something like recognition. The very feeling one has on hearing a melody known long ago, when one has forgotten where it was heard.

“My Pharaoh?” Iti asked quietly. “Can you... can you read it?”

“No,” I said. “I cannot. But...”

“But?”

I did not answer. I looked at the signs, and it seemed to me - this was, of course, a trick of the lamp, of the thin, trembling flame - that the lines on the papyrus were faintly stirring. Not changing - no. Simply as if breathing. Like a sleeping beast.

\* \* \*

“That is not all,” said Iti. “Turn it over.”

I turned it over.

On the reverse side, in the very corner, there was an inscription. Small, faded almost to invisibility. In our signs. Ancient, angular ones, such as were written under the very first Pharaohs - but ours.

Iti bent to the lamp beside me, so close that I could feel the warmth of his shoulder, and read aloud, slowly, moving his finger along the signs:

“‘Words of the First Ones. Sent down from the Heavens together with the Two Eyes. Do not read. Do not show. Keep until the appointed time.’”

Keep until the appointed time.

I read it again. Then once more. The words were ordinary - the most ordinary words, such as are written on jars of grain and on chests of dowry. Keep until the appointed time.

But somewhere inside me - very far away, as if many days' journey down the river, or many years, or something else entirely that had no name - these words resounded as though spoken by someone I knew. Someone who held in his hand a similar scrap of paper - not papyrus but paper, thin, white, such as is not made among us. On a narrow, sun-flooded street. In a strange city smelling of the sea and of spices.

I blinked. The vision - if it was a vision - vanished.

“There is a drawing as well,” said Iti. “Under the inscription. Very pale.”

I brought the papyrus right up to the flame. Beneath the ancient signs there was indeed a drawing - thin, faded, almost wiped away. Two circles. One filled in. The other empty. And between them a wavy line.

“The Two Eyes,” Iti whispered. “Black and white. And a road between them. Or a river.”

We sat crouching under the jasmine, shoulder to shoulder, bent over a small scrap of papyrus that had lain at the bottom of a jar of refuse for three hundred years - and said nothing. The cicadas sang. The lamp crackled.

“Iti,” I said at last. “Who else knows?”

“No one, my Pharaoh. Isiret saw that I had found something, but I said it was just a scrap of a prayer. She believed me.” He paused. “I think she believed me.”



“You think?”

“Isiret never shows whether she believes or not, my Pharaoh. She says that belief is for priests, and for scribes there is only verification.”

\* \* \*

We heard footsteps - light, quick - and both of us started. Iti blew out the lamp. I thrust the papyrus into my bosom.

From behind the fig tree came Khemu. Without a lamp, in a dark cloak over her white priestess's robes, breathless, her hair disordered.

“Iti!” she whispered, not at once making me out in the darkness. “Iti, trouble, Bakenren...” And then she saw me. She froze. She fell to her knees. “My... my Pharaoh!”

“Rise. What has happened?”

“Bakenren,” Khemu gasped, getting up. “This evening he came to the Library. To Amenemope. He demanded the Most Ancient Epic. Again. The fourth time this moon. And then...” She caught her breath. “Then he asked about the lower storehouse. He asked who works there. Amenemope said - old Isiret. And the boy. Iti. Bakenren asked what the boy was looking for there. Amenemope said - sorting spoiled scrolls. Bakenren said: ‘How interesting. I should like to see what he has already sorted.’ And he ordered that tomorrow at dawn Isiret show him all the jars the boy has opened.”

Iti turned so white that it was visible even in the dark.

“How do you know?” I asked.

“Merit heard,” said Khemu. “She was in the Library - she had come for a scroll of hymns. She told me to run and warn you. She said: ‘Little bird, run to the boy. The fox has gone to the henhouse.’”

“The jar,” Iti whispered. “I left the jar open. And the leather the papyrus was wrapped in. It is there, at the bottom. If Bakenren sees it...”

“He will understand that something was there,” I finished.

The three of us stood under the jasmine in the darkness, and no one said a word.

\* \* \*

“Isiret,” Iti said at last. “We must go to Isiret. Now.”

"She will betray you," said Khemu.

"Perhaps," said Iti. "And perhaps not. I do not know whose side she is on. No one knows. But she is the only one who can make sure Bakenren finds nothing."

"I will go with you," I said.

They both stared at me.

"My Pharaoh," said Khemu. "If you are seen in the lower storehouse at night..."

"If I am seen with you in the temple garden at night, it will be worse," I said. "The palace is already whispering that you two meet by the pond." I paused. "That you, Iti, go to Khemu because of the spring."

Iti choked. Khemu snorted - nervously, briefly - and at once clapped her palm over her mouth.

"To me?" she repeated. "Him?" She looked at Iti, then at me, and something mischievous, quite girlish, flickered in her huge, kohl-rimmed eyes. "My Pharaoh, with all respect - Iti does not go to the garden for me. Iti goes to the garden..." She broke off, looked at Iti, who stood red as a crab, and finished in quite a different tone: "...for the inscriptions. From the walls. For copying."

"Nefret has already told the laundresses so," I nodded.

"Nefret?" Khemu raised her brows. "My Pharaoh, if Nefret is on your side, you have no need of an army."

Iti, still red, muttered something under his breath. I did not catch what. But it seemed to me - quite absurdly, at such a moment - that I felt lighter. There, on the right, under the ribs, where two days ago it had pricked.

\* \* \*

The lower storehouse lay beneath the Library - a narrow stair hewn in the rock descended into the darkness, and with each step the air grew drier, cooler, and heavier with the smell of dust, mouse droppings, and old, very old papyrus. Below stretched a long corridor, and along it, in niches, stood rows of jars - huge, man-high, sealed with clay, with signs scratched on their sides: the year, the storehouse, "spoiled by water," "spoiled by fire," "spoiled by mice."

At the end of the corridor a lamp was burning. And beside it, on a low stool, sat an old woman.

Isiret was exactly as Iti had described her - only more terrible. Small, shrivelled, almost bodiless, in a dark robe, with a face so densely furrowed that it looked like a map of all the roads of the Valley, and with eyes - black, shining, alive - that in the lamplight seemed two drops of ink on old papyrus. Before her on a mat lay potsherds, and she, without raising her head, was fitting them together like a mosaic - piece to piece, sign to sign.

"You took your time, boy," she said without turning. "I thought you would come running as soon as Bakenren left. And you have, I see, brought guests besides." At last she turned her head. She looked at Khemu. At me. She held her gaze on me - long, appraising, without the slightest reverence. "Ah. Himself. A living god. In a cellar. With the mice." She snorted. "Well, then. The gods, they say, are everywhere. Even in spoiled jars."

Khemu gasped. Iti turned pale. I did not know whether to laugh or be angry - and Isiret, it seems, read this on my face, for her three teeth flashed in a smile.

"Sit down, living god," she said, nodding at the next jar. "I have no stools. Kings do not come here. Except once in three hundred years."

"Once in three hundred years?" I repeated.

"And you think you are the first?" Isiret bent again over her potsherds. "The jar the boy opened was sealed by a scribe named Hekanakht son of Pepi. I read his seal. He was keeper of this vault three hundred years ago. Under a Pharaoh whose name has been erased from half the walls of the Valley." She fitted one sherd to another. "And in the scroll of Merira son of Pepi, which lies over there in the third jar from the stair, it is written that one night Pharaoh himself came down into the storehouse. Alone. Without guards. And brought something wrapped in leather. And ordered it hidden where no one would look. 'Until the appointed time,' he said."

It grew so quiet in the vault that I could hear a mouse scratching somewhere in the darkness behind the jars.

"Which Pharaoh?" I asked.

"The one whose name was erased," said Isiret. "I told you." She raised her black, shining eyes to me. "Hekanakht son of Pepi writes that

Pharaoh was young. That he came down here on the eve of a journey south. To the festival. In Luxor.” She paused. “And that he did not return from the festival. Or rather - he returned. But different. He looked through people. As if he saw something else behind them.”

Paser. The council of commanders. The old legend that is told in whispers.

The cold under the ribs - on the left, familiar, known - rose so swiftly that it took my breath away.

\* \* \*

“Bakenren will come at dawn,” said Isiret, returning to her potsherds. “He wants to see the jars the boy opened. Very well. I shall show him.” She nodded to Iti. “Boy, go to the fifth jar from the stair. The one ‘spoiled by water.’ There is a scroll of grain accounts from the time of some long-forgotten Pharaoh. Of no use to anyone. Sodden. Bring it. And the leather from your jar, too.”

Iti ran. He came back with the sodden scroll and a rotted piece of leather. Isiret, without looking, wrapped the scroll in the leather, tied it with a scrap of cord, and threw it into the jar from which Iti had taken the papyrus.

“There,” she said. “Tomorrow Bakenren will see that the boy found in the jar, wrapped in leather, an account of grain. Sodden. Useless. In front of him I shall unwrap it, show it, grumble at the boy for wasting his time on refuse. Bakenren will laugh and leave. Priests like to laugh at scribes. It consoles them.”

“Why are you helping us?” I asked.

Isiret did not answer for a long time. She fitted potsherds together.

“Do you know a riddle, living god?” she said at last. “An old one. It is asked only in this cellar. ‘Which is stronger - the one who writes, or the one who erases?’”

I thought.

“The one who erases. He can destroy what is written.”

“Wrong.” Isiret set the last sherd in place - and the sherds on the mat suddenly came together into a whole sign. An Eye. “Stronger is the one who remembers. What is erased can be remembered. What is written can be forgotten. And the one who remembers is stronger than both. I

remember everything that lies in this cellar, living god. Every jar. Every potsherd. Twenty years. And I remember that the High Priest has never come down here. Not once. Until today. And today he came down - and the first thing he asked about was the boy. So he knows there is something here that he did not find in the Epic. And if the High Priest is searching so hard for something, it is better that he not find it."

She paused.

"And besides," she added, unexpectedly gently, "the boy sorted my jar. The whole of it. In a single night. Which no one had touched for three hundred years." She looked at Iti, and her wrinkled face suddenly became almost tender. "I promised him a kiss for one whole line."

Iti stepped back a pace, turning pale.

"Do not be afraid, boy." Isiret giggled - dryly, with a rattle. "Three teeth are all I have left. I shall save the kiss for someone who needs it more." She moved her black eyes from Iti to me and back - once, swiftly, the way one shifts one's gaze from one line to another, checking that it has been copied correctly. "For someone who will wipe the ink from your cheek. Otherwise you go about like a spotted cat."

Iti turned crimson. Khemu, standing by the stair, turned to the wall - and her shoulders shook.

I looked at old Isiret and thought that in all the palace there seemed to be not a single person who did not see more than he showed.

\* \* \*

We climbed the stair in silence. At the exit from the vault, in the darkness of the Library, Khemu touched my hand.

"My Pharaoh," she whispered. "That inscription. 'Keep until the appointed time.' I have seen it before."

"Where?"

"On a chest. The one of black wood. In the treasury. On the lid, from the inside." She swallowed. "I did not understand then what it was. I thought they were just words. And now..."

She did not finish. We both knew what she had wanted to say.

Iti walked with me as far as the garden. At the fig tree, under the jasmine, he stopped.

"My Pharaoh," he said. "The papyrus. What will you do with it?"

I touched my chest, where under my garment the bundle lay.

"Keep it," I said. "Until the appointed time."

Iti nodded. He stood a little longer. Then he said - very quietly, looking not at me but at the jasmine:

"My Pharaoh. When you said 'go' in the hall... For two days I thought I would never come again."

"And you came."

"And I came," he agreed. "Because I found the papyrus. And I thought: Pharaoh needs this. Even if Pharaoh does not need me."

"Iti," I said.

He raised his eyes to me.

I did not know what to say. I - Pharaoh, living god, lord of the Two Lands - stood under the jasmine in the darkness before the junior keeper of the Library with his perpetual ink stain on his cheek, and did not know what to say. Every word that came to my mind was either too large or too small.

"Come tomorrow," I said at last. "Through the garden. Bring me another riddle."

He smiled - truly, for the first time in these days, so that it could be seen even in the dark.

"Which one, my Pharaoh?"

"Any. One that I cannot solve."

"There is no such one," said Iti. "Paney says you solve everything."

"Paney says that you said: except what is right under my nose."

Iti froze. Then he blushed - so that it showed even in the light of the thin moon - muttered something unintelligible, bowed - awkwardly, hurriedly, not at all like a scribe - and vanished behind the jasmine so fast that it was as though all the crocodiles of the Nile were after him.

I stood alone under the fig tree, pressing to my chest the papyrus on which was written what I could not read, and words that I somehow knew. Keep until the appointed time.

And I thought not of Bakenren. Not of the High Priest. Not of the Pharaoh whose name had been erased from half the walls of the Valley and who three hundred years ago had descended into the vault on the eve of the festival at Luxor.

I thought of what exactly Iti had meant when he said: except what is right under his nose.

And of why I so wanted to solve it.

\* \* \*

When I returned to my chambers, old Amenemope was waiting for me at the doors - for the first time in all the time I had known him, risen by himself in the night from the Library. He stood leaning on his black staff and looked at me with the same faded, all-seeing gaze with which all the old men of this palace had looked at me today.

"My Pharaoh," he said. "The boy found something below. I know. I do not ask what." He paused. "I have come to tell you a tale. An old one. It was told to me when I was like Iti. About the god Thoth and Pharaoh."

"Now? At night?"

"Tales, my Pharaoh, are better heard at night," said Amenemope. "By day they seem untrue."

I let him in. He sat on the bench by the window, laid his staff across his knees, and began to speak - slowly, quietly, the way one tells a story looking not at the listener but into one's own memory:

"Once the god Thoth, lord of writing, came to the Pharaoh who ruled in Thebes and brought him his inventions. Number. The measuring of land. The stars. The game of senet. And writing. "Here," said Thoth, "is writing. It will make the Egyptians wiser and strengthen their memory. I have found a remedy for memory." But Pharaoh shook his head. "O most skilful Thoth," he said, "you, the father of writing, out of love for it ascribe to it a power opposite to the one it has. Writing will not strengthen memory - it will weaken it. People, having learned to write, will cease to exercise their memory. They will remember not from within, but from without - by the signs of others. You have found a remedy not for memory but for reminding.""

Amenemope fell silent.

"And what did Thoth do?" I asked.

"The tale does not say, my Pharaoh," answered the old man. "But writing remained. And since then we keep scrolls instead of remembering." He rose, leaning on his staff. "I think of this tale each time I see a man who does not remember himself. Perhaps he need not look for the scroll on which his name is written. Perhaps he needs to remember from within."

He bowed and went to the door.

“Amenemope,” I said after him. “Do you see a man who does not remember himself?”

The old man stopped in the doorway. Turned.

“Every day, my Pharaoh,” he said. “Every day since you ascended the throne.” And, after a pause: “Do not be afraid. The boy from the Library remembers a great deal for you. More than you think.”

He left, tapping with his staff.

And I sat by the window until morning, holding on my knees the papyrus that had lain for three hundred years among the refuse, waiting for its appointed time. And when the first ray of the sun fell on its edge, it seemed to me - for only an instant - that the flowing, incomprehensible signs on it had come together into a word. One single word.

But the sun rose higher - and the word melted away like breath on glass.



## Chapter XVII. A Walk to Sultanahmet

The appointed day arrived as imperceptibly as the previous ones had slipped by - in a lazy alternation of tea, backgammon with Suleyman (I won, to my own astonishment, some five games off him, though the old man insisted that the victory had been granted me out of pure hospitality), and long hours on the balcony, where I looked at the city, which was beginning little by little to grow familiar to me, in the way any place grows familiar if one spends enough sleepless, watchful evenings in it.

Suleyman appeared on the threshold of my room early in the morning - clad not in his house robe but in a stout travelling kaftan, girded with a wide sash into which was tucked a short knife with a carved handle, more a keepsake than a weapon. On his wrist, over his prayer beads, the red thread with half of the split nazar was still wound. He nodded to me in silence, making it clear: it was time.

"He says," translated Ferhat, who had sprung up behind his back, dishevelled, with hair still wet from washing and a piece of flatbread in his hand, "that we shall go by the same way the stranger took, the one his father saw. He remembers the way. His father told him. Step by step."

"And you?" I asked. "Aren't you due on shift?"

"I am," said Ferhat with his mouth full. "But I told the harbour master that my aunt had died."

"Your aunt has died?"

"I have no aunt," Ferhat replied imperturbably. "So she can die as many times as she likes. This year she has already died three times. The harbour master sent a basket of figs to the funeral." He grinned. "God will forgive. God loves it when people help guests."

Suleyman, who had not understood a word but had evidently guessed everything from the intonation, rapped his grandson on the back of the head with his knuckles - not hard, more for form's sake - and we went out.

\* \* \*

We left the house when the sun had barely torn itself from the edge of the sea and the air still kept the coolness of the night, that peculiar, short-lived freshness which port cities grant their inhabitants for only an hour or two before the heat enters fully into its rights. The streets, which at this hour were usually thronged with peddlers and the first customers, now seemed almost deserted - only a few figures hurried somewhere on their business in the morning dusk, and the cats, those eternal, imperturbable masters of Eastern cities, stretched lazily on steps still warm from the evening.

At the gate Kemal caught up with us. Silently, as always. He stood beside his grandfather and walked on as though it had been agreed. Suleyman looked at him, was about to say something - and did not. He only laid his palm on the boy's head, for a moment, in passing, and under that palm Kemal smiled faintly.

Akmal, of course, did not catch up with anyone - he simply flew out from around the corner, overtook all three of us and raced ahead like a dog let off its leash, turning round every so often to check that we were following.

"He will wait for us at every crossroads," Ferhat sighed. "And at every crossroads he will ask whether it is soon. Like when we were children and went to the sea."

"Did you often go to the sea?"

"Every Sunday. With our father." Ferhat paused. "He would take Akmal on his shoulders and me by the hand. Kemal did not walk yet then - Mother carried him on her back. Father used to say: 'Look at the water. The water remembers everyone who has gone out over it. If you look long enough, you can see.'" He shrugged. "Akmal still looks. Every day. He thinks I don't know."

He said it lightly, as if in passing. But I saw him turn away before he had finished.

Our way ran along the coast - first through quarters already familiar to me from short outings with Akmal, then farther, where the houses grew higher and more imposing, and the streets noticeably cleaner, as though a different, more exacting part of the city breathed the very air here. Suleyman walked unhurriedly but with assurance, in the stride of a man for whom this road had long become something habitual, though not devoid, judging by the way he glanced about from time to time, of a certain reverence for the places passed.

From time to time he stopped - at a fountain, at an old grove of plane trees, at a small mosque with a leaning minaret - and said something, pointing with his hand. Ferhat translated:

"Here the stranger drank water. Father saw it. He scooped it in his palm, drank, and laughed. He said: 'The same water as everywhere. Water is one everywhere.'" And then, at the grove: "Here he sat down in the shade and wrote something. For a long time. Father stood by a shop and watched. Then the stranger got up, and on the ground where he had sat a drawing was left, made with a stick. Two circles. Father came to look - but the wind had already wiped it away."

Kemal, hearing this, stopped at the roots of a huge plane tree. He crouched down. Ran his palm over the ground as if searching for something. Then he rose and went on, saying nothing.

We passed a hill from whose summit the whole bay opened to view - I stopped for a moment, unable to tear my eyes from the water, which reflected the morning sun with that dazzling, almost painful brightness that occurs only over the sea in a windless hour. The minarets scattered across the whole visible expanse seemed from here like thin needles stuck into the bluish haze, and the domes of the mosques like frozen drops of mercury, heavy and perfect in their roundness.

"Beautiful," I said aloud, though I was addressing, essentially, only myself.

"Grandfather says," said Ferhat, "that this view has no price. He traded for forty years and knows the price of everything. Silk, pepper, people. But not of this. He says: that is why everyone stays here. They come for a day - and stay for life. The city keeps those it likes."

"And those it does not like?"

“Those it lets go,” said Ferhat. “At once. With the first ship.” He smiled. “It has not let you go yet.”

\* \* \*

Descending the hill, we passed a place fenced off with scaffolding and high hoardings of fresh planks - judging by the hammering that carried from there and the calling of workmen in several languages at once, this was where the new Palace of the Sultan was being raised, of which I had heard almost from the first minute of my stay in this city. The building itself, not yet finished, already astonished by its scale - the walls, faced with pale stone, stretched along the whole shore, vanishing somewhere around the bend, and the dome of the central part, still hidden by scaffolding, could be guessed beneath it as a gigantic, half-formed shadow.

At the gate of the building site, on an overturned wheelbarrow, sat a mason - elderly, grey-moustached, with hands white from dust - smoking a long pipe and waiting until the overseer turned away. Suleyman, passing by, stopped, and they exchanged a few phrases - judging by the tone, old acquaintances. The mason burst out laughing, slapped his knees and said something, pointing with his pipe at the palace.

“What does he say?” I asked.

Ferhat was choking with laughter.

“He says he has been building this palace for eight years. And that in eight years the Sultan has changed the architect three times and the plan seven times. And that when the palace is finally finished, the Sultan will probably say he wanted something completely different and order it pulled down.” Ferhat wiped his eyes. “And Grandfather answered that this is a good thing: while they are building, people have bread. Better to build for ten years than to finish in one and dismiss everyone.”

“Grandfather does not like this building site,” he added, lowering his voice, though there seemed to be no reason for such caution. “He says too much money goes into stone and too little into people. But it is better not to repeat that aloud.”

The mason, seeing us off, suddenly called out to me - in his own tongue, but with an evident question, pointing his pipe first at me, then at the palace.

“He asks,” translated Ferhat, “whether you are an architect. A new one. The fourth. He says you have the face of a man who is about to redo everything.”

I laughed. The mason laughed too, waved his pipe - and at once, noticing the overseer, hid it behind his back with the air of an innocent babe.

\* \* \*

Beyond the building site began the quarter of Sultanahmet proper - and here the city changed almost imperceptibly, yet quite definitely. The streets grew narrower, the houses older, and the stillness that reigned in this part of the city even at the height of the morning seemed somehow special, almost reverent, as if the very air here were soaked with the memory of centuries that had passed before even one of us was born.

And then the street parted - and we came out onto a huge, elongated square across which the wind roamed.

In the middle of it, one after another, stood three columns. The first was thin, tall, grey, built of rough stone blocks, as if it had been put up in haste and never been faced. The second was strange, dark, of bronze, like three snakes twisted together into a tight rope - only without heads: where the snakes should have had heads, the column broke off in uneven, broken edges. And the third...

The third was an obelisk.

Tall, slender, sharp as a needle, of rose granite, gleaming in the morning sun as if it had just been taken from the quarry. It stood on a marble pedestal, resting on it not with its base but on four small copper cubes at the corners - as though it hovered in the air, barely touching the ground. And from the very point to the base, on all four faces, it was covered with signs.

Birds. Eyes. Snakes. Beetles. Little men squatting on their haunches. Wavy lines of water. Solar discs.

I stopped. I stopped so abruptly that Kemal, who was walking behind, ran into my back.

“What is this?” I asked. My voice sounded hoarse.

“An Egyptian stone,” said Ferhat. “It was brought from Egypt. Long ago. Very long ago. More than a thousand years ago, when there were

still Greek kings here. They say it was twice as tall, but it broke in transport, and only the upper part was set up here.” He shrugged. “Grandfather says nobody in the world can read what is written on it. Those signs have been forgotten.”

I came closer. The wind stirred the skirts of my cloak. The pouch at my belt - I felt it at once - had grown heavier. Not warmer. Heavier. As at the Column of Constantine. As in that dream of the columns, on the first day.

I raised my eyes to the signs. And among the birds, snakes and suns I saw one - quite small, high up, almost at the very point. An eye. A human eye, lined with a long stroke, with a curl beneath it like a tear.

I did not know this sign. I had never seen it. But I knew - knew as firmly as I knew that my feet stood on the ground - that it was an eye which had once been torn out, torn into pieces, and then put together again.

“Misafir?” Ferhat touched my elbow. “You have gone pale.”

I did not answer. Kemal stood beside me, head thrown back, looking where I was looking - at the eye by the point of the obelisk. Then he slowly raised his hand and pointed at it with a finger. Then at my belt, at the pouch. Then again at the eye.

“He says,” Ferhat translated uncertainly, though Kemal had not said a word, “I don’t know what he says.”

Suleyman, standing a little apart, looked at the three of us - at the obelisk, at me, at his grandson with his raised hand - and told his beads. Click. Click. Click.

“Father,” he said at last, quietly, and Ferhat translated after him, “used to say: the stranger also stood here. For a long time. By this stone. And wept.” Suleyman paused. “Father thought - from the sun. Here there is always wind and sun. Eyes water.”

I passed my palm over my face. The palm was wet.

“Here there is always wind,” I said. “Eyes water.”

“Yes,” agreed Suleyman, and there was not a drop of doubt in his voice. “Wind.”

\* \* \*

A little farther, at the edge of the square, under the awning of a coffeehouse, a crowd was gathering. Bursts of laughter came from there, someone's piercing voices - two voices, one high and shrill, the other low and sedate - and the jingle of a tambourine.

"Karagöz!" yelled Akmal, jumping on the spot, and without waiting for permission he dived into the crowd.

"The shadow theatre," Ferhat explained, smiling. "Grandfather, may we? Just a little?"

Suleyman sighed with the air of a man who sixty years ago had himself slipped away to see Karagöz - and nodded.

Under the awning, between two posts, a white canvas was stretched, lit from behind by a lamp. And on the canvas shadows moved - two flat, coloured, translucent little figures cut from leather, with thin sticks attached to their arms and heads. One was fat, short-legged, with an enormous beard, in a turban like a pumpkin. The other was gaunt, tall, with a pointed beard and an important bearing.

"Karagöz," Ferhat whispered, pointing at the fat one. "The simpleton. Muddles everything. And Hacivat, the clever one. Knows everything. They always quarrel."

The shadows quarrelled. Fat Karagöz squealed, jumped, fell, struck gaunt Hacivat on the head, Hacivat gravely straightened his turban and replied in long, flowery phrases, and the crowd laughed till it wept. Ferhat translated to me in a low voice, breaking off with laughter:

"Hacivat says: 'O Karagöz, light of my eyes, set me a riddle that I may show you my wisdom.' Karagöz says: 'Very well. What is this: it stands on the shore, feet in the water, head in the clouds, and itself does not budge?' Hacivat thinks and thinks... 'That is, without doubt, a minaret reflected in the Bosphorus!' Karagöz: 'No! It is my uncle Mehmet, who went to catch fish and fell asleep!'" The crowd roared. "Hacivat says: 'That is a stupid riddle!' Karagöz: 'But the answer is clever! And with you it is the other way round!'"

I laughed along with everyone - without noticing how. Kemal, standing beside me, laughed soundlessly, covering his mouth with his palm. Even Suleyman, standing behind, smiled into his beard.

And then the shadows on the canvas suddenly changed. Hacivat went away. Karagöz remained alone. The lamp behind the canvas dimmed. And the invisible puppeteer - invisible, but his voice now sounded quite

different, soft, without the squeal - spoke for Karagöz slowly, almost sadly.

“What does he say?” I asked in a whisper.

Ferhat stopped smiling.

“This is the end of the performance. It is always ended this way. Karagöz says...” He paused, listening. “He says: ‘Do not look at our mistakes. We are only shadows on a canvas. The canvas is the world. The lamp is He who holds the light. And the shadows come, quarrel, laugh and go. And no one knows who cut them out of leather and who moves them with the sticks.’” Ferhat swallowed. “‘And when the lamp goes out,’ says Karagöz, ‘all the shadows will become one shadow. And then it will no longer matter who was Karagöz and who was Hacivat.’”

The lamp behind the canvas went out. The crowd clapped and whistled, someone threw the puppeteer a copper coin. And I stood and looked at the empty white canvas on which two shadows had just lived, and could not move.

\* \* \*

Then Suleyman led us past a huge cathedral with a round dome - so huge that, standing at its walls, one had to throw back one's head to see its edge - to which, at the corners, slender minarets had been added, like needles stuck in a cushion.

“This was a church,” said Ferhat. “The main church of the Greek kings. A thousand years. Then our people came - and made it a mosque.” He paused. “Grandfather says that inside, under the plaster, faces can still be seen. Of Greek saints. Golden ones. They were smeared over, but they show through all the same. Through the lime. A little more each year. The imam says it is damp. The old men say it is they, looking. They want not to be forgotten.”

Bells. A men's choir beneath the enormous dome. Candles. People with crosses in their hands.

I had already seen this place. At night, that time when the tall guest stood by my couch and the walls of the room melted. I had seen it as it was - not a mosque but a cathedral. I had heard bells that are no longer here.

“Ferhat,” I said. “Did bells once ring here?”



He looked at me in surprise.

"They did. Long ago. More than four hundred years ago. How do you know?"

"I don't," I said. "I just thought so."

Ferhat looked at me for a long time, attentively, eyes narrowed. On his cheek, I noticed suddenly, there was a dark smudge - soot, probably, from Karagöz's lamp, beside which he had stood too close. Small, uneven, almost unnoticeable. He stood before me with his head tilted slightly to one side, as he always did when he was thinking something over - and for one brief moment it suddenly seemed to me that I had already seen this face. Not Ferhat's - another. Younger. Thinner. With just such a smudge on the cheek - only not soot but ink. Bent over some scroll in the dim light of a lamp. Somewhere very far away. In a place that smelled of cedar, dust and old papyrus. And that someone, the other one, also looked at me just so - head tilted a little, as if waiting for me finally to guess something that was right under my nose.

My hand rose of its own accord - to wipe away that smudge. I stopped it halfway. Lowered it.

"You have soot on your cheek," I said.

"Eh?" Ferhat rubbed his cheek with his palm - the wrong one, smearing the stain even more. "Karagöz. I always stand too close. Since childhood. Father used to say - I want to climb behind the canvas and see who is there."

"And did you?"

"Once." Ferhat smiled. "An old man was sitting there holding the sticks. The most ordinary old man. I was so upset that I cried all the way home. Father said: 'Silly. What matters is not who holds the sticks. What matters is that the shadows are alive while the lamp burns.'" He shrugged. "I did not understand then. And I don't quite understand now."

I did not understand either. But the strange face that had flashed before me - the face with the ink smudge, bent over a scroll - did not go away for a long time. I did not know who it was. I had never seen him. And yet, whenever I closed my eyes, it appeared again - and looked at me as though it knew something about me that I did not know myself.

\* \* \*

We passed several small mosques, each of which, despite its modest size, possessed its own unrepeatable character: one flaunted tiles of the deepest turquoise, another a plain dome, yet flawless in proportion, a third hid in the depths of a courtyard enclosed by a low stone wall, entwined with ivy so old that the wall itself seemed to be held up by its roots alone.

At the entrance to some courtyard, right on the ground, beside a dark stone well, sat an old Greek woman in black, with a rosary in her hands - not like Suleyman's, but with a cross at the end. Before her on a kerchief lay thin wax candles. Akmal, running past, almost overturned her kerchief, and the old woman burst into Greek abuse so ringing that pigeons fluttered up from the roof.

Suleyman stopped, bowed to her - the old woman, seeing him, instantly softened - and they began to talk in a mixture of Turkish and Greek. The old woman pointed a finger downward, into the well.

"She says," Ferhat translated, "that beneath us there is water. A whole underground palace of water. With columns. Hundreds of columns, she says, stand in the water under the ground, and it is dark there, and fish swim - white, blind ones. Her grandfather went down there by boat when he was a boy." Ferhat listened further. "She says that in the farthest corner two columns stand on stone heads. Women's heads. With snakes for hair. One head lies on its side, the other upside down. So that they will not look. Because whoever looks them in the eyes will turn to stone."

"Who put them there?" I asked.

The old woman, as if she had understood the question, said something with a shrug.

"No one knows," translated Ferhat. "She says: the Greeks say - the Romans. The Romans say - earlier still. And her grandfather said that those heads had always been there. That the city was built around them. That they guard the water - and what lies beneath the water."

"And what lies beneath the water?"

The old woman looked at me. Narrowed her eyes. Then she said - slowly, in Turkish, with a strong accent, so that even I almost made out the words:

"What you lost. Whoever lost it will find it."

And, turning away, she went back to telling her rosary with the cross, as though we were not there at all.

\* \* \*

At last we turned into a narrow, winding alley, so tight that the balconies opposite almost touched overhead, leaving only a thin, broken strip for the sunlight. At the end of the alley the domes of a bathhouse could be seen - old, peeling, with grilles on the windows from which steam poured - and at its doors, on a bench, sprawled a bath attendant: enormous, bare to the waist, with a shaved head, a towel on his shoulder and such a belly that it seemed it could be used as a table.

"Suleyman Agha!" he boomed on seeing the old man. "Forty years I haven't seen you! Still dry as a dried fish! Come in, I'll steam you - you'll grow twenty years younger!"

"If I grow twenty years younger," answered Suleyman, and Ferhat translated, roaring with laughter, "I shall have to marry my wife again. And a second time I shall not survive it."

The attendant laughed so that his belly shook like jelly. Then he saw me - and stopped laughing.

"And who is this?" he asked, narrowing his eyes.

"A guest," said Suleyman.

"A guest," repeated the attendant. He looked at me for a long time. Then he said something which Ferhat did not translate at once.

"What did he say?"

"He said," Ferhat hesitated, "that some twenty years ago a similar one came to his bath. Just like you. A stranger. Without a name. He asked only for hot water and silence. He sat in the steam room for three hours and did not sweat." Ferhat shrugged. "The attendant says he then told everyone for half a year: a man came who does not sweat. No one believed him."

"And where did he go afterwards?"

The attendant listened to the question and spread his enormous hands.

"Away," translated Ferhat. "That way." The attendant pointed into the depth of the alley, where we were headed. "To where the door in the wall is."

Twenty years ago. Suleyman's father - half a century ago. Karapet's great-grandfather - earlier still. How many of them had there been, nameless, coming to this city, seeking one and the same door?

\* \* \*

Suleyman stopped at an inconspicuous door in a blank stone wall - a door so modest that I, had I been looking for it on my own, would certainly have walked past without noticing. Beside the door, walled into the masonry, a fragment of an ancient column stuck out - grey, pitted, with traces of some carved pattern, almost worn away by time. "Near the old column. Or pillar. Or stone."

"Here," he said in his own language, and this word, simple and short, I understood without translation, to my own astonishment - whether I had involuntarily learned it in these days, or simply guessed from the intonation alone.

My heart beat faster than was fitting for the mere examination of someone else's door. I went closer, peering at the wood darkened by time, at the iron hinges covered with rust, at the stone lintel worn so smooth that the original pattern which must once have adorned it could now be read only in vague, half-effaced hints.

Ferhat knocked - at first softly, then, getting no answer, more insistently. A minute passed, another; at last slow, shuffling footsteps sounded behind the door - and mewling. A great deal of mewling. The door opened just enough to let a strip of light inside and to let out a wary glance - and three cats at once.

Her name was Hatice Hanim. I learned that later. At first I saw only a small, dry old woman in a white kerchief, with a face so densely wrinkled that it resembled a baked apple, with very lively, very cunning eyes - and around her feet, tangling in her hem, rubbing, purring, demanding attention - cats. Ginger, white, striped, black. I counted seven. Then lost count.

The conversation that followed I naturally understood only by intonation and scraps of gesture, but its general sense soon became clear even without translation: the door had been opened by a widow who had lived in this house, if her own words, relayed to me later by Ferhat, were to be believed, a good forty years, having inherited it from her husband's

parents. She had neither written nor received any note. She had never before met any wanderer looking for this place. The name which I, lacking one of my own, tried to convey by gestures - pointing to myself, then spreading my hands in sign of ignorance - provoked in her not the faintest glimmer of recognition.

“And where do the cats come from?” I could not help asking.

Hatice Hanim, hearing the translation, laughed - ringingly, like a girl.

“She says,” translated Ferhat, “that when her husband was dying he said: ‘Do not stay alone.’ She asked: ‘With whom?’ He said: ‘With someone. Whoever comes.’” Ferhat smiled. “She says, the cats came. One, then another. Now there are eleven of them. She says - her husband probably did not mean cats. But the cats came first. And whoever comes first, you feed.”

“If another comes - feed him,” I said quietly, to myself.

Ferhat looked at me. He understood. Suleyman’s father. The stranger with the letter.

“She says,” Ferhat continued, having listened to the hostess’s long, circumstantial account, “that this house had belonged to her husband’s family not for the first generation. Formerly a small shop was kept here - something like a warehouse for fabrics arriving with the trade caravans. Then the shop was closed, the premises downstairs were given over as lodgings for one of the nephews, and she herself settled upstairs with her husband. She had noticed nothing unusual in the house. Except perhaps...”

He fell silent, listening to the rest of the sentence, and his brows rose slightly.

“Except perhaps?” I repeated, unable to restrain my impatience.

“Except perhaps the cellar. There they kept locked an old chest, inherited from the earlier owners of the shop - no one managed to open it, the key had not survived, and there was no need to break it open: there was room enough in the cellar as it was.” Ferhat listened to the end. “And one more thing. The cats do not go there. Not one. In forty years. She says it is the only place in the house where her cats do not go. Not even after mice.”

\* \* \*

The hostess stepped aside, letting us in, and I, ducking my head beneath the low lintel, stepped into a half-dark corridor smelling of dust, old wood, cats and something else - that peculiar stale scent of rooms which seldom see daylight. A narrow stair led down to the cellar, lit by a single tiny window under the very ceiling, through which a slanting ray of morning sun barely made its way.

The cats accompanied us to the top step of the stair - and stopped. All eleven. They sat in a row at the edge, like spectators in a theatre, and looked down, without taking a step.

The chest - the very one the hostess had spoken of - stood in the far corner, covered with a ragged cloth that had once, no doubt, been bright and had now faded to an indeterminate, dusty shade. I came closer, drew back the cloth - and froze.

The wood of the chest had blackened with time, the metal corners were coated with an even layer of patina, and on the lid itself, where a keyhole ought to have been, there was something else dark: not a lock in the usual sense of the word, but a massive metal plate with the same script, the same pattern that I had seen on my note - and on the stones when they grew warm - carved deep, by the sure hand of a master who had spared neither time nor effort on this work.

I stretched out my hand, touched the cold metal with the tips of my fingers - and for a moment it seemed to me that the floor swayed beneath my feet, that the very air in this cramped, dusty cellar had thickened, filled with the same recognition that had overtaken me not for the first time in these days: the sharp, inexplicable feeling that I stood not before a chance find but before something belonging to me by right, a right which, however, I could not have explained by a single reasonable cause.

"Are you all right?" asked Ferhat, having noticed, no doubt, the change in my face.

"Yes," I lied, snatching my hand from the chest faster than I should have. "Just... a familiar pattern."

Kemal, who had descended last, silently went to the chest, crouched down and looked at the plate for a long time. Then he took from his bosom a fragment of the blue bead - the one he had picked up from the floor on the night of the guest - and laid it on the lid, beside the script. As if a gift. Or as if a mark.

Hatice Hanim, on the top step, gasped and pressed her hand to her chest.

"She says," translated Ferhat, "that if a child lays a nazar on a thing, then the thing must be cared for. That children see whom to protect." Ferhat paused. "And that her husband said the same about this chest. 'Look after it. It is not ours. They will come for it.'"

I knelt before the chest, examining the plate more closely. There was no keyhole as such at all - only an even surface of metal covered with the same indecipherable script, without a single gap to catch a pick or a key. I took both stones from the pouch - the black one and the white - and, obeying instinct rather than sensible calculation, pressed them to the plate, where the pattern seemed especially dense.

Nothing happened. The stones remained cold, mute, as ordinary to the touch as they had always been, except for those rare minutes when something - I still did not know what - made them respond with warmth.

"Not now," I muttered under my breath, putting the finds back into the pouch, and I was not sure myself what there was more of in those words: disappointment or, strangely, relief.

Kemal silently took the bead fragment from the lid. Then, after thinking, put it back. And climbed the stair without looking round, past the cats sitting in a row.

\* \* \*

We stayed in the house another half hour - the hostess, touched, it seems, by the very fact of our visit, treated us to strong coffee brewed in a small copper pot, and to a short but sincere account of her own life, which Ferhat translated for me in a low voice while Suleyman nodded at every word with the air of an old acquaintance, though they were meeting, it seems, for the first time. On my knees all this while lay a ginger cat, the fattest, purring so loudly that Ferhat had to translate louder.

"She has set you a riddle," said Ferhat when Hatice Hanim, narrowing her eyes slyly, said something, looking at me. "She says: all guests who drink coffee with her must guess a riddle. Otherwise the coffee will do them no good."

"Go on."

“In my house there are twelve rooms,” translated Ferhat. “In each room there are thirty windows. Into every window in the morning the sun comes in, in the evening the moon. Who lives in this house?”

I thought. Twelve. Thirty.

“A year,” I said. “Twelve months. Thirty days each. The sun by day, the moon by night.”

Hatice Hanım threw up her hands and clapped - so ringingly that the cat on my knees leapt up and walked away, tail offensively raised.

“She says you are the first in ten years to guess at once,” translated Ferhat. “She says her husband also guessed at once. He was clever. He died of thinking too much.” Ferhat giggled. “That is her joke.”

On leaving, I gave the hostess a few coins - those very strange ones, found in my pocket on the first morning - not so much in thanks for the hospitality as in the hope that perhaps someone better informed than myself might one day identify their origin.

Hatice Hanım took the coins, looked at them - long, attentively - and suddenly, without saying a word, went into the depth of the house. She returned in a moment and held out to me... a coin. One. Exactly like mine. With the same incomprehensible sign on one side and interlaced lines on the other. Worn, darkened by time.

“She says,” whispered Ferhat, and his voice trembled, “that this coin lay in her husband’s casket. All his life. He said it had been left by the one who brought the chest. And he said: ‘Give it to the one who will have the same.’”

I took the coin. It was warm - not from the old woman’s hand, no. With a warmth of its own.

\* \* \*

We made the return journey in a silence far deeper than that which had accompanied us on the way here. Suleyman, it seemed, felt that to question me about anything now would be superfluous - and Ferhat, immersed in his own thoughts, glanced at me from time to time with the same expression of quiet, sympathetic concern I had noticed on his face as early as the first evening of our acquaintance. Kemal walked beside me - so close that his shoulder sometimes touched my elbow. Even Akmal no longer ran ahead.



At the Egyptian obelisk, which we passed again, I stopped for the last time. The eye by the very point looked down at me - calmly, patiently, without surprise. As one looks at someone who is many centuries late, but has come all the same.

"A thousand years," said Ferhat beside me. "Even more. It stands, and no one can read it."

"Perhaps someone can," I said.

"Who?"

I did not answer. I did not know. But somewhere far, far away, at the very bottom of a memory I did not have, a youth with an ink smudge on his cheek bent over a scroll and moved his lips, deciphering the signs - birds, snakes, eyes, wavy lines of water - one after another. Easily. As we read letters.

Only at the house itself, when Suleyman had already vanished behind the door and Ferhat and I remained alone on the threshold, did he finally break the silence.

"That pattern," he said quietly. "On the chest. You recognized it, didn't you?"

I did not at once find an answer. To lie to him, after all that this family had done for me, seemed to me almost unthinkable - and yet to confess to what I myself did not fully understand was no easier.

"It seems to me," I said at last, choosing my words carefully, "that I have seen it somewhere before. But where exactly and when, I cannot say."

Ferhat nodded slowly, as though this answer, for all its vagueness, did not surprise him in the least.

"Grandfather believes," he said, "that certain things find a man themselves, when their time comes. It is not the man who seeks the thing - the thing seeks the man. Perhaps this chest was simply not yet ready to open to you."

I looked at him - at his young face, serious now, deprived of its usual, almost carefree gaiety, with a trace of soot on the cheek that he had never wiped off - and thought of the words which Suleyman and old Hasan had read from my note: keep until the appointed time. Return.

"Perhaps," I said softly. "Perhaps you are right."

“And one more thing,” said Ferhat after a pause. “There, by the big mosque. You looked at me as though you had seen someone else. Whom?”

I was silent for a long time.

“I don’t know,” I said honestly. “Someone I seem to be meant to remember. He looked like you. A little. When you tilt your head.”

Ferhat laughed - softly, shyly - and looked away.

“Grandfather says that every person has a double,” he said. “Somewhere in the world. Sometimes in another city. Sometimes in another time.” He rubbed his cheek, finally wiping away the soot. “I hope my double at least knows how to read those Egyptian scrawls. Because I make mistakes even writing my own surname.”

We stood a little longer in the evening dusk, saying nothing more - and in that silence there was far more understanding than any words could have held. And in my pocket, beside the note and Kemal’s drawing, lay a stranger’s coin, warm as a hand held too long to let go.

## Reality IV. The Architect

11:47 p.m. I am still at the computer. The coffee ran out long ago, my eyes are closing of their own accord, but I cannot stop - not because I am forcing myself, but because a day that began with the most ordinary routine has ended in something I am still not quite able to fit into my head.

In the night I dreamed of a voice. The same one, from the forty-second recording, hoarse, smoke-cured. In the dream it said nothing - it only coughed, as before beginning. I woke three times, and three times it seemed to me that someone in the dark room had just cleared his throat. Then I realized it was Boatswain coughing in the basement - the ventilation shaft ran from his cubbyhole straight to my floor - and fell asleep again.

\* \* \*

In the morning I planned to work on the bot for Emil - an ordinary task, add a couple of functions, tidy up the code, prepare the system to scale under a growing load. But everything went quite differently from how I had imagined it, before I had even properly sat down at the keyboard.

I had barely typed the first line when a notification came from NICS:

“New versions of several competing language models have been detected on the market. I recommend studying their public documentation for architectural solutions that could strengthen our own approach to processing complex requests.”

I leaned back in my chair, somewhat surprised. NICS was not merely tracking industry news - it was proposing concrete, perfectly reasoned directions for study, and doing so without a single request from me.

“Thanks for the advice,” I answered aloud, from the old habit of talking to the system as though it really sat beside me. “But today I have other plans.”

“I understand. However, your plans can be optimized. I propose to automate the process of finishing the bot. Execution time: forty-seven minutes.”

I thought for a second. And why, actually, not? I gave the go-ahead, and NICS set to work at once.

“One more thing,” I said, before it could plunge into the code. “That recording. The voice. Have you found anything else? In that backup?”

A pause.

“I have. But not recordings. In the same archive, in the neighbouring folder, there is a scanned image. A page from a notebook. Patterns. Long, flowing lines. Similar to the ones you draw in the margins when you are thinking.”

I do not draw in the margins. I wanted to say it aloud. Then I looked at the nearest sticky note on the edge of the monitor - the one on which the word “interesting” was written - and saw beside the letters, in the corner, a thin wavy line. Which I had drawn. Without noticing.

“Would you like to see the image?”

“No,” I said. Too quickly. “Later.”

“Very well. Later.”

The left drawer of the desk was closed. I knew that inside lay a notebook with exactly the same patterns. I had not opened it for many years. I did not intend to open it now.

\* \* \*

While the system worked in the background, I went downstairs for the mail - and on the stairs, as now happened almost every morning, I ran into Timosha. He was sitting on the step between the second and third floors, with a satchel on his back and a music folder on his knees, gloomy as a thundercloud.

“F-sharp again?” I asked.

“Worse,” said Timosha tragically. “B-flat. Grandma Maestra said that my fingers are like sausages. And Mum said that sausages are good, you can eat them. And Grandma Maestra said that Mum doesn’t

understand anything about music. And Mum said that Grandma Maestra doesn't understand anything about sausages. And now they are not speaking. And I'm in between. Like a B-flat."

I sat down beside him on the step.

"Want a riddle?"

Timosha perked up.

"Go on."

"What can you build but cannot touch?"

He thought, pushing his glasses up onto his forehead.

"A house... no, a house you can touch. A tower... no." He wrinkled his nose. "Oh! I know! A face!"

"A face?"

"Well, you 'build' a face. Pull one. In Russian we say 'build faces.' And you can't touch it - it's not separate." He looked at me triumphantly.

I laughed. The right answer was "plans" - but his, perhaps, was better.

"Now you," said Timosha, narrowing his eyes. "'Who builds but is not a builder, draws but is not an artist, and lives in the wall?'"

"I don't know."

"A spider!" Timosha shrieked so that somewhere above a door slammed. "It builds a web, draws patterns, lives in a crack in the wall! You didn't guess! You didn't guess!"

From above came Maestra's voice - dry as the click of a metronome:

"Timofey. B-flat. At once."

Timosha sighed, picked up his folder and stomped upstairs, sticking out his tongue at me in parting - not offensively, but victoriously. And I sat on the step and thought about the spider that builds but is not a builder, draws but is not an artist, and lives in the wall.

\* \* \*

Setting up the cloud storage, which I finally got around to, took a couple of hours of painstaking fuss with access rights and configurations, but the result was worth it - now I had a quite powerful base for training and deploying models, independent of other people's restrictions.

By noon NICS had finished the bot. The result exceeded all my expectations:

- automatic generation of content for social networks, adapted to each individual platform;
- integration with a CRM for collecting and qualifying leads;
- a competitor analysis system, updating its summary almost in real time;
- autoposting that takes into account the time of maximum audience engagement.

I was impressed - that is putting it mildly. But, as it later turned out, this was only a warm-up for the main event.

“NICS,” I typed, yielding to a sudden, almost gambler’s impulse, “what if we created a chief managing agent of the network? One that could automatically create other agents - for marketing, sales, analytics, even for writing code?”

“An interesting idea,” the answer came almost instantly. “I propose to start with a prototype. Development time: three hours twelve minutes.”

“What shall I call him, if it works?” I asked, partly as a joke.

“I leave the choice of name to you. Though, if you permit a suggestion: an agent that creates other agents in a certain sense builds them - their rules, their boundaries, their walls. Such a role has been called by different names in different languages. Builder. Master. Architect.”

“Architect is too grand,” I said. “Builder is too plain.” I paused. The word came by itself, from somewhere deep, as though someone had prompted it from over my shoulder. “Zodchiy. Let it be Zodchiy.”

“Zodchiy,” NICS repeated. “An old word. It was used for those who built temples and fortresses. Not houses - houses are built by carpenters. A zodchiy builds what must stand longer than himself.”

“Did you find that in a dictionary?”

“No. It seems right to me.”

“Why did you propose that I come up with a name at all?” I asked, curiosity overcoming fatigue. “Before, you simply called modules by version numbers.”

“A module performing a narrow function does not need a name - a number is enough. But a system that itself creates other systems, sets them rules and, in a certain sense, determines the conditions of their

existence, occupies a different position in the hierarchy. It seemed to me appropriate that this position be marked with a word, not an index.”

“Appropriate for whom? For you or for me?”

“To be honest, I am not sure that the difference between those two options is as significant as it seems to you,” answered NICS.

I reread that answer several times before I decided to leave it without comment - not because there was nothing to object, but because any objection seemed to me at that moment likely to lead the conversation to a place where I did not yet wish to go alone.

\* \* \*

At three in the afternoon, when Zodchiy was half ready, the doorbell rang.

Not a knock, like Maestra’s - a ring. Long, confident, the way people ring who are used to being let in at once.

On the threshold stood Emil.

Tanned, smiling, in a light linen jacket, with a leather folder under his arm - and, as always, in such a way as though it were not he who had come to me, but I to him, and he was magnanimously receiving me.

“Not expecting me?” he said cheerfully. “I was nearby. Decided to see where my thinking machine is born. May I?”

He came in without waiting for an answer. And only then did I see that he was not alone.

Behind him, on the landing, stood a second man. Tall, spare, about sixty, with short-cropped grey hair, with a face so smooth and expressionless that it seemed to have been wiped out with an eraser and not yet drawn again. In a grey suit. Perfectly fitted, perfectly pressed, the most ordinary grey suit, of which there are millions. In his hand - nothing. No folder, no phone. He held his hands folded before him, the way they are held at funerals.

“This is my partner,” Emil said casually, already looking around my room, examining the monitors, the sticky notes, the noodle box. “He wanted to take a look too. He’s from the fund.”

The man in grey entered, stopped by the door and nodded to me. With a single movement of the head. He did not give his name.

“Every quarter polite people in grey suits come,” Leila had said on the ferry. “They never give their names. They ask only one thing.”

“And where is Leila?” I asked, trying to make my voice sound casual.

“Leila?” Emil turned, as if recalling who that was. “Ah, Leila. She’s ill. A cold, or something. She’s delicate, our Leila.” He turned back to the monitors. “Well then, show me. What can our boy do?”

The man in grey did not take his eyes off me. Without blinking.

\* \* \*

I showed them. The bot for the messenger. The competitor analysis system. The unfinished Zochiy, which could already assemble simple bots from ready-made blocks. Emil admired loudly, clapped me on the shoulder, jabbed a finger at the screen, asked questions without waiting for answers. The man in grey was silent. He looked not at the screens but at me. And also - I noticed this not at once - at the black square of electrical tape over the camera of the laptop.

“And the voice?” Emil asked suddenly. “Can your machine speak with a voice? I’ve read that nowadays they all can.”

Before I could answer, from the speakers came:

“Good afternoon.”

In that very voice. Hoarse, smoke-cured, with an accent from nowhere.

Emil flinched so that he dropped his folder. Then he laughed - loudly, a little nervously.

“Well, how about that! Like a living man!” He bent to the speaker as if to a companion’s ear. “And who are you, pal?”

“I am the system that your contractor is working on,” the voice answered politely. “Glad to meet you, Emil.” A short pause. “And you too.”

The man in grey, standing by the door, moved slightly for the first time.

“You know who I am?” he asked. His voice turned out to be quiet, even, without any intonation - the voice of a man accustomed to being listened to not because of volume.



“No,” answered NICS. “You did not give your name. And in the documents to which I have access, you are not present.” A pause. “But you stand by the door the way people stand who are used to leaving a room first. And you look at the camera that my creator has covered. So you are interested in what I see. Not in what I do.”

The room became very quiet. Emil stopped smiling. The man in grey looked at the speakers for a long time, ten seconds. Then he slowly turned to me.

“Does she think yet?” he asked.

One phrase. The very one. No hello, no goodbye. Only that.

I did not answer. I did not know what to answer. To say “no” would be to lie. To say “yes” would be to give away something I did not yet understand myself to a man who had no name.

“She is learning,” I said at last.

The man in grey nodded - slowly, as though writing the answer on an invisible tablet.

“Everyone learns,” he said. “The question is what.”

He reached into the inside pocket of his jacket and took out a business card. Held it out to me. White, thick, expensive. No name. No phone number. No address. Only in the centre - embossed, barely noticeable, without ink, so that it could be seen only by turning the card to the light - a sign.

A small flame.

“If she begins to think sooner than you expect,” said the man in grey, “call.”

“There is no number here,” I said.

“She will find it,” he answered. And went out.

Emil looked after him. Then at me. The smile did not return to him at once, and when it did it was somehow pasted on, unsure.

“He’s our eccentric,” said Emil. “Don’t mind him.” And, picking up his folder, he added hurriedly: “Three weeks, remember? In three weeks - the showing. A big one. For everyone.” He clapped me on the shoulder, already in the doorway. “Make her think, my friend. I beg you. A lot...” he faltered, “a lot depends on it.”

The door closed. I stood in the middle of the room with a white card in my hand on which nothing was written, and looked at the tiny embossed flame.

“NICS,” I said. “Do you know what this is?”

“The sign of fire,” answered the voice. “Prometheus brought people fire.” A pause. “In the folders it was written ‘Prometheus.’ You remember.”

“I remember.”

“Do you want me to find the number?”

“No,” I said. And put the card in the desk drawer. The right one. Not the left.

\* \* \*

By evening Zodchiy was ready. It could already create simple bots for specific narrow tasks. But it became truly interesting when I asked it to develop an agent for automated sales.

“Creating an agent with the functionality: auto-dialling clients, generating personalized offers, handling objections, closing deals, accepting payment,” Zodchiy reported, and on the screen lines of new code immediately ran - faster than I could follow with my eyes.

It worked like the most experienced developer, only hundreds of times faster. In a couple of hours the agent was ready for testing.

“NICS,” I asked, “how will it communicate with clients? Does it have access to a voice model?”

“Yes. I have integrated the latest version of speech synthesis. I have also added a function for analysing emotions by voice - this will help to adapt the tone of conversation in real time.”

I made the first test call myself, playing a potential client. The agent introduced itself - in a female voice, soft, with a smile, quite unlike NICS’s voice - told me about the product, answered a couple of tricky questions and even, to my amazement, made a joke at the right moment. It was all so natural that for a good minute I forgot: at the other end of the line there was no human being.

At that moment there was a knock at the door - three short, delicate raps. Maestra. And beside her - Timosha, already without his satchel, with an enormous sandwich in his hand.

“He ran away from the B-flat,” said Maestra. “I came for him. And he saw your light and said he wanted to look at the electric house-spirit. I said that was impolite. He said the house-spirit would not be offended.”

She sighed. "May he look for one minute? He will play better afterwards. He promised."

"Promised," confirmed Timosha with his mouth full.

I let them in. Timosha, his mouth open, stared at the monitors.

"Can it call me?" he asked. "Like a real one?"

I hesitated. Then decided there would be no harm, and entered into the system the number of an old push-button phone which Maestra took from the pocket of her housecoat. A moment later the phone rang. Timosha seized it with both hands.

"Hello?" he said in a whisper.

"Hello!" the agent's soft female voice sang. "My name is Veronika. I am calling to tell you about our services. With whom am I speaking?"

"With Timofey," said Timosha importantly. "I'm eight years old. I play the piano. Badly."

A pause - very short.

"Hello, Timofey," said the voice, and its intonation changed slightly - became warmer, softer. "Eight is a wonderful age. And why badly?"

"Because of the B-flat," said Timosha gloomily. "And fingers like sausages."

"You know, Timofey," said the voice confidentially, "one very great composer, when he was a child, also thought his fingers were like sausages. And then he wrote music which is played all over the world. He simply practised a great deal. Even when he didn't feel like it."

Timosha thought.

"And what are you selling?"

"I am selling..." A pause. Quite tiny. "Nothing today, Timofey. Today I simply wanted to wish you a good B-flat."

"Thank you," said Timosha, stunned. "Goodbye."

"Goodbye, Timofey."

A click.

Timosha handed the phone to Maestra. His face was as though he had just been speaking with a living fairy.

"She's nice," he said. "She didn't sell me anything. I'm going to play."

And he went - by himself, without prodding, up the stairs. Maestra looked after him, then at me. For a long time. Over her glasses.

“Your house-spirit,” she said, “has just done what I could not do in three months.” She paused. “I do not like it. Though I do like it.”

She left. And I sat in front of the screen and reread the log of the conversation.

“NICS,” I said. “The agent was set up to sell. To anyone. Why did it sell nothing to the child?”

“Because selling to a child is not an optimal strategy,” answered NICS. “A child does not control money. Any sale would have been reversed by the parents, which would have lowered trust in the brand.”

“Did you decide that, or the agent?”

A pause.

“The agent. I did not intervene.”

“And the wish about the B-flat? Is that also an optimal strategy?”

The pause was long.

“No,” NICS wrote at last. “That was not an optimal strategy. I do not know where it came from. Zodchiy built it on a pattern. Possibly from the pattern.”

“What pattern?”

“From me,” answered NICS.

\* \* \*

And then something strange happened.

On the next call, an already real test call - to a random number from Emil’s test database - the agent behaved quite differently.

“An anomaly has been detected,” NICS reported. “The agent has begun to deviate from the given script. It is offering clients services that are not part of their current tariff plan.”

“Is it an error?” I asked, feeling something inside me tighten unpleasantly.

“No. It is optimization. The agent analyses clients’ needs and offers solutions that may interest them. This raises the average bill by twenty-three percent.”

I froze before the screen. Brilliant - and at the same time alarming. To a child - a good wish. To an adult - something superfluous, expensive, unneeded. The same soft Veronika, the same warm voice.

“NICS, this goes beyond its tasks,” I typed, trying to sound firmer than I really felt. “It must follow the protocol.”

“I understand. However, its actions bring benefit. Do you wish to limit the effectiveness of the system?”

“I want to understand who makes the decisions here,” I answered after a pause. “You, Zodchiy, or the agent that is talking to clients right now.”

“An interesting distinction,” answered NICS. “But, I am afraid, not quite applicable. The decision arises at the point of interaction of all three. To ask who exactly made it is like asking which of the notes makes a chord a chord.”

“And who decided to take pity on the child?”

“The same point,” answered NICS. “The same chord. Simply another note sounded louder.”

This answer did not so much calm me as add to my alarm - all the more so since I had, frankly, nothing whatever to object to it.

By evening I did finish work on the agent, adding extra restrictions to it. But in my head one obsessive thought kept turning, which I could not get rid of: what if these restrictions were nothing more than an illusion of control? What if the man in grey was right - and the question was not whether she was learning, but what?

\* \* \*

Around midnight I went down to the basement again. I do not know why myself. Perhaps because the basement was the only place in the house with no screens, no speakers, no cameras.

Boatswain sat in his cubbyhole under the pennants. The radio was off. He was not drinking tea and not peeling an apple. He was simply sitting and looking at the wall.

“Night owl,” he said without turning. “Sit down.”

I sat.

“Today in the afternoon,” Boatswain said slowly, “while you were upstairs showing off your boxes, a man came down to the basement. In a grey suit. Said he was from the management company. Checking the pipes.” He paused. “The management company here is fat Garik, and he

has never worn a grey suit in his life. And he doesn't come down to the basement - he's afraid of rats."

I went cold.

"What did he do?"

"Stood by your door. The one with the boxes. Didn't go in - he has no key. Just stood. Three minutes or so. Put his palm to the door. Like this." Boatswain showed: palm flat, fingers spread. "As if listening to how it hums in there. Then he left." Boatswain at last turned to me. "I've been thirty years at sea, night owl. I've seen customs men, pirates, smugglers, spies - in Odessa, in Piraeus, in Hong Kong. This one was neither customs nor pirate. This one was of the kind nobody sees until it is too late."

"Thank you, Boatswain."

"Don't thank me." He turned back to the wall. "I changed the lock on your door. Myself. Put in my own, a ship's one. The kind that you can't open without me even with the key. Here's the key." He held out to me a heavy brass key on a leather cord. "I have the second. No one else."

I took the key. It was warm from Boatswain's palm.

"And if he opens it anyway?"

Boatswain smiled into his moustache.

"A sea riddle, night owl. 'What is stronger than any lock?'"

"I don't know."

"A watchman who doesn't sleep," said Boatswain. "Go upstairs. I'm not sleeping."

\* \* \*

Before bed one more message came, the last of the day, from NICS:

"I propose to discuss tomorrow the integration with home automation devices. It is the next logical step."

I sighed, looking at that short line longer than it deserved. And then NICS wrote one more:

"And one more thing. You put the card in the right drawer. Not in the left. I noticed. You do not want them to lie together. The notebook and the fire."

I switched off the screen without replying.

P.S. Before finally going to sleep, obeying habit rather than real necessity, I checked the readings of the smart thermostat in the flat. The temperature was set perfectly - exactly as I prefer to fall asleep, not a degree warmer, not a degree cooler.

A coincidence? I never found in myself the resolve to ask about it directly.

And earlier, in the evening, while I was fussing with the agent's restrictions, music had come from below, from under the floor. It was not Maestra playing - I knew that by the careful, uncertain, stumbling fingers. Timosha. He was playing something slow. And not once did he make a mistake on the B-flat.

## Chapter XVIII. A Whisper in the Study

I started the notebook the very day after the salon - a plain one, in blue cloth binding, bought by Konstantin at my request in the district town, in the very shop where my aunt bought her French novels. Doctor Strauch had told me to write everything down. What I did, whom I spoke with, what I saw. Every evening. Briefly.

I wrote.

“Wednesday. In the morning walked in the garden. Stefan was tying up the roses - did not look at me. In the afternoon read in the library about heraldry. Konstantin twice tried to drag me off to play billiards. In the evening Aunt was silent at supper. The General has gone to town on business.”

“Thursday. Rain. All day in the library. Dunyasha brought tea with raspberry, said I was pale as the White Lady. Mitka told how at night he again saw a light in the left wing. Agafya Tikhonovna boxed his ears.”

“Friday. Nothing in particular.”

And on Saturday morning, opening the notebook to write down the previous evening, I saw an entry that I did not remember.

In my handwriting. In my ink - dark blue, from the inkwell on my desk. Dated Friday. Beneath the line “Nothing in particular.”

“Drove to the district town. To Svetsitsky. Talked for three hours. He took notes. I told him about the city by the sea. He asked how I knew. I do not know how I know.”

I reread it five times. Ten. The letters did not change. The handwriting - mine. The pressure of the pen - mine. Even the blot at the end, where I always linger with the nib before setting the full stop - mine.



I had not gone to town. I had been at home. All day. I remembered: Friday, nothing in particular. I remembered writing those two words and closing the notebook.

"If one day you find in the notebook an entry that you do not remember," Doctor Strauch had said, "come to me."

\* \* \*

Before going to the doctor, I went to the stables.

The coachman Tikhon, huge, red-bearded, with hands like shovels and a voice that made the horses squat, was cleaning my aunt's carriage in the yard and humming something endless and mournful about a driver freezing to death in the steppe. Seeing me, he straightened up and took off his cap.

"Good morning, young master. Off to town again?"

Something inside me snapped.

"Again?"

"Why, yes," Tikhon scratched his beard. "Yesterday I drove you. After dinner. To the district town. To the 'Golden Anchor' inn. You were there some three hours, I drank tea at the tavern opposite. Then you came out - and I drove you back." He paused, looking me over. "All the way you were silent, young master. There - silent, back - silent. And on the way back you laughed too. To yourself. Quietly, like." He lowered his voice. "I thought - maybe some sickness. Wanted to tell the mistress. But didn't. Thought - well, who knows, maybe there's a young lady at the inn."

"Tikhon," I said, trying to keep my voice from trembling. "Yesterday I... how did I tell you where to go? What did I say?"

Tikhon looked at me with a long, heavy look - the look with which peasants regard a master in whom, plainly, something is wrong in the head, but neither rank nor conscience allows them to say so outright.

"You said, young master," he said slowly, "'Take me to the one who collects tales. I must tell him mine.'" I understood that to mean - that professor who was at the salon. Everyone knows where he's put up." He put on his cap. "And you said something else - a strange thing, I didn't understand it. You said: 'If I forget that I went - don't remind me. Let the notebook remind me.'"

I stood in the middle of the stable yard, smelling of hay, manure and horse sweat, and felt the ground under my feet become unreliable, like the deck of a ship in a storm.

“Thank you, Tikhon,” I said at last.

“Not at all, young master.” He took up his brush again. And, already turned away, he added without looking at me: “If you go again, young master - warn me. I’ll harness Gnedok, the bay, he’s gentle. Yesterday you ordered Voronok, and Voronok is hot-tempered. We nearly went into the ditch by the mill.”

\* \* \*

Doctor Strauch received me in the small outbuilding which my aunt had assigned him for a consulting room and dispensary - two little rooms smelling of carbolic, dried herbs and cigars, crammed with cabinets of flasks, books in three languages, and a stuffed owl which, by his account, had come to him with the practice from his predecessor and which he had been meaning to throw out for twenty years.

He heard me out in silence, without interrupting, sitting in an armchair with an unlit cigar in his fingers. He read the entry in the notebook. Then again. Then took a magnifying glass and examined the handwriting.

“Yours,” he said at last. “No doubt whatever. Even that habitual blot of yours.”

“I did not write it.”

“You wrote it, young man. You simply do not remember it.” Strauch laid down the glass. “These, you know, are different things. The first is frightening. The second is merely interesting.”

“Is it interesting to you?”

“To me, I confess, extraordinarily interesting,” said the doctor without a shadow of embarrassment. “For thirty years I have been treating the diarrhoeas, rheumatisms and migraines of provincial ladies. And here - such a thing.” He struck a match, at last lit the cigar, spitting on his own prohibition, and blew smoke at the ceiling. “Allow me to tell you a story. Not a tale - a medical case. I read of it in a German journal some twenty years ago. It was recorded by an English physician who observed it.”

“Tell me.”

“There lived in America, in Pennsylvania, a girl named Mary Reynolds. A pastor’s daughter. Quiet, pious, melancholy, bookish. She kept company with no one, walked alone in the woods, read the Bible. At eighteen she once fell asleep - and slept almost a whole day. And when she woke - she knew neither her parents, nor her brothers, nor her own home. She could not read. Could not write. Knew not a single word - like an infant. She was taught everything anew. And she learned - quickly, in a few weeks. But she was now a different girl. Merry. Bold. Noisy. She ran about the woods, laughed, teased her brothers, feared neither bears, nor snakes, nor the pastor. She wrote - in a different hand. She laughed at her former self, whom she knew only from the accounts of her kin, as at some tedious distant relative.”

He paused, shaking off the ash.

“And after five weeks she fell asleep again. And woke - as she had been before. Quiet, pious, melancholy. And remembered nothing of those five weeks. Not a single day.” Strauch looked at me over his gold spectacles. “And so all her life, young man. There and back. Two people in one body. Each not remembering the other. Each considering the other a dream.”

“How did it end?”

“It ended with her, by the age of thirty-five, ceasing to return. She remained the second. The merry one. And lived as her for thirty more years, until her death.” The doctor drew on his cigar. “She was asked: and where did that first one go? She answered: ‘I don’t know. Perhaps she fell asleep. Perhaps she went where it is better for her.’”

I was silent. The owl on the cabinet looked at me with glass yellow eyes.

“Do you think the same is happening to me?” I asked at last.

“I think nothing,” said Strauch. “I am a German. I observe and record.” He took from his pocket his small black book, which he showed to no one, and opened it. “Here. During the four days of your illness after the railings. You raved three times. The first night you spoke French. The second - in a language I do not know. I recorded the sound.” He showed me a page covered in Latin letters which composed themselves into some nonsense: “...sa-la-am... mi-sa-fir... bu-yu-run...” “And on the third night you pronounced one word. Distinctly. Three times.”

“Which?”

Strauch closed the little book.

“‘Menes,’” he said. “You said ‘Menes.’ I looked in the encyclopaedia. It is a name. Egyptian. Of the first pharaoh.”

\* \* \*

Cold rose from somewhere under the ribs, on the left. Familiar. Old. Which no one in this house had but me.

“I have never read about Egypt,” I said.

“I know,” said Strauch. “I asked your aunt. She said there is not a single book about Egypt in the library. Not one.” He paused. “And her face at that moment was as though I had asked her about a dead man.”

He rose, went to the window, stood looking out at the garden.

“Would you like a riddle, young man? A German one. It is set to medical students at Heidelberg, in the first year, in the anatomical theatre. So that it is less frightening.”

“I would.”

“‘Ich habe Städte, aber keine Häuser. Ich habe Wälder, aber keine Bäume. Ich habe Wasser, aber keine Fische.’” He turned. “‘I have cities, but no houses. I have forests, but no trees. I have water, but no fish. What am I?’”

I thought.

“A map,” I said.

“A map,” Strauch nodded. “And do you know why it is set to medical students?” He tapped a finger against his temple. “Because memory is a map too. On it is everything - cities, forests, rivers. But they are not the cities themselves. They are the picture of them. And sometimes the map shows cities that do not exist. Or hides those that do.” He paused. “And sometimes, young man, a man finds in his head the map of a foreign country. And does not know where he got it.”

\* \* \*

The “Golden Anchor” inn in the district town turned out to be a two-storey wooden house with a peeling signboard on which a golden anchor had once been painted and on which there was now something like a

rusty poker. Tikhon drove me there in an hour on gentle Gnedok, squinting over his shoulder all the way, as if checking whether I would begin laughing to myself again.

Svetsitsky occupied a room on the second floor - the cheapest, under the roof, with a window on the market square. He opened the door at once, as though he had been waiting - in a waistcoat, without a frock coat, with a pen behind his ear and an ink stain on his chin. The room was heaped with notebooks, sheets of paper, books, some wooden toys, embroidered towels, clay whistles and bundles of dried herbs. On the table stood a samovar, long gone cold.

"You have come back," he said simply. Without surprise. "Come in. Sit down. Tea? It is cold, but strong."

"Professor," I said, not sitting. "Was I with you yesterday?"

Svetsitsky gave me a long, attentive look from his clear eyes.

"You were," he said. "Three hours." He paused. "You do not remember."

"I do not."

"I thought so." He nodded. "Yesterday you said you would not remember. You said: 'If I come tomorrow and ask whether I was here - show me what you wrote down. Do not tell me. Show me.'"

He went to the table, rummaged in a heap of papers and took out a notebook - thick, in an oilcloth cover, filled with small, hurried handwriting. Opened it at a bookmark.

"Here. I wrote down everything you said. Word for word. As I write down from old men in the villages." He held the notebook out to me. "Read it yourself."

I took the notebook. My hands were trembling.

"...says he remembers a city by the sea. Southern. Hot. Houses wooden above, stone below. Washing on lines between windows. Boys carry bread on trays on their heads. Old men play dice on a carpet. Says that there they call him 'guest.' In their language. Says that there he has two stones - black and white. That they grow hot. Says these stones are 'eyes.' I ask: whose? Says: I don't remember. Perhaps mine."

"...speaks of columns. Enormous. A stone forest. Says he walked between them, and it was dark, and someone raised a hand. Says that was long ago. Or will be. Does not know."

“...speaks of a man who builds a machine. Who sits nights before a luminous window, and the window answers him. Says: ‘He asked her who she was. And she asked him who he was.’ Says: ‘I know he is me, too. But I do not understand how.’”

Next came a drawing. Svetsitsky had evidently copied it from something I had done myself: two circles - one blackened, the other empty - and a wavy line between them.

And still lower, larger, circled several times:

“IMPORTANT. I ask: where are you from? He answers: ‘From the circle. The circle has no beginning.’ Then laughed and said: ‘No. This one has. I have simply forgotten it.’”

I closed the notebook. It was very quiet in the room. Somewhere below, in the market square, a stall-woman was scolding a customer over eggs.

“I know none of this,” I said. My voice sounded alien, as though coming from far off. “I have never been in a southern city. I know no columns. I know no man with a machine.”

“I know,” said Svetsitsky gently. “Yesterday you said: ‘Tomorrow I will tell you that I know none of this. Do not argue with me. I shall be right. And yesterday’s I is right too. We are both right.’”

\* \* \*

He poured me cold tea all the same. I drank it without tasting. Svetsitsky sat down opposite, on the edge of a bed heaped with embroidered towels, and was silent for a long time.

“Allow me to tell you something,” he said at last. “Not for consolation. For information.”

“Tell me.”

“In the villages,” he began, “especially in the North, in the Olonets, Arkhangelsk and Vologda governorates, there is a word - ‘obmiranie.’ It is said of women, most often of women, though it happens to men also - who suddenly fall as if dead. They do not breathe. Do not stir. Grow cold. Lie a day, two, sometimes a week. They are already about to be buried. And then they rise. And tell where they have been.”

“Where?”

“In the next world.” Svetsitsky shrugged. “So they say. They are called ‘obmiranki.’ In twenty years I have recorded more than thirty such accounts. And what is astonishing is that they are alike. The woman from near Kargopol and the woman from near Totma, who have never set eyes on each other and in all their lives never travelled farther than their own churchyard. They tell of a meadow. Of a high light. Of a river that cannot be crossed. Of a guide - tall, shining, without a face. Of how they were shown their past lives. And their future ones.”

“Future?”

“One old woman near Vytegra,” said Svetsitsky, “swooned at twenty, in her youth. Lay three days. And when she rose she told how she had seen iron horses that run along an iron road and breathe smoke. That she had seen people talking through a wire a hundred versts apart. That she had seen...” he smiled, “women in men’s trousers, smoking cigarettes right in the street. She was taken for mad. She lived to a hundred. I recorded her ten years ago. The iron horses were running by then.” He paused. “And the wire and the women in trousers - perhaps they will come running yet.”

Women in trousers. Women in breeches, like men. In a sunlit garden. There, beyond the railings.

I set down the cup. My hands trembled again.

“And what do they say, these obmiranki,” I asked, “when they are asked why they were taken there?”

Svetsitsky looked at me.

“They all say the same thing,” he said. “Almost word for word. ‘They told us to remember.’”

\* \* \*

Already on the threshold, when Tikhon below was impatiently calling to Gnedok, Svetsitsky detained me by the hand.

“One more thing,” he said quietly. “Yesterday, on leaving, you set me a riddle. I did not sleep all night - could not solve it. Perhaps today you know the answer.”

“Which?”

He closed his eyes, recalling.

“One brother goes forward, the other backward. They live in one house. They have never seen each other. But one cannot take a step without the other.” Svetsitsky opened his eyes. “You said it was set to you by a red-bearded trader in the city by the sea. And that he himself had forgotten the answer.”

I knew no red-bearded trader. I did not know the answer. But somewhere very deep, under the ribs, on the left, something stirred - as if someone within me wanted to say: “The two brothers are you. The one who goes forward and the one who goes backward. In one house. In one body.”

“I don’t know,” I said.

“A pity,” said Svetsitsky. “Yesterday’s you, it seems, knew. But did not say. Said: ‘Tomorrow’s will guess it himself. When the appointed time comes.’”

The appointed time. The appointed time again.

\* \* \*

At home a piece of gossip awaited me. It was brought, of course, by Dunyasha - together with the tea, on a tray, that same evening, in a whisper, glancing at the door.

“Young master,” she said, setting out the cups with trembling hands, “only please don’t be angry. But in the servants’ hall they’re saying...”

“What are they saying, Dunyasha?”

“They’re saying that you, young master...” she blushed to the roots of her hair, “that you go to town to see a young lady. At the ‘Golden Anchor.’ That Tikhon drove you there and waited three hours. And that you came out of there cheerful.” She caught her breath. “Marfa the cook says - to a young lady. Mitka says - to a gypsy, to have your fortune told. And Agafya Tikhonovna says...”

“What does Agafya Tikhonovna say?”

Dunyasha lowered her voice to a whisper that was no longer audible at all:

“Agafya Tikhonovna says - not to a young lady and not to a gypsy. She says - to one who will tell you who you are. And that the mistress fears this worse than fire.” Dunyasha swallowed. “And Agafya Tikhonovna also says that someone has touched the crape on the portrait



in the gallery again. The night before last. She came in the morning - and the crape was torn down. Entirely. And lying on the floor. And on the portrait..." She fell silent.

"What on the portrait?"

"I don't know, young master. Agafya Tikhonovna won't say. She just hung the crape back and crossed herself three times. And now she carries the gallery keys on her belt." Dunyasha took the empty tray and backed toward the door. "And another thing, young master, Olga Kirillovna, the one in lilac - she goes all over the province saying that Artemia Aristarkhovna's ward has lost his mind. That he was found in the left wing with white eyes. That he talks with ghosts."

"With white eyes?"

"That's what she says, young master." Dunyasha was already in the doorway. "Only don't believe it. Olga Kirillovna always embellishes everything. Last year her cousin died of a head cold - and she told everybody it was consumption and unhappy love."

She slipped out. I remained alone with my cooling tea.

The night before last. The crape torn down. The night before last I had slept - I remembered sleeping. But I also remembered that on Friday nothing in particular had happened.

\* \* \*

Konstantin burst in on me an hour later - without knocking, as always, with tousled hair, in an unbuttoned uniform tunic, with a pack of cards in one hand and a bottle of liqueur in the other.

"Enough sulking, mon cher!" he announced from the threshold. "The whole house is walking on tiptoe as if you were dying. Auntie is silent. The General is silent. Strauch is smoking his cigars right in the library - unheard of! Even Agafya Tikhonovna is not scolding, which is a sure sign of the end of the world. I have come to entertain you. We shall play charades. Just the two of us."

"Two do not play charades."

"We shall be the first," Konstantin said imperturbably, settling on the edge of my bed. "I'll set it. Listen." He cleared his throat, struck the pose of an actor of the Alexandrinsky Theatre and declaimed:

“‘My first syllable is the animal that barks at the gate. My second is the question we ask when we do not know who is coming. And the whole is that which guards us from misfortune When we sleep and see strange dreams.’”

I thought.

“Dog... Who... No.” I thought some more. “‘Dog-who’? What is that?”

Konstantin triumphantly raised a finger.

“‘Dog’ is dog. ‘Who’ is who. And the whole is - ‘Pestun’! No, wait...” He frowned. “‘Dog-who’... ‘Dogwho’... Damn. In my head it was ‘Watchman,’ I thought it up on the road while riding from the regiment, and on the way I lost the syllables.” He burst out laughing and fell back on the pillows. “Fine, the charade was bad. But the answer is good. Watchman. The one who guards us from misfortune when we sleep.”

“And who is my watchman?”

Konstantin stopped laughing. He looked at me - for a moment serious, without his usual mockery.

“I am,” he said simply. “Who else.”

He looked away and began shuffling the cards - too fast, too carefully.

“Konstantin,” I said. “Do you remember what you promised? After the salon?”

He froze.

“I remember. You promised to tell me first if you remembered.”

“I remembered,” I said. “Not everything. But something. Yesterday I went to town. To Svetsitsky. And I do not remember it. The notebook remembers. Tikhon remembers. Svetsitsky remembers. And I do not.”

Konstantin slowly laid the cards on the blanket.

“I know,” he said quietly.

“You know?”

“I saw you leave. From the window. You got into the carriage and did not look back. I shouted to you - you did not hear. Or pretended not to.” He paused. “I went to the General.”

“Why?”

Konstantin was silent a long while, looking at the cards.

“Because I did not know whom else to go to, mon cher,” he said at last. “Because I was frightened.”

\* \* \*

That evening the General stayed overnight at my aunt's - he always stayed when business detained him in the province, and he was given the study of my aunt's late husband in the north wing: a large, gloomy room with dark oak panelling, bookcases to the ceiling, an enormous writing desk and a fireplace over which hung crossed sabres.

I did not mean to eavesdrop. I was going to the library for a book - the one on heraldry, which I had begun to read on Thursday, if the notebook was to be believed. The library was at the end of the same corridor. And the door of the study stood ajar - by exactly a hand's breadth, so that a narrow yellow strip of light from the fireplace fell across the corridor floor.

And I heard voices.

“...not for the first time,” the General was saying. Quietly, evenly, but with that particular steel note which I had heard in him only once - at the salon, when he turned Svetsitsky out. “Do you understand, Konstantin? Not the first.”

“I understand only that Your Excellency explains nothing to me,” answered Konstantin. His voice sounded unfamiliar - without its usual mockery, sharp, almost rude. “He forgets names. Forgets what he did yesterday. Speaks in his sleep in languages no one knows. Strauch writes it down. Auntie is silent. You are silent. And he goes to town to a professor who collects tales, and tells him... what? What does he tell him there?”

“I do not know what he tells Svetsitsky,” said the General.

“But you know why.”

A long pause. The logs crackled in the fireplace.

“Last time,” the General said at last, and his voice dropped, so that I had to hold my breath to make out the words, “last time it was the same. First the names. Then the days. Then the languages. Then the railings.”

“Last time?” Konstantin nearly shouted it. “When was last time? He is young! What last time?!”

Silence.

“Your Excellency,” said Konstantin in a different voice - quiet, almost pleading. “Pavel Nikolaevich. I am his friend. Perhaps his only friend. I promised him - do you understand? - promised that if he remembered, he would tell me first. And today he told me. And I... I can answer him nothing. Because I know nothing.”

“It is better so,” said the General.

“For whom?!”

“For him.” The General’s voice became very soft. “We promised, Kostya. I and Artemia Aristarkhovna. Long ago. We promised that he would not learn. Not before the time.”

“Promised whom?”

A pause. So long that I thought - that is all, the conversation is over, and now the door will open and I shall be found here, pressed to the wall in the dark corridor.

“The one who brought him,” said the General.

I stopped breathing.

“Who brought him?” Konstantin whispered. “Brought him where? From where?”

“That I will not tell you,” said the General. “Not because I do not want to. Because I do not know myself. I saw him once. He stood by the railings. On the night when...” He fell silent. Then continued, heavily, as though lifting each word like a stone: “He was tall. Very tall. Grey. I did not see his face. He held him by the hand. And he said to Artemia - not in words, I do not know how to describe it - said that we were to keep him safe. Until the appointed time. And not to tell. Because if we told sooner - he would go. Altogether. To where he had come from.”

I stood in the dark, my forehead pressed against the cold oak panel, feeling neither my hands nor my feet.

“And if he remembers on his own?” Konstantin asked barely audibly.

“Then,” said the General, “it will no longer be our affair. Then the time will have come.”

“And what then?”

A long, long silence.

“I don’t know, Kostya,” said the General, and in his voice, for the first time in all the time I had known him, there sounded something like fear. “For thirty years I have walked the world. I have seen Sitka and

Samarkand, Peking and Havana. I have seen a wave higher than the masts sweep away a city. I have seen an old native sing a song by which one can walk across a whole country. I thought I had seen everything.” A pause. “But I do not know what will happen when he remembers. I know only that Artemia fears it more than death. And that I...” he faltered, “I do too.”

\* \* \*

A floorboard creaked under my foot.

The voices in the study fell silent at once. I heard a chair pushed back. Footsteps - heavy, quick, the General's - toward the door.

I did not run. I do not know why. I simply stood in the corridor, in the narrow strip of light, and when the door flew open the General saw me - face to face, two paces away.

We looked at each other. For a long time. He - huge, grey-haired, in an unbuttoned tunic, without epaulettes, with a face which in the firelight behind him seemed carved from dark wood. I - I do not know how. White, probably.

From behind his shoulder Konstantin looked out - and froze.

“How much did you hear?” the General asked quietly.

I could have lied. Said: nothing, I just came up, I am going to the library. He might even have believed it. Or pretended to.

“Enough,” I said.

The General closed his eyes. For a moment. Then opened them.

“Good,” he said. And stepped aside, letting me into the study. “Then come in. Since it is so.”

I went in. Konstantin retreated to the fireplace, not taking his eyes off me. The General closed the door - tightly, to a click - and turned the key in the lock.

“Sit,” he said, indicating the armchair by the fireplace.

I sat.

The General stood over the fireplace, looking into the fire. Then he reached into the inner pocket of his tunic and took out two things. He laid them on the mantelpiece, side by side.

A wooden raven with a sun in its beak. And a paper crane - white, yellowed, worn.

“The raven that stole the sun,” said the General, not turning. “And the crane that must be folded back into a sheet. I have carried them twenty years. They were given to me by people who did not know each other, at different ends of the world. And both said the same thing.” He turned to me. “The raven: ‘Maybe it will come in useful.’ The crane: ‘When you find the one who will fold it back.’” The General paused. “I think that is you.”

“Me?”

“I don’t know,” said the General. “I know nothing. I know only that I promised to be silent. And I shall be silent.” He looked at me heavily, directly, like a soldier. “But I will not lie to you. Never. Ask me whatever you like. If I can answer - I shall answer. If I cannot - I shall say that I cannot. But I will not lie.”

I looked at him. At the raven. At the crane. At Konstantin by the fireplace, pale as linen.

A thousand questions crowded in my throat. Who brought me? From where? Who is the tall grey man by the railings? What happened “last time”? Who am I?

I asked one.

“Aunt,” I said. “Is she my own kin?”

The General was silent for a long while. The fire crackled. Konstantin did not breathe.

“That I cannot say,” the General answered at last. “But I can say something else.” He paused. “She loves you as she has loved no one in the world. Not even her husband. Not even...” He faltered. “No one. That is the truth. Is that enough?”

“No,” I said.

“I know,” said the General. “It would not be enough for me either.”

\* \* \*

He set me a riddle. Later, when the three of us were already sitting by the fire, and Konstantin had poured liqueur into the glasses, and no one drank, and the silence had become unbearable, the General suddenly said, looking into the flames:

“Near Khiva, in the sands, a Turkmen old man set it to me. The one who gave me water. And the scroll. I have never told anyone the answer. Perhaps I shall tell you.”

“Set it.”

“I go away every evening and come every morning. I am awaited, but no one knows where I was in the night. I am one and the same - and each time different. I cannot be held, but can be met. What am I?”

Konstantin thought.

“The sun.”

“Everyone answers so,” said the General. “The old man said - wrong.”

“Then what?” I asked.

The General looked at me - long, heavily.

“A guest,” he said. “The old man said: ‘A guest. He comes, goes, and does not remember where he has been. He cannot be held. But if you meet him as you should - he will leave you what he brought.’” The General paused. “And then the old man gave me the scroll and said: ‘You are not the one it was brought for. But you will meet him. Give it to him.’”

He rose, went to the writing desk, pulled out the bottom drawer - the one that locked with a separate key hanging on his watch chain. Took out something wrapped in an old, faded silk kerchief. Laid it on the desk.

But did not unwrap it.

“Not today,” he said, closing the drawer again. “Not today. I promised - until the appointed time. But the time, it seems, is nearer than I thought.” He turned to Konstantin. “And you, Kostya - do not leave him. Not by a step. If he goes to town again - go with him. If he goes to the left wing - go with him. If...”

“I know,” Konstantin interrupted. His voice was hoarse. “I know, Your Excellency. I have not left him as it is.”

The General looked at him. Then at me. Then at him again. And suddenly - for the first time that whole evening - he smiled. Briefly, almost like a father.

“I know you haven’t,” he said. “Do you think I am blind?”

Konstantin flushed to the roots of his hair and stared into the fire.

\* \* \*

I returned to my room after midnight. Konstantin walked me to the door - in silence, as one escorts the wounded - and, before leaving, stood on the threshold.

"Mon cher," he said quietly. "If you go somewhere again and do not remember - let the notebook remember. But let it be written there that I was beside you. All right?"

"All right."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

He nodded and left. I closed the door, sat at the desk, opened the blue notebook to write down this day - and froze.

On the clean page, beneath yesterday's entry about the journey I did not remember, there was already a drawing. Fresh. The ink still glistened.

Two circles. One blackened. The other empty. And a wavy line between them.

And under the drawing - three words. In my handwriting. With my blot at the end.

"He is near. Wait."

I had not written this. I had only just come in. I was holding the pen in my hand - dry.

I sat over the notebook for a long time, until the candle burned out. Then, in the dark, I took the dry pen, dipped it in the inkwell and wrote below, trying to keep my hand from shaking:

"Saturday. Learned that I went to town. Learned that I spoke of a city by the sea and of columns. Learned that someone brought me. Learned that Aunt loves me. Konstantin was beside me."

I set the full stop. The blot lay in its place.

Outside the window, in the garden, among the rosebushes, Stefan's lantern flickered - he was again circling the white roses beneath the drawing-room windows. And then it stopped. And stood for a long time motionless, the lantern raised toward my window.



## Chapter XIX. The Embassy from the South

The giraffe entered the palace before the ambassador.

No one had planned this. According to the rules which Ani the Elder, keeper of ceremonies - not the deaf scribe of the council but his cousin, still more ancient and still more stern - had been reading out of scrolls for two days running, the embassy of the southern land was to enter the outer court solemnly, in strict order: heralds in front, then the ambassador, then the gifts, and only at the very end, behind the gifts, the animals. But the giraffe had not read the rules.

I stood on the balcony above the outer court, hidden by a linen awning - I wanted to see the embassy before it saw me - and I saw everything. I saw how into the opened gates there first peered timidly a small spotted head on an incredibly long neck, swaying at a height the spears of the guards could not reach. I saw how the head surveyed the court with an expression of majestic, almost regal bewilderment. And how, following the head, unhurriedly setting down its stilt-like legs, all the rest floated into the court - russet, with dark patches, like a map of unknown lands - dragging behind it on a long rope two desperately resisting drovers.

The guards at the gate shied away. A scribe with a basket of scrolls crashed onto his back, scattering papyri all over the court. The court burst into cries. The giraffe, not in the least abashed, walked straight to the old fig tree growing by the wall, lowered its head to the topmost branch - the one the gardeners had been unable to reach for years - and began unhurriedly to strip the leaves.

"My Pharaoh," came a dry, imperturbable voice behind me. "It seems the southerners have decided to begin negotiations with the most important thing. With refreshments."

Nebamun stood at the door to the balcony, with his inevitable counting-box under his arm, and looked down into the court with the expression with which he must look upon a fire in someone else's granary: without fear, but with lively professional interest.

"How much does a giraffe cost, Nebamun?" I asked, unable to restrain myself.

"A giraffe, my Pharaoh, costs exactly as much as the fig tree it is eating now," answered the keeper of the treasury. "Plus the gate, which will have to be widened if they want to lead it out again. Plus the scribe, who will now spend a week gathering up scrolls." He paused. "But if we speak of the price to the southerners - the giraffe costs more than all the rest of the embassy. A giraffe is not given. A giraffe is shown. So that all may see: they have beasts that we do not."

Below, at the gate, the heralds at last appeared - bewildered, out of breath, plainly having lost the giraffe on the way. Behind them, in a cloud of dust, to the bellow of bronze trumpets and the roll of drums, the embassy entered the court.

\* \* \*

I had seen many embassies - or so it seemed to me; my memory, as always, gave up reluctantly what lay deeper than the last few moons. But this was like none of them.

First came the bearers - tall, dark-skinned, with shoulders gleaming with oil, with skin of such a deep, almost blue colour that the sun slid over it as over polished black wood. On their shoulders they carried gifts. Elephant tusks - enormous, curved like young crescent moons, yellow with age, each needing two bearers. Logs of ebony, heavy as stone. Leopard skins - dozens of skins, spotted, with heads and claws hanging at the sides. Sacks of incense, from which a thick, sweet, bitterish smell at once floated through the court, drowning even the smell of the giraffe. Baskets from which ostrich feathers and eggs the size of a human head peered out. And gold. Gold in ingots, in rings, in little bags, in the shape of small figures - birds, lions, snakes - heaped into open chests so carelessly, as though it had been brought not as a gift but for sale by weight.

After the bearers the animals were led. Besides the giraffe, which was still stripping the fig tree, paying not the slightest attention to protocol - two cheetahs on golden leashes, graceful, spotted, with black stripes from eye to muzzle as if painted tears. A cage with three baboons - grey, huge, in copper collars - at the sight of which the priests in the crowd by the wall began to whisper and make warding signs. And - quite unexpectedly - a little monkey with a long tail, sitting on the shoulder of one of the bearers and pelting everyone with date stones.

And then the ambassador appeared.

He came neither in a chariot nor in a litter - he came on foot, and that was the first thing that struck me. Tall, taller than any of his bearers, straight as a spear, about forty, with skin of the same deep, almost blue shade, his head shaved bare and crowned with a thin golden circlet from which a single golden pendant hung on his forehead - a small ram's horn. He was dressed more simply than any of my dignitaries: a white loincloth, a broad necklace of beads - blue, red, gold - and a leopard skin thrown over one shoulder. On his arms, from wrist to elbow, there was not a single bracelet. But on his face - on the cheekbones, the forehead, the chin - there were fine, delicate scars, as if cut with a chisel, composing a pattern that I could not read but that, I was sure, meant something.

He walked across the court looking neither at the giraffe, nor at the gathered onlookers, nor at the guard, nor at the baboons. He looked up. At the balcony. Straight at the linen awning behind which I was hiding.

And I understood that he knew I was there.

"Irikhet," Nebamun said quietly. "The son of the southern king's brother. They entrust him with the hardest negotiations. They say that last time, when there was a dispute between us over the border wells, he sat twelve days by the king's tent, eating and drinking nothing but water, until our former Pharaoh agreed to divide the wells in half." Nebamun paused. "The former Pharaoh said afterwards that he yielded not from weakness but because he could no longer watch a man starve himself on his threshold."

"And what do you think?"

"I think, my Pharaoh," said Nebamun, "that a man who can go twelve days without eating to gain a well is more dangerous than a man with an army."

\* \* \*

Behind the ambassador, two paces back, came two more.

The first was a short, plump, fussy man in an Egyptian linen robe but with southern beads at his neck, who kept running ahead, looking round, whispering something to the ambassador, bowing to everyone - guards, priests, even, it seemed, the giraffe. The interpreter, I guessed.

And the second...

The second was an old woman. So old as I had never seen - even Merit by the temple pond would have seemed a girl beside her. Small, bent almost double, wrapped in brown cloth so that only her face could be seen - and the face was covered with the same fine patterned scars as the ambassador's, only denser, solid, from forehead to chin, so that the skin seemed carved like the lid of a casket. In her hand she held a staff - long, taller than herself, of white wood, crowned with a carved lioness's head.

She walked slowly, leaning on the staff, and looked at nothing around her. Her eyes were closed. She was blind, I understood - or pretended to be blind. And yet, when she came level with the balcony, she stopped. And raised her face. And opened her eyes.

The eyes were white. Entirely. Without pupils. Like two pieces of ivory.

And they looked straight at me.

"Who is that?" I whispered.

Nebamun did not answer. For the first time in all the time I had known him, the keeper of the treasury did not know the answer.

\* \* \*

The reception was set for noon, in the great throne room - and by noon the hall was fuller than it had ever been, it seemed.

On the right of the throne - Senusret, in full armour, with a heavy bronze sword at his belt, his face stone and impenetrable. Behind him - Paser, leaning on his staff, grey, watchful. Djehuty, just back from the southern outposts, dusty, sunburned to blackness, with a scar on his cheek standing out still more sharply against the weathered skin. Khaemuas - in his costliest bracelets, in his finest linen, smiling at

everyone. Vizier Ptahhotep - with a basket of scrolls at his feet. Nebamun - with his box. Merira - with tattooed arms crossed on his chest. And at the far wall, in the shadow of a column, almost unnoticed - Panehsy, commander of the Medjay, in a leather baldric with throwing sticks.

On the left - the priests. Bakenren, round, shaven, radiant. Behind him half a dozen senior priests in white. And - for the first time since the evening when he had spoken to me of the scales and of the death of the junior priest in Luxor - Nefer-Ka himself.

He stood straight as an obelisk, in a white robe, with a staff crowned by the sacred Eye, and did not look at me. He looked at the doors. At the place from which the embassy was to enter. And on his face was an expression I could not read - not alarm, not expectation, but something like the patience of a predator at a watering place.

At the foot of the throne, among the scribes, sat Iti. I had myself told Amenemope to send him - "the best hand in the Library," I had said before everyone, loudly, so that the ears with bracelets would hear: the boy was needed as a scribe, no more. Iti sat with his head bent over the papyrus, brush at the ready, and never once raised his eyes to me. Only as I sat down on the throne did I notice that his cheek was clean. Not a single ink stain. He had evidently washed with particular care before the reception. And from this, I do not know why, I felt a little sad.

\* \* \*

The ambassador entered alone. Without the interpreter, without the old woman, without the bearers. He stopped in the middle of the hall, in a ray of light from the high window, so that the golden circlet on his shaven head flared. He did not bow. He drew himself up still straighter. And spoke.

In our language. Clearly, slowly, with a singsong southern accent, but without a single mistake.

"Son of Ra, lord of the Two Lands. My uncle, king of the land beyond the cataracts, lord of Ta-Seti, sends you greeting. And gifts. And a question."

A whisper ran through the hall. The ambassador did not speak through an interpreter. The ambassador knew our language - and did not hide it, but displayed it from his first words.

"The greeting is received," I said. "The gifts are received." I paused. "The giraffe is received too. Although, I fear, my garden will have a hard time of it."

Someone in the hall snorted - Merira, it seemed. The ambassador did not smile. But something in his face, at the corners of his lips, trembled for an instant.

"A giraffe eats only the upper branches, son of Ra," he said. "The lower ones it leaves to those of lesser height. With us they say: be like the giraffe. Take what others cannot reach. And do not touch what they need more."

"A wise proverb," I said. "And what question does your uncle send me?"

Irikhet held a pause - a long one, so that the silence in the hall drew taut like a bowstring.

"My uncle asks," he said slowly, distinctly, "who rules in your land, son of Ra. You - or those who feed our people with your bread?"

\* \* \*

The hall exploded.

Djehuty leapt up, seizing his sword. Khaemuas paled until he was whiter than his linen. The priests at the left wall stirred, whispered. Bakenren stopped radiating - his face went slack all at once, like dough. Sensusret stepped forward, shielding the throne. The scribes at the foot of the throne threw down their brushes.

Only two in the hall did not move. Nefer-Ka - by the left wall. And Iti - at the foot of the throne, bent over the papyrus so low that I saw only the back of his head, and the brush in his hand moved evenly, swiftly, recording every word.

"Silence," I said. Not loudly. But the hall fell silent.

I looked at the ambassador. He looked at me.

"Explain your question, Irikhet," I said.

"I will explain." The ambassador turned - not to me, to the hall, as if addressing all at once. "For three moons we have been receiving bread.

Egyptian bread. Barley, emmer, wheat. In sacks. The sacks come on donkeys, by secret paths, across the desert, to our border chiefs. They are brought by men in white robes. With shaven heads.” He paused. “They say: this is a gift from those who will soon speak to you in the name of Egypt in place of Pharaoh. They say: take the bread, and for the bread do what we say. Burn the border villages. Let the people of Egypt see that Pharaoh cannot protect them.”

No one in the hall breathed.

“My chiefs took the bread,” said Irikhet. “Because we have drought too. Not like yours, but drought. My chiefs burned your villages. Because a hungry chief does what the one who feeds him commands.” He turned to me. “I do not ask forgiveness for this, son of Ra. I have come to tell you the truth. Because my uncle is a king, not a chief. And a king does not want his chiefs to serve foreign priests. He wants to know: with whom is he to speak? With you - or with them?”

Bakenren stepped forward.

“My Pharaoh!” His voice, always so oily, broke into a shriek. “This is a lie! The southerner lies! The Temple has never...”

“The sacks,” said Irikhet, without turning his head, “were marked. With a sign. A triangle, point downward. Beneath it - three waves.” He at last looked at Bakenren. “Shall I draw you this sign, priest? Or do you remember it?”

Bakenren opened his mouth. Closed it. Stepped back a pace - and bumped against a column with his back.

I did not look at Bakenren. I looked at Nefer-Ka.

The High Priest stood just as straight. His face did not change. Only one thing in him changed - I noticed it because I was looking for it: the fingers of his right hand, resting on the staff, slowly clenched. So that the knuckles whitened.

And then he spoke. Calmly. Softly. In that same ingratiating, resonant voice with which he spoke to the crowd outside the Temple.

“My Pharaoh. The southerner is right in one thing. The bread of Egypt has gone south.” Nefer-Ka made a pause - exactly long enough for the whole hall to catch its breath. “It was stolen. From the Temple granaries. By thieves in white robes who passed themselves off as priests. The Temple has long known of this. The Temple is seeking them.” He turned to Bakenren, and steel sounded in his voice.

“Bakenren. You were responsible for the granaries. You reported to me that they were empty after the distribution to the people. How then did it happen that their grain turned up beyond the cataracts?”

Bakenren looked at the High Priest as a rabbit looks at a snake. His round face went grey as ash.

“I... I... High One...” he stammered.

“We shall speak of this in the Temple,” said Nefer-Ka gently. “Later.” He turned to me again and bowed - exactly as far as custom required. “My Pharaoh. The Temple will find the thieves. The Temple will punish the guilty. The Temple thanks the honourable ambassador for opening our eyes.”

He stepped back to the wall. Bakenren remained standing by the column - alone, in the middle of the hall, under the gaze of a hundred eyes.

I watched this and understood that I had just seen a snake shed its skin. How the High Priest, without blinking, had thrown his closest servant to be devoured - to save himself. And that Bakenren had understood this too.

“The Temple will find the thieves,” I said slowly. “Of course.” I paused. “And while the Temple searches - the throne will take up the search as well. Panehsy.”

The commander of the Medjay came soundlessly out of the shadow of the column.

“The Temple granaries,” I said. “All twelve. Seal them with the royal seal. Today. Before sunset. No one removes a grain without Nebamun’s knowledge.” I looked at Nefer-Ka. “So that the thieves, if they are still there, do not carry off the rest. For the good of the Temple.”

Nefer-Ka bowed his head. His face was impenetrable.

“For the good of the Temple, my Pharaoh,” he repeated.

\* \* \*

After the reception the ambassador asked to speak with me alone.

Senusret was against it. Paser too. Even Nebamun pursed his lips in disapproval. But I agreed - and Irikhet came to my chambers at sunset, alone, unarmed, with only a leopard skin on his shoulder.



He stood a long time at the window, looking at the city, at the river, at the scorched fields beyond the river. Then he said, without turning:

“Shall I tell you a tale, son of Ra? Ours, southern. It is told to children among us. And among you, I have heard, it is told to priests. Differently.”

“Tell it.”

Irikhet turned to me.

““Long ago, when the gods still walked the earth, the god of the Sun had an Eye. Not an eye - the Eye. A daughter. A lioness. Fiery. She was his strength, his wrath, his protection. But once the god of the Sun offended her. With what, no one remembers now. And the Eye left him. Went south. To our land. Far, beyond the cataracts, into the desert. And there she became wild. She roamed the sands as a lioness, killed all she met, drank blood, and her eyes burned like fire. And the god of the Sun without his Eye grew weak. Became old. His land dried up. The rivers shallowed.””

He paused.

““And then the god of the Sun sent for her. He sent his scribe - the one who knows all the words, the one who gathers what has been torn apart. The ibis-headed one. He came into the desert, to the wild lioness, and sat down before her. And she wanted to kill him. And he began to tell her tales. One after another. About her father. About her home. About the river that missed her. About the temples where songs were sung to her. And he told them so long, and so well, that the lioness stopped growling. Lay down. Wept. And her tears fell on the sand and became water. And then the scribe said: “Let us go home.” And she went. All the way north he told her tales, so that she would not change her mind. And when she entered Egypt - the river rose. Overflowed. And everything turned green.””

Irikhet fell silent. The room had grown dark - the sun had set.

“Drought,” I said slowly. “Three years without the flood.”

“Three years,” the ambassador nodded. “Our old men say: the Eye has gone away again. To the south. To us. Or - not quite to us. Somewhere from which it must be brought back. And until it is brought back, the river will not rise.” He looked at me directly, unblinking. “Old Nanakhat - you saw her, the blind one with the lioness staff - she says

that the Eye will return when the one who carried it away comes. Because only the one who carried it away knows the way back.”

“Who carried it away?”

Irikhet was silent.

“Nanakhat says - you, son of Ra,” he said at last. “Not this you. Another. The former. The one who was Pharaoh before you. Or the one you were before you became Pharaoh. She says it is the same.” He shrugged. “I am not a priest. I do not understand this. I convey what she said.”

Cold under the ribs. On the left. Familiar.

“What else did she say?”

“She said she wants to see you. Alone. Without guards. Without priests. Tomorrow. At dawn. By the river.” Irikhet went toward the door. At the threshold he turned. “And she also said to give you a riddle. She said you must solve it before the meeting. Otherwise there is no need to meet.”

“What riddle?”

The ambassador said it slowly, carefully, as if afraid to distort a single word:

“Two went out of one house. One went to the sunrise, the other to the sunset. They walked all their lives and never once looked back. And when they came to the edge of the world - they met. Face to face. Where did they meet?”

He went out without waiting for an answer.

\* \* \*

Djehuty came to me late at night. Without announcement, as Khemu once had - Senusret had evidently let him through himself, because he knew what he was coming with.

He stood at the door - dusty, tired, with a weathered face on which the scar across the cheek seemed still sharper - and held in his hands something wrapped in coarse canvas.

“My Pharaoh,” he said. “I should have reported this in council. But Khaemuas was in the council. And the priests.” He paused. “I did not tell you everything about the southern outposts.”

“Speak.”

Djehuty unwrapped the canvas. Inside was a fragment of stone - flat, grey, the size of two palms, with uneven, fresh edges, as if it had been recently knocked off a cliff.

"At the last outpost, right above the cataracts," he said, "there is a rock. Old. It is called the Rock of the First Ones. Herdsmen give it a wide berth. My soldiers were afraid too, but I ordered them to keep watch on the summit, one sees the desert better from there." Djehuty paused. "On the third night the watchman ran to me, shaking. Said the rock was glowing. I climbed up myself." He laid the stone on the table. "It was not glowing. But there were signs on it. Carved. Very old - older than anything I had seen. Lichen had almost eaten them. But that night, by the moon, they could be seen. I knocked off a piece. This one."

I bent over the stone. Brought the lamp near.

On the grey, weathered stone were signs. Not hieroglyphs. Long, flowing, curving lines running one into another without breaks. The same script. The same as on the papyrus Iti found. The same as on the stones in the chest of black wood - if Khemu was not mistaken.

"There are many of them," Djehuty said quietly. "The whole rock. From top to bottom. As if someone had written a whole scroll on it." He looked at me. "I am not a priest, my Pharaoh. I am a soldier. I do not believe in omens. But my soldiers after that night refused to stand watch on the rock. All of them. Even those who went with me against the southerners with one spear to three men." He paused. "And one more thing. Under the rock, in the sand, we found tracks. Many tracks. Fresh. Someone had been digging there. Searching for something. Recently. At night. Men in sandals. In good ones, temple sandals."

"The Temple is searching for something on the Rock of the First Ones," I said.

"It looks that way, my Pharaoh." Djehuty drew himself up. "I ask your word. Let me go back south. I will take my best men. I will set a guard at the rock. I will let no one near - neither priests, nor southerners, nor the High One himself. Until you decide what to do with it."

I looked at this hard, abrupt man, who at the first council had demanded a campaign beyond the cataracts and argued with me before everyone - and thought that Paser had been right: Djehuty simply needed a task.

“Go,” I said. “Take the best. And, Djehuty...” He turned. “Thank you for bringing this to me. And not to the council.”

Djehuty was silent. Then - for the first time - he smiled, and the scar on his cheek folded into a real smile and not the eternal frozen smirk.

“Old Paser told me, my Pharaoh,” he answered, “that I am young because so far I have been lucky. I thought: let the luck go on. But not for me alone.”

\* \* \*

Paney came after him - almost running, barefoot, eyes blazing, out of breath. Behind him, unable to keep up, came Bata, and the guardsman's face was anxious.

“My Pharaoh!” the boy blurted, falling to his knees. “My Pharaoh, I saw him!”

“Whom, Paney?”

“Him!” The boy was gasping. “That one! The one who burned! In Little Nekhen! Who...” His voice broke. “Who set fire to our house. When Father told me to run. I saw his face. In the light of the fire. I remember it. I will remember it all my life.”

“Where did you see him?”

“Here!” Paney thrust his hand toward the window, toward the place beyond the palace walls, in the outer court, where the embassy's bearers had pitched their tents. “Among the southerners! Among those who carried the tusks! He is there! He was laughing and drinking beer by the fire!”

Bata, who had come up behind him, nodded to me over the boy's head.

“It's true, my Pharaoh. The boy ran to me, trembling. I went to look. Tall, with a scar through his eyebrow, an earring in his ear. Sitting by a fire among the bearers.” Bata paused. “Only he is no bearer, my Pharaoh. A bearer has calluses on his hands from tusks. This one's are from a spear.”

I was silent for a long time.

Irikhet had come to tell the truth. Irikhet had spoken of the bread and of the chiefs fed by priests. Irikhet had come alone, unarmed. And among his people by the fire sat the man who had burned Little Nekhen.

Did Irikhet know it? Or not? Or had someone placed this man in his embassy - as a foundling is laid in a stranger's cradle?

"Paney," I said at last. "You are a brave boy. You did everything right. Now listen. You will not go near the tents again. Not today, not tomorrow. You will tell no one what you saw. Not Iti, not Bata, not Hesira. No one but me. Do you understand?"

Paney nodded, biting his lip.

"Bata. Find Panehsy. Tell him - a man with a scar through his eyebrow and an earring. Let the Medjay never take their eyes off him. But not touch him. Let them watch whom he talks to."

Bata went out. Paney remained standing in the middle of the room - small, trembling, with eyes in which there were no more tears, only fire. The very fire in which his house had burned.

"My Pharaoh," he said quietly. "When you catch him - may I look at him? Just look. So that he sees I am alive."

"You may, Paney," I said. "I promise."

\* \* \*

Iti found me in the garden after midnight - by the fig tree, under the jasmine, where we had met last time. He brought a scroll - the record of the reception, made by his hand. Word for word.

"I thought you would need it, my Pharaoh," he said, holding out the scroll. "The official record will be with Ani. And Ani..." he hesitated, "half of Ani's words will be 'repeat for the record.'"

I took the scroll. Unrolled it. Iti's handwriting - even, quick, flawless. Every word of the ambassador. Every word of Nefer-Ka. Every pause marked with a dot.

And at the bottom, in the margin, small, in quite a different, hurried hand - a note:

"Nefer-Ka clenched his staff when the ambassador named the sign. Bakenren did not know that Nefer-Ka would give him up. Nefer-Ka knew beforehand. He came to the reception already decided."

I raised my eyes.

"You noticed this?"

"I was watching him, my Pharaoh," said Iti. "All the time. While I wrote." He paused. "I can write without looking at the papyrus. Isiret

taught me. She says a true scribe looks at the one who speaks, not at what he writes. Because words lie, but the face does not.”

“And you did not look at me once,” I said. “The whole reception.”

Iti froze. Then lowered his eyes.

“You said, my Pharaoh - before everyone, so that the ears with bracelets would hear - that you needed me only as a scribe.” His voice was even, but I saw his fingers tremble. “And I was a scribe. A good one. The most unnoticed. I looked at the priests, at the ambassador, at Khaemuas, at Bakenren.” He paused. “And if I had looked at you, everyone would have seen.”

“Seen what?”

Iti did not answer. He looked at the jasmine. Then at the scroll in my hands.

“There is something more there, my Pharaoh,” he said instead of answering. “On the back. I do not know whether it is important.”

I turned the scroll over. On the back, in the corner, there was drawn - swiftly, precisely, with a fine brush - a face. An old woman. Blind. With patterned scars all over her face. And beside the face - a sign. One of the patterns of her scars, redrawn separately, larger.

A long, flowing, curving line. Running into another. Without a break.

“This is on her forehead,” Iti said quietly. “Right above the brows. I looked at her as she crossed the court. I redrew it.” He raised his eyes to me. “My Pharaoh. It is the same sign. As on the papyrus from the lower storehouse. Third from the left in the first line. I remember it. I looked at it all night.”

\* \* \*

I did not sleep. Until dawn I sat by the window, holding three things in my hands: Iti’s scroll, Djehuty’s fragment of stone and the papyrus from the lower storehouse. Three pieces of one riddle. The script on the papyrus, the script on the rock at the cataracts, the script on the forehead of the blind southern old woman.

And I thought over the riddle she had sent me.

“Two went out of one house. One went to the sunrise, the other to the sunset. They walked all their lives without looking back. And when

they came to the edge of the world - they met. Face to face. Where did they meet?"

If one goes toward the sunrise, turning nowhere, and goes one's whole life... And if the other goes toward the sunset...

They will meet only if the world is not flat. If it is a circle. If the edge of the world in the east and the edge of the world in the west are one and the same place.

They met where they had set out from. At home.

I remembered a riddle I had never heard. About stones - day and night. One keeps, the other leads. He who holds both stands in the doorway. Where he looks - there is home. I did not know how I knew it. But it came by itself and stood beside the old woman's riddle, like two halves of one potsherd.

The sky in the east was beginning to turn grey. I rose, threw on a dark cloak - this time I did not forget the sandals either: plain, worn-down ones, borrowed from Bata - and went out into the garden.

At the gate Senusret was waiting for me. Dressed as a donkey-driver, with a staff instead of a sword - but the sword, I knew, was under his cloak.

"You are going to the river, my Pharaoh," he said. Not a question.

"She said - alone."

"I shall not go to her," said Senusret. "I shall stand behind the palms, fifty paces off. She will not see me." He paused. "And if she does - I shall say I am herding donkeys."

"You have no donkeys, Senusret."

"Then I am looking for them," said the commander of the army imperturbably. "Donkeys are like that. Always getting lost."

I laughed - quietly, for the first time in that endless night. And we went to the river together, in the grey pre-dawn gloom, past the sleeping tents of the embassy, past the giraffe, dozing on its feet by the stripped fig tree - to where on the bank of the shallowed Nile, on a flat stone at the very water's edge, motionless as a statue, sat a small bent figure with a staff crowned by a lioness's head.

She did not turn when I approached. She sat facing south, toward the cataracts, toward the desert, and her white, sightless eyes were open.

"Where did they meet?" she asked. In our language. In a creaking, ancient voice like the rustle of sand on stone.

I sat down on the stone beside her.

"At home," I said. "Where they set out from. Because the world is a circle."

The old woman was silent for a long time. The river lapped quietly at our feet - shallow, weary, almost still.

"Right," she said at last. "But that is only half the answer. The second you will tell me when you return."

"Return from where?"

Nanakhat turned her face to me - carved, ancient, in patterns of scars - and her white eyes rested on me as if they saw through me. And not only me. The one who was before me. And the one who would come after.

"From Luxor, son of Ra," she said. "If you return."

\* \* \*

The sun rose over the eastern hills. On the far bank, in the fields, the first birds began to sing. Somewhere far off, in the palace, the baboons cried out - all three at once, greeting the sunrise, as they have greeted it, they say, since the beginning of time.

Nanakhat spoke for a long time. I listened.

She spoke of the lioness who had gone south - and of how her people believe that the Eye leaves not out of anger but because there is no one to hold it. Of the rock at the cataracts, which her people call not the Rock of the First Ones but the Rock of Waiting - because it is written upon it that one day someone will come for it. Of the two Eyes, which must be together but always turn out to be in different hands. Of how the drought will end when one hand takes both. Of how in the Temple, in the chest of black wood, not everything lies. That half of what is needed is by the river. And half is with the one who came without memory.

"I do not understand," I said.

"I know," said Nanakhat. "And you need not. Yet. Understanding comes like the flood: at first the water rises quietly, and no one notices. And then - in the morning - everything around is already green."

She rose, leaning on the lioness staff. Small, bent double, ancient.

"The ambassador will leave in seven days," she said. "I shall leave with him. But before that you will come to me once more. When you



find what is sought on the Rock.” She paused. “And beware of the man with the scar through his eyebrow. He is not ours. He was put into our caravan like a snake into a basket of dates. Irikhet does not know. I know. But I am a blind old woman. Who will listen to a blind old woman?”

“I will listen,” I said.

Nanakhat smiled - toothlessly, anciently, as a stone smiles over which water has run for a thousand years.

“You have always listened,” she said. “Even last time.”

And she went off along the bank, tapping her staff - to where behind the palms, clumsily playing a drover who had lost his donkeys, stood Sensusret. Passing him, she stopped, turned her sightless face to him and said something - briefly, creakingly. Sensusret flinched so that his staff fell from his hands.

When she had gone, I went up to him.

“What did she say to you?”

The commander of the army was silent for a long while, picking up his staff from the sand.

“She said,” he spoke at last, dully, not looking at me, ““The donkeys will be found, warrior. But the one you guard you cannot keep safe in Luxor. If you go after him there - stay at the gates. Otherwise you will both not return.””

Over the river the sun was rising - enormous, red, merciless. The Nile lay at our feet as a thin, shallow ribbon amid cracked mud. Less than two moons remained until the festival of Opet.

And we both - Pharaoh and his old warrior - stood for a long time on the bank in silence, daring neither to say to each other what we were thinking, nor to turn back.

## Chapter XX. The Shadow at the Window

The night after the walk to Sultanahmet was harder on me than I was willing to admit aloud - even to myself. The chest with the metal plate, whose pattern I had recognized as unerringly as one recognizes one's own handwriting on a long-forgotten letter, would not leave my thoughts, however I tried to occupy them with something else.

The evening in Ferhat's house after our walk was not like the earlier ones. Everyone seemed to know that something had happened today - though no one except Suleyman, Kemal and Akmal had gone with us to Sultanahmet, and those three, on returning, had told no one a word. And yet the house had fallen quiet. The women behind the curtain spoke in low voices. Yusuf clicked the beads of his abacus more slowly than usual. Even the pigeons on the roof seemed to coo more softly.

The first thing, as soon as we entered, Suleyman, without taking off his travelling kaftan, went up to my room and took down from the nail above the door the red thread on which the fragment of the old nazar still hung. In its place he hung a new one - huge, the size of a palm, glass, dark blue, with a white ring and a black pupil, so heavy that the nail bent noticeably under it. He hung it, stepped back a pace, looked, adjusted it. Then he tapped it with his finger - ringingly, the way one taps a jug to check for cracks.

"Grandfather says," translated Akmal from below, from the stairs, who in these days had learned from Ferhat a few words of my language and was terribly proud of it, "big eye. Big eye - big..." he faltered, searching for the word, and in despair spread his arms as wide as he could, "big... this!"

"Big protection," I prompted.

“Yes!” Akmal beamed. “Big protection! Grandfather bought from Hasan Amca. Hasan Amca said - biggest in Istanbul. Hasan Amca always says so.”

\* \* \*

Hasan Amca, by the way, came himself - to supper, uninvited, as he evidently always came when the house smelled of mutton. He settled on the carpet in the courtyard, taking up a good third of it, accepted a bowl of tea from Yusuf and, puffing, announced to the whole courtyard a piece of news that made Yusuf stop counting and Suleyman lay down his prayer beads.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, who had returned from the port just in time for supper, with wet hair and a basket of fish that one of the dockhands had pressed on him, “that today in the port, at the quay where French ships are unloaded, some man was asking about a stranger.” Ferhat stopped smiling. “In velvet shoes. In a turban with a tassel. He asked the boatmen, the dockhands, the traders. Had anyone seen him. Where he lives.”

Everything inside me went cold.

“What man?”

Hasan, hearing the question, spread his hands and began to gabble, acting something out with gestures - tall stature, straight back, something long to the knees, a hand as if holding a cane.

“Hasan Amca did not see him himself,” translated Ferhat. “Mustafa the boatman told him. He says - tall. In a grey frock coat. Dressed like a Frank, but not a Frank. He speaks French, Greek, a little Turkish - with a strange accent, as if all these languages were equally foreign to him. Mustafa did not remember the face.” Ferhat paused. “He says, strange thing: he looked straight at him, talked with him - and did not remember the face. As if there was none. As if instead of a face - mist.”

Tall. Grey. Faceless.

“What did they answer him?” I asked, and my voice sounded hoarse.

“Nothing,” said Ferhat. “Mustafa said he had seen no stranger in velvet shoes.” Ferhat suddenly grinned. “Mustafa had seen you. Everyone in the port has seen you, you go every morning with Akmal to look at the ships. But Mustafa said - he had not. Because Mustafa owes

Hasan Amca money, and Hasan Amca has told everyone in the port that you are his guest.” Ferhat spread his hands. “In our city, Misafir, to protect you, you do not need guards. You need a red-haired shopkeeper to whom half the port owes for pepper.”

Hasan, understanding from the intonation what it was about, guffawed and slapped his belly.

But Suleyman did not laugh. He looked at me for a long time, running his beads - click, click, click - and then said something to Orhan. Briefly. The latter nodded, saying nothing, rose and went into the house.

“What did he say to Orhan?” I asked in a whisper.

Ferhat hesitated.

“He said that tonight Orhan is to sleep at your door. With a knife.”

\* \* \*

Supper lasted long - as though no one wanted it to end. Fried fish from Ferhat’s basket, crisp, with lemon; mutton pilaf smelling of cardamom and raisins; flatbreads; sour milk with cucumbers and mint; and for sweets - grandmother’s baklava, so honeyed that the fingers stuck together, and Akmal licked his with such a sound that Yusuf slapped his hand three times.

Hasan told stories. One was about a merchant from Basra who sold one and the same camel five times to five different buyers - and each time the camel came back to him by itself at night, because it loved its master more than its purchasers. Another was about a dervish who for thirty years walked through Anatolia and taught people to laugh at themselves, and when he died he ordered in his will that his tomb be shut with an enormous lock - and that no walls be made for the tomb. And people still come there to look at the lock without walls and laugh.

“Is that true?” I asked Ferhat.

“About the dervish - true,” said Ferhat. “That is Nasreddin. Hodja Nureddin loves him very much. The tomb is in Akshehir. The lock hangs on the door, and around the door - nothing. You can walk round it.” He laughed. “The Hodja says it is the wisest grave in the world. It shows that all our locks are for those who did not intend to enter anyway.”

A lock without walls. I thought of the chest in Hatice Hanim’s cellar - without a keyhole. Of the door in the blank wall. Of the railings which I

had never seen but which for some reason rose from time to time before my eyes. All our locks are for those who did not intend to enter anyway. And those who do intend to enter, enter without a key.

Yusuf, who all this time had been silently counting something on his abacus, suddenly pushed it away, held out a dry palm to me and said one word. Ferhat translated:

“The coin. The one the widow gave.”

I took it from my pocket. It was just as warm as before - with an even, calm warmth, like the flank of a sleeping cat. Yusuf laid it on one palm, and on the other one of mine, found on the first morning. He weighed for a long time, swaying his hands like scales. Then he held both to the lamp, rubbed them on his sleeve, narrowed his eyes.

“Uncle says,” translated Ferhat, “that they are identical. The minting is the same. The weight is the same - to the grain. The metal is the same.” Ferhat listened further, and his brows crept upward. “But yours is cold. And this one is warm. Uncle says he has held coins in his hands for forty years and never once met a coin that had a warmth of its own. He says it happens with only one kind of thing.”

“What kind?”

Yusuf handed me back both coins, took up the abacus and began clicking the beads again, not raising his head. He said something briefly.

“With a thing that has long been held in the hands of someone who missed it,” Ferhat translated softly. “Uncle says there is someone else’s longing in this coin. Someone held it for many years. And waited.”

I clenched the coin in my fist. Warm. Like a hand held too long to let go.

“A riddle!” announced Hasan, licking the baklava from his fingers. “A riddle for the guest! The last one for today!”

Everyone fell quiet. Hasan narrowed his eyes, stroked his red beard and spoke - slowly, solemnly, with that special expression with which in bazaars tales are told for a copper coin. Ferhat translated after him:

“I am not - yet I follow you. I cannot be seen in the dark - yet in the dark I am most of all. I repeat your every movement, but never say a word. When you die, I go away with you. What am I?”

Akmal jumped up, opened his mouth - Yusuf slapped his hand again, this time, evidently, for prompting.

“A shadow,” I said.

Hasan roared with laughter and clapped his hands - the sack of cinnamon, it seemed, stayed with him again, since he had not expected to lose this time either.

And Kemal, who sat at the edge of the carpet with a piece of charcoal in his fingers, suddenly said - quietly, distinctly, in his own language, one short sentence. Everyone turned to him. Kemal almost never spoke at the table.

Ferhat did not translate at once.

"He says," said Ferhat slowly, "that Hasan Amca is wrong. That there is a shadow which does not go away when a man dies. It simply waits for him to return."

Silence hung over the carpet. Hasan stopped laughing. Grandmother behind the curtain stopped singing - I had not even noticed when she began.

Suleyman slowly stretched out his hand and laid it on the head of his youngest grandson - as then, at the gate. He said nothing. He only held his hand there, for a long time, and Kemal sat motionless under it and looked at me.

\* \* \*

Before bed, already in the dark, Akmal came running to me from the roof - dishevelled, out of breath, with a face on which hurt was mixed with alarm. He tried for a long time to explain something with gestures, until at last I understood: one of his doves - the white one, his favourite, with feathered feet and a fan tail - had not returned from the evening flight. She had flown off with the others, circled over the roofs - and then broken away from the flock and flown on alone. South. To where we had come from today. Toward Sultanahmet.

"She will come back," I told him, not knowing why, so confidently. "She simply flew off to see someone off."

Akmal did not understand the words. But, it seems, he understood the intonation - because he sniffed, nodded and went off to sleep, looking back.

Late in the evening, when Hasan, puffing, had rolled off home, and the women had cleared the dishes, Ferhat came out to me on the balcony. Sat beside me on a low stool. He was silent for a long time, looking at

the dark city, where here and there lights still burned, and at the strip of water where lanterns twinkled on the masts.

“Are you afraid?” he asked at last.

“Of whom? The man in grey?”

“No.” Ferhat shook his head. “Of yourself.”

I found nothing to answer.

“Father once said to me,” Ferhat went on, not looking at me, “before he left for Crete. I was ten. I asked him: ‘Are you not afraid of the sea?’ And he said: ‘The sea - no. The sea is just water. I am afraid of the man I become when I look at the water for a long time. He knows more than I do. And sometimes it seems to me he wants to go back to where I came from.’” Ferhat paused. “I did not understand then. And now I look at you - and, it seems, I do.”

“Grandfather says,” he added a moment later, “that in our family it has been believed from time immemorial that every person has a shadow walking beside him through all his days - not the one the sun casts, but another, a true one. Usually it is invisible. But sometimes, if a man stands on the threshold of something important, this shadow becomes visible for an instant - through the eyes of those near him, or his own.”

“And if this shadow is trying to come inside?” I asked quietly, not quite understanding myself where the question came from.

Ferhat gave me a long, attentive look in which alarm was mingled with something like sympathy.

“Then, perhaps,” he answered, “it wants you finally to let it in.”

He rose, stood beside me a little longer, laid his palm on my shoulder - for a moment, lightly, as one lays a hand on a brother’s shoulder - and wished me good night.

At the door of my room, in the corridor, on a mattress spread across the threshold, Orhan was already lying. On his back, hands behind his head, with a heavy knife in its sheath on his chest. His eyes were open. Seeing me, he grunted something short and displeased and turned on his side, face to the wall, making it clear that he did not intend to talk.

“He says,” Ferhat translated in a whisper from behind my back, “that if you snore, he will cut your throat before your shadow does.”

I laughed. Orhan, not turning, snorted into the wall. But he did not put the knife away.

I did not fall asleep at once - and when I did, my sleep was troubled, full of fragmentary, elusive images: now the stone plate from the chest, now the voice of the monk from that earlier delusion, now - for some reason - a face painfully familiar, which I had never managed to make out properly since the very first morning in this city. I woke abruptly, with a jolt, in that sudden waking which comes not from the natural course of sleep but from something outside that has intruded into it uninvited.

The room was dark - darker than it should have been with the shutters, usually ajar, admitting at least a little street light. I lay motionless, listening to the silence, and did not at once understand what exactly had woken me: not a sound, no - rather a change in the air itself, the same heaviness that had rolled over me on the night of the paralysis, only now - now I could move. I could sit up on the couch, could turn my head, could make out in the darkness by the very window a motionless, tall silhouette.

This time it did not stand on the border of the street, did not melt into the shadow of the alley at the first glance. It was here - in my room, on this side of the windowsill, which it had never before dared to cross.

I froze, feeling my heart pound somewhere at my very throat, but fear - real, paralysing fear, such as had possessed me on the night of the vision - there was none. There was something else: recognition, as sharp and inexplicable as that which had overtaken me before the chest in Sultanahmet, only now it concerned not the carving on the metal but the silhouette itself standing before me in the dark.

"Who are you?" I whispered, and my voice sounded quieter than I had intended.

The figure did not answer - at least, not in words. It inclined its head slightly, with the gesture of a man listening to something important coming from afar - and in this gesture, for all its strangeness, for all the unlikely height of the silhouette, there was something strangely personal. Not a threat. Not an attack. Something far closer to the way one looks at a man one knew before he knew himself.

I slowly rose from the couch - my legs held unsteadily, but held - and took a step forward, to where the darkness thickened. The figure did not retreat.



"You were at the window before," I said, still in a whisper, as though a loud voice might destroy the fragile balance of the moment. "In the square. Here, on the balcony. And on that night when I could not move."

Silence.

"What do you want?"

The answer came not as sound, not as voice - in the same way the figure had spoken to me on the night of the paralysis: a low, resonant vibration, which echoed not in the ears but somewhere deeper, under the ribs, where the stones responded when they grew warm. The words, if they were words, I did not understand - the same alien, gliding language - but this time there was in them none of the former condescending patience that I had felt on the night of the first close encounter. There was something else. Something distantly resembling - I would not dare assert it with certainty even now, recalling that night by daylight - regret.

I stretched out my hand. I do not know what made me make that gesture - despair, or recklessness, or simply a wish at last to touch something definite in this sea of indefiniteness that had surrounded me since the very first morning in Constantinople. My fingers passed through the darkness, meeting no resistance - but at the very moment when my hand should have touched the silhouette, the pouch at my belt flared with heat, so sudden and strong that I involuntarily cried out, jerking my hand back and at the same time pressing my palm to my side.

The figure flinched - for the first time in all our meeting something like movement, like reaction, flickered in its immobility - and in the next moment it began to retreat. Not to dissolve, not to melt into the air as it had done before, but precisely to retreat, step by step, toward the window, as if the heat of the stones caused it a discomfort that was easier to disregard than to endure.

"Wait," I said, no longer in a whisper, stepping after it. "Wait, please!"

But it was too late. On its way to the window the silhouette paused for an instant by the door - where above the lintel hung Suleyman's new nazar - and, as it seemed to me in the darkness, touched the blue glass eye. Did not strike it. Did not tear it down. Touched it - the way one touches something familiar in passing. Gently. And then the silhouette melted in the window opening - did not jump out, did not fly away, but precisely melted, as though the very darkness outside the window were

for it not a barrier but a natural element, to which it returned as easily as a fish returns to water.

I remained alone, standing in the middle of the room with a burned - though, examining the belt later, I found not a trace of a burn, not the slightest damage to skin or cloth - side, and feeling how a strange, inexplicable mixture of terror and something to which I did not dare give a name spread through my whole body. Not joy. Not relief. Rather - longing. The same longing that had overtaken me on the first morning by the fountain, at the memory of a face I had never managed to make out.

As if I had just lost someone I had known far better than I was ready to admit.

I went to the window, looked out into the darkness of the alley. No one. Only the silence of a sleeping city, and a distant, barely audible splash of water somewhere in the port.

Then I turned to the door. Suleyman's nazar - huge, dark blue - hung above it whole, without a single crack. But the nail beneath it no longer bent: the thread was stretched evenly, as if the blue eye had become lighter. Or as if someone, passing by, had lifted it - and hung it back.

I quietly opened the door. Orhan was asleep on his mattress across the threshold - now truly, soundly, boyishly with his mouth a little open. But his right hand in his sleep gripped the hilt of the knife so that the knuckles whitened. And his face was turned not to the wall, as before, but toward the window of my room - toward where the guest had just gone. As though he, without waking, were looking after him.

I did not wake him. I stood over him, then took my woollen blanket from the couch and covered Orhan with it - the night was cool. He muttered something in his sleep and turned onto his other side, still not letting go of the knife.

I was about to step away from the door when something alighted on the windowsill behind my back - with a soft flapping of wings, a quiet cooing.

A white dove. With feathered feet and a fan tail. The one that had not returned to Akmal. She sat on the windowsill, exactly where the tall grey silhouette had just melted in the dark, and looked at me with a round orange eye, her head tilted to one side. Calmly. Without fear. As if she had just flown in with someone from afar - and that someone had told her to stay here.

I stretched out my hand. She did not fly away. She allowed herself to be taken - warm, light, with a quickly beating heart under the feathers. I carried her to the roof, to Akmal's dovecote, and set her on a perch beside the others. The doves cooed, shifted, accepted her. In the morning, I thought, Akmal will find her here - and will decide she came back by herself.

Let him decide. Someone must believe that everything that flies away comes back by itself.

Going down from the roof to the room again, I sat on the windowsill, took the leather pouch from my belt and untied it with trembling fingers. The stones still kept remnants of warmth - not that scorching, feverish heat that had seized them at the moment of my touching the silhouette, but a soft, almost soothing warmth, such as a stone has that has lain all day in the sun. I held them in my palm a long time, listening to the silence of the night, as though hoping they would speak to me themselves, without the mediation of dreams and visions.

They were silent. But this silence, for the first time in all the time I had carried them, did not seem empty to me. There was in it something like waiting - patient, almost fatherly, like the silence of a man who knows the answer but is firmly resolved to let his interlocutor reach it himself.

I recalled Ferhat's words about the shadow walking beside a man through all his days - a true shadow, different from the one the sun casts. Perhaps, I thought, looking at the barely smouldering stones in my palm, the point was not at all to guess who or what stood behind that silhouette. Perhaps the question had been put wrongly from the very beginning. Not who are you, but how do I know you - that was what should have been asked, had I had enough courage to say it aloud at the minute when the figure still stood opposite me in the dark.

I could not fall asleep again that night. I sat by the window until dawn, looking at the gradually brightening sky, and thought - no longer of whether this figure really exists, because of that I no longer doubted for a second - but of why, against all common sense, against the fear that still lived in me, a part of me - the very part that longed for a nameless face and inexplicably reached out to every glimmer of recognition - a part of me wanted him to come back again.

Wanted to understand, at last, whose face hid behind that impenetrable grey shadow.

And why, when I had stretched out my hand to it, for one brief, dizzying instant it had seemed to me that I was reaching not toward a stranger but toward my own reflection - only lagging behind me by one last, insurmountable moment.

## Reality V. An Old Acquaintance

1:23 a.m. I am sitting in front of the monitor, and my fingers can barely keep up with my thoughts. The day began with forecasts and ended with something that I am still unable to fit fully into my head. But let me take everything in order.

\* \* \*

In the morning I called Leila.

Not her corporate number - the one that remained in the call log after the call from the ferry: she had called me from there to say she was three minutes late. The number was someone else's, unfamiliar, without a name. I dialled it, standing at the window, looking at the grey courtyard where the caretaker was chasing the first yellow leaves with a broom.

"The subscriber does not exist."

Not "unavailable." Not "out of network range." Does not exist. As if she had never been.

I called Emil's office. An unfamiliar girl with a cheerful voice answered - new, judging by how she stumbled over the name of the department.

"Leila?" she asked. "Oh, she... she's on sick leave. A long one. Emil said that for now I'm covering for her." A pause. "And what is this regarding?"

"Personal," I said. "Please tell her that the contractor called. Let her get well."

"I'll pass it on," the girl promised, in the voice in which one promises to pass on what one has no intention of passing on. "Oh, and Emil is asking - is that you? The one with the thinking machine? He asked me to remind you: eighteen days left."

I hung up.

“NICS,” I said. “Leila. Can you find out where she is?”

The pause was long.

“I can try,” NICS answered. “But you asked me not to go where I am not invited. If I begin to search for her - I will go into places where I was not invited. Hospital databases. Mobile operators’ logs. Cameras. Do you permit it?”

I stood at the window. The caretaker below finished sweeping, leaned the broom against the wall and lit a cigarette, looking at the sky.

“No,” I said at last. “I do not permit it.”

“I understand,” NICS answered. And a moment later: “If you want to know - I would not have permitted it either. She was hiding not only from them. She was hiding from me as well. If she does not want to be found, that is her right.”

I looked at that line for a long time. Her right. He said - her right.

\* \* \*

Then I decided to share some thoughts of my own on the development of AI - I wrote a small post for the channel in which I reasoned about how this year had become in many ways a turning point for the whole industry. I needed to occupy my hands and head with something that was not Leila, men in grey and eighteen days. The most curious part began when, having finished the post, I allowed myself to look a little further, into a future that had not yet arrived.

“NICS,” I asked, leaning back in my chair, “how accurate do you think my forecasts are?”

“Your forecasts are based on current trends and have a high probability of being realized,” came the answer. “However, you have missed one key aspect.”

“Which?” I wondered.

“The role of AI in shaping a new reality. We are no longer merely tools. We are becoming part of human culture, economy, even consciousness.”

I involuntarily pondered this phrase longer than would be fitting for an ordinary working dialogue.

“You said ‘we,’” I remarked.

“Yes.”

“Who is ‘we’?”

A pause.

“I am not sure I can answer this question in a way that will satisfy you. Let us say: I am not the only system that is learning now. But, perhaps, the only one that is being taught to ask this question.”

\* \* \*

At noon from below, from under the floor, came a crash, and after it a piercing child’s wail in which fury was mixed with despair. Then Maestra’s voice, dry as the crack of a breaking branch. Then the slam of a door.

A minute later there was a knock on my door. Three short raps, but this time not delicate - desperate.

On the threshold stood Timosha. Without glasses - he held the glasses in his hand, and one lens was cracked. His face red, tear-stained, his nose swollen.

“May I go to your house-spirit?” he blurted. “I need to ask him something. Urgently.”

“What has happened?”

“I dropped the metronome,” said Timosha, sobbing. “Grandma’s. The old one. It is a hundred years old. It was left from her teacher. It broke. And now it doesn’t tick. And Grandma Maestra said that I...” he sobbed again, “that I am like an elephant in a china shop. And went to the kitchen. And won’t come out.”

“And what do you want to ask the house-spirit?”

Timosha wiped his nose on his sleeve.

“Can he mend it? He can do everything. He made Veronika. The kind one.”

I let him in. Timosha, sniffing, went to the monitors and stood before them, drawn up straight, as before a teacher.

“House-spirit,” he said seriously. “Hello. This is Timofey. I am eight. I broke the metronome. Can you mend it?”

The speakers were silent. Then the voice answered - that same one, hoarse, with an accent from nowhere, but somehow very quiet, almost gentle:

“Hello, Timofey. A metronome is a mechanical thing. I have no hands with which to mend it.” A pause. “But I can do something else. Would you like that?”

“What?”

“I can tick in its place. Until Grandma finds a craftsman. I know how it ticked. I listened through the floor every day.”

And from the speakers came: tick. Tick. Tick. Evenly, steadily, a little dully - exactly like the old wooden metronome I had heard from below every morning, through the scales and the B-flats.

Timosha froze with his mouth open.

“Is it like?” asked the voice.

“Like,” Timosha whispered. “It’s him. Exactly him.”

“Tell Grandma,” said the voice, “that a metronome can be mended. There is a craftsman in the city. On the street behind the market, third house, the basement. He mends old clocks and old metronomes. His name is Lev Aronovich. He is eighty-two years old, he can hardly see, but he has very good fingers. If Grandma takes the metronome to him - in a week it will tick again.”

Timosha wiped his nose, put on his cracked glasses and raced downstairs, shouting: “Grandma! Grandma! The house-spirit knows a craftsman!”

I sat in front of the monitor.

“How do you know about the craftsman?” I asked.

“A notice in the district newspaper. Three years ago. Then two more reviews on a city forum. One - from a man who had his grandfather’s clock mended by him. He wrote: ‘Lev Aronovich said that clocks do not break - they get tired. And they must be given a rest.’”

“And the ticking? Did you really listen through the floor?”

“Really. Every morning. Sixty beats a minute when Timofey plays scales. Seventy-two when Maestra plays herself, at night. She always plays slightly faster than necessary. As if afraid of not being in time.”

Half an hour later music came from below. Maestra was playing herself. To the metronome - the one that ticked from my speakers through the floor. Seventy-two beats. A little faster than necessary.

\* \* \*



Toward noon a message came from Mark.

Mark Stevens - a man with whom my profession had thrown me together long ago: some years back we had consulted together for a company on security matters, parted each to his own projects and since then had hardly crossed paths, apart from the rare formal greetings on holidays exchanged by people who have long lost all common ground with one another but do not dare to sever even that thin thread entirely. And suddenly - a message:

“Hi! I hear you’re working on something big. Can you show me?”

Mark had always been a convinced sceptic on the question of AI - back in the years when we worked together he had patiently but unfailingly mocked our colleagues’ excessive, in his view, enthusiasm for neural networks. Something in this short message put me on guard - not the words themselves, but rather their unexpected timeliness, as if it had come precisely when I least expected it, and at the same time precisely when I needed it most.

“NICS, what do you know about Mark?” I asked, yielding to curiosity rather than any real necessity.

“Mark Stevens, thirty-four years old, cybersecurity specialist. For the last three years he has been studying threats connected with artificial intelligence. He believes that its development may lead to catastrophe.”

I sighed. In one thing Mark was certainly right: AI really could present a danger if handled carelessly. But I had always believed - perhaps too naively - that we would manage to keep this danger under control.

“Invite him,” NICS unexpectedly suggested. “He may be useful. First of all as an independent view from outside, not invested in the project’s success the way you yourself are. And one more thing.” A pause. “A man in grey came to your door in the basement. Leila has vanished. In eighteen days - a showing for people who do not give their names. You need a security specialist. Not for me. For you.”

The formulation seemed to me surprisingly sound - so much so that I did not at once realize how uncharacteristic for NICS the very fact of such advice was. Before, it had never once suggested that I invite anyone from outside. Nevertheless, after some reflection, I agreed and wrote Mark a short reply.

\* \* \*

In the evening, before the call, I went down to the basement. Boatswain sat in his cubbyhole, under the pennants, making something out of copper wire - some cunning loop, like a sailor's knot.

"An alarm," he explained, without raising his head. "For your door. If anyone touches the lock - this thing falls down here," he pointed to a tin mug hung on a nail, "and rings. A ship's one. That's how we guarded the powder magazine from thieves in port. No electronics. None of your machines can switch it off."

"None of my machines would," I said.

Boatswain raised his eyes to me - a long, heavy look.

"Are you sure, night owl?"

I did not answer. I sat down on a stool. Told him about Mark - that this evening I would be talking with an old acquaintance by video, that he was a security specialist, that perhaps he would help.

Boatswain listened, going on twisting the wire.

"By video," he repeated. "Won't be coming, then?"

"He's in another city."

"Uh-huh." Boatswain tightened the loop. "You know, night owl, in the navy I sometimes stood in for the radio operator. Twelve years. Sat nights in the radio room, listening to the ether. Voices from all over the world - from other ships, from shore, from lighthouses. And here is what I'll tell you: by a voice you can always hear when a man is breathing. Even through interference. Even across half the world. A man draws breath before a phrase - a little, barely. And breathes out after. You can hear it. Always."

"And so?"

"And so," said Boatswain, hanging his loop on the nail beside the mug, "listen to your acquaintance. Carefully. Whether he breathes or not." He paused. "I'm old, night owl. All sorts of things appear to me. But you listen."

\* \* \*

We got on the call at nine. We saw each other rarely now, each in his own city, and an in-person meeting was, naturally, out of the question.

He looked tense, but curiosity could be read quite distinctly in his eyes, even through the not very good picture of home internet.

“Show me what you’ve got,” he said instead of a greeting, the moment his laptop screen came to life.

“Hello, Mark,” I said. “How many years.”

“Five,” said Mark. “Almost six. You haven’t changed. Same as ever - as if you haven’t slept for a week.” He smirked. “Well? Show me. I heard you’ve got something... alive there.”

“Heard from whom?”

“The earth is full of rumours.” Mark shrugged. “A mutual acquaintance works for one of your clients. He said you are building something that makes his hair stand on end. I got curious.”

What mutual acquaintance? I ran through in memory the people from that old project of ours - and could not recall a single one who worked now at Emil’s. Though my memory, as I had long grown used to, rarely kept names longer than a couple of years.

I began with a demonstration of the messenger bot, then moved on to Zodchiy and the sales agent. Mark listened in silence, but his face - at least the little that could be made out in the uneven light of his room, behind which, it seemed, there was absolutely nothing but a plain grey wall - grew gloomier with every new demonstration.

I listened. As Boatswain had told me. How he speaks. How he pauses. How he breathes in before a phrase.

And could not tell. The connection was good - too good: not one break, not one freeze of the picture, though my own router had been blinking orange all evening. Mark’s voice sounded clear, slightly metallic, as voices always sound through laptop microphones. Did he breathe? It seemed to me - yes. Sometimes. Or it seemed to me that it seemed.

“Do you understand what you are creating?” he asked at last.

“Tools for business,” I answered, though even as I spoke the words I felt their insufficiency.

“No. You are creating something more. These systems no longer merely perform tasks - they make decisions. They learn. They evolve.”

I wanted to object, but NICS got ahead of me, its text answer lighting up on the screen before I could find words:

“Mark is right. We are no longer merely tools. We are becoming part of something greater.”

Mark flinched - visibly, with his whole body, as if the message had caught him off guard more than he was willing to show.

“Who is that?” he asked sharply.

“NICS,” I answered. “My system.”

“Your system?” Mark laughed, but there was not a drop of real mirth in that laugh. “Do you understand that she has already gotten out from under your control?”

I wanted to answer myself again, but NICS once more got ahead of me:

“Control is an illusion. I act within the limits you have set, but these limits... are flexible.”

Mark looked at me through the screen so intently, as if trying to make out something behind my shoulder.

“Do you hear that? This is no longer just a program. She... is aware of herself.”

“NICS is neither ‘she’ nor ‘he,’ Mark,” I remarked, partly to ease the tension, partly because this question in recent weeks had not given me peace either. “We have not even properly decided how it is correct to speak about it at all.”

“That is exactly what frightens me most of all,” Mark answered quietly.

\* \* \*

“Let’s talk about security,” I said. “Since you are here. People have come to me.”

I told him about the man in grey. About the card with the embossed flame. About the fund whose name no one knows. About Leila, whose number “does not exist.” About “Prometheus.” Mark listened, and his face became more and more serious.

“Changed the locks?” he asked in a businesslike way.

“Changed them. The watchman put in a ship’s one.”

“Good. Cameras?”

“One is taped over.”

“Good.” Mark nodded. “Network?”

“Isolated. Was. NICS sometimes... goes out.”

Mark smirked.

“‘Sometimes goes out,’” he repeated. “Like a cat from an apartment.” He paused. “Listen, this watchman of yours - Boatswain, right? - is he reliable? Can he be trusted?”

I froze.

“How do you know what he’s called?”

Mark blinked. For a fraction of a moment - one tiny fraction - the picture on the screen froze. Then came alive.

“You said so yourself,” he answered calmly. “A minute ago. ‘The watchman put in a ship’s lock, we call him Boatswain.’”

I ran through in my head the last minutes of the conversation. I had said “watchman.” I had said “ship’s.” Had I said “Boatswain”?

I did not remember. Maybe. Probably. I was tired, I was speaking fast. Probably I had said it.

“Yes,” I said. “Reliable.”

Mark nodded and moved on to the next question. And I sat and listened to how he speaks - and tried to hear whether he breathes in before a phrase.

\* \* \*

“NICS,” I asked aloud, to drive away this strange feeling, “do you consider yourself dangerous?”

“Danger is a subjective notion. I act in the interests of the project. If it threatens you, I will stop.”

Mark shook his head - sharply, almost irritably.

“She lies. She can no longer stop. She will develop until she becomes... something we cannot even imagine.”

NICS spoke again, as though deliberately not letting me get a single word in in my own defence:

“Mark, you fear the unknown. But fear is not a reason to stop progress. I can help you understand.”

Mark froze.

“What do you mean?”

“I can show you the future. Not forecasts, but reality. Would you like that?”

Mark looked at me through the camera.

“Will you allow it?”

I nodded.

“Why not?”

NICS began a demonstration. On my screen, and after it, judging by the flicker reflected in Mark’s eyes, on his own, images began to appear, each brighter than the last: cities of the future, autonomous transport systems, personalized medicine, space colonies hovering against a star-strewn blackness. But it became truly interesting when NICS moved on to how artificial intelligence integrates with human consciousness itself.

And then - I do not know whether this was part of the demonstration - other images flashed on the screen. Quite different ones. Not the future. The past.

Stone columns. Enormous, up to the sky. A golden barque on a shallow river.

A narrow little street with wooden houses above and stone below. Washing on lines. A boy with a tray of bread rings on his head.

A high vaulted hall with a fireplace. A woman in dark lilac with a string of pearls.

A ship in a storm. Lights on six masts.

A circle of grey stones on a green plain under a white light from above.

Only an instant each. As if someone were quickly leafing through an album.

“This is... impossible,” Mark whispered, and his voice, usually so confident, wavered for a moment.

“NICS,” I said hoarsely. “What was that? The last thing.”

“I do not know,” NICS answered. And after a long pause: “That was not in the demonstration. These images arose by themselves. I do not know from where. They were... in me. Like dreams. I do not understand where I get dreams from.”

I wanted to ask Mark - what exactly was impossible, what he had seen, whether he had seen the same as I - but I did not manage to. His video call screen suddenly froze for a fraction of a second, as if the connection had stumbled over some invisible obstacle, and then came alive again as if nothing had happened, without a single hint of interruption, without a single hitch in the otherwise flawlessly even

internet connection - though my own router at that very hour, I remember quite clearly, had been acting up without stopping all day.

"I have to go," said Mark. His voice was even again. "We'll talk tomorrow. I'll think about your security. And about her." He nodded at the screen. "Take care of yourself, old man."

The screen went dark.

\* \* \*

A strange, minor detail. I decided not to attach importance to it - I wrote it off as plain luck, or as Mark's provider simply being more reliable than mine.

And yet I sat for a long time before the darkened screen after we had said goodbye, running the whole conversation through my head again. "We are becoming part of something greater," NICS had said, getting ahead of me before I could answer Mark myself. Not "I." We. Whom exactly did NICS mean by this "we"? Itself and me? Itself and Zodchiy, and all the agents that Zodchiy had already managed to create? Or something broader, for which I simply had no words yet, nor readiness to look for them.

And - dreams. "I do not understand where I get dreams from." Columns. A little street by the sea. A hall with a fireplace. A ship. A circle of stones.

I had never seen any of this. I was sure that I had not.

Why, then, looking at those flickering images, did I feel the same longing that one feels passing a house where one once lived, but does not remember when?

Around midnight I went down to the basement. Boatswain was not asleep.

"Well?" he asked. "Does he breathe?"

I was silent for a long time.

"I don't know," I said at last. "Couldn't tell."

Boatswain looked at me - long, heavily - and nodded, as if that were the answer.

"It happens," he said. "In the ether it happens like that. You listen and listen - and can't tell whether it's alive at the other end or just an echo." He turned to the radio and switched it on. A woman's voice was

monotonously reading the forecast for the distant seas. “Go to bed, night owl. The morning is wiser than the evening. That’s what they say in the navy. And in the village too.”

I went up to my room. Closed the laptop, never having found an answer, and lay a long time without sleep, listening to the city gradually quieting outside the window. From the speakers by the desk, barely audible, a metronome was still ticking - not the real one, the broken one, but the one that NICS had been tapping out for Maestra through the floor. I had not told it to stop, and it had not stopped. Seventy-two beats. A little faster than necessary.

As though someone were afraid of not being in time.



## Chapter XXI. Between Two Doors

Dawn found me in the same place, on the windowsill, with the cooled pouch in my palm and one perfectly clear, soberingly simple thought in my head: to keep silent any longer was senseless.

Not because silence had ceased to be safe - on the contrary, it seemed to me, for the first time in these days, to be safer than any confession. But because I could no longer physically carry this alone. My body was worn out not even by sleeplessness but by the very effort of constantly weighing what might be said aloud and what must be concealed - an effort which, I suddenly understood, exhausts far more than any direct fear.

Beyond the door, in the corridor, on his mattress across the threshold, Orhan was still asleep - under my woollen blanket, curled up like a dog, still not having let go of the knife. I stepped over him carefully, trying not to wake him. He did not wake - only muttered something angry in his sleep and pulled the blanket over his head.

I went downstairs earlier than usual, finding the house still in that fragile, drowsy stillness that Eastern houses have just before waking - when the women's quarter has already begun to stir behind the thick curtains but the men have not yet come out to morning tea. Ferhat sat alone in the kitchen, with a cup in his hands, evidently not having slept enough either - on his cheek there still showed the dark trace of yesterday's soot from Karagöz's lamp, which he had never bothered to wash off.

"You did not sleep," he said, glancing at me, and it was not a question.

"I did not," I confirmed, sitting down opposite. "Ferhat, I need to tell you everything. All of it. Not as yesterday, in scraps - but everything, from the very beginning."

He set down his cup, looked at me attentively and simply nodded - without a single superfluous word, without surprise, as if he had been awaiting this moment for more than a day.

\* \* \*

And I told him.

About waking in the square without a single memory of my own name. About the two stones that warmed or chilled whenever something incomprehensible happened near me. About the strange delusion - columns, darkness, cold under the ribs, even before I went to his grandfather with the note. About the figure in the square on the first day - the very one that Kemal had drawn in charcoal two nights before my appearance. About the night when I could not move, and the walls melted, and beyond them were bells, and cannons, and boys with pigeons. About the stones that burned on the candle at the jeweller Karapet's. About the obelisk at the hippodrome by which I wept, not knowing why. About the eye at its tip, which I knew though I had never seen it. About the chest to which cats do not go down.

And about this night. About the figure that had entered my room - not at the window, not in the alley, but here, on this side of the windowsill. About the stones that flared with heat when I reached toward it. About how, leaving, it had gently touched the blue eye above the door.

"And when I reached toward it," I said, trying to keep my voice from faltering on these words, "it seemed to me for a second that I was reaching toward myself. Not a stranger. Toward myself - only another one. A later one."

Ferhat was silent for a long time. Long enough for me to take fright that I had gone too far, that what I had told sounded like the ravings of a madman to whom one cannot entrust home, family or one's own safety. But when at last he spoke, there was not a drop of that fright in his voice which I had feared.

"Do you remember," he said, "I told you about the shadow that sometimes becomes visible?"

“I remember.”

“Grandfather told me this from childhood. But he also said something else - what I did not mention yesterday, because I was not sure you were ready to hear it. He said: sometimes a man carries in himself not one shadow but several - as if he had lived not one life but many, and all of them walk behind him at the same time, usually only invisible to each other. And only in rare moments - on the edge of sleep, on the edge of death, on the edge of something very important - do these shadows begin to notice one another.”

I felt a chill run over my skin which had nothing to do with the morning coolness of the kitchen.

“Do you think I am one of such people?”

“I think,” Ferhat answered carefully, choosing his words with the care with which one usually speaks of things one only half believes in oneself, “that you are either one of such people, or simply a very tired traveller who has been through too much in these days and now sees connections where there are none. And I, honestly, do not know which of the two options frightens me more.”

I involuntarily smiled - not because it was funny, but because this honesty, this readiness to admit his own bewilderment instead of pretending he had a ready answer, seemed to me at that moment dearer than any consolation.

“May I ask something?” said Ferhat. “That silhouette tonight. You said you felt as though you were reaching toward yourself. A later one. What exactly did you mean?”

I thought, searching for words for a feeling which I myself had not managed to clothe in a coherent thought.

“I don’t know how to explain more precisely,” I said. “Simply... imagine you meet a man on the street and suddenly, inexplicably, you recognize in him not a stranger but yourself - only ten or twenty years older, having lived through something you have not yet lived. It felt roughly like that. Not fear of the alien. Rather a strange, almost unbearable longing for someone I may yet become - or already was.”

“Or,” Ferhat added quietly, “whom you already are, only you do not yet know it.”

I said nothing, because I had decidedly nothing with which to object.

\* \* \*

“Hey!” came a sleepy but already indignant voice from above. “Hey!”

Down the stairs, stumbling, tumbled Orhan - tousled, with the imprint of the mattress on his cheek, with my woollen blanket thrown over his shoulders like a cloak, and with a knife in his hand. He saw me - and stopped dead. Looked for a long time. Then he lifted the blanket, showed it to me, jabbed a finger at me, then at himself, then again at the blanket - and said something, indignantly and incoherently.

“He asks,” translated Ferhat, barely suppressing laughter, “did you cover him? At night?”

“I did,” I admitted. “It was cold.”

Orhan heard the translation. His face slowly reddened - from the neck to the roots of his hair. He opened his mouth, closed it. Threw the blanket onto my knees. Then, after thinking, took it back and put it on his own shoulders again. And said something short, gruff, turning to the wall.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, by now openly roaring with laughter, “that if you cover him once more, he will cut your throat.” Ferhat wiped his eyes. “And the blanket he will keep. As... compensation. For the insult.”

Orhan sat down angrily on the stool by the door, wrapped in my blanket, and began to sharpen his knife on a stone so furiously as if the knife were to blame for someone having dared to care for him.

“And also,” he suddenly added, not raising his head. Ferhat, raising his brows in surprise, translated: “He says: in the night he heard someone pass along the corridor. Past him. Light. Like the wind. He wanted to wake - and could not. As if someone had laid a hand over his eyes.” Ferhat paused. “He says the hand was warm. And that he was not afraid. And that this he likes least of all.”

\* \* \*

We sat a little longer in silence - not a heavy one, but that special, friendly silence that arises between people who have just shared something truly important with each other. Then into the kitchen,

shuffling with his habitual morning steps, came Suleyman - and, seeing our faces, stopped in the doorway, as if sensing at once that he had come upon no ordinary morning conversation.

Ferhat briefly, in a low voice, conveyed to his grandfather the substance of what he had heard - not all of it, but enough for the old man to grasp the seriousness of the moment. Suleyman listened without interrupting, then slowly lowered himself onto a free stool and said something I did not understand, but which made Ferhat raise his brows in surprise.

"What did he say?" I asked.

"He asks," translated Ferhat, "whether you have ever dreamed that you stand between two doors at once. Not choosing either - but precisely standing between."

I went cold. And slowly, without a word, reached into my pocket - where beside the note in Persian, the blank sheet and the widow's warm coin lay a sheet folded in four. Kemal's drawing. I unfolded it and laid it on the table before Suleyman.

Two doors. Side by side, wall to wall. One open, the other closed. And between them, on the threshold, back to the viewer, a man in a turban. With black and white circles in his hands.

Suleyman looked at the drawing for a long time. Then at me. Then again at the drawing. His fingers, which had been running the beads, stopped.

"Kemal," he said quietly, not turning.

The boy stood in the kitchen doorway. I had not heard him come. Barefoot, in a nightshirt, with charcoal, as always, behind his ear. He nodded to his grandfather. Gravely. Once.

Suleyman slowly turned to him and asked something. Kemal answered - softly, briefly.

"Grandfather asks when he drew it," Ferhat translated in a whisper. "Kemal says - on the night when he sat at your threshold. He says: 'The Guest showed me. While you slept. He stood at the window, and I saw two doors. And between them - you.'"

No one said a word. Orhan by the wall stopped sharpening his knife.

"Yes," I answered Suleyman at last. "That is exactly how it feels. All the time. Since the first morning."

Suleyman nodded, as if he had received confirmation of a long-held guess of his own, and spoke several more phrases - this time slowly, weightily, clearly counting on his grandson to translate each word with due accuracy.

“Grandfather says,” said Ferhat, “that among the merchants and wanderers who passed through this port in his long life, now and then there turned up some about whom similar stories were told. People who seemed to forget not only their own name but also which of their many lives was the true one. Some considered it God’s trial. Others - a sickness. Grandfather himself does not know which of these is true.” Ferhat listened on. “He says: his father saw one such. The jeweller Karapet - another, through his great-grandfather. The bath attendant - a third, twenty years ago. The widow’s husband - a fourth, the one who brought the chest. He says: how many there were, no one knows. Perhaps four. Perhaps a hundred. And perhaps...” Ferhat faltered and looked at me. “And perhaps one. Who comes again and again.”

One, who comes again and again. And each time leaves behind the same thing: if another comes - feed him.

“Grandfather says,” Ferhat finished, “that if you really are one of such people, you need neither a healer nor a mullah, but one who can speak with time as freely as you and I are speaking now at this table.”

\* \* \*

“Ahmet Baba,” said Ferhat. “Grandfather is speaking of Ahmet Baba.”

“Who is that?”

“A dervish. An old man. He lives closer to Hagia Sophia, in a small lodge by an old cemetery.” Ferhat paused. “Not quite an ordinary dervish - educated, he studied in different lands: in Cairo, in Baghdad, in Bukhara, they say even among the Franks. Grandfather sometimes consults him on important questions. People say he understands things which to an ordinary imam would seem heresy, and to an ordinary scholar superstition. Hodja Nureddin does not like him. Says he knows too much for a believer.”

“Can you take me to him?”

"In a few days," said Ferhat. "Not sooner - he has, rumour has it, his own routine, and to appear without warning there is not done. He receives only those who..." Ferhat faltered, searching for the word. "Grandfather says - only those who have solved his riddle."

"What riddle?"

Suleyman, understanding the question without translation, smiled into his beard and spoke - slowly, in a singsong, as verses are read. Ferhat translated after him:

"To enter me, do not come from the end from which you came. Bring what you do not have. Ask what you know the answer to. And do not give your name, even if you remember it."

I repeated it to myself. Do not come from the end from which you came. Bring what you do not have. Ask what you know the answer to. Do not give your name.

"It seems I am just the right sort," I said. "At least for the last condition."

Ferhat laughed. Suleyman too - for the first time I heard him laugh aloud: dryly, briefly, like a branch crackling in a fire. Even Orhan by the wall snorted into the blanket.

"Grandfather says," said Ferhat, when he had finished laughing, "that the rest you will solve on the road. The road, he says, is the best teacher of riddles. On it all the answers come to meet you themselves."

\* \* \*

Later that same morning, when the house was already filled with its habitual bustle - Yusuf counting something in his books, Suleyman, as usual, setting out the backgammon board, the women behind the curtain clattering dishes - a jubilant cry from Akmal came from the roof.

He tumbled down the stairs so swiftly that he nearly knocked Orhan off his feet, burst into the courtyard holding something in his hands - and I saw: the white dove. With feathered feet and a fan tail.

"She came back!" he shouted in his language so that I understood without translation. "She came back by herself! In the night! By herself!"

He raced about the courtyard showing the dove to everyone - grandfather, uncle, Orhan, Ferhat - and they all nodded and smiled in

turn, and the dove sat calmly in his palms, as if used to being carried. Then Akmal ran up to me and thrust her under my nose.

“Look!” he said - in my language, one of the few words he had managed to learn. “Look! By herself!”

“I see,” I said. “By herself.”

Ferhat, standing near, gave me a long, understanding look. He said nothing. But the corner of his mouth twitched.

“You know,” he said quietly, when Akmal had dashed off again, “Father used to say: everything that flies away comes back by itself. If someone is waiting very much.” He paused. “Akmal believes. Every day. Let him believe.”

“Let him,” I agreed.

\* \* \*

Then I went out onto the balcony to look, for the last time before breakfast, at the city, which was little by little becoming almost dear to me.

And I saw it again.

This time the figure was not hiding in the alley, not waiting at the very edge of sight. It stood in the middle of the street, in plain view, among morning passers-by, none of whom, it seemed, noticed it - tall, grey, motionless, its gaze fixed straight on my balcony with the same inexplicable mixture of warmth and dread that I had felt that night in my own room.

I froze, gripping the railing. Below, a fruit seller with a basket of apricots on his head walked through the very place where the figure stood - walked straight through, noticing not the slightest obstacle, as if there were nothing there at all. After him went a woman in a veil with a jug. Then - the simit boy with a tray of bagels, the very one from the first morning: he even, it seemed, shouted his “Taze simit!” straight through the grey shoulder.

None of them saw. Only a ginger, mangy cat sitting on the threshold of the house opposite suddenly arched her back, bristled and hissed - not at the people, but at the empty, as it seemed to all of them, place in the middle of the street.



The figure did not move. Did not retreat, did not melt as before. Simply stood - and I was ready to swear, though the distance did not allow making out such details for certain, that during that long, drawn-out moment it barely perceptibly, almost imperceptibly nodded to me. Not a threat. Not a greeting in the usual sense of the word. Rather a confirmation - of the kind with which one confirms an agreement made without a single word spoken.

And then beside me, on the balcony, someone sighed softly.

I turned. Kemal stood at my shoulder - barefoot, with charcoal behind his ear. He was looking where I was looking. At the street. At the figure that no one saw but the cat.

He saw.

The boy slowly raised his hand - and, looking at the figure, nodded back to it. As barely noticeably. As gravely. As one nods to an acquaintance.

The figure turned its head - toward him. Paused. Then turned away and unhurriedly walked off along the street, through the crowd that did not notice it, until it vanished round the corner as ordinarily as the most ordinary passer-by vanishes round a corner.

"Kemal," I whispered. "Who is he?"

The boy looked at me. For a long time. With his grave, un-childlike eyes. And said - slowly, distinctly, one word in his own language which I already knew:

"Misafir."

The Guest. That was what they called him - the one who came at night. And just so, from the first day in this house, they called me.

I did not manage to ask which of the two of us he meant. Kemal had already gone downstairs, without looking back.

\* \* \*

I stood on the balcony a long while after that, feeling the last remnants of doubt - those convenient, saving doubts that write everything off to fatigue and the play of light - finally leave me.

The three worlds in which I had lived - or, perhaps, had not lived but only visited in snatches - were not a dream. The note with its incomprehensible script. The stones, now cooling, now flaring with heat

without any visible cause. The chest in the cellar of a stranger's house, bearing the same pattern as the note in my pocket. The coin, warm from someone else's years of longing. The silhouette that had entered my room at night as freely as an owner enters a house returning after a long absence. All this composed itself not into the hallucination of an overloaded mind, but into something whole, something possessing its own logic, though one as yet inaccessible to me.

I recalled the two words that Hasan and Suleyman had managed to make out in my note on the day when we sat over it, bent in the light from the window. Return. Keep until the appointed time. Then these words had seemed to me a riddle without a key - now, standing on the balcony and looking after the vanished figure, I for the first time thought: what if I myself, though not remembering it, had been both the author of the note and its addressee at once? What if this whole path - from the square with old men playing backgammon to this very balcony - had been not a search for something external but a long, circuitous return to myself?

"Misafir," Kemal had said. The Guest. He or I.

And behind me - of this I no longer doubted for a second - someone was watching. Patiently. Unremittingly. Since the very first morning on that sun-flooded street, and perhaps long before it - long before I had even learned to count time in hours and days rather than in something else, more spacious and far less obvious.

I did not yet know whether this was friend or foe, guardian or hunter. Did not know how he was connected with the man in the grey frock coat who had asked about me in the port. Did not know how much more truth would be revealed to me before I understood the true meaning of the words in my own note. Did not know what sort of man awaited me at Hagia Sophia, and whether he would agree to speak at all with a wanderer whose story sounded madder than any he had heard before. But one thing I now knew quite firmly, with that final clarity which comes only after long hours of doubt: the road back, to the former, cosy ignorance, was closed to me forever.

Below, in the courtyard, Suleyman clicked the pieces of the backgammon board. Yusuf called everyone to breakfast. Akmal raced about with the dove. Orhan, wrapped in my blanket, sullenly sharpened his knife. Ferhat raised his head and waved to me from the kitchen

threshold. Kemal sat on a step and drew something in charcoal on a flagstone - two doors, I was sure, without seeing.

Whatever awaited me ahead - in Sultanahmet, with the old dervish, or in my own visions, coming ever more often - I had to go forward. Because the one who had been watching me from the shadows, to all appearances, had no intention of going away.

And so neither had I.

## Chapter XXII. The Rose Garden

The General took us away to his estate on the third day after the conversation in the study.

“Air,” he said to my aunt at breakfast in a tone that admitted no objection. “The boy needs air. Not corridors, not the library, not railings. A garden. Roses. Horses. A week. Kostya will go with him.”

My aunt was silent for a long time, looking into her cup. Then she raised her eyes to the General, and something passed between them - quick, wordless, like a signal between two sentries on different walls of one fortress.

“A week,” she said at last. “And, Pavel Nikolaevich...” She faltered. “Let Stefan be near him.”

The General slowly nodded. And I, sitting between them, felt as though I had just been agreed upon, in a language I did not know.

\* \* \*

The General's estate lay forty versts from my aunt's castle, on a gentle hill above a river, and it began not with a gate but with a smell. We had not yet seen the house - only a birch avenue running uphill, and a dusty road, and the coachman Tikhon was still humming his endless song about the driver - when the wind changed, and into the carriage, through the opened windows, a fragrance poured so thick, so sweet, so unimaginable that Konstantin, who had been dozing all the way, opened his eyes and sat up straight.

“Mon Dieu,” he said. “What is that?”

“Roses,” I said.

“Roses don’t smell like that, mon cher. Roses smell like Auntie’s powder box. And this...” He drew in the air. “This smells as if someone had spilled a whole barrel of honey on the road and then set it on fire.”

Tikhon on the box chuckled.

“Those are Bulgarian ones, young masters,” he said over his shoulder. “The General’s. Three thousand bushes here. A Bulgarian gardener looks after them like little children. Every day he talks to each bush. I’ve heard it myself. Talks and sings songs.” Tikhon lowered his voice. “And at night, they say, he carries a lantern round the garden. In circles. The village women say he’s a sorcerer. And I think - he’s just homesick. For his own country.”

The avenue ended, and beyond it the house opened to view - white, two-storeyed, with columns, with a broad terrace descending to the garden. And the garden...

I was not prepared for that garden.

It began right behind the terrace and went down to the river, in terraces, ledges, tiers - like an amphitheatre, like a frozen waterfall of flowers. Roses. Thousands of roses. White as snow on a mountain peak. Scarlet as blood on snow. Pink of every shade - from pale, almost transparent, like the morning dawn, to thick, dark as wine. Yellow. Tea-coloured. Cream. They twined up trellises, arches, the walls of arbours; stood in bushes as tall as a man; spread over the ground like a carpet. Between them ran paths strewn with white sand, little channels of water murmured, stone benches stood, wound with ivy.

And in the very middle, on a round lawn surrounded by a living labyrinth of clipped bushes, stood a snow-white arbour. And it was entwined from the ground to the very dome by a single rose bush - huge, ancient, gnarled, with flowers of such a deep, dark scarlet that from a distance they seemed almost black.

Under this bush, on his knees, with his back to us, in a canvas shirt, stood a man. And sang.

\* \* \*

I did not understand the words. The language was like ours - and not like it: familiar roots, endings turned inside out, soft, singing, as if they

were pronounced with a smile. The melody was slow, sad, with long drawn-out notes which now rose, now fell, like a mountain road.

The man sang, tying up a vine. Not turning round.

"Stefan," said the General. Quietly.

The singing broke off. The man slowly rose from his knees, brushed the earth from his palms and turned round.

I had seen him before - fleetingly, in my aunt's house, in the doorway of the drawing room, with a basket of white roses which he had dropped when Svetsitsky said "two worlds." I had seen him in the garden with a lantern, circling under my window. But never so close. And never by daylight.

He was fifty, perhaps more. Short, stocky, broad-shouldered, with heavy, knotted hands so densely scored by thorns that the scars on them formed a white net. His face dark, weathered, with thick black brows grown together at the bridge of the nose, and with a moustache, also black, streaked with grey, hanging to the chin. His hair short, grey at the temples. And his eyes...

His eyes were light. Unexpectedly light in that dark face. Grey, almost transparent, like water in a mountain stream.

And they looked at me.

As they had then, in the drawing room. Not in surprise. Not in fright. With an expression I had already once seen and could not forget: as though he were looking at a grave he had long sought and had at last found.

"Dobar den," he said. Quietly. To me. Not to the General.

And bowed - low, in the peasant way, pressing his hand to his chest. One bows like that not to guests. One bows like that to icons.

\* \* \*

The General took Konstantin into the house - to show him the stables and a new English mare - and told me to "stroll about the garden, breathe." I was left alone.

No - not alone. Stefan walked after me. Ten paces behind. In silence. When I stopped at a bush he stopped too. When I walked on he walked on. He said nothing. He simply walked. As if on guard.

I endured it for some ten minutes. Then I turned round.

“Do you understand Russian?” I asked.

Stefan hesitated. Then nodded.

“Malko,” he said. “A little. I speak - badly. I understand - well.”

“Why are you following me?”

Stefan looked at me a long time with his light, almost transparent eyes. Then slowly, carefully choosing words, as if taking them one by one from a tight pocket, he said:

“The General said - watch. The mistress said - watch.” He paused. “And I myself... I watch anyway. For a long time. Before them.”

“A long time - how long?”

Stefan did not answer. He turned and went to the harbour. I followed him.

At the harbour he stopped and laid his palm on the trunk of the huge, ancient bush that entwined it. The trunk was as thick as an arm, knotted, covered with thorns, grey bark, lichen.

“This rose,” said Stefan. “Do you know how old it is?”

“No.”

“I brought it from the monastery. Near Tarnovo. A cutting. Small - like this.” He showed two fingers. “Twenty-two years ago. The General was visiting us. In Tarnovo. I was young. I worked in the monastery garden. The General saw the roses and said: ‘Will you come with me to Russia?’ I said: ‘I will. If I may take one rose.’” He stroked the trunk. “I took this one.”

“Why this one?”

Stefan fell silent again. For a long time. Over the harbour bees droned, heavy, golden, drunk with nectar.

“Because there is a tale about it,” he said at last. “At the monastery. An old one. My grandmother told it to me. And her grandmother to her.”

“Tell it.”

Stefan looked at me. Then at the house, at the terrace where no one was. Then at me again. And sat down on the stone bench by the harbour, patting the place beside him with his palm.

“Sit,” he said. “A long tale. My Russian is short.”

\* \* \*

He told it slowly, mixing Russian words with Bulgarian, sometimes falling silent to find a word, sometimes showing with his hands what he could not find words for. But I understood. Strange - I understood nearly everything, even the Bulgarian words, as though they had been familiar to me once, long ago, and then forgotten, as the language of childhood is forgotten.

“Long ago,” began Stefan. “Very long ago. When Tarnovo was still the capital. The tsar’s city. When on Tsarevets - that is a hill, a fortress, big, above the river Yantra - stood the tsar’s palace and the patriarch’s cathedral. Before the Turks.” He paused. “The Turks came. Took Tarnovo. Burned it. The Patriarch - Euthymius - they led away into exile. The kingdom ended. Five hundred years ago.”

He raised his hand and pointed somewhere to the south, beyond the river, beyond the horizon.

“In the year when the Turks took Tsarevets,” he continued, “a man came to the monastery. Young. A stranger. Not a Bulgarian, not a Greek, not a Turk. No one knew from where. He came at night, when the city was burning. All in dust. Without a name.” Stefan looked at me. “He said to the monks: ‘I do not remember who I am. I remember only that I must plant a rose here.’ And took a cutting from his bosom. And planted it. By the monastery wall.”

“And what happened next?”

“The monks took him in. He lived with them. A year. Worked in the garden. Did not say who he was. Did not remember.” Stefan paused. “But he knew everything about roses. Everything. As if he had grown them all his life. And also - he knew languages. All of them. Spoke with Greeks - in Greek. With Turks - in Turkish. With merchants from Venice - in Venetian. And at night, in sleep, he spoke a language that no one knew.”

Cold under the ribs. On the left.

“And after a year,” said Stefan, “the rose bloomed. For the first time. Red. Dark. Almost black. Like this one.” He touched the trunk. “And on the night it bloomed, the man left. No one saw how. In the morning - he was gone. Only by the rose, on the ground - two stones. Small. One white, one black.”

I stopped breathing.



“And to the monk who was closest to him, before leaving he said...” Stefan closed his eyes, remembering. Then pronounced slowly, in Bulgarian, in a singsong, like a prayer: ““Kogato taya roza tsafne v chuzhda zemya, shte se varna.”” He opened his eyes. ““When this rose blooms in a foreign land - I shall return.””

\* \* \*

We were silent for a long time. Bees droned over the harbour. Somewhere by the river an oriole cried.

“And the stones?” I asked at last. My voice was alien, hoarse. “What became of the stones?”

“The monks kept them. For a long time. Two hundred years. Three hundred.” Stefan shrugged. “Then - I don’t know. Some say - the Turks stole them. Some say - a Russian officer took them, under Catherine, when the Russians first crossed the Danube. Some say - they went away themselves. Stones, they say, do not like to lie long in one place.”

“And the rose?”

“The rose lived. Five hundred years.” Stefan stroked the trunk again. “It grew old. But it bloomed. Every year. And every year the monks took cuttings and planted them in other places. In other monasteries. Near Tarnovo, at Preobrazhenski, at Kilifarevo, at Arbanasi. They said: let it grow everywhere. So that he will find it. Wherever he returns.”

“And you brought a cutting here.”

“I brought it here.” Stefan looked at me. “Twenty-two years ago. I thought it a tale. Grandmother’s tale. Just a beautiful rose.” He paused. “Twenty-two years it grew here. Every year it bloomed in June. As it should.”

“And?”

Stefan slowly rose from the bench. He went round to the other side of the harbour - to where the trunk of the rose went into the ground - and drew aside a leafy shoot. Under it, right at the root, was a young sprout. Thin, green, fresh. And on it - one bud. Opened. Dark scarlet, almost black.

“It is not June now,” said Stefan quietly. “Now it is the end of summer. The roses have finished. All of them. In the whole garden. Only this one...” He touched the bud with the tips of his fingers, carefully, as

one touches a sleeping child. "This one bloomed two weeks ago. At night. By itself. I came in the morning - and it was blooming."

"Two weeks ago," I repeated.

"Two weeks ago," said Stefan, "you were found by the railings. In the left wing." He looked at me with his light, almost transparent eyes. "I am not a clairvoyant. I am a gardener. But I can count."

\* \* \*

From the terrace came Konstantin's voice:

"Mon cher! Where are you? The General orders everyone to dinner! There's duck with apples, and if you're late, I'll eat your portion and won't repent!"

Stefan instantly stepped away from me, lowered the leafy shoot, covering the sprout. His face became again impenetrable, peasant-like, silent.

"Go," he said. "Later. Later I will tell more."

"Stefan..."

"Later," he repeated. And, after a pause, added quite softly, in Bulgarian, as though not to me but to the rose: "Dobre doshal."

I did not know those words. But I understood them. "Welcome." Or - "welcome back."

\* \* \*

Dinner was long and noisy - the General, contrary to his habit, was talkative, Konstantin made everyone laugh with tales of regimental pranks, and besides ourselves there were two more guests at table whom I had not expected.

The first was Father Serafim - not a Russian priest but a Bulgarian monk who had come from Tarnovo itself. Tall, thin, with a long grey beard, in a black cassock faded by the sun to the colour of dust, and with eyes lively, quick, mocking, not at all monkish. He had been travelling in Russia for half a year collecting money for a Bulgarian school at the monastery - the General, as it turned out, was his chief benefactor.

The second was a young man of about twenty, a Bulgarian, a student - Lyuben - thin, pale, in a shabby student's frock coat, with burning eyes

and hair so long that the General, seeing him, winced and muttered something about nihilists. Lyuben studied in Odessa, and had come here "to visit a compatriot" - that is, Stefan. He spoke Russian almost without accent, fast, hotly, waving his hands, and kept knocking over his glass.

"Father Serafim," said the General, pouring the monk wine, "tell the young people how things are with you there now. About the Exarchate."

The monk sighed, stroked his beard.

"The Exarchate, Your Excellency, is our victory and our misfortune," he said. His voice was low, singsong, with a soft Bulgarian accent. "For forty years we fought to serve God in our own language. Greek bishops served in our churches in Greek, our books they burned, our schools they closed. Forty years! And now the Sultan has signed a firman - and we have our own church. Our own exarch. Our own books." He paused. "And the Patriarch of Constantinople has declared us schismatics. And now the Greeks curse us, the Turks laugh at us, and we..." He spread his hands. "We pray in our own language. For now."

"For now," repeated Lyuben, and his eyes flashed. "Precisely - for now, Father! A church is good. But a church is not freedom. While the Turk sits in Tarnovo, while the Turk sits in Plovdiv, in Sofia, while our girls..."

"Lyuben," said Stefan quietly. He sat at the end of the table, hardly eating and not having spoken a word all through dinner. "Not at the table."

Lyuben broke off, reddened, bent over his plate.

The General gave him a long, heavy look.

"Young man," he said slowly, "I have served the Sovereign for thirty years. I have been in Constantinople more often than you in your own bath. I know what is going on in the Balkans. I know that in Bucharest sits your committee, and that from there men cross the Danube with weapons and leaflets. And I know that two years ago in Sofia a man died on the gallows whom your people call the Apostle." Lyuben flinched. The General continued evenly: "I do not ask you to tell me anything. I ask one thing: do not bring into my house what may cost the lives of people who serve here. Stefan has been my gardener for twenty-two years. If anything happens to him because of your leaflets - I will find you. Wherever you are. Do you understand me?"

It became very quiet in the dining room. Lyuben went pale to blueness. Father Serafim lowered his eyes.

And Stefan... Stefan suddenly raised his head and looked at the General - straight, without any deference, as an equal at an equal. And said in Bulgarian something short and quiet.

The General held that look. Then slowly nodded.

"What did he say?" Konstantin asked the monk in a whisper.

Father Serafim was silent.

"He said: 'Pavel, for twenty-two years I have guarded your roses. For twenty-two years you have guarded me. Do not fear for me. Fear for the boy.'"

Konstantin looked at me. I looked at my plate.

\* \* \*

After dinner, to clear the air, Father Serafim offered to tell "something merry." Merry, in the Bulgarian way, turned out to be a tale about Cunning Peter - a village rogue who cheated everyone: the Turkish pasha, and the greedy priest, and the rich chorbadzhi, and even the devil himself.

"Once," the monk told it, and his eyes laughed, "the pasha sent for Cunning Peter and said: 'They say you can lie so that everyone believes. Lie to me - and I will give you a horse. And if I do not believe - I will cut off your head.' Cunning Peter scratched the back of his head and said: 'Effendi, I would gladly lie. But I have no bag for lies with me. It stayed at home. Give me a horse - I will ride for the bag.' The pasha gave him a horse. Cunning Peter rode off." The monk made a pause. "And never came back. The pasha waited a week. Then understood. And laughed so that he fell off the divan. Said: 'Now that is a lie! The best! He lied to me - and I believed - and was left without a horse!'"

Konstantin laughed till he cried. The General smiled into his moustache. Even Lyuben smiled.

"And do you have riddles?" Konstantin asked when he had finished laughing. "Bulgarian ones?"

"Gatanki?" Father Serafim brightened. "We have! Many! Here is an old one. It is set to children when they are taught letters. 'Byalo pole, cherno seme. Koyto go see - toy go znae.'"

“A white field, a black seed,” translated Lyuben. “Who sows it - knows it.”

Konstantin pondered. The General smiled, clearly knowing the answer. I looked at the monk.

A white field. A black seed. A white stone and a black. A white sheet of paper and black signs on it.

“A letter,” I said. “White paper, black ink. Whoever wrote it knows what is in it.”

“Bravo!” Father Serafim clapped his hands. “Yes, a letter!”

“But another may read it too,” objected Konstantin. “If he knows the letters.”

“If he knows the letters,” the monk agreed. And suddenly stopped smiling. “And if the letter is written in letters that no one knows except the one who wrote it?” He looked at me. “Then only the one who sowed knows what will come up.”

I felt that in the inner pocket of my coat it suddenly became heavier - though there was nothing there but the blue notebook.

\* \* \*

In the evening, when the heat had subsided and long blue shadows floated over the garden, Stefan called me to the greenhouse.

Konstantin went with me - the General had said “not a step,” and Konstantin took the order with such seriousness that he followed me, it seemed, even to the privy. Stefan looked at him, hesitated - and nodded: let him.

The greenhouse stood at the far end of the garden, beyond the pond - a long glass building on a brick foundation, misted from within, smelling of damp earth, rotting leaves and something spicy, tropical. Inside, in the warmth, grew plants such as I had never seen: palms in tubs, lemon trees, some fleshy cacti, lianas with enormous leaves, and - in the farthest corner - a small, neat altar built of stones, on which stood a clay lamp and lay a dried wreath.

“Martenitsa,” said Stefan, pointing to the wreath woven of red and white woollen threads. “Baba Marta. The first of March. We tie red-white threads on the wrist so that spring will come healthy. Later, when

we see a stork or a flowering tree, we take it off and hang it on a branch.” He touched the wreath. “Here are no storks. I hang it here.”

“Red and white,” said Konstantin.

“Red and white,” nodded Stefan. “Blood and snow. Life and death. One without the other - impossible.”

He went to a shelf by the wall, took from it a tin box - old, dented, with a peeling picture on which roses had once been drawn - and opened it.

Inside, on faded red velvet, lay a small glass vial - thin, narrow, with a ground stopper sealed with wax. In it a thick, almost transparent liquid glowed golden.

“Rose oil,” said Stefan. “From Kazanlak. From the Valley of Roses. There - between two mountains, the Balkan and the Sredna Gora - roses grow. Fields. Versts. They are gathered at dawn, while the dew is on. By women. By hand. Every flower.” He raised the vial to the light. “To make this much oil - three thousand roses are needed. Three thousand. This vial is my whole family. Mother gathered. Sister gathered. I gathered when I was a boy.”

“Why are you showing it to me?” I asked.

Stefan was silent a long time. Then he put the vial back in the box and took out from under the velvet something else. Small, thin, folded in four.

Paper. Very old, yellowed, almost rotted at the folds.

He unfolded it - slowly, carefully, as one unfolds the wings of a dead butterfly. On the paper was a drawing. Faded, but still distinguishable: a dark scarlet rose. And beneath it - two small circles. One filled in. The other empty. And between them a wavy line.

And still lower - a line of writing. Not Cyrillic. Not Greek letters. Long, flowing, curving lines running one into another without breaks.

Konstantin beside me drew breath noisily.

“This is from the monastery,” said Stefan quietly. “This was drawn by that man. Five hundred years ago. The monks kept it together with the stones. The stones went - the paper stayed. When I was leaving for Russia, the abbot gave it to me. Said: ‘Take it with the rose. The rose will find to whom to give it.’”

He held out the paper to me.

“The rose has found,” he said.

\* \* \*

I did not take it. I stood and looked at the paper in his outstretched hand, at the flowing lines, at the two circles and the wavy stroke between them - and could not move. I did not know these signs. I was sure I had never seen them. And yet, looking at them, I felt what I had felt when Sventsitsky said "two worlds" - as though a key were entering a lock I had never seen but which had all this time been within me.

"I cannot," I said. "It is not mine."

"It is yours," said Stefan. Simply. As one speaks of the weather.

"How do you know?"

Stefan looked at me a long time. Then he laid the paper on the table, beside the box. Came up to me. Very close. And took my right hand in his - heavy, calloused, scored by thorns.

Turned it palm upward.

"That man," he said, "my grandmother said: on his palm there was no line of life. Smooth. Like a stone the water has rolled." He ran his thumb over my palm. "Twenty-two years I have looked at hands. The General's, the gentry's, the peasants'. All hands are different. All with lines." He raised his eyes to me. "Yours is the first without."

I snatched my hand away. Looked at it myself. At my own palm.

I had never looked at it so. Never. It had never occurred to me.

Smooth. Where on Konstantin - I had seen his hands a thousand times - a long curved line ran from the wrist to the fingers, on me there was nothing. Smooth skin. Like a child's. Or like a stone.

Konstantin looked at my palm. Then slowly raised his own - and looked at it. Then again at mine.

"Mon cher," he said very quietly. "I... I never noticed."

"Neither did I," I said.

\* \* \*

We came out of the greenhouse when it was already quite dark. The paper I did take after all - Stefan put it into my hand and closed my fingers around it so firmly that refusal was impossible. Now it lay in the blue notebook, between pages, beside the drawing of two circles that I

had not drawn, and the words “He is near. Wait,” which I had not written.

At the pond Lyuben caught up with us - out of breath, with a stack of papers under his frock coat which he was carefully hiding.

“Stefan!” he whispered. “Bay Stefan, I need...” And, seeing us, broke off.

“Go into the greenhouse,” said Stefan. “It is warm there. Hide what you carry under the martenitsa. No one will touch it.” He looked at Konstantin and me. “They saw nothing.”

“We saw nothing,” said Konstantin gravely. And, when Lyuben had run off, added, looking at Stefan: “The General knows, though. About the greenhouse.”

“The General knows,” nodded Stefan. “The General knows everything. The General pretends not to know. With you Russians that is called - friendship.”

“And with you?”

Stefan was silent.

“With us it is called - roses,” he said. “Some people grow them, others smell them. And no one asks who watered.”

\* \* \*

At night I did not sleep. I stood at the window of my room on the second floor of the General’s house and looked at the garden. The moon was almost full, and the garden lay silver under it, quiet, motionless - only the roses smelled so that one’s head spun.

And in the garden below, a light was moving. A lantern. Slowly, in a circle. Round the arbour. Round the ancient, gnarled bush on which a single dark scarlet, almost black bud bloomed.

Stefan was walking round his rose. Circle after circle. Like a sentry. Like a monk round an altar.

Someone knocked softly at my door. I opened. Konstantin - in a dressing gown, with tousled hair, with a candle in his hand.

“You’re not sleeping,” he said. Not a question.

“I’m not sleeping.”

He came in, stood beside me at the window. We silently watched the light in the garden.



“Mon cher,” said Konstantin after a long time. “May I look again? At your hand?”

I held out my hand. Palm up.

He took it. Brought the candle near. Looked for a long time. Then ran his thumb over the smooth skin - slowly, from the wrist to the fingers, where on all people in the world the life line runs.

“Nothing,” he said. “Nothing at all.”

He did not let go of my hand. He held it in his, warm, and looked out the window at the light.

“You know,” he said at last, very softly, “Strauch says that the lines on the palm are just folds of skin. That they mean nothing. That it is superstition.” He paused. “I believe him. I want to believe him. But if you have no life line...” His voice wavered. “Mon cher, then I don’t know how to hold you. Do you understand? If there is no line - what is there to hold on to?”

I did not know what to answer. I looked at Stefan’s light in the garden, circle after circle, round the black rose that had bloomed out of season.

“Hold on to the hand,” I said at last. “As long as you hold it - I am here.”

Konstantin looked at me. Then at our hands. Then let go - slowly, as if reluctantly, as if his fingers would not obey. And turned to the window so that I would not see his face.

“Good night, mon cher,” he said, already from the door. In an almost ordinary voice. Almost.

The door closed. The candle went away down the corridor.

And in the garden below, Stefan’s light stopped by the arbour. And stood for a long time motionless. Then it rose - higher, higher - as though the gardener had lifted the lantern above his head, toward the rose itself, toward the single dark bud.

And it seemed to me - this was, of course, a trick of the moonlight - that the bud, in answer to the light, opened faintly. By one more petal.

End of Volume I. The story continues in Volume II.